

The Formula of Becoming

A Year at McCall-Hart University

Season One Prose Edition

Week One: Two Kinds of Plans

The first thing Malik Baptiste discovered about Bellwether, Alabama, was that the heat did not simply sit on you. It negotiated.

It followed him from the rideshare drop-off to the limestone steps of Eliza Moss Hall, offering sweat in exchange for every box he carried. It fogged the edge of his glasses while he tried to balance a laptop bag, a duffel, and the promise he had made before leaving Gulfport: *I have the money part handled.*

Inside, the Quantitative Summer Bridge welcome room was cool enough to make him forgive the entire city.

Malik chose a table near an outlet, opened his laptop, and pulled up the family budget he had finished three nights ago. He only meant to check one thing. Then he found the mistake.

The repair estimate for his mother's car had been entered in the monthly column instead of the emergency-expense column. Correcting it pushed the August balance below zero.

Not far below zero. But zero did not care how close you came.

He stared at the red number as students entered around him in bright shirts, fresh sneakers, and the nervous confidence of people pretending not to look for somewhere safe to sit.

"That spreadsheet looks like it just told you a family secret."

Malik looked up.

The girl beside the chair across from him wore copper-colored headphones around her neck and carried a notebook thick with tabs. Her smile was curious, not cruel.

"It made an accusation," Malik said.

"Serious one?"

"Misplaced expense."

She pressed a hand to her chest. "In broad daylight?"

He almost smiled. Almost.

She pointed at the chair. "Can I sit here, or is it reserved for the audit committee?"

"Go ahead."

She slid into the seat. "Nia Reynolds. Mathematical sciences. Huntsville. I like graphs when they tell the truth and people when they try to."

"Malik Baptiste. Actuarial science. Gulfport. I like complete introductions."

"That was complete. You know my major, my hometown, and my entire moral philosophy."

This time, he did smile.

Around them, the room filled with the sound of new beginnings: chairs scraping, families calling with last instructions, staff passing out indigo folders stamped with a copper heron. Through the tall windows, McCall-Hart University glowed honey-gold in the morning light. Malik had studied the campus map for two weeks, but a map had not prepared him for how old and alive the place felt.

Nia tilted her head toward his screen. "Do you need help?"

His first instinct was no. His second was also no, but with better manners.

"I can fix it," he said.

"I didn't ask if you could."

That answer stayed with him longer than it should have.

Friday, August 1: The Red Number

The Bridge program opened with introductions, placement details, and a challenge from Dr. Camille Brooks, a calculus professor with silver-framed glasses and the calm voice of someone who could hear weak reasoning from across a building.

"This program is not here to prove whether you belong," she told the room. "Admission settled that question. We are here to learn how you think, where your preparation is strong, and where we need to build."

Malik wrote the sentence down exactly.

Nia drew a box around *where we need to build* and added a tiny crane beside it.

Their first activity was simple: examine a table showing hours worked, transportation costs, and weekly take-home pay. Identify the variables. Describe a possible relationship. State what the table did not reveal.

Malik listed the inputs, output, units, and likely errors before Nia had finished drawing arrows.

"Why are you decorating the data?" he asked.

"I'm showing the situation."

"The situation is in the columns."

"No, the numbers are in the columns. The situation is a person trying to get to work."

Malik glanced at the prompt. "It doesn't say that."

"Exactly. We don't know whether the transportation cost is gas, a bus pass, rideshare money, or paying somebody's cousin. That changes what choices are possible."

He disliked how quickly her answer improved his.

When Dr. Brooks asked for observations, Malik explained the numeric pattern. Nia followed by naming the missing context. Dr. Brooks nodded at both of them.

"A clean calculation built on an invisible assumption is still an unstable model," she said. "Make your assumptions visible."

Malik underlined that sentence too.

At lunch, Nia found him correcting the family budget.

"You fixed the accusation?"

"I moved the expense, reduced two categories, and added a warning rule."

"So your spreadsheet can yell before the problem gets bad."

"It does not yell. It changes color."

"Corporate yelling."

He showed her the repaired balance. He did not show her the text from his mother asking whether everything still worked. Some truths felt easier in formulas than in conversation.

Saturday, August 2: Room at the Table

Saturday's Bridge session was optional, which meant Nia arrived ten minutes late carrying iced coffee and insisting that optional mornings should begin at noon.

Malik had already claimed the same table.

"Look at us," she said, sitting across from him. "A tradition."

"It has happened twice."

"Every tradition starts before somebody puts it on a T-shirt."

They worked through readiness problems until Nia noticed Malik checking the budget between questions. He minimized it.

"You do that every time somebody walks by," she said.

"Do what?"

"Hide the sheet."

"It is private."

"Private is fine. Panicked is different."

Malik's shoulders tightened. Nia saw it and leaned back.

"Sorry," she said. "That came out like I had earned access. I haven't."

The quick apology surprised him more than the question.

He reopened the file. "My family budget was balanced when I left. Now it isn't. I told them it was."

"Was that a lie?"

"No."

"Then it was a model with new information."

"That sounds like something people say to feel better about being wrong."

"Sometimes. It can also be true."

She took out her notebook and drew two boxes. In the first, she wrote *what changed*. In the second, *what can change next*.

Malik looked at the page. "That is not a budget."

"Correct. It is me stopping you from staring at one red number like it has been elected president of your life."

He laughed loudly enough that two students turned around.

Together they found a duplicate textbook estimate and a subscription Malik could pause. The balance returned to black, but that was not the part he remembered. He remembered that Nia had known when to ask, when to back up, and when to make him laugh.

Sunday, August 3: Draw It First

Their diagnostic modeling task arrived Sunday afternoon.

A neighborhood food cooperative wanted to offer produce boxes at several prices. Students had to create a model showing how the number of subscribers could affect weekly revenue. The prompt included a tiny data table and just enough ambiguity to start an argument.

Malik built formulas immediately.

Nia turned the page sideways and drew three families standing near a bus stop.

"We have forty minutes," he said.

"I know."

"Then why are there people?"

"Because people buy the boxes."

"The model needs variables."

"And the variables need meaning."

He pointed to his screen. "Subscribers, price, revenue."

She pointed to her drawing. "Distance, pickup time, household size. If the pickup site is hard to reach, lowering the price might not increase subscribers the way we expect."

"None of that is in the data."

"Then we write that it is not in the data."

For five stubborn minutes, they worked beside each other instead of together. Malik's table became neat and uselessly confident. Nia's sketch became thoughtful and mathematically unfinished.

Finally, Malik rotated his laptop toward her. "Suppose we label my formula a first model and list your factors as limitations."

Nia rotated her notebook toward him. "Suppose we also explain what information we would collect next."

"That is outside the prompt."

"It is also a good idea."

He sighed. "Fine."

Their final answer was the strongest in the room.

Dr. Brooks praised the explicit function, then tapped the limitations section. "This is where calculation becomes judgment."

Nia nudged Malik with her elbow.

"Do not celebrate," he whispered.

"I am celebrating us. Different thing."

He pretended to review the equation so she would not see how much he liked the word *us*.

Monday, August 4: Why Math Matters

On Monday, Dr. Brooks closed the classroom door and asked everyone to put away their calculators.

"Today," she said, "I want the answer nobody can compute for you. Why does mathematics matter?"

The room went quiet in the special way classrooms do when a question becomes personal.

Students spoke about engineering, medicine, money, teaching, technology, and being the first in their families to pursue a technical degree.

When Malik's turn came, he folded his hands on the desk.

"My father can repair almost anything," he said. "Engines, roofs, appliances. But one unexpected bill can undo months of planning. I want to understand risk well enough to help families and businesses prepare without pretending every loss can be prevented."

The answer came out more honest than he intended. He looked down after finishing.

Nia did not make a joke.

When her turn came, she said, "My aunt runs a neighborhood tutoring program. Every year she has to prove the same thing to different people: that kids are learning, that the program matters, that the money should continue. I want to use math to make important things harder to ignore."

After class, they walked down Eliza Moss Hall's broad staircase.

"You want to make risk visible," Nia said.

"You want to make people visible."

"That sounded like the end of a movie trailer."

"I regret saying it."

"Too late. I heard the music."

Tuesday, August 5: The Campus Has a Memory

The campus tour began at Jubilee Library, moved through the glass-walled North Star Learning Commons, and ended beneath the live oaks along Cypress Walk.

Nia photographed everything: the copper-framed windows of Eliza Moss Hall, the old reading room inside Jubilee, the wall of whiteboards at North Star, even a campus cat sleeping under a bench as though it had tenure.

Malik photographed the map.

"You know they give us that online," Nia said.

"Phones lose signal."

"Paper maps exist."

"Paper gets wet."

"Do you prepare for joy like this too?"

He considered it. "I have not had to."

Their guide led them to Founders' Bell, greened with age and suspended beneath a limestone arch. It had once called students to assembly, she explained. Now it rang at Opening Convocation and commencement, marking the entrance and exit of a McCall-Hart education.

Nia looked up at it. "Imagine hearing that on your last day here."

Malik looked down Cypress Walk, where indigo banners shifted in the humid breeze. Four years seemed both enormous and dangerously brief.

"We have to make it to the first day first," he said.

"You really refuse to skip steps."

"Steps exist for a reason."

"So do leaps."

He glanced at her. "Leaps are just steps with poor documentation."

Nia laughed so hard the tour guide turned around.

Wednesday, August 6: Indigo Night

Indigo Night transformed Hart Student Union into a festival of music, food, club tables, and first-year students trying out possible versions of themselves.

Nia moved through it like a spark in dry grass. She signed an interest card for the Association for Women in Mathematics, took a flyer from Math Circle, promised to visit campus radio, and nearly volunteered for a service event before Malik removed the pen from her hand.

"You cannot join the whole university tonight."

"Watch me."

"I am watching. It is concerning."

Across the terrace, an alto saxophone climbed above the crowd. A small group from the Marching Herons was performing beside the radio booth. The saxophonist played with his eyes half closed, then opened them at the exact moment Nia stepped closer.

After the set, he introduced himself as Julian Cross, second-year media arts student, campus radio host, and, according to him, "occasional rescuer of boring events."

"This event was not boring," Nia said.

"Then I can take the night off."

His confidence should have been irritating. Somehow, it was not.

Julian told her about a radio showcase on Friday and invited her to stop by. Nia said yes with the speed she used for nearly every interesting opportunity.

At another table, Malik found a sign for the Heron Analytics Challenge. Fourth-down decisions. Player performance. Ticket demand. Real datasets, competitive teams, regional presentations.

He read every line twice before writing his name.

When he and Nia met again near the Copper Cup Cafe, they both had news.

"I got invited to the radio showcase," Nia said.

"I signed up for an analytics information session."

"Look at us choosing things."

"You chose six things."

"Seven, technically."

He shook his head, but his attention drifted to Julian across the room. Julian saw Nia and lifted two fingers in a casual salute. She smiled back.

Malik did not yet have a name for the small drop inside his chest. He treated it like a number too minor to enter.

Thursday, August 7: Accountability

Their final Bridge presentation returned to the budget model Malik had repaired, expanded into a scenario for a first-year student managing books, meals, transportation, and emergencies.

Malik explained the spreadsheet logic. Nia told the story of what happened when one assumption changed. They showed the original error, the revised categories, and a sensitivity table that made visible how quickly a small surprise could become a larger problem.

"A budget is not a promise that nothing will go wrong," Nia told the room. "It is a way to notice change early enough to make choices."

Malik advanced the slide. "And a model should show what it assumes, so the person using it knows when the answer no longer applies."

Dr. Brooks smiled from the back row.

Afterward, Malik and Nia carried their laptops to the Founders' Bell. The campus was copper in the late sun, and somewhere near the union a drumline practiced the same eight measures until they became part of the air.

"We work well together," Nia said.

"After arguing."

"During arguing. The arguing is part of the system."

"That sounds unhealthy."

"Only because you hate being challenged by someone delightful."

Malik leaned against the limestone arch. "We should keep each other on schedule when classes start. Weekly check-in. Assignments, deadlines, major commitments."

Nia held out her hand. "Accountability partners. Academic honesty, honest schedules, and emergency snack intervention."

"Define emergency."

"If you have to ask, you are already in one."

He shook her hand.

Then Nia mentioned that Julian had sent her the details for Friday's showcase.

"I think he might actually be asking me out," she said, trying and failing to sound casual.

Malik released her hand and adjusted the strap of his laptop bag.

"You should go," he said. His voice was kind, steady, and almost completely convincing. "You wanted to see the radio station."

Nia studied him for half a second, then smiled. "I did."

They walked away from the bell together, carrying two kinds of plans into the next week: the ones they had said aloud and the ones they had not yet admitted, even to themselves.

Week Two: The Shape of an Invitation

By Friday afternoon, Nia Reynolds had learned that the campus radio booth was much smaller than it sounded.

On air, Julian Cross's voice seemed to occupy its own weather system: warm, smooth, and confident enough to convince listeners that he had never once walked into the wrong classroom. In person, the booth on the second floor of Hart Student Union was a narrow room with two microphones, three chairs, a control board covered in glowing buttons, and a handwritten sign that said **DO NOT SPIN IN THE GOOD CHAIR**.

Julian was spinning in the good chair.

"You came," he said when Nia appeared behind the glass.

"You invited me."

"People say yes to things all the time. Showing up is the impressive part."

She liked that answer. She also suspected he knew she would.

The radio showcase gathered new students around the Media House and union booths for short demonstrations. Julian's segment was called *First Week Frequencies*, a mix of music, interviews, and confessions collected from students who were excited, lost, homesick, overdressed, underprepared, or some combination of all five.

Nia stood at the back while Julian leaned toward the microphone.

"Today's public-service announcement," he said, "is for every first-year who looked at a campus map, calculated the shortest distance between two buildings, and still arrived late because McCall-Hart added a staircase as a character-building exercise."

Nia laughed.

Then Julian continued. "In mathematical terms, the domain is the campus, the range is wherever you accidentally end up, and the function is confusion."

Nia stopped laughing.

When the music came up, she tapped on the glass.

Julian opened the door. "Good confusion joke?"

"That is not how domain and range work."

He put a hand over his heart. "I have wounded mathematics."

"Publicly."

"Can it be saved?"

Nia stepped into the booth. "Move over."

Friday, August 8: Fact-Checking the Flirt

During the next break, Nia rewrote Julian's joke on the back of a station schedule.

"The domain could be all the starting locations students choose," she explained. "The function maps each starting point to the place they reach after following your directions. The range is the set of places they actually end up."

Julian stared at the paper. "That is both more correct and less funny."

"Accuracy has a price."

"What if the function maps every student to the wrong building?"

"Then your directions are consistent, which is somehow worse."

He grinned. "There it is. That's the joke."

When the microphone went live again, Julian introduced her as "Nia Reynolds, first-year mathematical sciences major and defender of functions everywhere."

She corrected the explanation in twenty seconds, added the line about consistently bad directions, and earned a burst of laughter from the students outside the booth.

Julian watched her with open admiration.

Afterward, he walked her to the terrace. "You make ideas sound like stories."

"Ideas are stories. They have relationships, rules, and consequences."

"I might need you to fact-check the whole show."

"That sounds suspiciously like unpaid labor."

"Then I will pay in coffee."

"Copper Cup coffee?"

"I respect professionals."

Nia tried not to smile too widely and failed.

Saturday, August 9: The Test Before the Team

While Nia replayed the radio clip more times than she planned to admit, Malik sat in Porter Center for Enterprise learning that signing an interest sheet did not make him a member of Heron Analytics.

Dr. Isaac Bennett stood beside a screen displaying a football field overlaid with numbers. He was a statistics professor, actuarial adviser, and the kind of speaker who could turn a room quiet without raising his voice.

"Sports analytics is not decorating opinions with decimals," he told the group. "A model has to help someone make a decision under uncertainty. If your answer only works after the game is over, you have built a very expensive replay."

Malik sat straighter.

The competitive team studied questions such as fourth-down choices, fatigue, roster use, and attendance. Experienced students would form the core squad, but first-years could earn developmental positions through a screening test and a short explanation exercise.

Then Simone Hart took the front of the room.

She was a second-year data science and finance major with a copper clip holding back her braids and a look that suggested she had already found three flaws in everyone's assumptions.

"The screening is not a trivia contest," she said. "We need people who can calculate, interpret, and revise. If you love your first answer more than you love the evidence, this team will be uncomfortable for you."

Malik wrote that down, then immediately wondered whether writing it down was evidence that it applied to him.

After the session, he studied the sample problem taped near the exit. Simone stopped beside him.

"You have been looking at that table for four minutes," she said.

"Three and a half."

"That correction tells me more than you intended."

"The average gain is hiding the distribution."

"Good. What else?"

"Small sample. Different opponents. Unknown field position."

Simone nodded once. "Screening is the Wednesday after move-in. Bring that suspicion with you. Leave room for other people to be right."

Malik watched her go. He was not sure whether he had been encouraged or warned.

Sunday, August 10: Who Counts

The Bridge class returned to domain and range on Sunday with a scenario about a tutoring center that assigned one appointment time to each student request.

Malik defined the domain as submitted requests and the range as available appointment slots. His answer was fast, clean, and incomplete.

Nia circled the phrase *submitted requests*.

"What about students who need tutoring but cannot use the request form?"

"They are not in the domain."

"That is my point."

"It is the domain described by the problem."

"And if we report that the center served ninety percent of its domain, it sounds excellent. But maybe the form excludes students with unreliable internet, screen-reader problems, or schedules outside the listed times."

Malik rubbed his forehead. "You keep adding people the problem does not mention."

"Real life keeps doing that too."

The sentence landed harder than she meant it to.

Malik closed his notebook. "A model has boundaries. That does not make the model cruel."

"I didn't call it cruel."

"You looked at me like I was removing people from campus."

Nia crossed her arms. "And you looked at me like context was an annoying hobby."

For the rest of the exercise, their table became painfully quiet.

Dr. Brooks eventually stopped beside them. She looked at Malik's formal definition and Nia's notes in the margin.

"Both of you are protecting something useful," she said. "Malik is protecting a precise claim. Nia is protecting the difference between the observed population and the population we care about. Can your answer do both?"

Neither spoke immediately.

Then Malik reopened his notebook. "We can define the given domain and add a limitation about unobserved demand."

Nia uncrossed her arms. "And recommend more ways to request help."

"As a next step, not part of the current function."

"Fine."

They revised the answer.

Outside class, Nia bumped his shoulder. "For the record, I do not think you are cruel."

"For the record, I do not think context is a hobby."

"You think it is an aggressive side quest."

"Sometimes."

That was close enough to peace.

Monday, August 11: Saying Yes Too Fast

Julian found Nia outside Jubilee Library on Monday with a saxophone case on his back and two cold drinks in his hands.

"One is coffee," he said. "One is a science experiment pretending to be tea. Choose wisely."

She chose the tea.

"Marching Herons rehearse tonight," he said. "You should come."

"Tonight?"

"That is generally when tonight happens."

Nia checked neither her planner nor the Bridge assignment waiting in her bag.

"Yes," she said.

Julian's smile made the decision feel excellent for almost six minutes.

Then her phone reminded her about a residence-life meeting. Another notification announced a Math Circle interest session. Malik had also sent the time for their accountability check-in.

She stared at the screen.

"Problem?" Julian asked.

"No. Just a very popular evening."

"You can say no."

"I know."

But Nia had spent years believing that good opportunities were doors that might lock if she did not sprint through them. By dinner she had moved the residence meeting, skipped Math Circle, and asked Malik to push their check-in later.

His reply came quickly: **Okay. Send a time you can actually keep.**

The message was reasonable. Somehow, it irritated her.

She typed three different responses before sending: **9:30. I will keep it.**

Tuesday, August 12: Absolutely Not About Nia

Malik met his future roommate, Darius "DJ" Cole, during a residence-hall orientation on Tuesday.

DJ wore a McCall-Hart football training shirt, carried no pen, and borrowed Malik's before the first slide ended.

"You look like a man who travels with backup ink," DJ whispered.

Malik handed him a second pen.

"I knew it. We are going to thrive."

They discovered they had been assigned the same room. DJ immediately proposed putting a television on the largest wall. Malik immediately explained that the largest wall offered the best placement for two desks.

"We have not moved in and you are already taking square footage from joy," DJ said.

"A desk supports multiple activities."

"Not Madden."

After orientation, they ate at the union. Nia passed the table, waved, and hurried toward the Media House.

DJ watched Malik watch her.

"Who is that?"

"My accountability partner."

"That phrase has never sounded less academic."

"We met in Bridge. We work well together."

"You like her."

"I am interested in the Heron Analytics Challenge."

DJ blinked. "I asked about a person."

"And I answered with the thing I am interested in."

"That is the verbal version of leaving through a bathroom window."

Malik took back the spare pen. "I need this."

"Truth tax?"

"You have your own pen now."

Wednesday, August 13: Under the Sound

Marching-band rehearsal did not resemble the loose jam session Nia had imagined.

It was repetition under pressure. Musicians reset a section again and again while student leaders corrected timing, spacing, posture, and breath. The August air stayed thick even after sunset. Julian's shirt darkened with sweat, but each time the altos returned to the phrase, his sound came out clear.

Nia sat high in the empty side of Henry Boyd Stadium, watching discipline transform into spectacle one measured piece at a time.

When rehearsal ended, Julian climbed the steps and dropped beside her.

"Still think I just wander around being charming?" he asked between breaths.

"I did not say *just*."

He laughed. "Fair."

They shared fries from a paper tray while the stadium lights clicked off section by section.

Julian told her that media arts had given a name to something he had always done: notice what changed when a story was framed one way instead of another. Campus radio let him ask questions. Documentary work let him keep the answers.

"And band?" Nia asked.

He looked toward the field. "Band is where nobody cares how naturally talented you think you are. Either you hit the mark with everybody else or the whole shape bends."

That answer made her see him differently. Beneath the easy smile was someone who practiced until the public moment looked effortless.

"Why math?" he asked.

Nia told him about her aunt's tutoring program and the reports that determined whether it received support. She told him she wanted to make evidence understandable without stripping away the people inside it.

"So you want numbers to testify," Julian said.

"Exactly."

He tapped his fry against hers like a toast. "I knew you were good radio."

When he walked her back toward the residence hall, their shoulders touched twice. Neither apologized.

Thursday, August 14: Range and Limits

Nia met Malik at North Star Learning Commons the next morning, nine minutes late and still smiling about the night before.

"It felt like a date," she said before sitting down.

Malik's pencil stopped.

He could have asked whether Julian had called it a date. He could have pointed out that walking someone home and sharing fries did not constitute formal evidence. He could have done several things that would have made Nia's happiness smaller.

Instead he said, "Did you have a good time?"

"A really good time. He is different when he is working. Focused. Not fake-focused for two minutes, either."

"Then it sounds like you learned something useful."

She watched him. "You okay?"

"Yes."

It was not exactly a lie. He was healthy. Seated. Fully conscious.

Nia opened her notebook. "We can talk about something else."

"We should talk about your schedule. You moved three commitments for one invitation."

"I handled it."

"You skipped the interest session you said mattered to you."

Her smile faded. "I know what I skipped."

Malik heard the edge in her voice and stopped. This was not the moment to turn disappointment into authority.

"You're right," he said. "It is your schedule."

They completed their check-in, but the conversation never fully recovered.

That evening, Malik stayed at North Star after the tables emptied. The analytics screening test was less than a week away. He worked through probability questions, interpreting every mistake as evidence that somebody else wanted the position more.

Across campus, Nia sat on her bed and added Julian's rehearsal to her planner in copper ink. Then she moved her missed Math Circle session to a page titled **Find Another Way In**.

Two invitations had taken shape that week. One opened toward romance; the other toward competition. Both looked exciting from the outside. Neither had yet revealed what it would cost.

Week Three: Rooms, Rules, and First Impressions

Malik had drawn the room before he moved into it.

Not artistically. He had used the residence hall's posted dimensions to make a scale diagram, then tested three furniture arrangements. Layout B gave each roommate equal desk access, kept the vent unobstructed, and created a clear walking path from the door to both beds.

Layout B survived for eleven seconds.

"Television goes here," DJ announced, setting a large box directly in the planned walking path.

Behind him came two duffel bags, a laundry basket, a foam roller, three pairs of football cleats, and an auntie carrying enough snacks to provision the floor through midterms.

Malik looked from the television to his diagram.

DJ looked at the diagram. "Is that our room?"

"It was."

"Why does it look like a tiny courthouse?"

"It is to scale."

"Where is the joy to scale?"

DJ's auntie laughed, handed Malik a container of lemon cookies, and told him he was now responsible for making sure her nephew attended class. Before Malik could object, she hugged both of them and joined the stream of families filling the hall.

DJ picked up a cookie. "Congratulations. You have been hired."

"I did not accept."

"Family appointment. Very powerful."

Malik moved the television box six inches so the door could close.

Early move-in for Bridge students and athletes had begun. The rest of the first-year class would arrive Monday.

Friday, August 15: Layout B

By noon, Malik understood that sharing a room meant surrendering the fantasy that every object would remain where logic placed it.

DJ's football schedule appeared on the wall above his bed. His alarm sounded at 5:15 each morning, including Saturdays. He needed space to review film, stretch, and store team gear. He also received visitors with the casual frequency of a campaign office.

Malik needed quiet, a reliable sleep schedule, and surfaces that did not become permanent clothing habitats.

They negotiated.

"Headphones after eleven," Malik said.

"Unless it is game film."

"Game film also produces sound."

"Educational sound."

"Headphones."

DJ pointed to the empty section of floor in Malik's diagram. "Television stand here. Both desks on that wall."

"That blocks part of the window."

"Sunlight has had the planet for billions of years. It can share."

They eventually built Layout D, a compromise that existed nowhere in Malik's original file. The desks sat side by side, the television remained visible from both beds, and a narrow strip near the window became DJ's stretching area.

Malik hated how well it worked.

That evening, DJ returned from a team meeting and found labels on two shelves.

"Did you assign me storage?"

"I assigned both of us storage."

"Malik, my brother, we are going to get you through college."

"That is why I came."

DJ grinned. "See? Dry jokes. I knew you had range."

Saturday, August 16: The Six-Club Emergency

Across campus, Nia's new roommate was saving her from herself.

Keisha Morgan arrived with one suitcase, a desktop computer packed like medical equipment, and a wall calendar showing class blocks, track practices, coding time, and exactly two blank evenings each week.

Nia arrived with four bags, a plant named Katherine Johnson, and a stack of organization flyers collected at Indigo Night.

"How many of those did you join?" Keisha asked.

"Join is a strong word."

"How many gave you a signup confirmation?"

Nia counted. "Six."

Keisha held out her hand. "Phone."

"Why?"

"Because this is an intervention."

Keisha was a first-year computer science major and sprinter from Mobile. She spoke with the calm efficiency of someone who knew exactly how long 200 meters felt at full speed and had no interest in wasting energy elsewhere.

Together they reviewed Nia's list: Association for Women in Mathematics, Math Circle, service council, campus radio volunteers, residence programming board, and a general first-year leadership group.

"You also have Bridge, classes starting soon, and whatever is happening with Saxophone Man," Keisha said.

"His name is Julian."

"That sounds ongoing."

Nia moved campus radio into the maybe column. "I just do not want to miss the thing that could matter."

Keisha sat on the edge of her bed. "Everything matters to somebody. That does not make all of it yours."

The sentence quieted the room.

Nia crossed out two commitments and postponed a third. It felt less like freedom than failure.

Keisha handed back the phone. "You did not close doors. You chose which room to stand in first."

"Do you always talk like a very fast life coach?"

"Only during emergencies."

Nia looked at the reduced list. "Six clubs counts as an emergency?"

"Six clubs before classes absolutely counts."

Sunday, August 17: The Missing Riders

The Bridge capstone began with a problem that looked made for Malik.

Move-in traffic had increased wait times for McCall-Hart's campus shuttles. Student teams had to estimate demand and recommend temporary routes. The packet included residence-hall counts, parking information, shuttle capacity, and scheduled arrival windows.

Malik built a demand table. Nia sketched the campus. They had practiced combining those methods, and for the first hour they moved with satisfying speed.

Their model sent extra shuttle service to the largest residence halls during the busiest arrival windows. It minimized average wait time and stayed within the available driver hours.

"We are good," Malik said.

Nia traced the route with a copper marker. "We are suspiciously good."

During the preliminary review, another Bridge student named Tasha studied their map.

"Where is the accessible stop for Douglass Hall?" she asked.

Malik pointed to the nearest marked stop.

"That path has stairs."

He looked at the map again.

Tasha used a forearm crutch. She tapped the western side of the building. "The ramp entrance is back here. Your shuttle drops people on the opposite side."

Nia lowered the marker.

Their optimization had treated every route between a stop and a residence hall as equally usable. The average wait looked excellent because the model did not count the extra distance, slope, or barriers faced by some students.

"We did it again," Nia said quietly.

Malik knew what she meant: the food boxes, the tutoring requests, the habit of letting missing context hide outside clean columns.

"The packet did not include accessibility data," he said.

Tasha's expression changed.

Nia looked at Malik. "Then we should have asked."

He heard accusation, even though she was accusing both of them.

"We modeled the information provided."

"And called ourselves done."

Malik closed the laptop harder than necessary. "If you knew the map was incomplete, you could have said so before review."

"I didn't know either. That is the point."

They had built the best-looking first draft in the room. It was also the first draft that embarrassed them most.

Monday, August 18: Ask Before Defending

Residence halls officially opened Monday, bringing vans, trailers, grandparents, coolers, lamps, rugs, and several impossible attempts to fit queen-size mattresses into twin-size spaces.

Malik and Nia spent the busiest part of move-in outside with clipboards.

Dr. Brooks had given every team a choice: defend the assumptions in the original model or collect better information.

For once, Malik did not need long to decide.

They interviewed students, family members, drivers, and residence staff. They timed routes instead of estimating from the map. Tasha showed them the accessible entrance and identified two curb cuts that were technically present but difficult to use when unloading vehicles blocked them.

A parent pushing a cart explained that the nearest stop was not always the easiest stop. A student carrying an instrument could walk farther but boarded more slowly. A residence assistant pointed out that demand surged after families returned from shopping, not only during assigned arrival windows.

The problem became messier with every answer.

It also became real.

Back in Eliza Moss Hall, Malik added route penalties for stairs, steep slopes, and blocked access. Nia revised the campus diagram to distinguish shortest distance from usable distance. They recommended a temporary west-side stop, an accessible shuttle loop, and two flexible driver periods based on observed demand.

"Average wait goes up in our revised model," Malik said.

"Because we are counting more of the actual waiting."

He nodded. "The first number was better because it was less honest."

Nia looked at him. "Can I put that in the presentation?"

"No."

"Can I put a more professional version?"

"Yes."

She wrote: **A lower reported average can conceal unmeasured access costs.**

Malik read it twice. "That is better."

"We are better," she said.

This time, he let her celebrate.

Tuesday, August 19: Through Julian's Lens

Julian arrived at their capstone rehearsal carrying a camera and an apology.

"Campus media wants a short Bridge feature," he said. "Dr. Brooks said I could film if the team agrees. If anybody says no, the camera stays in the bag."

Malik appreciated the clarity. Nia appreciated the camera angle Julian found near the route map.

During the interview, Julian asked why their model had changed.

Nia began with the missing accessibility information, but she spoke so quickly that the answer tangled itself.

Malik stepped in. "Our first model optimized the experience we had measured. We mistook that for everyone's experience. Interviews changed the variables and the recommendation."

Julian lowered the camera slightly. "That is the line. Say it again."

Malik did, less comfortably the second time.

After filming, Julian asked Nia if she wanted to attend the Heritage Kickoff with him after the first week of classes. This time, she checked her planner.

He noticed. "Should I be nervous?"

"No. This is personal growth."

She had one evening open.

"Yes," she said. "I would like that."

Julian smiled, and the room seemed to brighten around him.

Malik pretended to adjust a chart that was already straight.

Wednesday, August 20: One Bad Question

The Heron Analytics screening test included data interpretation, probability, short calculations, and one written response about model limitations.

Malik moved confidently through the first section. He checked his units. He marked assumptions. He even forced himself to leave one question and return later instead of wrestling it into submission.

Then he reached the probability problem.

A team could choose between two fourth-down strategies under changing field conditions. Malik calculated the expected outcomes, reconsidered whether the events were independent, erased half a page, and watched twelve minutes disappear.

When time was called, his final answer sat in a box without the explanation he had meant to add.

Outside Porter Center, Simone leaned against the railing.

"How bad?" she asked.

"One probability problem."

"That was not my question."

"I may have treated dependent events as independent, corrected it, then failed to justify the correction."

"How was the rest?"

"Irrelevant if the cutoff is high."

Simone shook her head. "You are doing that thing."

"What thing?"

"Turning incomplete information into the worst available conclusion, then calling it realism."

Malik looked back through the glass doors as if the test might still be visible.

"Results come next week," she said. "Until then, you do not know."

"Uncertainty is not comforting."

"It is not supposed to be. It is supposed to be accurate."

He wanted to dislike her. Instead he stored the sentence beside all the other useful things people had said that week.

Thursday, August 21: The First Bell

Opening Convocation began under a sky the color of washed denim.

First-year students gathered at the end of Cypress Walk in academic dress clothes, fresh MHU shirts, polished shoes, and sneakers chosen by people who had correctly predicted the amount of standing involved.

Malik found DJ near the live oaks, answering messages from teammates. Nia arrived with Keisha, who had convinced her not to carry three organization folders to a ceremony. Julian stood farther ahead with campus media, filming the procession.

The four first-years joined the crowd.

DJ leaned toward Malik. "This is a lot of symbolism before breakfast."

"It is ten thirty."

"Athlete breakfast rules. I have lived two days already."

Keisha looked at Nia. "Your people are strange."

"They are growing on me."

At the signal, the Founders' Bell rang.

The sound rolled over Cypress Walk, deeper than Malik expected. Conversations stopped. Phones lowered. For a few seconds, thousands of individual worries shared one silence.

They began walking.

Nia looked toward Eliza Moss Hall, where she and Malik had met over a red number and an empty chair. DJ pointed out an upperclassman receiver he hoped to learn from. Keisha counted how many minutes remained before track paperwork. Malik noticed all of it: the different ambitions moving together, not yet coordinated but no longer separate.

At the midpoint of the walk, Julian stepped backward with his camera raised.

"First-years," he called. "Look like you know where you are going."

"Historically inaccurate," Malik said.

Nia laughed just as Julian took the picture.

The image caught them in motion: DJ pointing, Keisha half smiling, Nia turned toward Malik, Malik looking more hopeful than he felt. Behind them, indigo banners lifted in the breeze.

Classes would begin next. Julian's invitation had become a real date. Malik's analytics decision remained beyond his control. Roommate rules would be tested, schedules would collide, and the mathematics would stop waiting for them to feel ready.

But on Cypress Walk, beneath the fading echo of the bell, readiness seemed less important than movement.

They kept walking.

Week Four: The First Limit

On the first morning of Calculus I, Dr. Camille Brooks drew a graph that looked like it was lying.

The curve traveled smoothly toward an open circle at a height of four. Directly above that empty point, at the same horizontal position, sat a solid dot at seven.

Dr. Brooks placed the chalk on the tray and faced the class.

"What is the answer?"

Malik's hand rose before the final word stopped echoing.

"Seven," he said. "The filled point gives the function value."

"Correct," Dr. Brooks said.

Malik lowered his hand.

"And incomplete."

His hand stopped halfway to the desk.

Around him, the room shifted into attention. Eliza Moss Hall had traded its Bridge-program looseness for the official energy of a first college course. New notebooks lay open. Laptops glowed. Everybody had chosen a seat that might become theirs for the semester.

Nia sat beside Malik, turning a copper pen between her fingers. Two rows ahead, a quiet student named Amara Lewis studied the graph without looking up.

Dr. Brooks circled the empty point. "The function's value is seven. But what value does the graph approach?"

"Four," Nia said.

"Also correct. So which answer tells us what the function is doing?"

Malik looked from the solid dot to the open circle. He disliked questions that allowed two correct answers to stand in the same room without fighting.

Dr. Brooks smiled as if she could see the discomfort crossing his face.

"Welcome to limits," she said.

Friday, August 22: The Answer Beside the Answer

Dr. Brooks did not begin with notation. She began with approach.

She traced the graph from the left, then from the right. Students described what the outputs did as the input moved closer to the marked value. The function could be defined at seven, undefined entirely, or assigned almost anything at that single point without changing the value the surrounding graph approached.

"A limit asks about behavior nearby," Dr. Brooks said. "Not necessarily what happens at the destination itself."

Nia leaned toward Malik. "Math has trust issues."

"Math has definitions."

"Same thing with better symbols."

Malik copied the formal notation, but his attention remained on the graph. In most of his work, arriving at the answer ended the problem. Here, the course was asking him to study what happened before arrival, to separate a visible point from the pattern surrounding it.

At the end of class, Dr. Brooks assigned a short reflection: explain the difference between a function value and a limit to someone who had never taken calculus.

Malik wrote three precise sentences.

Nia drew a bus approaching a stop, then added a passenger who appeared at a completely different location.

"That is absurd," Malik said.

"That is why people will remember it."

"The passenger represents the function value?"

"Exactly. The bus approaches one place. Somebody drops the passenger somewhere weird. Related location, different story."

Malik stared at the drawing. "Your bus metaphor is mathematically reckless."

"But you understood it."

He hated when she won with evidence.

Saturday, August 23: Too Ready to Speak

Saturday's review workshop was crowded with students still deciding whether Calculus I belonged on their schedules. Add-drop week had made every seat temporary.

Dr. Brooks displayed three graphs and asked the class to compare their left-hand and right-hand behavior. When silence lasted more than two seconds, Nia filled it.

"On the first graph, both sides approach three, so the limit is three even though the point is missing. On the second, the left side approaches negative one and the right side approaches two, so the two-sided limit does not exist. And on the third--"

"Pause," Dr. Brooks said gently.

Nia stopped.

Amara's hand was halfway raised in the row ahead.

"Amara," Dr. Brooks said, "would you take the third?"

Amara explained that the graph grew without bound from one side. Her voice was soft, but her reasoning was exact. She named the one-sided behavior and carefully avoided calling infinity a function value.

"Well done," Dr. Brooks said.

Nia sank lower in her chair.

Afterward, she caught Amara near the stairs.

"I am sorry," Nia said. "I saw your hand and kept talking anyway."

Amara adjusted the strap of her bag. "You probably did not mean to."

"I didn't. But I still did it."

Amara's expression softened. "Sometimes I take longer to decide how I want to say something. By the time I am ready, the class has moved on."

Nia nodded. "Next time, I can leave some air in the room."

"You do not have to stop answering."

"Good, because that might require medical supervision."

Amara laughed.

When Nia told Keisha about it later, she expected reassurance. Keisha was lacing her running shoes and offered none.

"You apologized?"

"Yes."

"You know what to do differently?"

"Yes."

"Then do that. Guilt is not community service."

Nia threw a pillow at her. Keisha caught it without looking.

Sunday, August 24: Alternate

The Heron Analytics email arrived at 3:17 Sunday afternoon.

Malik read the subject line twice: **Fall Team Selection Decision.**

DJ sat on his bed reviewing formations on the television. "Open it before your face cracks."

Malik clicked.

The message praised his screening performance, especially his interpretation and written discussion of model limits. Due to roster capacity and his limited experience, he had been selected as an alternate. He could attend open reviews, complete practice assignments, and step into a trial if a position became available.

Alternate.

Not rejected. Not chosen.

The word occupied the most frustrating possible location between two outcomes.

"Well?" DJ asked.

"Alternate."

"Is that good?"

"It is what I expected."

DJ paused the film. "That sentence did not answer me."

"It is a reasonable placement for a first-year."

"Still not an answer."

Malik closed the laptop. "I can attend reviews."

"And you wanted the team."

"I wanted access to the work. I have access."

He repeated the same version to Nia, to his parents, and later to Dr. Bennett when he confirmed the alternate position. Each repetition became smoother.

Only Simone refused to let it pass.

"You can be disappointed and still accept the role," she told him outside Porter Center. "Those facts are not mutually exclusive."

"I am not disappointed."

"Then you are doing an incredible impression of somebody swallowing a stapler."

Malik looked away.

Simone did not press. "Open review is Monday evening. Alternates are allowed to contribute. Contribution is not the same as auditioning every second you are in the room."

He heard the warning. He immediately began planning an audition.

Monday, August 25: Useful Work

Fall classes officially began Monday, turning McCall-Hart's pathways into fast-moving rivers of students.

DJ returned from practice with two printouts and dropped them on Malik's desk.

"I need a second brain."

"What happened to the first one?"

"It has been awake since five."

The printouts showed two sets of play-call results from practice. One suggested a short route worked best from a certain formation. The other suggested it failed more often than it succeeded.

"Coach wants us to learn tendencies," DJ said. "These tables look like they are arguing."

Malik compared the labels. The first dataset included all practice repetitions. The second included only plays against the starting defense.

"Different domains," he said.

"In human language?"

"The first tells you what happened against everyone. The second tells you what happened against the strongest unit. Neither is wrong. They answer different questions."

DJ sat beside him. "So if I am trying to earn game snaps, which one matters?"

"Both. The full set shows whether the play is generally reliable. The starter set shows where the defense exposes it. We should compare the route depth and coverage too."

They worked until Malik had a small chart separating opponent unit, coverage type, and result. DJ carried it to his position meeting.

That evening, he texted: **Coach said this was useful. Do not become unbearable.**

Malik saved the message.

At analytics review, he did not lead with a grand model. He showed Simone the same comparison and explained what the data could and could not support.

"Useful," she said.

The word should have felt smaller than *selected*. It did not.

Tuesday, August 26: Define the Date

Nia met Julian at Copper Cup Cafe between classes. He had saved her a seat beside the window and ordered the iced tea she had chosen during their first coffee negotiation.

"You remembered," she said.

"I conduct interviews. Details are the whole job."

"That answer almost ruined the sweetness."

"Almost?"

"You remain under review."

They talked about first classes. Julian's documentary course had assigned a one-minute portrait without dialogue. Nia described limits with enough enthusiasm to make the people at the next table glance over.

"So the graph can be going toward one answer while the actual point is somewhere else," Julian said.

"Yes."

"That sounds emotionally dangerous."

"Calculus is full of warnings."

Julian stirred his coffee. "Speaking of clarity, I want to make sure we are describing Thursday the same way. Heritage Kickoff. You and me. A date."

Nia's smile arrived before she could manage it. "An official date?"

"Unless there is paperwork I missed."

"No paperwork. I might make a rubric."

"I am suddenly less confident."

"Good. Healthy uncertainty."

They agreed to meet outside the union after Nia finished her homework set. She entered it in her planner while Julian watched.

"Personal growth again?" he asked.

"I am becoming a woman who checks her calendar before creating problems for herself."

"I support her."

Nia liked the ease between them. She liked even more that he had called the date what it was.

Wednesday, August 27: Leave Some Air

The group limit problem began with four students and one piecewise graph.

Malik handled the algebraic simplification. Nia explained the left-hand behavior. When the group reached the right-hand limit, she looked at Amara.

"Do you want this part?"

Amara studied the expression. "Give me a second."

Nia gave her one.

Then another.

The silence felt much longer than it was. Nia resisted the itch to rescue it.

Amara pointed to the denominator. "We cannot substitute yet, but after factoring, the behavior from the right is positive. The magnitude grows because the denominator approaches zero."

Malik leaned closer. "So the one-sided limit is positive infinity, while the left is negative infinity."

"Which means the two-sided limit does not exist," Amara finished.

Their argument was complete.

When the groups presented, Malik surprised Nia by saying, "Amara should explain the final step. She caught the sign change."

Amara did.

Outside class, Nia bumped Malik's arm. "Look at you sharing airtime."

"She had the strongest explanation."

"You could let this be growth."

"I am reporting evidence."

"Growth with a clipboard. Still growth."

Thursday, August 28: What Malik Does Not Say

Nia emerged from the residence hall wearing copper earrings, an indigo top, and the expression of someone trying not to look like she had thought carefully about looking effortless.

Malik was crossing the courtyard on his way to Porter Center when he saw her.

"Too much?" she asked, turning once.

"For an outdoor event in August? Possibly."

"I meant the outfit."

He looked at her properly. "You look nice."

"Nice?"

"Very nice."

"Better."

Julian approached from Cypress Walk with his saxophone case over one shoulder. He had changed out of rehearsal clothes and carried two event passes.

"Ready?" he asked Nia.

She looked back at Malik. "Good luck at analytics review."

"Have fun."

He meant it. That was the irritating part.

Nia and Julian walked away together, their conversation easy before they reached the path. Malik stood still until DJ called from an upstairs window.

"My brother! That is what feelings look like when you refuse to process them!"

Malik looked up. "Close the window."

At Porter Center, he opened a blank project document and created a work plan for his alternate period: opponent tendency tables, fourth-down conversions, field-position splits, weather variables, player availability, model comparison, and a dashboard no one had requested.

Simone read the list over his shoulder.

"This is six weeks of work," she said.

"I can finish a first version in ten days."

"Why?"

"To contribute."

She studied him. "You are allowed to have a life outside proving you should be in this room."

Malik added a deadline beside the dashboard.

The first week of calculus had taught him that the value at a point and the behavior around it could disagree. Officially, he was an alternate. Nearby, he was working like a starter. Nia was his accountability partner. Nearby, she was walking into a new relationship.

Malik understood the mathematics.

Understanding what to do with it was another problem.

Week Five: Kickoff

The first college homework deadline arrived wearing football-weekend colors.

By Friday morning, indigo banners hung from the balconies of Hart Student Union. Copper herons appeared in shop windows across Bellwether. Alumni tents rose along Cypress Walk, and the Marching Herons rehearsed often enough that drumbeats seemed to travel through the sidewalks.

Inside North Star Learning Commons, Malik and Nia stared at Problem Twelve.

"The graph says the limit is negative infinity," Nia said.

"The graph suggests it. We still have to justify the sign."

"The function falls off the bottom of the page like it owes somebody money."

"That is not justification."

"It is visual evidence with personality."

Malik pointed to the denominator. "Approaching from the left makes this factor negative and extremely small. The numerator stays positive. Positive divided by a small negative number gives a large negative output."

Nia wrote his explanation beneath her sketch. "See? Teamwork. I provide vision. You provide bail money."

Their first limit set was due before the holiday weekend. Both had other places to be: Nia had plans with Julian around the Heritage Kickoff Classic, and Malik had an analytics data review that alternates were technically invited to observe.

Still, neither packed up when the last problem was finished.

Outside, the campus was warming into celebration. Inside, they checked each other's work one unnecessary time.

Friday, August 29: The Hour They Do Not Name

Add-drop ended Friday, making everyone's schedule feel less like a proposal and more like a contract.

Nia submitted the limit set at 2:06. Malik submitted at 2:08 after correcting a comma in his written explanation.

"We are free," Nia said.

"We have reading for Tuesday."

"You are spiritually exhausting."

They carried their bags to the terrace outside North Star. Students crossed Cypress Walk in game shirts and sundresses, greeting relatives who had returned for the weekend. The air smelled like food trucks, cut grass, and rain that had not yet decided whether to fall.

Nia's phone lit up with a message from Julian: **Band call changed. Meet tomorrow at the stadium gate? I owe you the full tour.**

She smiled, then turned the screen facedown.

"Analytics?" she asked.

"Data review at four."

"Are you presenting the enormous work plan Simone told you not to build?"

Malik looked offended. "She did not tell me not to build it."

"She called it six weeks of work."

"That was an estimate."

"Malik."

"I reduced the scope."

"To five weeks?"

He almost laughed.

For one quiet hour, they sat on the terrace and talked about everything except where they were expected next. Nia described Keisha's first track conditioning session. Malik repeated DJ's complaint that special-teams meetings involved "a disrespectful quantity of sprinting." They debated which Copper Cup pastry was least likely to collapse in a backpack.

Neither said, *I wanted this afternoon with you.*

At three thirty, Nia stood. "We should go."

"Yes."

Neither moved for another minute.

Saturday, August 30: Waiting for the Moment

Bellwether Civic Stadium, the neutral-site venue for the Heritage Kickoff Classic, filled hours before kickoff.

Indigo covered the stands. Copper flashed in pom-poms and band plumes. Alumni hugged across rows, children wore oversized heron wings, and the public-address announcer stretched every name until it sounded historic.

Julian met Nia at the gate in his Marching Herons uniform. He had ten minutes before report time and used nine of them explaining where she should sit, when the band would move, and which cues would be easy to miss.

"Watch the drum major after third down," he said. "If the defense gets a stop, we go immediately. If the offense converts, we hold."

"So the music is conditional."

"Everything is conditional."

"That is the most mathematical thing you have said voluntarily."

Julian lowered his voice. "Also, when the altos turn toward your section, I am absolutely playing to you."

"How will I know which one you are?"

He looked wounded. "Copper wrist tape. Handsome posture."

"That narrows it to at least twelve people."

He laughed and hurried toward the tunnel.

On the sideline, DJ waited.

He was dressed, taped, warmed up, and ready for a special-teams call that never came. Each time the return unit gathered, he moved closer to the coordinator. Each time, another name was called.

From the student section, Malik watched DJ bounce on his toes to stay loose. The crowd saw a player standing near the bench. Malik saw the 5:15 alarms, the route notes, the foam roller beneath the window, and the chart taped above DJ's desk.

McCall-Hart won by ten.

The stadium erupted. The band played. Nia screamed until her voice cracked and found Julian's copper wrist tape when the altos turned toward her section.

DJ celebrated with the team, helmet raised, smile visible from the stands.

Back in their room, he set the helmet on his desk and sat without turning on the light.

"You okay?" Malik asked.

"We won."

"That was not my question."

DJ gave him a tired look. "You have been waiting to use that on me."

"A little."

DJ leaned back. "I was ready. Nobody needed me to be."

Malik understood that feeling too well.

"They will," he said.

"You know that?"

"No."

DJ nodded. The honest answer helped more.

Sunday, August 31: The Tendency

Sunday's analytics review opened with game data and closed, according to the agenda, after ninety minutes.

It did not close after ninety minutes.

The team was already preparing for the next opponent. Simone assigned sections of film and data while Malik sat at the end of the table with the other alternate, listening harder than some people spoke.

One chart showed fourth-down attempts by field position. Another separated play direction. A third listed personnel groupings.

Malik noticed that the opponent's apparent aggression near midfield changed when its tight-end-heavy package entered the game. On fourth-and-short, that package strongly predicted a run to the wide side, but the tendency disappeared inside the red zone.

He checked the sample size. Small, but not useless. He checked two seasons to see whether the pattern survived. It weakened but remained visible.

The room had emptied before he finished.

Malik drafted a message to Simone, deleted it, rebuilt the chart, and drafted again.

Possible tendency, not a rule. On fourth-and-2 or less between the opponent 40 and our 35, heavy personnel has preceded a wide-side run in 8 of 10 available cases. Two clips have missing formation labels. I would use this as a film-review flag, not a standalone prediction.

He attached the chart and sent it.

Three dots appeared almost immediately.

Good limitation note. I will check it with Coach Bennett and football staff. Sleep.

Malik looked at the time. 1:14 a.m.

He closed the laptop.

Then he reopened it to make sure the attachment had been correct.

Monday, September 1: A Quiet Kind of Official

Labor Day closed the university, but nobody had informed the Marching Herons, the football staff, or the students who considered a free day an invitation to reorganize their entire lives.

Nia and Julian met near the closed radio booth after his morning rehearsal. The union was unusually quiet. Without the usual traffic, their footsteps echoed along the second-floor hall.

They had already spent Thursday evening at the kickoff festival and Saturday at the game. The date had stretched around practices and responsibilities instead of unfolding in one perfect block. Nia liked that. It felt less staged.

They walked outside to Cypress Walk, where rain from an early shower darkened the brick paths and left the leaves shining.

"Did you enjoy the game?" Julian asked.

"I understood at least forty percent more because of you."

"That is a passing grade in some departments."

"Not mine."

He smiled. "I saw you when we turned toward the student section."

"Copper wrist tape. You were right."

"About the handsome posture too?"

"The evidence was inconclusive."

They stopped near the side entrance to the union. Nia could hear the soft hum of the building's air system and a distant drumline practicing somewhere it was probably not supposed to.

Julian's confidence changed when the moment became private. He looked at her, then away, then back.

"Can I kiss you?" he asked.

Nia's heart performed something no limit law had prepared her to explain.

"Yes," she said.

The kiss was gentle, brief, and just awkward enough to be real. Julian's saxophone strap slid from his shoulder halfway through, and Nia caught the case before it hit the ground. They pulled apart laughing.

"Smooth," she said.

"The case is jealous."

When he kissed her again, they both knew where to put their hands.

Tuesday, September 2: The Trial

Malik received Simone's message Tuesday morning while DJ was searching for a clean practice shirt.

Your tendency helped staff flag the wide-side run during halftime review. They adjusted the edge alignment in the second half. Dr. Bennett approved a two-week trial seat for you. Meeting at 6.

Malik read it once.

Then twice.

"Something happen?" DJ asked from inside a pile of laundry.

"I have a trial seat."

DJ emerged holding two shirts. "On analytics?"

"Two weeks."

DJ dropped both shirts and grabbed Malik by the shoulders. "My roommate is moving up in the world!"

"Please stop shaking me."

"Did your chart help us win?"

"It helped identify one second-half adjustment. Football is not a controlled experiment."

"So yes, but nerdy."

At the meeting, Simone placed Malik between two full members instead of at the end of the table.

"A trial seat is not a reward," she said quietly. "It is more responsibility with less certainty."

"Understood."

"And you do not have to bring a new discovery every day to justify the chair."

Malik opened his notebook. "Understood."

Simone looked unconvinced.

Wednesday, September 3: The Hole in the Graph

Nia arrived at calculus on Wednesday with twelve unanswered club messages, two calendar conflicts, and the dreamy distraction of someone who had replayed a kiss often enough to edit its lighting.

Dr. Brooks gave the class a continuity problem. The function was piecewise, and students had to choose a missing constant so the graph joined without a break.

Nia understood the limit. She set the left and right expressions equal. Then she made an algebra error so basic that she did not notice it until Dr. Brooks returned the warm-up with a question mark beside the line.

"I distributed correctly," Nia whispered.

Amara leaned over. "You changed the sign here."

Nia stared at the page.

The mistake was not mysterious. It was an old weakness she had meant to review during the holiday. Instead, she had answered organization messages, adjusted volunteer schedules, helped draft a radio post, and floated through several hours thinking about Julian.

At North Star, Malik found her attacking algebra exercises with personal resentment.

"What happened?"

"I have been betrayed by negative signs."

He examined the paper. "This is review material."

"I know what it is."

He heard her tone and changed direction. "Do you want help or company?"

Nia looked up, surprised.

"Company," she said. "For ten minutes. Then help."

Malik sat across from her and opened his own work. He did not mention Julian. Nia was grateful, though she did not know whether the silence protected her or him.

Thursday, September 4: Congratulations

Nia decided Malik should hear the news from her rather than from a photo, a rumor, or DJ performing an unauthorized relationship announcement in the dining hall.

They met beside Founders' Bell after class.

"Julian and I are seeing each other," she said. "Officially, I think. We have not filed anything with the registrar."

Malik's expression barely changed, but Nia knew him well enough now to notice the small stillness in his shoulders.

"Congratulations," he said.

"Thank you."

The space after those words became delicate.

Malik could have lied brightly. He could have acted as if the news meant nothing. Instead he looked down Cypress Walk, where students moved between classes beneath the indigo banners.

"I am happy you are happy," he said. "I may also need a little time to adjust."

Nia's chest tightened. "Adjust to what?"

He met her eyes. For one dangerous second, she thought he might answer fully.

"Our schedule," he said. "You have more commitments. I have the analytics trial. We should make sure the accountability check-ins still work."

It was true. It was not the whole truth.

Nia nodded slowly. "We can move them. Not cancel them."

"Agreed."

"And you can tell me if something is weird."

Malik gave a small, tired smile. "Something is weird."

She laughed, and the tension loosened without disappearing.

That week, Nia had received the relationship she wanted. Malik had received the chance he wanted. Both discoveries carried joy. Both also came with new conditions, hidden gaps, and no guarantee that the next step would be easier than the last.

In calculus, continuity meant the pieces met.

In life, meeting was only the beginning.

Week Six: Continuity Under Pressure

Malik's first mistake as a trial member looked beautiful.

The chart used McCall-Hart indigo for successful plays, copper for failures, and pale gray for neutral outcomes. Labels aligned. Axes began at defensible values. The title stated exactly what the image claimed to show: third-down conversion rate by distance and formation.

Malik had checked every calculation twice.

He had not checked why one stretch of the season contained almost no data.

Simone enlarged the chart on the Quantitative Futures Lab screen. The team sat around the long table with laptops open and Friday-afternoon fatigue settling over the room.

"What happened here?" she asked.

Malik followed the cursor to the gap.

"Low sample size," he said.

"Why?"

"The source file has fewer tagged plays for those games."

"Why?"

He opened the raw table. Several rows included play descriptions and outcomes but no formation label. His filter had removed them automatically.

"Missing category values," he said.

"How many?"

Malik counted. The room seemed to grow quieter with each row.

"Forty-three."

Nearly one fifth of the relevant plays had disappeared from the visualization. The chart was mathematically accurate about the records it included and dangerously silent about the ones it did not.

Simone stepped away from the screen.

"Explain that to the team."

Malik wished she had yelled. Anger would have let him defend himself. Her calm left him alone with the facts.

Friday, September 5: The Missing Fifth

Malik stood beside the screen.

"I filtered out rows without formation labels," he said. "I treated the result as a complete subset instead of reporting how much information the filter removed. The conversion rates are correct for labeled plays, but the chart does not show whether the missing plays differ systematically."

Dr. Bennett folded his arms. "What could make them systematic?"

"Tagging changed between staff exports. Certain game files may be less complete. If the missing labels cluster by opponent, game situation, or personnel group, the displayed rates could be biased."

"And did you check?" Simone asked.

"No."

The word hurt more than a complicated explanation would have.

A senior team member named Andre asked whether the chart should be discarded.

Malik wanted to say no. He wanted to defend the hours behind the colors and labels.

"Not necessarily," he said. "But it cannot be used as submitted. I need to map the missing rows, recover labels from film where possible, and show uncertainty where they cannot be recovered."

Dr. Bennett nodded. "Do that."

After the meeting, Malik closed his laptop with careful hands.

Simone remained by the screen. "You think I embarrassed you."

"You asked me to explain an error in front of the team."

"Yes. Because the team might use your work. They need to know what failed and whether you understand it."

"You could have told them."

"Then they would know that I understand your mistake. The point was to find out whether you do."

Malik looked at the blank screen.

"You explained it clearly," Simone said. "Now rebuild it clearly."

That was not forgiveness. It was something more useful: another chance with conditions.

Saturday, September 6: Before the Shortcut

On Saturday, Dr. Brooks filled the board with secant lines.

She began with two points on a curve and the familiar formula for average rate of change. Then she moved one point closer to the other. The secant line shifted. The interval narrowed. The average rate approached something students recognized but had not yet been allowed to name casually.

"The derivative," someone said.

Dr. Brooks turned. "Eventually. First, tell me what has to happen."

The class worked through the difference quotient. Every time someone tried to jump to a memorized rule, Dr. Brooks returned them to the limit.

Malik's patience thinned.

"If we know the power rule is coming," he said, "why spend this long deriving it?"

Dr. Brooks rested the chalk against the board. "Because a shortcut is only trustworthy when you understand the road it shortens."

The sentence struck the sore place left by his chart.

She reduced the interval again. The secant line approached the tangent line, and average change approached instantaneous change.

"We are not plugging in zero," Nia said, thinking aloud. "We are asking what the quotient approaches as the interval becomes arbitrarily small."

"Exactly," Dr. Brooks said. "The expression at zero may be undefined while the limiting behavior gives us the rate."

Malik copied each step. His chart had offered a shortcut too: a polished picture that skipped the road from raw data to conclusion. He had trusted the destination because it looked right.

After class, Nia waited while he packed.

"You were quiet today."

"Analytics error."

"Bad?"

"Visible."

She nodded as if that answered the real question. "Want help?"

"Not with the chart."

"I can provide company first and help later. I hear that is a service we offer."

Malik smiled. "Company would be fine."

Sunday, September 7: The Choice Nobody Requested

Nia had reserved Sunday afternoon for calculus review.

At 1:40, Julian texted that the band had unexpectedly gained rehearsal time in the stadium. At 1:42, he added: **No pressure, but if you are nearby, I can see you during break.**

Nia looked at the derivative problems on her desk.

She imagined Julian alone during break, though he had not said he would be alone. She imagined him disappointed, though his message had contained no disappointment. She imagined a good girlfriend would show up.

At 1:48, she closed the book.

The stadium was hot, the rehearsal ran late, and Julian's break lasted nine minutes. He was happy to see her. He shared his water, asked about calculus, and returned to the field when the whistle blew.

Nia sat for another hour waiting for the next break that never came.

By dinner, she was behind, hungry, and irritated.

Julian met her outside the stadium. "I thought you had a study block."

"I moved it."

"You did not have to do that."

"I know."

"Then why do you sound mad at me?"

"I do not."

Julian gave her a look that made clear his audio training could detect tone.

Nia shifted her bag. "I came all the way over here and barely saw you."

"I said I had rehearsal."

"You said I could come."

"I also said no pressure."

The conversation stood at the edge of becoming an argument.

Julian lowered his voice. "I was glad you came. But I did not ask you to give up your afternoon."

Nia knew he was right, which made her feel worse.

"I need to study," she said.

"Okay."

He did not chase her. She resented that for half a block before realizing how unfair the resentment was.

Monday, September 8: Availability Is Not Affection

Keisha found Nia asleep over an open calculus book Monday morning.

"This is not studying," she said. "This is decorative unconsciousness."

Nia lifted her head. A limit expression had printed itself faintly on her cheek.

"I went to rehearsal."

"Were you performing?"

"No."

"Then why?"

Nia explained the text, the nine-minute break, and the argument that technically had not become an argument.

Keisha listened while packing her track bag.

"You volunteered your study time," she said, "then charged Julian emotionally when the thing he told you would happen happened."

"That sounds harsh."

"Do you want soft or useful? I can schedule soft tonight."

Nia dropped her face into her hands. "Useful."

Keisha sat across from her. "You keep treating availability like proof of affection. If you are always reachable, always helping, always rearranging, then nobody can say you did not care."

"I do care."

"I know. But care is not the same as having no boundaries."

Nia looked at her crowded planner. "What if I say no too often and people stop asking?"

"Then they wanted access, not you."

The answer was simple enough to frighten her.

Keisha tapped the missed study block. "Restore it. Tell Julian. Do not make it dramatic."

Nia moved the review session to Thursday evening and marked it in indigo.

"Why indigo?" Keisha asked.

"Protected time."

"Good. Now wash the equation off your face."

Tuesday, September 9: Number Thirty-Seven

McCall-Hart's first road game unfolded badly.

The offense stalled. The defense spent too long on the field. By the third quarter, the Herons trailed by thirteen and the visiting section had reduced its optimism to stubborn noise.

DJ stood near the special-teams coordinator wearing number thirty-seven, waiting through every return call.

Then a second-year player cramped after a long coverage sprint.

"Cole!" the coordinator shouted.

DJ's body moved before his fear could vote.

He ran onto the field for the kickoff. Across the formation, the returner shifted his weight. DJ remembered the film: this unit liked to create a seam behind the second blocker, then cut toward the sideline.

The ball rose beneath the stadium lights.

DJ sprinted, avoided the first block, and saw the cut before it happened. He reached the returner near the numbers and struck through the tackle exactly as coaches had drilled. The ball came loose.

For one impossible second, it rested on the turf with twenty-two people changing direction around it.

A McCall-Hart player recovered.

The visiting section erupted.

The Herons failed to turn the possession into enough points. They lost by six. There was no miracle comeback, no score that transformed the night into a clean victory.

But in the locker room, the coordinator found DJ.

"Good read. Better finish," he said. "Be ready next week."

DJ texted Malik from the bus: **WE LOST BUT I FORCED IT OUT. TELL THE ROOM I AM A COLLEGE ATHLETE NOW.**

Malik replied: **The room was already aware. Your laundry confirms it.**

Then he watched the replay link three times and smiled every time number thirty-seven crossed the screen.

Wednesday, September 10: Show the Weakness

Malik rebuilt the analytics chart from the raw data outward.

He recovered eleven formation labels from game film. He separated the remaining missing rows by opponent and date. He added a visible bar showing data completeness for each game and replaced single conversion rates with intervals where sample sizes were small.

The new chart was less beautiful.

It was also more honest.

At Wednesday's review, Malik stood beside the screen again.

"The missing labels cluster in two early exports," he explained. "That means the original omission was not random. The revised view shows observed rates, available sample sizes, and the percentage of plays with usable formation tags. Where the evidence is weak, the chart says so."

Andre asked whether the result could still guide decisions.

"It can guide what film to review," Malik said. "It should not independently determine a play call."

Simone studied the uncertainty labels. "What did you give up?"

"A simpler story."

"And what did you gain?"

Malik looked at the team. "A claim we can defend."

Dr. Bennett nodded.

After the meeting, Simone caught up with Malik on the Porter Center steps.

"That was good work."

"The first version was not."

"I am aware. I was there."

He glanced at her.

"Respect is not believing somebody never makes mistakes," she said. "It is knowing what they do after one."

Malik felt the sentence settle somewhere deeper than praise.

Thursday, September 11: Protected Time

Nia met Julian outside Bellwether Media House on Thursday with her planner in her bag and Keisha's voice in her head.

"I was unfair Sunday," she said.

Julian nodded slowly. "A little."

"You told me rehearsal might only give us a few minutes. I canceled my study block anyway, then acted like you made the choice."

"I could have been clearer about how busy it would be."

"You said 'no pressure.' That is clear in at least two languages."

He smiled, but let her continue.

"I like showing up for you," Nia said. "But I cannot organize my whole schedule around surprise rehearsal time. I have a protected study block tonight. If you get free, I am still studying."

Julian considered this for so little time that Nia wondered whether he had heard her.

"Okay," he said.

"Okay?"

"Yes. You should study. I have editing to do anyway."

"You are not upset?"

"Nia, I like you. I do not need you sitting alone in stadium seats to prove it."

She stared at him.

"What?"

"I prepared for that to be harder."

"I can argue if it helps."

"No, thank you."

Julian took her hand. "Tell me when time is protected. I will believe you. I need you to believe me when I say I am busy too."

"Deal."

At North Star that evening, Nia completed the review problems she had postponed. Malik sat two tables away, revising analytics notes. Their first calculus exam had been announced, and neither knew yet whether the lessons they had learned outside class had arrived early enough to protect their grades.

For the moment, the room was quiet.

Nia kept the time she had promised herself. Malik labeled the weakness in his model instead of hiding it. Across campus, DJ replayed his forced fumble while pretending not to.

Continuity did not mean nothing changed. It meant that when pressure arrived, the pieces still connected.

Week Seven: What the First Test Measures

By Friday night, DJ's forced fumble had acquired music.

The clip appeared on the stadium screen before McCall-Hart's home opener: number thirty-seven racing downfield, slipping past a blocker, striking the returner, and sending the football loose beneath the lights. Someone in campus media had slowed the moment of impact and added a bass drop dramatic enough to suggest DJ had saved the entire city of Bellwether.

The student section exploded.

Beside Malik, DJ's auntie screamed, "THAT IS MY BABY!" with enough force to create weather.

DJ stood on the sideline pretending not to look at the screen. The grin inside his helmet ruined the performance.

Nia waved from several rows below, where she sat near Keisha and the band section. Julian was already in formation with the Marching Herons, copper wrist tape visible beneath his glove.

Malik let the noise wash over him. For one clean moment, every difficult thing seemed to be moving in the right direction. DJ had earned recognition. Nia looked happy. Malik's corrected analytics chart had held up under team review, and Simone had asked him to attend a roster meeting Monday.

Tomorrow morning, he would take his first calculus test.

Tomorrow afternoon, analytics would review opponent data.

Both mattered. Malik had already decided he could fit them into the same day.

Friday, September 12: The Highlight

McCall-Hart won the home opener under a storm-blue sky that never released its rain.

DJ played on two coverage units. He did not force another turnover, but he stayed in his lane, beat one block, and made a tackle that drew a sharp nod from the special-teams coordinator.

After the game, students crowded around him near the tunnel.

"Number Thirty-Seven!" somebody called.

"Fumble King!"

DJ pointed at Malik. "That man charted the returner's tendencies. Academic contribution."

"I did not," Malik said.

"He keeps me humble too. Full-service roommate."

Nia and Keisha joined them. Julian had a postgame band responsibility, but he sent Nia a selfie from the field, his uniform collar open and his face shining with sweat.

"Look at him," Nia said, showing Keisha.

Keisha glanced at the screen. "Yes. That is Julian. We have confirmed his identity."

"You are no fun."

"I ran intervals this morning. I used my fun already."

DJ replayed his highlight for the group even though all of them had just watched it on a screen forty feet wide.

Malik laughed with everyone else, but his mind kept counting backward from the analytics meeting. If the calculus test began at nine, he could finish by ten fifteen, cross campus, review his notes over lunch, and arrive at Porter Center before one.

The test window lasted two hours.

Malik planned to need seventy-five minutes.

Saturday, September 13: The Time He Saves

The first page of the calculus test felt familiar.

Evaluate limits. Compare one-sided behavior. Identify discontinuities. Malik moved quickly, writing enough to satisfy himself and not enough to hear Dr. Brooks asking, *What claim are you making? What supports it?*

Halfway through, he checked the clock.

Forty-three minutes remained in the schedule he had created for himself. Ninety-eight minutes remained in the actual test window.

The next problem asked students to determine whether a two-sided limit existed and justify the conclusion from both sides. Malik wrote **DNE** and one line about unequal values.

On another problem, he used a limit law without stating why the required component limits existed.

He knew how to explain both answers. He could feel the complete arguments waiting just behind the shortened versions.

But the analytics meeting was across campus. A full roster decision might be coming. Every minute spent proving something he already knew felt like a minute taken from the opportunity he had not yet secured.

Malik turned in the test with thirty-one minutes left.

Dr. Brooks glanced at the clock, then at him. "Finished?"

"Yes."

"Or leaving?"

The question stopped him.

"Finished," he repeated.

At Porter Center, he arrived early.

The meeting did not begin for another twenty minutes.

Malik sat outside with his analytics notebook open and remembered the empty space beneath **DNE**. He told himself the answer was correct. He told himself correctness mattered most.

Then Simone arrived carrying coffee.

"You look upset."

"I am early."

"Those conditions can coexist."

He looked back at the notebook. "Test."

"How did it go?"

"Fine."

It was the first time he used the word that week.

It would not be the last.

Sunday, September 14: Borrowed Strength

Nia left the test feeling lighter than she had entered.

She had slowed down. She checked the algebra that had embarrassed her the previous week. On the final graph problem, she explained that one side approached positive infinity while the other approached negative infinity, so the two-sided limit did not exist.

The explanation sounded clear because it was clear.

It also sounded like Amara.

During Sunday's study check-in, Nia found Amara at North Star.

"I used your sign explanation on the test," Nia said.

Amara looked alarmed. "The exact answer?"

"No! Not copied. I mean the way you separated the sides before naming the two-sided limit. It helped me see what I was doing."

"Oh." Amara smiled. "Good."

"I wanted to tell you because I keep thinking about that first workshop. I was so ready to show I understood that I nearly missed the best explanation in the group."

Amara closed her notebook. "You did miss it. Then you came back."

Nia nodded. "Still embarrassing."

"Maybe. But now you listen longer."

They worked through derivative rules together. Nia talked less than usual. Amara talked more.

Later, Nia texted Malik: **How are you feeling about the test now?**

His reply came after six minutes: **Fine. Analytics meeting tomorrow.**

Nia stared at the word.

Fine was Malik's favorite locked door.

Monday, September 15: The Chair Is His

The analytics roster meeting lasted twelve minutes.

Simone sat across from Malik in the Quantitative Futures Lab. Dr. Bennett stood near the window, reading through Malik's revised chart notes one last time.

"The team has an open development seat," Simone said. "We would like you to take it for the remainder of the fall cycle. Full access, assigned deliverables, and travel eligibility if the team advances."

Malik kept his expression still. "Based on the tendency report?"

"Partly," Dr. Bennett said. "More because of the missing-data correction."

That surprised him.

Simone folded her hands. "Plenty of students can make a polished chart. Fewer can stand in front of a room, name what they did wrong, and rebuild the claim without pretending the mistake never happened."

"You will still need to manage your coursework," Dr. Bennett added. "A team seat is not permission to neglect the classes that make you useful to the team."

Malik heard the warning and thought of the test he had left early.

"Understood," he said.

Simone slid a team folder across the table. His name appeared on the roster beneath hers.

For the first time since arriving at McCall-Hart, Malik had been chosen for something he was not certain he could earn.

He called his parents from the Porter Center steps.

His mother answered on speaker. His father shouted congratulations from somewhere in the background, then asked whether analytics had benefits.

"Experience," Malik said.

"Experience is what people pay you in before money," Marcel replied.

Celeste laughed. "Let the boy enjoy it. We are proud of you."

Malik closed his eyes.

"How are classes?" she asked.

"Good."

The second lie arrived more easily.

Tuesday, September 16: Sixty-Four

DJ celebrated Malik's full roster seat with grocery-store cupcakes and a handwritten sign taped above the television: **DATA MAN HAS BEEN ACTIVATED.**

"This font is hostile," Malik said.

"This font is joy."

They ate cupcakes from paper towels while DJ replayed the forced fumble and Malik pretended he had not already memorized the clip.

Then his laptop chimed.

Calculus I: Test 1 grades posted.

Malik opened the course page.

64.

For a moment, the number did not belong to him. It looked like a score attached to somebody who had forgotten to study, somebody who guessed, somebody whose parents had not just told the whole family that he made a college analytics team.

He opened the feedback.

Two limit arguments had lost nearly all available credit because the justifications were incomplete. A continuity problem contained a sign error he would have caught if he had checked. Dr. Brooks had written one sentence at the bottom: **Your answers show more understanding than your explanations reveal. Please come to office hours.**

DJ leaned over. "What did you get?"

Malik closed the screen.

"Not what I expected."

"Bad?"

"I know what happened."

"That was also not my question."

Malik stood and began clearing the cupcake wrappers. "I rushed. I can correct it."

DJ watched him turn celebration into cleanup.

"You want me to leave it alone?"

"Yes."

DJ did, though concern stayed in the room after the questions stopped.

Wednesday, September 17: Fine

Nia caught Malik outside calculus.

"Scores posted," she said.

"I saw."

"How did you do?"

"Fine."

She searched his face. "Number fine or emotional fine?"

"I made avoidable mistakes."

"So did I. What number?"

Students moved around them toward the stairs. Dr. Brooks remained inside, beginning office hours in ten minutes.

Malik adjusted his laptop bag. "I have analytics work."

"Malik."

"It is handled."

He left before Nia could ask again.

At North Star, he opened the test correction form. It required students to identify each error, explain the corrected reasoning, and describe what habit would prevent the mistake next time.

Malik completed the mathematics quickly.

The habit question sat blank.

He knew the answer: he had treated time spent explaining as time wasted. He had valued arriving at analytics over showing what he understood. He had made a choice, not suffered an accident.

Dr. Brooks's office hours came and went.

Malik left the correction sheet beneath a stack of scrap paper and went to the lab.

Thursday, September 18: The Goal and the Bad News

Nia found the correction sheet while gathering their notes after an accountability session Malik had left early.

She saw the score before she could decide not to.

64.

Below it, Malik's corrected arguments were careful and complete. The blank reflection box looked louder than the red marks.

She found him outside Eliza Moss Hall.

"You left this," she said.

Malik saw the paper in her hand and stopped.

"You said the test was fine."

"I said I made avoidable mistakes."

"You also said fine. More than once."

"It is my grade."

"Yes. And we agreed to be honest accountability partners."

"Accountability does not mean you are entitled to every number."

Nia flinched. "I know that."

Malik heard the hurt and wanted to take the sentence back. Shame had already made it sharp.

She lowered the paper. "You trust me with goals. You tell me what you are applying for, what team you want, what you plan to become. Why do you not trust me with bad news?"

He had no answer that did not expose more than the grade.

His phone rang.

Mom.

Malik almost silenced it. Then another alert covered the screen: **Gulf Coast storm system strengthens; watches possible.**

He answered.

Celeste did not begin with hello.

"Baby, your daddy is bringing things in from the yard," she said. Wind scraped across the connection. "The forecast shifted. They are saying we could get more water than they thought."

Malik looked at Nia. The correction sheet trembled slightly in her hand.

The calculus grade, so enormous one minute earlier, became one problem among several without becoming any less real.

"Tell me exactly what the weather service said," Malik told his mother.

He opened his laptop on the limestone steps, already reaching for numbers that might make the fear obey.

Week Eight: No Model for the Storm

By Friday morning, Malik had six weather tabs open.

One showed the storm's projected path. One displayed rainfall totals. Another tracked river gauges near the Mississippi coast. Two offered different wind estimates. The final tab was a local news livestream from Gulfport, muted beneath Dr. Brooks's calculus lecture.

His mother had texted at 7:11.

Water is already gathering at the end of the street. We moved the photo boxes up. Daddy says do not worry. You know how he is.

Malik knew exactly how his father was.

Marcel Baptiste believed most problems improved when met with work boots, a good wrench, and fewer people standing around discussing them. If a storm pushed water toward the house, he would lift furniture until his back hurt. If the lights failed, he would check every breaker before admitting the outage extended beyond their walls.

On the board, Dr. Brooks differentiated a product of two functions.

"We cannot treat both factors as fixed," she said. "Each is changing, so each contributes to the rate of change."

Malik refreshed the forecast.

The projected rainfall increased by two inches.

Friday, September 19: Refresh

Nia noticed the third time Malik looked down during class.

He never looked at his phone during class. He barely approved when other people did.

"Home?" she whispered.

He nodded.

Dr. Brooks moved from the product rule to examples, but Malik's notes became fragments. He copied the derivative of the first factor, forgot the second, and refreshed the river gauge again.

After class, Nia followed him into the hall.

"What do they need?"

"Nothing yet."

"Do they have supplies?"

"Yes."

"Have they moved the car?"

"My mother did. My father says the truck is high enough."

"Is it?"

"That depends on the water."

Malik was already walking toward North Star, where he could use three screens at once. Nia kept pace.

"I can help call--"

"Please do not."

The words came out harder than he meant.

Nia stopped.

Malik turned back. "I am sorry. Everybody keeps asking what they can do. I do not have a job to assign."

"You do not have to assign me one."

"Then I need quiet."

Nia swallowed the ten responses that arrived immediately.

"Okay," she said. "Quiet."

She left him at North Star with the forecasts, the grade he had still not discussed, and a fear too large for either of them to organize.

Saturday, September 20: A Range Is Not Comfort

Dr. Bennett's Saturday colloquium had been scheduled weeks earlier. Its title, **Decisions Under Uncertainty**, now appeared designed specifically to torment Malik.

The lecture hall filled with students, faculty, and several members of Heron Analytics. On screen, Dr. Bennett displayed a storm cone.

"People often read a projected path as a promise," he said. "It is not. A forecast communicates a range of plausible outcomes based on current evidence. The center line is not destiny, and the edge is not safety."

Malik wrote down the definitions. Confidence interval. Scenario range. Conditional probability. Expected loss.

Each term gave him a more precise way to describe why he could not breathe normally.

None made breathing easier.

During questions, a student asked why forecasts changed so often.

"Because the atmosphere changes and observations improve," Dr. Bennett said. "Revision is not proof that the earlier forecast was dishonest. It is what responsible modeling looks like when new evidence arrives."

Malik thought of his family budget. His missing-data chart. His calculus score. Every model this semester had asked him to revise.

He was tired of revision. He wanted one answer to hold.

After the talk, Simone found him in the aisle.

"I can reassign your opponent-data section," she said.

"No."

"That was an offer, not a demotion."

"I can finish it."

"I did not ask whether you could."

The echo of Nia's first question at the Bridge table caught him off guard.

Simone lowered her voice. "Tell me by Sunday night. If I do not hear from you, I am dividing it. That is a team decision, not a judgment of your character."

Malik nodded, though control was the only thing he did not want divided.

Sunday, September 21: Help Without Taking Over

McCall-Hart opened a storm-relief supply table in Hart Student Union on Sunday.

Nia arrived early, created category signs, rearranged the donation bins, drafted a volunteer schedule, and began designing a tracking sheet before remembering that nobody had asked her to run the operation.

The actual coordinator, a public-health senior named Imani Cole, arrived carrying two flattened boxes.

"You must be DJ's sister," Nia said.

"And you must be the person who turned my folding table into a logistics center."

Nia looked at the labels. "Too much?"

Imani considered them. "Useful. But ask before you redesign somebody's whole system."

"That advice is following me lately."

Together they sorted batteries, cleaning supplies, shelf-stable food, work gloves, and hygiene items for affected families. Imani explained that useful relief work depended on verified requests, not on collecting whatever made donors feel generous.

Malik stopped by in the afternoon.

Nia started to tell him about the supply categories, transportation list, and emergency grant information. Then she saw his face.

"Quiet?" she asked.

"Please."

She nodded toward an empty chair behind the table.

Malik sat. Nia worked beside him without requesting updates. She handed him water once. When another student recognized his Gulfport hometown and began asking questions, Nia redirected the student toward the volunteer signup.

After twenty minutes, Malik stood.

"Thank you," he said.

"I did nothing."

"Exactly."

Nia watched him leave and understood, perhaps for the first time, that care did not always need to become visible labor.

Monday, September 22: Verified

Julian canceled his usual music segment Monday evening.

Instead, campus radio carried storm updates, university support information, and interviews with staff coordinating student assistance. Julian repeated only details confirmed through official sources and corrected one rumor about mandatory evacuations before it could spread across residence-hall group chats.

Nia sat behind the booth glass, watching him work.

His public confidence had changed shape. He did not joke to fill every pause. He checked names, links, and times before speaking. When a caller began describing frightening footage from an unknown account, Julian interrupted gently.

"I hear why that worried you," he said. "We cannot verify that video, so we are not going to tell listeners it shows the current conditions. Let me give you the confirmed update we have."

During a break, Nia entered the booth.

"You are good at this."

Julian removed one headphone. "I am trying to be careful."

"That is what I mean."

He looked through the glass toward the students waiting with resource sheets. "Media can make fear move faster than weather. If we add to it, we need to know why."

Nia thought of Malik refreshing forecasts, trying to separate probability from panic.

"Can you share the supply-drive hours again?" she asked.

"Already in the next block."

He took her hand for three seconds beneath the desk, then returned to the microphone.

Nia had liked Julian when he made a room brighter. That evening, she admired him for refusing to make a crisis about his own voice.

Tuesday, September 23: The Call

The storm crossed the coast before dawn.

Malik slept in intervals of twelve and seventeen minutes, waking each time his phone vibrated. At 5:36, Celeste reported water at the front steps. At 6:02, it entered the utility room. At 6:19, the power failed.

Then messages stopped.

Malik called his mother. No connection.

He called his father. Voicemail.

He called the neighbor across the street. Nothing.

By eight, water had flooded the lower rooms of the Baptiste home.

At 10:14, Celeste finally reached him from a relative's phone.

"We are safe," she said before he could speak. "We got to Aunt Renee's. Micah is with us."

Micah, Malik's twelve-year-old cousin, spent most afternoons and many weekends at the Baptiste house. His school backpack and the game system he had saved for all summer were still there.

"Where is Daddy?" Malik asked.

Silence.

"Mom."

"He went back when the water started dropping. He wanted to move the shop equipment before more rain. Something slipped. He cut his leg bad and twisted his knee. Mr. Landry took him to urgent care."

Malik stood so quickly his desk chair struck the wall.

DJ sat up in bed. "What happened?"

Celeste continued talking: stitches, imaging, no fracture visible, more evaluation needed. Malik wrote every detail on the back of an analytics printout because it was the closest paper within reach.

"Why did he go back?" he demanded.

"Because that equipment is how he works."

"He cannot work if he cannot walk."

His mother went quiet.

Malik pressed his hand over his eyes. "I am sorry. I am sorry. Tell him I am coming home."

"We do not even know which roads are open."

"I will find one."

The same instinct that had built budgets and charts now seized on bus routes, rental cars, airport schedules, and road closures. If he could arrange transportation, perhaps the rest of the disaster would become a list.

It did not.

Wednesday, September 24: The Quiz He Misses

Malik was still trying to get home when his calculus quiz began.

The earliest bus had been canceled. The next route required two transfers and ended far from Gulfport. Flights cost more than his family had available. A rideshare estimate looked almost insulting.

At 9:10, Nia texted: **Are you coming to class?**

He typed **Yes**, deleted it, and called Dr. Brooks.

She answered from her office.

"Malik?"

For several seconds, he could not force the situation into an orderly sentence.

"The storm flooded our house," he said. "My father was injured during cleanup. I am trying to get to Gulfport. I missed the quiz."

"Are your family members safe now?"

"Yes. My father has stitches and a knee injury. They are staying with my aunt."

"All right. The quiz is not today's emergency."

"I can take it online."

"No. You can document the absence when you have access to the records. We will arrange make-up work after you know your travel plan."

"I already have a sixty-four on the test."

The confession escaped before he could stop it.

Dr. Brooks's voice remained steady. "Which is why I invited you to office hours. We will address that grade. It is not improved by pretending your family crisis is a normal study day."

Malik sat on the edge of his bed.

"I should have come," he said.

"Yes," she replied, without pretending otherwise. "And you called today. That matters."

After they hung up, Malik emailed documentation requests, notified Dr. Bennett, and accepted that the team would redistribute his work.

The list did not make him calm.

It gave him somewhere to begin.

Thursday, September 25: The Station

Nia found a bus route leaving Montgomery late Thursday and connecting toward the coast. DJ borrowed his sister's car to get Malik to the station.

The three of them drove through Bellwether beneath a sky scrubbed clear after days of threat. The normal weather felt rude.

Malik carried one backpack. Nia had packed snacks. DJ had packed twice as many snacks and called them "infrastructure."

At the station, announcements cracked through tired speakers. Families clustered around charging outlets. A television above the ticket counter showed aerial footage of flooded neighborhoods.

Malik kept his eyes off the screen.

"Simone said the team has your work," DJ told him. "Dr. Brooks knows. I have the room."

"Do not touch the folders on my desk."

"I will guard them with my life."

Nia held out the bag of food. "You do not have to text updates. But if you want to, I will answer."

Malik took the bag. "Thank you."

His bus had not yet arrived. The waiting made every thought louder.

"My mom says they are safe," he said. "My father says his knee is fine, which means it is not."

DJ nodded.

"I keep looking at flood estimates," Malik continued. "But I do not know how high the water got inside. I do not know what insurance will cover. I do not know whether his equipment works."

He looked at Nia then, letting her see the fear without turning it into a question she had to solve.

"I do not know what they will come back to."

Nia's eyes filled, but she did not promise everything would be all right.

"You will not face it by yourself," she said.

The bus pulled beneath the station lights.

Malik hugged DJ first, quick and hard. When Nia stepped forward, he hesitated only a moment before holding her too.

Then he boarded with no model for the house waiting at the other end.

Week Nine: What Water Takes

The house smelled wrong.

Malik noticed it before he saw the waterline. The air held mud, wet wood, spoiled food, cleaning chemicals, and the sour beginning of mold. It did not smell like the lemon oil his mother used on Saturdays or the pepper and onions his father cooked into nearly every breakfast. It did not smell like home.

A brown line crossed the walls of the lower rooms, marking how high the water had risen. Cabinet doors hung open. The living-room rug had been dragged into the yard, where it lay folded over itself like something exhausted. Marcel's tools rested on towels across Aunt Renee's garage, separated into piles labeled **DRY**, **CLEAN**, and **MAYBE**.

Malik stood in the doorway with his backpack still on.

His mother came from the hall wearing rubber boots and work gloves.

"Baby."

She hugged him carefully, though she was not the one injured.

Behind her, Marcel sat in a dining chair with his left leg braced and elevated on a plastic storage bin. A bandage covered the cut along his shin. He lifted one hand.

"You came all this way to inspect my bad decisions?"

Malik dropped his backpack. "I can start with the knee."

His father smiled, but pain tightened the corners of his mouth.

Nothing in Malik's forecasts had prepared him for that expression.

Friday, September 26: The Inventory

Insurance required an inventory.

Malik built one at the dining table while relatives and neighbors moved through the house in boots and masks. He listed the couch, two bookcases, kitchen cabinets, small appliances, Marcel's damaged equipment, and boxes of documents stored too close to the floor.

Each line needed a description, estimated age, estimated value, and evidence if available.

The work should have suited him.

Instead, every item resisted becoming a number.

The couch was where Micah slept during movie nights. One bookcase had belonged to Malik's grandmother. A ruined plastic bin held old school records, childhood drawings, honor-roll certificates, and the program from Malik's high school graduation.

Celeste lifted damp papers one by one and placed them between towels.

"Take pictures before we throw anything away," Malik said.

"I know."

"The policy may require--"

"Malik." His mother's voice was tired, not angry. "I know."

He stopped.

Across the room, Marcel tried to stand without help. His injured leg buckled, and he caught the chair back.

Malik moved toward him.

"I have it," Marcel said.

"You almost fell."

"Almost is not fell."

"That is not how risk works."

His father gave a humorless laugh. "Do not bring college words into my kitchen."

The kitchen floor squished beneath his crutch.

Malik looked down.

Marcel did too. Some of the fight left his face.

"Help me to the porch," he said.

It was the first task Malik completed all day that felt entirely useful.

Saturday, September 27: The Rate of Rising Water

Dr. Brooks had sent a make-up packet with flexible dates and a note: **Complete only what you can document time for. Family recovery comes first. Communication keeps options open.**

One assignment covered related rates.

Water poured into a cylindrical tank. Its depth increased at a known rate. Students had to determine how quickly the volume changed.

Malik stared at the problem from Aunt Renee's kitchen table.

He wanted to close the laptop.

Outside, waterlogged furniture lined the curbs. Inside, a textbook had invented polite water that entered a perfect container at a steady rate and damaged nothing.

Micah climbed into the chair beside him. The twelve-year-old had been quieter than usual since the storm. He wore somebody else's slides because his sneakers were still inside a ruined closet.

"Is that flood math?" he asked.

"Tank math."

"Same water."

"Different problem."

Micah looked toward the room where Celeste was speaking with the insurance company. "How fast did the water come in our house?"

Malik began to say they did not have enough information. Then he remembered his mother's texts.

At 5:36, water was at the steps. At 6:02, it reached the utility room. At 6:19, the power failed after water moved farther inside. They had approximate depths from marks on the walls and videos from a neighbor.

Malik drew the house footprint on paper.

"If we estimate how much floor area the water covered," he explained, "and how the depth changed over time, we can estimate how quickly the amount of water inside was growing."

"Can we find when it got to my game?"

The console had been on a low shelf.

Malik swallowed. "Probably within a range. Not an exact minute."

Together they marked times and estimated depths. The numbers suggested the worst increase came after water crossed the threshold, when a small rise outside spread across a large indoor area.

"So it got deep fast," Micah said.

"Yes."

"Could we have moved more stuff?"

Malik heard the real question.

"Maybe a few things," he said. "But nobody should have stayed inside trying to beat the water. Things can be replaced. You cannot."

Micah traced the line representing the wall. "Even the game?"

"Even the game."

The textbook problem still felt cruel. But the mathematics gave Micah a way to ask what had happened, and Malik a way to answer without pretending the loss had been preventable.

Sunday, September 28: Divided Work

Simone called Sunday afternoon.

Malik stepped onto Aunt Renee's porch, where an extension cord ran from a neighbor's generator and three pairs of cleaned work gloves dried on the rail.

"How is your father?" she asked.

"The knee is badly sprained. The cut needed stitches. He has an orthopedic appointment."

"And the house?"

Malik looked across the street at debris piled along the curb. "Not livable yet."

Simone let the answer stand.

"I divided your analytics section," she said. "Andre has formation tagging. Priya has game-state splits. I am handling the uncertainty notes."

Malik's grip tightened on the phone. "I can work tonight."

"No."

"The deadline did not change because of me."

"Correct. That is why the team adjusted."

"I should at least review the final version."

"When you return, if there is time."

He paced to the end of the porch. "It was my section."

"It was the team's section assigned to you."

The distinction irritated him because it was true.

Simone's voice softened. "Nobody is punishing you. Nobody thinks you disappeared because you are unreliable. We are doing what a team is supposed to do when one person's life catches fire. Or floods. You know what I mean."

Malik looked through the screen door. His father struggled to adjust the brace without asking for help.

"Thank you," he said.

After the call, he opened the shared folder anyway. Andre had already improved the tagging notes. Priya had found a useful game-state split Malik had missed.

Relief and jealousy arrived together.

The work could continue without him.

That was the point of a team. It was also, at that moment, the part he found hardest to accept.

Monday, September 29: Official

At McCall-Hart, Founders' Cup week opened with a short ceremony near Founders' Bell. Alumni representatives spoke about the university's history, student leaders announced service projects, and the Marching Herons formed an indigo-and-copper line along Cypress Walk.

Nia stood with Keisha near the limestone arch. She had checked her phone twice for an update from Malik and stopped herself from checking a third time.

Julian found her after the ceremony.

"Walk with me?"

They moved away from the crowd, though not far enough to escape the bell's shadow.

Julian had been thoughtful all week: sharing verified resources on air, helping publicize the supply drive, and asking about Malik without behaving as if concern made him part of a competition.

"I have a question," he said.

"Math or media?"

"Relationship administration."

"Very serious department."

Julian smiled, then became nervous enough that Nia stopped joking.

"We have been seeing each other," he said. "I would like to call you my girlfriend. I would like to be your boyfriend. Not because a label makes everything different, but because I do not want to act casual about something that is not casual to me."

Nia looked at him beneath the old bell, surrounded by students beginning traditions they did not yet fully understand.

"Yes," she said. "I want that too."

Julian exhaled. "Good. I had a whole second speech if you asked for time."

"Was it better?"

"Much worse."

She laughed and kissed him.

Later, Nia sent Malik a photo of the supply shipment leaving campus, not a relationship announcement. It did not feel like the moment to add another emotion to his week.

She told herself she would explain when he came back.

Tuesday, September 30: Three Catches

The Founders' Cup game gave DJ his first real opportunity on offense.

An upperclassman receiver left in the second quarter with a shoulder injury. DJ heard his name and ran into the huddle before anybody could reconsider.

His first target came on third-and-seven. The pass arrived high and behind him. DJ twisted, caught it against his shoulder, and took a hit before securing the ball.

First down.

The second catch required him to drag both feet near the sideline. The third came across the middle with a safety closing fast.

Three difficult catches. Thirty-eight yards. No touchdown, no viral miracle, but enough reliable work to keep him on the field during the fourth-quarter drive that sealed McCall-Hart's win.

Nia, Keisha, and Imani celebrated in the stands. Julian played with the band, turning toward Nia's section after every scoring drive. Malik watched the game on Aunt Renee's television with Micah asleep on the couch and Marcel's injured leg elevated beside him.

When DJ made the sideline catch, Marcel pointed at the screen.

"That is your roommate?"

"Yes."

"Boy has hands."

Malik texted DJ: **Three catches. One missed blocking assignment in Q3. Good work.**

DJ replied after the game: **I LOVE YOU TOO, DATA MAN.**

Malik smiled at the phone.

For the first time since arriving home, campus felt connected to him rather than impossibly far away.

Wednesday, October 1: Emergency Aid

Malik returned to Bellwether Wednesday morning carrying photographs, medical paperwork, repair estimates, and a new understanding of how quickly a family could become a file.

His emergency financial-aid appointment took place at Porter Center. The counselor reviewed temporary assistance, documentation requirements, meal support, and a possible adjustment while his father's income was interrupted.

"Some funds are limited," she said. "I do not want to promise an amount before review."

Malik appreciated the honest uncertainty and hated needing it.

He submitted copies of the urgent-care bill and storm-damage report. He asked about campus employment.

"There may be evening hours at North Star Learning Commons," the counselor said. "Desk support, equipment checkout, and closing tasks. It will compete with study time."

"I can manage it."

The answer came automatically.

That afternoon, Malik completed the job application. He listed his Bridge experience, technical skills, and availability after classes. He did not list analytics meetings until the form forced him to.

At the bottom, a question asked why he wanted the position.

He typed: **To support student access to academic resources while developing professional experience.**

Then he deleted it.

He wrote: **My family experienced storm damage and a temporary loss of income. I need evening work that can fit around my courses.**

The second answer felt exposed.

He submitted it anyway.

Thursday, October 2: What He Does Not Hand Her

Malik saw Nia and Julian outside Hart Student Union.

They were holding hands. Not accidentally, not tentatively. Julian said something that made Nia lean into his shoulder, and the happiness on her face was familiar enough to hurt.

Nia noticed Malik first.

Her smile changed. "You're back."

She released Julian's hand and stepped forward, then seemed unsure whether to hug him.

Malik solved the uncertainty by hugging her.

"How is your family?" she asked.

"Safe. My father has more appointments. The house needs a lot of work."

"I am sorry."

"The supply shipment arrived. My mother saw the McCall-Hart labels. She told me to thank everybody."

Julian offered his hand. Malik shook it.

"The station is still sharing recovery resources," Julian said. "If your family has a verified fundraiser or community drive, send it to me. No promises, but I can take it through review."

"Thank you."

The three of them stood in a small triangle of things not yet said.

Nia drew a breath. "Julian and I made it official Monday. I wanted to tell you myself, but you were dealing with--"

"Congratulations," Malik said.

This time, the word cost more. It was also true.

"Are you okay?" she asked.

No. His father's work had stopped. The insurance claim had barely begun. He had make-up calculus assignments, a sixty-four, a job application, and analytics work now improved by other people. He had returned to find the person he wanted holding hands with someone who had shown up responsibly during a crisis.

Malik could have placed all of that in Nia's arms and waited to see what she did with it.

"I am glad you told me," he said instead. "I need to meet Dr. Brooks before class. We can talk later."

Nia studied him. "Do not disappear."

"I will not."

He walked toward Eliza Moss Hall.

The promise was harder than it sounded. Malik's instinct was to hide until the grade improved, the job was secured, the house was repaired, and wanting Nia no longer made him feel disloyal to a friendship he valued.

But water had already shown him what waiting could take.

This time, he entered Dr. Brooks's office with the bad news still visible.

Week Ten: The Cost of Looking Fine

Malik's new job began at the exact place where he was supposed to study.

At six Friday evening, he sat behind the welcome desk at North Star Learning Commons wearing a temporary name badge and learning the checkout system for calculators, laptop chargers, whiteboard kits, and small study rooms. Students passed him carrying calculus books, coffee, and the unmistakable panic of deadlines that had been reasonable until they became tonight's problem.

His supervisor, Ms. Alvarez, showed him the closing checklist.

"Last reservation ends at ten thirty. We close at eleven. You wipe the boards, check equipment, reset the rooms, and call campus safety if anybody refuses to leave."

"Does that happen often?"

"Around finals, students try to claim squatter's rights."

Malik smiled.

The shift fit the availability he had submitted. Friday and two weeknights, mostly after classes and analytics. It offered enough hours to send something home without losing every study block.

That was the model.

The model assumed no delayed buses, family calls, make-up assignments, team emergencies, or human need for sleep.

Malik did not write those limitations down.

Friday, October 3: Closing Time

The first shift was quiet until nine, then every group room filled at once.

Malik found a missing calculator, reset a student's password request through the proper office, and explained three times that North Star loaned chargers but did not possess magical replacements for unfinished essays.

At ten fifty-eight, the final students left.

Malik completed the closing checklist, clocked out, and chose a table near the darkened tutoring boards. His linear approximation assignment was due Saturday. He only needed to finish four problems.

The first asked him to estimate a square root using a nearby value and a tangent-line approximation.

He wrote the function, chose the convenient point, calculated the derivative, and rested his forehead on one hand.

His phone showed two messages from Celeste about an insurance adjuster's request and one from Simone asking for a model update by noon.

Malik answered all three.

Then he returned to the tangent line.

At 12:43, Ms. Alvarez found him asleep over the problem while returning for the keys she had left in her office.

"Malik."

He woke so quickly his pencil rolled to the floor.

"The building is closed," she said.

"I work here."

"You worked here. Past tense. Now you are unconscious furniture."

He packed his bag, embarrassed.

Outside, Bellwether's night air felt cooler than it had all semester. Malik walked back to the residence hall telling himself the first shift was an adjustment.

He did not change the next shift on his calendar.

Saturday, October 4: The Narrow Story

The analytics model checkpoint focused on late-game fourth-down decisions.

Malik had built a forecast using field position, yards to gain, score difference, time remaining, and recent opponent tendencies. The main visualization produced one clean recommendation for each scenario: attempt, punt, or kick.

It looked decisive.

Simone studied the screen. "Where is the uncertainty?"

"In the appendix."

"Put it here."

Malik opened a second chart. The recommendation changed across a wide interval when the sample was small or when assumptions about possession value shifted.

Andre leaned back. "So the main chart says go for it, but the range says all three options may be defensible."

"Under certain parameter choices," Malik said.

"How certain are those choices?" Simone asked.

"They use league averages."

"That was not my question."

Malik felt heat rise beneath his collar. "The single recommendation is easier for staff to interpret."

"Easy is not the same as useful."

"If we present every interval, the model looks indecisive."

Simone turned from the screen. "The model *is* uncertain. You are asking the colors to hide that."

The room went still.

Malik heard another meaning beneath her words, though she had not put it there. His family was safe. His job was manageable. His calculus recovery was underway. His analytics work remained on schedule. Every statement was technically defensible if nobody asked for the intervals.

"I will not present the main chart like this," Simone said. "Revise it."

Malik closed the file. "Understood."

He did understand.

He also resented her for making the weakness visible again.

Sunday, October 5: Two Promises, One Evening

Julian's media showcase had been on Nia's calendar for three weeks.

His documentary class would screen one-minute student portraits at Bellwether Media House on Tuesday. Julian had filmed an elderly barber describing the first haircut he gave after returning from military service, all without spoken narration. He had shown Nia an early cut and asked her to attend the final screening.

"Front row?" he asked Sunday over lunch.

"Front row," she promised.

Two hours later, an Association for Women in Mathematics group chat began filling with panic about Monday's applications exam. The student scheduled to lead the review had lost her voice. Nia knew the material better than most of the first-years and had already made visual notes.

Can anyone cover Tuesday at six?

The showcase began at six thirty.

Nia typed **I can do 5:00-6:00**, then stared at the message. If the review ran on time, she could cross campus in fifteen minutes. If students had questions, she could still leave. Somebody else could close.

She sent it.

Within minutes, a flyer appeared in the group chat: **CALCULUS APPLICATIONS EXAM RESCUE REVIEW, TUESDAY 5-6:30, LED BY NIA REYNOLDS.**

"Six thirty?" Nia whispered.

She messaged the organizer to correct the time, but the flyer had already been reposted by two student accounts.

Nia considered telling Julian.

Instead, she decided she would make both.

It did not feel like lying. It felt like optimism with a tight schedule.

Monday, October 6: The Missing Sentence

The applications exam began after Malik's father called at 12:08 a.m.

Marcel could not sleep. The knee brace rubbed against his stitches, the insurance adjuster had questioned part of the equipment claim, and he wanted to know whether Malik remembered where a receipt folder had been stored.

They talked until one twenty.

Malik studied until two fifteen because stopping felt like letting the call take something else.

On the exam, he handled basic derivatives correctly. Then he reached a linearization question asking him to explain why the approximation should be accurate near the chosen point.

He had practiced the justification: differentiability gives a locally linear model; error generally grows as the input moves farther from the center; the estimate should be evaluated within a reasonable neighborhood.

The words would not arrive.

Malik wrote, **Because the tangent line is close to the function**, then stared at the sentence. Close where? Under what conditions? How did he know?

He could see Dr. Brooks's likely comments before she wrote them.

Across the room, Nia worked steadily. Amara paused over one problem, then continued. The clock moved with cruel consistency.

Malik added a diagram and an incomplete error statement before time was called.

Outside, Nia asked, "How was it?"

He nearly said fine.

"I could not retrieve one justification," he said.

It was a small truth, but at least it was not the locked door.

Tuesday, October 7: The Flyer

Julian discovered Nia's schedule conflict on a poster outside the union.

His own girlfriend's name appeared in large copper letters beneath **EXAM RESCUE REVIEW**. The end time matched the beginning of the media showcase.

He photographed the flyer and sent it to her with one question: **When were you planning to tell me?**

Nia called immediately.

"The time is wrong," she said.

"So you are not leading it?"

"I am, but only until six."

"The showcase starts at six thirty."

"I can make it."

"That is not what I asked."

Nia looked around the North Star lobby, lowering her voice. "I was going to tell you."

"Before or after I saved you a seat?"

The question felt sharper because she had promised the front row.

"Students need help," she said.

"I am not asking you to abandon them. I am asking why I keep learning your choices after everybody else."

"This is not like rehearsal."

"No. At rehearsal you rearranged your life without telling me. Here you rearranged our plans without telling me. Different direction, same surprise."

Nia's instinct was to list the ways she could still make everything work. Instead she looked at the students beginning to gather.

"You are right," she said. "I should have told you Sunday."

Julian was quiet.

"I will be there," she added.

"I hope so."

The review ended at 6:12. Three students still had questions. Nia handed them to another volunteer and ran across campus.

She entered the showcase as Julian's film ended.

He saw her in the doorway.

The empty front-row seat saw her too.

Wednesday, October 8: No Rescue Plan

Malik brought the first test, the make-up packet, and his unfinished correction form to Nia.

They sat on a bench behind Jubilee Library, away from the students preparing Cypress Week decorations.

"I got a sixty-four," he said.

"I know. I saw the sheet."

"I have not finished the make-up work. I missed office hours before the storm. After I came back, I told Dr. Brooks about the travel and documentation, but not how far behind I already was."

Nia waited.

Malik had expected questions, schedules, and possibly a color-coded emergency plan.

"That is all?" he asked.

"Do you want me to say something?"

"You usually do."

"I am practicing not turning every hard thing into my assignment."

He looked at the test in his hands. "I rushed because of analytics. Then I hid the score because my parents had just celebrated the roster seat."

"That sounds lonely."

"It was avoidable."

"Those can both be true."

Nia did not tell him whom to email. She did not open her planner. She listened while he explained the midnight calls, the job hours, and the model revision Simone had refused to present.

When he finished, she asked, "What truth have you not told Dr. Brooks yet?"

Malik knew.

"That I cannot do all of it at the level I keep promising."

Thursday, October 9: Reduced

Dr. Brooks listened without interrupting.

Malik told her about leaving the first test early, missing office hours, the make-up work, North Star shifts, analytics deadlines, and family calls that he kept treating as interruptions rather than part of his actual life.

"What are you asking for?" she said.

Malik had prepared requests for more time. Instead he said, "Help deciding what has to change."

Together they built a documented recovery plan: complete corrections, attend weekly office hours, use one North Star shift break only for food and rest, and schedule make-up work in pieces rather than one impossible weekend.

Then Malik met Dr. Bennett and Simone.

"I need a reduced role until my calculus work stabilizes," he said.

The sentence felt like stepping away from the chair he had fought to earn.

Dr. Bennett nodded. "What can you responsibly own?"

They moved Malik from primary model development to data validation and one smaller decision module. He would remain on the roster but lose some presentation responsibility at the checkpoint.

Simone updated the task board.

"You are not being removed," she said.

"It feels like going backward."

"Sometimes going backward is how you stop walking over a cliff."

Malik looked at the reduced assignment beside his name.

It was not the plan he wanted.

For the first time in weeks, it was a plan that might be true.

Week Eleven: Cypress Week

Cypress Week arrived with a parade banner, three drumlines, seven group chats, and the collective belief that sleep was an event for less spirited universities.

By Friday morning, McCall-Hart had transformed. Indigo and copper ribbons wrapped the lampposts. Alumni posed beneath Founders' Bell. Food vendors lined the edge of Cypress Walk, and every open patch of grass seemed occupied by a service project, reunion tent, dance rehearsal, radio interview, or student selling a shirt that would become vintage as soon as the week ended.

Nia stood outside Hart Student Union studying the official schedule.

Homecoming service day offered five projects: packing pantry boxes, cleaning a river trail, tutoring middle-school students, assembling hygiene kits, and recording oral histories with alumni.

She wanted all five.

Keisha appeared beside her in track warmups. "Choose one."

"I have not said anything."

"Your face signed up for everything."

Nia pointed to the math outreach project. "One. I am choosing one."

"Proud of you."

"That sounded sarcastic."

"It was seventy percent sincere."

Nia wrote the service block in her planner and drew a neat boundary around it. She believed, with the confidence of someone learning the first layer of a lesson, that her overcommitment problem had been solved.

Friday, October 10: One Project

The math outreach group met at North Star to build game kits for Bellwether middle-school programs.

Nia helped design a coordinate-grid treasure hunt. Students would plot points, solve clues, and uncover a final message. She tested the game with volunteers, caught two ambiguous directions, and resisted joining the neighboring hygiene-kit line when they fell behind.

"Look at me," she told Keisha. "Staying in my lane."

"It has been forty minutes."

"Growth deserves witnesses."

Julian stopped by with a camera crew to collect footage for the homecoming recap. He filmed Nia explaining the game and asked her to hold up the finished kit.

"Perfect," he said after the take.

"Do you have time to eat?"

"Later. Band rehearsal, alumni interview, media check-in, then step-show coverage."

"That is four things."

"Homecoming rules."

Nia started to warn him about overcommitment, then remembered the shape of her own planner.

"We still have Sunday evening?" she asked.

Julian checked his phone. "Absolutely. Seven o'clock. Just us."

He kissed her cheek and hurried toward the next event.

Nia returned to her one project feeling disciplined.

She did not notice that Julian's schedule had become the thing she was trying to manage next.

Saturday, October 11: Maximum Revenue

Saturday's calculus workshop asked students to design the most profitable homecoming T-shirt order under production limits.

The selling price depended on demand. Printing had a fixed setup cost and a per-shirt cost. Storage space limited the maximum order. Students had to build a revenue function, subtract costs, find critical points, and test the feasible endpoints.

"Finally," Malik said, "a problem willing to identify its constraints."

Nia looked at him. "Was that a joke about our lives?"

"It was a statement about shirts."

"Sure."

With his analytics role reduced and his first make-up block complete, Malik had slept seven hours. The difference showed. He organized the variables, found the derivative, and paused before declaring the critical point optimal.

"We have to test the boundary," he said. "The unconstrained maximum may require more shirts than storage allows."

Amara checked the endpoint values. Nia sketched the profit curve. Their feasible maximum occurred at the storage limit, not at the theoretical peak.

Dr. Brooks asked Malik to explain.

"Optimization does not mean finding the biggest possible value in an imaginary world," he said. "It means finding the best defensible value inside the actual constraints."

The class was quiet for half a beat.

Nia raised one eyebrow. "Still only talking about shirts?"

Malik smiled. "Mostly."

The problem gave him something his real life had refused to offer: boundaries printed clearly enough to respect.

Sunday, October 12: Homecoming Rules

Sunday evening belonged to Nia and Julian.

At 6:22, Julian texted that an alumni interview was running late. At 6:48, he said the band had added a staging rehearsal. At 7:09, campus media needed him to approve audio before a post went live.

Can we make it eight? he asked.

Nia agreed.

At 8:17, she sat alone at Copper Cup with two teas growing watery on the table.

Julian arrived at 8:31 wearing a media credential around his neck and carrying his saxophone case.

"I am sorry," he said, dropping into the chair. "This week is eating me alive."

"You said seven."

"I know."

His phone buzzed. He looked down automatically.

Nia moved the second tea toward him. "Are you here?"

"I am sitting in front of you."

"That was not my question."

Julian put the phone facedown. "Five minutes. I need to answer one production message after that."

Nia almost said no. Then she remembered arriving late to his showcase.

"Fine," she said.

They spent twelve minutes talking about classes and the service project. Then the phone buzzed again. Julian apologized, answered, and began discussing audio levels with someone named Marcus.

Nia watched the ice melt in his tea.

She had assumed Julian would understand her crowded schedule because he was busy too. Julian had assumed Nia would understand his for the same reason.

Understanding did not make either of them feel chosen.

Monday, October 13: Brilliant and Unreachable

Battle of the Bands filled Ruth Ellis Fieldhouse with sound powerful enough to vibrate the seats.

The Marching Herons entered in indigo uniforms with copper plumes, their opening formation widening like wings across the floor. Julian's alto line cut through the brass. He moved with the same discipline Nia had first admired during summer rehearsal, every step sharp, every turn placed exactly.

Nia stood with Keisha and screamed until speaking became unnecessary.

Julian was brilliant.

After the performance, Nia fought through the concourse toward the band exit. She wanted five minutes: a hug, a private congratulations, proof that the person on the floor and the person in her messages still belonged to the same relationship.

Campus media intercepted Julian first. Then an alumnus asked for a photo. Band leaders called the altos into a debrief. Two first-year musicians pulled him into a group selfie.

Nia waited near the wall.

Julian saw her and mouthed, **One minute.**

Ten minutes later, a media coordinator waved him toward another interview.

He jogged over to Nia, breathless. "You saw it?"

"All of it. You were amazing."

His face lit up. A camera operator called his name.

"I have to--"

"Go," Nia said.

Julian kissed her quickly while people moved around them. A photographer captured the moment. Then he disappeared back into the crowd.

Nia remained against the wall, proud of him and lonely beside his success.

Tuesday, October 14: Next Man

DJ began the homecoming game fourth on the receiver rotation.

By the second quarter, one player had aggravated a hamstring and another had taken a hard hit. The receivers coach pointed at DJ.

"Cole, X position. Know the adjustment?"

"Yes, sir."

DJ ran onto the field with seventy years of alumni noise rolling down from the stands.

His first route cleared space for another receiver. His second ended with the quarterback scrambling. On the third, McCall-Hart lined up near the twelve-yard line. The corner played inside leverage, expecting the slant.

DJ remembered the adjustment. He released outside, planted, and broke toward the back corner.

The ball arrived over his shoulder.

For a fraction of a second, the entire year narrowed to his hands.

Catch. One foot. Second foot. Boundary.

Touchdown.

Henry Boyd Stadium became sound.

DJ ran toward the student section, then stopped before earning a penalty and celebrated with his teammates instead. Malik jumped from his seat. Nia nearly knocked Keisha's drink over. Imani screamed with both hands around her mouth. Julian, in the band block, played through a grin he could not hide.

McCall-Hart won in the fourth quarter.

In the locker room, DJ received no speech about destiny. The receivers coach moved his magnet two places higher on the depth chart.

"You earned more reps," he said. "Now prove you can block when the ball is not coming."

DJ stared at the board.

Publicly, he had scored the homecoming touchdown. Privately, his reward was more work.

He loved both parts.

Wednesday, October 15: Full Credit

The game's late fourth-down decision became the subject of campus discussion Wednesday.

With a narrow lead and the ball near midfield, McCall-Hart had attempted the conversion instead of punting. The offense succeeded and drained most of the remaining clock.

At a student analytics event, Dr. Bennett displayed the decision model. Malik's corrected module helped define the range in which the attempt had a favorable expected value.

When a student reporter asked Malik whether his model had won the game, he shook his head.

"No model wins a football game. Simone Hart led the uncertainty revision. Andre and Priya rebuilt missing tags and game-state splits. Coaches combined the analysis with personnel, field conditions, and what they saw during the game. The players executed the play."

The reporter tried again. "But your section supported the call?"

"Our section supported one option within a range. That is different from predicting the result."

Simone stood near the back, listening.

Afterward, she caught Malik by the door. "Good answer."

"It was accurate."

"It also gave people credit."

Malik looked toward DJ, who was retelling the touchdown to anyone who had somehow avoided seeing it online.

"The work got better when it stopped being only mine," he said.

Simone smiled. "Careful. You are becoming tolerable."

Thursday, October 16: The Perfect Picture

Julian posted the homecoming recap Thursday afternoon.

The video was excellent. Service projects, alumni laughter, band rehearsals, step-show lights, DJ's touchdown, the fourth-down conversion, and Founders' Bell all moved together beneath Julian's narration.

The final image was the photograph from Battle of the Bands: Julian kissing Nia while copper light caught the edge of his uniform.

The caption read: **Homecoming is history, excellence, and the people who make every crowded moment worth it.**

Comments filled with heart symbols and declarations that they were "campus couple goals."

Nia stared at the image. It looked like a perfect week she had not experienced.

She found Julian on Cypress Walk.

"Why did you post that picture?"

His smile faded. "You do not like it?"

"It is beautiful. It is also the only private moment we almost had, and there was a camera in it."

"It was taken at a public event."

"That is exactly the problem."

Julian shifted his bag. "I thought it showed us supporting each other."

"I spent the week waiting for you. The picture makes it look like I got everything I wanted."

"You were late to my showcase."

"I know. I apologized."

"And I understood because you were helping people. Why can you not understand that homecoming is the busiest week of my year?"

"I do understand! I am saying understanding did not make me feel less alone."

Students moved around them, some recognizing the couple from the post as they argued beneath the real trees.

Julian lowered his voice. "Do you want me to delete it?"

Nia hesitated. Deleting the image would not give them the missing time.

"I want you to ask before our relationship becomes content," she said. "And I want us to stop using busy as if it explains everything."

Julian looked down the crowded walk. "I need to think."

"So do I."

They walked away in opposite directions while their perfect photograph continued collecting approval online.

Week Twelve: The Maximum Is Not the Meaning

Dr. Alana Price opened her colloquium with a map and a warning.

The map showed a fictional river town under evacuation. Roads appeared as thin lines. Neighborhoods became colored regions. Small circles represented households, and arrows pointed toward shelters beyond the projected flood zone.

"Suppose I ask you to minimize total evacuation time," Dr. Price said. "What will your model try to do?"

Students offered answers: choose the shortest routes, reduce congestion, distribute traffic, avoid bottlenecks.

Dr. Price clicked to the next slide.

The fastest solution sent most drivers across one bridge, routed residents without cars to pickup points nearly two miles away, and treated a nursing facility like a cluster of identical households.

"The objective function improved," she said. "The evacuation became less humane."

Nia sat forward.

Only a week earlier, she had treated choosing one service project as proof that she understood limits. Then she had spent Cypress Week measuring connection by how many commitments she and Julian could squeeze around each other.

On screen, the route map glowed with an elegant answer to the wrong question.

Friday, October 17: People Are Not Points

Dr. Price described the information an evacuation model might need beyond distance: vehicle access, mobility, language, medical support, departure timing, road capacity, trust in official messages, and whether a shelter could actually meet people's needs.

"Optimization does not remove values from a decision," she said. "It hides them inside what you choose to maximize, minimize, and constrain."

Malik wrote the sentence in his analytics notebook.

Nia drew three versions of the route map, each centered on a different goal. Fastest total clearance. Fewest households left without transportation. Most robust plan if one road failed.

During questions, she asked, "How do you keep adding human factors without making the model impossible to use?"

Dr. Price nodded. "You do not add everything. You make the choices visible. You involve the people affected. And you resist calling one output *the* optimum when it is only optimal under one set of priorities."

Afterward, Nia and Malik walked down Eliza Moss Hall's steps.

"That felt personal," Nia said.

"Because of the shuttle project?"

"Because I keep optimizing my schedule like every opportunity and every person can be converted into one measure called 'doing enough.'"

Malik looked at her. "That sounds tiring."

"It is. How is reduced analytics?"

"Also tiring. Less impossible."

"A powerful review. Put it on the brochure."

Saturday, October 18: The Wrong Objective Function

Saturday's calculus workshop began with returned applications exams and the Mean Value Theorem.

Dr. Brooks drew a smooth curve between two endpoints and marked the secant line connecting them. Somewhere between the endpoints, she explained, the theorem guaranteed at least one tangent line with the same slope as that average rate, provided the function was continuous on the closed interval and differentiable inside it.

"The theorem guarantees existence," Amara said. "It does not tell us where the point is."

"Or whether there is only one," Malik added.

"Exactly," Dr. Brooks said. "Conditions matter. Conclusions have boundaries."

Their test-correction forms required more than replacing wrong answers. Students had to identify the first unsupported step. Nia had earned a strong score but lost points on an optimization problem because she found a critical point and never tested one feasible endpoint. Malik had improved from his first test, yet his linearization explanation still assumed that *nearby* automatically meant *accurate enough*.

They corrected the arguments at North Star. Nia wrote that a critical point was a candidate, not a crown. Malik added an explicit error check and the interval over which his approximation remained useful.

Only after finishing did Nia return to the larger optimization problem waiting in her room.

Nia spread her commitments across the dorm-room floor.

Class deadlines. Math outreach. AWM meetings. Accountability check-ins. Residence activities. Julian's band calendar. Julian's media calendar. The private study blocks Keisha had made her protect.

Keisha stepped around the paper without disturbing it. "Are we solving a crime?"

"Possibly mine."

Nia had been proud of choosing one service project. But the paper showed the deeper pattern. She did not merely say yes to too many events. She tried to maximize how useful she was inside each relationship.

If Malik struggled, she wanted to build the recovery plan. If a club needed a leader, she wanted to become the answer. If Julian was busy, she stretched herself around his schedule, then expected him to notice the stretching.

"I keep maximizing commitments," she said. "And minimizing attention."

Keisha sat on her bed. "Attention to what?"

"The work. The people. Myself. Pick one."

"That sounds like the same problem three times."

Nia placed a blank sheet in the center of the floor and wrote: **What is the goal?**

For academics: learn deeply, not appear endlessly capable.

For service: contribute where she had responsibility, not collect proof that she cared.

For Julian: build a relationship they could actually experience, not one that looked full on a calendar.

"Are you going to call him?" Keisha asked.

Nia looked at the last line. "Not until I know whether I am apologizing or trying to win the argument."

"That may be the smartest thing you have said all semester."

"Rude."

"Accurate."

Sunday, October 19: Honest, Not Certain

Malik and Simone rebuilt the fourth-down model around intervals.

Instead of one bright recommendation, the interface displayed a range of expected outcomes under different assumptions. A broad neutral band showed scenarios where no option clearly dominated. Users could examine how the recommendation changed when possession value, weather, opponent strength, and sample quality changed.

"It is less dramatic," Malik said.

"Good," Simone replied. "We are submitting analysis, not auditioning for a game show."

The regional semifinal rubric rewarded technical quality, communication, and usefulness. A single answer might look stronger in a screenshot, but any judge could expose its fragility by changing one assumption.

Malik added a note explaining where formation tags remained incomplete.

"Do you think this can advance?" he asked.

Simone rotated her chair toward him. "Yes."

"How likely?"

"That is a different question."

"Do you have a range?"

"I have several opinions disguised as one."

He smiled.

They reviewed the limitations again. Malik no longer felt that every uncertainty label weakened his contribution. Some made the work stronger because they showed the user where judgment had to begin.

"You look more rested," Simone said.

"Seven hours last night."

"A revolutionary methodology."

"Results are preliminary."

Their laughter came easily. Neither treated it as more than the growing trust between teammates, though the warmth stayed with Malik after the screen went dark.

Monday, October 20: No Camera

Julian invited Nia to dinner at a small table behind Copper Cup, away from the main terrace.

There was no camera. His phone stayed in his bag.

"I took the photo out of the homecoming recap," he said.

Nia had noticed. "You did not have to erase the whole moment."

"I know. But I posted it without asking, and after our argument I did not want the image speaking for us."

He looked tired in a way stage lights usually concealed.

"I am sorry," he said. "I turned our relationship into a closing shot because it made the week feel complete. The week was not complete. We barely saw each other."

Nia traced the edge of her napkin. "Thank you."

"I also used your being late to the showcase as evidence that I was allowed to be unavailable all homecoming. I kept score instead of saying I missed you."

"I did miss your film."

"You missed most of it."

"I am trying to apologize."

He smiled slightly. "Sorry. Continue."

Nia explained the review commitment and the moment she chose not to tell him. She admitted that she had believed the schedule would work because she wanted to be both the dependable tutor and the supportive girlfriend.

"Then when it failed," she said, "I treated being helpful as if it made the promise to you less real. It did not."

Julian reached across the table. "I do not want to compete with everybody who needs you."

"You should not have to."

They held hands in the quiet corner, relieved to be speaking honestly and not yet aware that honesty could identify a mismatch without resolving it.

Tuesday, October 21: One Evening

Nia and Julian met again Tuesday to make the repair practical.

They chose one private evening each week. No media coverage, club leadership, tutoring, band extras, or relationship posts without discussion. Emergencies could change the plan, but ordinary busyness could not quietly consume it.

"Thursday?" Julian asked.

Nia checked her schedule. "Thursday. Seven to nine."

"Protected."

"Protected."

Then Nia added her own apology.

"I have been acting like love means endless flexibility," she said. "If I move everything for you, I feel devoted. If you move everything for me, I feel chosen. That is not fair to either of us."

Julian considered her words. "I like that you show up."

"I like that you make moments feel important."

"Those are good things."

"Yes. Until they become the only way we know how to care."

He nodded, though the answer seemed more complicated than the calendar block they had just created.

They walked Cypress Walk together without taking a picture.

For the first time since homecoming, the relationship felt quiet enough to hear.

Wednesday, October 22: Submit

The Heron Analytics regional submission was due at 8:00 p.m.

At 6:15, Andre found a mislabeled formation. At 6:42, Priya corrected a legend. At 7:03, Dr. Bennett removed a paragraph that claimed more transferability than the evidence supported. At 7:21, the export broke one of Simone's interval labels.

Nobody panicked gracefully.

Malik rebuilt the label. Simone checked the final narrative against the charts. Andre and Priya verified the source table. Dr. Bennett read the limitations aloud.

At 7:47, Simone placed the cursor over **Submit**.

"Last objections?"

Malik looked at the model. It did not promise the best fourth-down answer. It showed when evidence favored an option, when the range widened, and when a coach should treat the model as one input among several.

It was honest.

It was competitive.

It might lose.

"Submit," he said.

Simone clicked.

The confirmation page appeared.

For three seconds, the room remained silent. Then Andre cheered, Priya dropped her head onto the table, and Simone raised both hands as if surrendering to the deadline.

Malik took a picture of the team, not the model.

He sent it to his parents with the message: **Regional submission complete. Team effort.**

Celeste replied with six celebration symbols. Marcel wrote: **Proud of you. Call when you can. Repair update not good.**

Joy and worry occupied the same screen.

Thursday, October 23: A Larger Map

Dr. Price's email arrived Thursday morning.

DELTA NATIONAL LABORATORY STUDENT TOUR: APPLICATIONS OPEN

The visit offered a limited number of seats for students interested in applied mathematics, computing, risk, energy, and environmental modeling. Applicants needed a short statement explaining what question they hoped to explore.

Nia found Malik outside calculus reading the message.

"Are you applying?" she asked.

"Yes."

"That was fast."

"The lab studies risk modeling."

"It also has scientific visualization and community systems."

They looked at each other.

"Accountability application session?" Nia asked.

"Saturday. Two hours. No disappearing into other commitments."

"You have become aggressive about constraints."

"Evidence supports them."

They agreed to apply separately and review each other's statements only after drafting their own.

Malik wanted to ask how things were with Julian. Nia wanted to ask what Marcel's repair update meant. Both sensed the other question and let it wait until they had more privacy.

Ahead of them, the Delta visit offered a wider world: supercomputers, scientists, models connected to consequences larger than a classroom or a football field.

Behind them, the house repairs had stalled, and one protected evening could not prove a relationship was healed.

The next opportunity did not erase the current problems.

It gave them a larger map on which to carry them.

Week Thirteen: Beyond the Campus Map

The insurance company wanted proof that a drill press had existed before water destroyed it.

Malik read the request during his Friday break at North Star. Around him, students ate vending-machine dinners and argued quietly over derivatives. On his laptop, a claims portal listed six items as **NEEDS ADDITIONAL DOCUMENTATION**.

Drill press. Air compressor. Power saw. Custom tool cabinet. Two small appliances. School-record storage.

His father had owned the drill press for eleven years. It had repaired lawn equipment, shaped replacement parts, and helped Marcel earn money from jobs too small for larger shops to accept. It appeared in family photos only as a gray shape in the background.

Malik called home.

"They need a receipt," he said.

"From eleven years ago?" Marcel asked.

"Or a dated photo, bank record, warranty, repair invoice, anything showing model and ownership."

"It was in my shop. The water did not ask for paperwork before ruining it."

Malik closed his eyes.

"I know."

"Do you?"

The question was unfair. It also came from a man looking at the damaged equipment that had once made him independent.

Malik opened a new evidence folder.

Friday, October 24: Evidence of a Life

During his twenty-minute break, Malik searched years of family messages.

He found a photograph from Micah's tenth birthday. In the background, Marcel stood beside the drill press cutting a replacement bracket before the party. Another image showed the tool cabinet during a garage cleanup. A bank statement contained a payment to a repair shop that had serviced the compressor.

Malik renamed each file with dates and item descriptions. He wrote short notes connecting the images to the inventory.

Ms. Alvarez passed the desk carrying returned calculators. "Eat."

"I have fourteen minutes."

"Which is enough time to eat and not enough time to solve insurance."

He opened the sandwich Nia had made him buy before his shift.

The claims process wanted a clean history for every object. Families did not live that way. They bought used tools in cash, repaired appliances instead of replacing them, inherited furniture, misplaced receipts, and assumed the things surrounding them would not someday need to prove themselves.

Malik submitted the new evidence.

The portal changed from **NEEDS ADDITIONAL DOCUMENTATION** to **UNDER REVIEW**.

It was not approval.

It was movement.

Saturday, October 25: The Missing Constant

Dr. Brooks introduced antiderivatives by erasing part of a story.

She drew a graph of velocity over time, then asked the class to recover a possible position function.

Students reversed the derivative rules. Malik integrated the polynomial terms. Nia checked by differentiating the result.

"Are we finished?" Dr. Brooks asked.

"Plus C," Amara said.

Dr. Brooks wrote the constant of integration in a box.

The rate of change could reveal how position evolved, but not where the object began. Without an initial value, an entire family of histories fit the same derivative.

"Same rate, different starting point," Nia said.

"Exactly. If I give you one position at one time, you can select a particular history. Without it, do not pretend the rate tells you everything."

Dr. Brooks gave them an initial-value problem: a shuttle's velocity was known, along with its position at noon. Malik found the family of antiderivatives, used the noon position to determine the missing constant, and checked the result by differentiating. Nia drew two candidate position curves that shared the same rate but began miles apart.

"The derivative tells us how the story moves," she said. "The initial value tells us which story we are in."

For the final question, they computed accumulated change across an interval and added it to the starting position. The process felt almost investigative: recover what could not be observed directly from the rate that remained.

Malik thought about the insurance inventory. The current loss did not reveal the family's starting point: which objects were inherited, repaired, or essential to income. Numbers showing damage could not reconstruct every history unless someone supplied the missing constants.

After class, Nia reviewed Malik's Delta application statement one last time.

"You wrote about the storm," she said.

"The lab studies risk."

"You also wrote about your father's equipment."

"Risk is financial too."

Her own statement focused on visualizing evacuation choices so communities could question assumptions instead of merely receiving an official map.

Both had been selected.

The bus left before dawn Sunday.

Sunday, October 26: Beyond the Gate

At 4:50 a.m., Hart Student Union looked like a gathering of ghosts carrying travel mugs.

Malik arrived with a backpack organized by category. Nia arrived wearing two different socks and blamed the hour.

"They are both blue," she said.

"One is indigo. One is navy."

"At five in the morning, all colors are rumors."

Dr. Price checked names against the travel list. The selected group boarded the bus for Delta National Laboratory, a federal research campus several hours from Bellwether.

Nia texted Julian: **Boarding now. I will call after orientation.**

He replied with a heart and a request for photos if security rules allowed them.

By the time the bus reached Delta's guarded entrance, phones had to be silenced and stored during security orientation. Students received visitor badges, data-handling rules, photography restrictions, and a direct warning that curiosity did not override consent or clearance.

Julian messaged twice during the long briefing.

Nia did not see either message.

Malik did not see his mother's update that the adjuster had delayed a decision.

Inside the laboratory, their ordinary campus concerns did not disappear. They waited beyond the gate while the students entered a world of controlled rooms, wall-sized displays, and questions too large for one spreadsheet.

Monday, October 27: Water in Motion

Dr. Arturo Vega led the storm-surge demonstration.

On a visualization wall, a model coastline appeared beneath layers of wind, pressure, elevation, and water depth. The simulation advanced. Blue spread inland through channels, across low roads, and into neighborhoods that looked safe on a simple distance map.

Nia moved closer. "Can you separate the layers?"

Dr. Vega toggled rainfall, river flow, and coastal surge. "The image is not decoration. Each layer should answer a question. Too many at once can make uncertainty look like authority."

Malik asked how the model represented household-level loss.

"It does not, directly," Dr. Vega said. "We estimate physical exposure. Economists, public-health experts, emergency managers, and communities help interpret consequences. A water depth is not the same loss for every household."

He displayed two homes under the same projected depth. One had flood-resistant materials and savings. The other housed a family with limited transportation and no easy place to relocate.

"Same hazard," Malik said. "Different vulnerability."

"Exactly."

Nia began sketching a visual that paired route options with uncertainty and access needs. Malik filled a page with questions about repair delays, work interruption, and how models valued equipment used for income.

They approached the simulation from different directions and kept arriving at the same point: a forecast mattered only through the decisions people could make with it.

Tuesday, October 28: Failure Is Information

Dr. Lena Washington began her presentation with photographs of models that had failed.

She was a Black applied mathematician who led a validation group at Delta. One slide showed a flood map that underestimated water movement through an industrial canal. Another showed a traffic model that performed well in simulation and badly during a real evacuation.

"Nobody invites you to a national laboratory to admire your perfect first draft," she said. "We need you to find where a model stops deserving trust."

Students laughed, then became quiet as she described validation: compare predictions with observations, test extreme cases, examine transferability, document bias, and revise or reject the model when evidence demanded it.

Malik thought of the missing-data chart and the calculus score he had hidden.

During questions, he asked, "How do you keep a failed model from feeling like a verdict on whether you belong in the work?"

Dr. Washington studied him for a moment.

"You separate accountability from identity," she said. "If your method failed, you must name it, learn from it, and protect people from the consequences. But a failed test is information about the work. It is not a complete measurement of the worker."

Nia wrote the answer down word for word.

Malik did not. He wanted to remember it without turning it into another line he could hide behind.

Wednesday, October 29: Work That Matters

On the ride back to Bellwether, Nia and Malik sat across the aisle from each other, talking over the low engine noise while most of the bus slept.

"I used to think applied math meant getting the classroom answer into the real world," Nia said. "Now it feels like the real world changes what counts as an answer."

Malik looked at the photographs he had been allowed to take: a public lobby display, the group beneath the Delta sign, Nia pointing at a permitted visualization poster.

"My family had forecasts," he said. "They still lost things. I keep wondering whether a better model would have changed anything."

"Maybe not everything."

"That is the problem."

"Or maybe that is the honest reason to do it. Not to promise no loss. To give people more time, clearer choices, or one less surprise."

Malik looked out at the dark highway. "One less surprise is not nothing."

They talked about majors, summer research, and the terrifying possibility that the questions they cared about might become careers. The conversation felt intense without feeling romantic to either of them. It was the closeness of two young people recognizing that their private fears could become public work.

Nia posted three approved photos after the bus returned. One showed her and Malik laughing beneath the Delta visitor sign.

Julian saw that image before he heard her voice.

Thursday, October 30: What He Was Asking

Julian met Nia outside Bellwether Media House.

"You did not call," he said.

"Security orientation ran long. Then we had sessions, and the hotel Wi-Fi was terrible. I texted when I could."

"You posted."

"After we got back."

"With Malik."

Nia's patience tightened. "There were six students in the group."

"The picture is you and Malik."

"So this is jealousy."

Julian looked away. "Partly."

The honesty should have slowed her. Instead, she was tired and already defending herself.

"Malik is my friend. I am not going to apologize for having a meaningful conversation with someone who understands the work."

"I did not ask you to apologize."

"You are acting like the photo proves something."

"I am acting like a big part of your life happened, and I learned about it through the same post as everybody else. Again."

Nia opened her mouth, then stopped.

Julian continued. "I do not understand the math the way he does. I wanted you to tell me what mattered. I wanted a way into the story."

"You could have asked without making it about Malik."

"I am asking now, badly."

There it was: jealousy, yes, but also exclusion. Nia heard only the first part clearly enough to answer.

"I cannot keep proving our relationship by making my friendships smaller," she said.

Julian's face closed. "And I cannot keep pretending I do not notice where you feel most understood."

They separated without discussing the laboratory at all.

The trip had expanded Nia's world. The argument made her wonder why bringing that world home felt so difficult.

Week Fourteen: Riemann Sums and Missing Pieces

Nia wore a copper cape to teach Riemann sums.

The cape was not mathematically necessary. She had found it in a costume bin at North Star and decided an outreach night held on Halloween deserved commitment.

At her table, middle-school students received irregular paper masks shaped like heron wings. A square grid lay beneath each mask. Their challenge was to estimate the area using rectangles, then compare estimates made with different widths.

"The mask has curves," a seventh grader named Zoe said. "Rectangles do not fit."

"Exactly," Nia replied. "So we let them fit imperfectly on purpose."

She showed how left-endpoint rectangles missed some regions and covered others that were not part of the mask. Smaller rectangles followed the shape more closely.

"So we are wrong a lot of times," Zoe said, "but in smaller pieces?"

Nia laughed. "That is one way to describe numerical approximation. We make the error visible, then refine it."

Across the room, paper bats hung from the ceiling, volunteers dressed as famous scientists, and Malik helped students calculate candy-bag volume while wearing the smallest possible concession to costume: an indigo tie printed with tiny silver equations.

For two hours, the semester's tension loosened.

Nia remembered that mathematics could feel like an invitation.

Friday, October 31: Smaller Rectangles

The first outreach session ended with masks taped across the wall in a bright flock.

Zoe's group compared estimates using four, eight, and sixteen rectangles. The numbers approached a stable range without becoming perfectly exact.

"Which estimate is the answer?" another student asked.

"The best one we can defend with this method," Nia said. "And we should say how we made it."

She pushed the idea one step farther. If they kept shrinking the rectangle width while increasing the number of rectangles, the sums could approach a definite integral: an exact mathematical object built from the limit of approximations.

"But our measurements are still imperfect," Zoe said.

"Right. The integral does not magically improve the data we started with. A precise method can still produce a questionable total if pieces are missing."

They tested that warning by removing two width measurements from the mask. One group filled the gaps using nearby values; another left the region uncouned. Their totals differed enough to matter.

Nia wrote both results on the board and labeled the assumptions. Estimating a total from incomplete data was not only about adding rectangles. It was about reporting which pieces had been observed, which had been inferred, and how those choices changed the answer.

She heard Malik's influence in the sentence.

He heard it too. "Reasonable."

"That is the nicest thing you have ever said about my teaching."

"It is not."

"Let me have the moment."

The two of them reset the table for Saturday's family session. Nia told Malik about Dr. Washington's description of model failure. Malik told her the insurance company had accepted two pieces of documentation and requested more for the compressor.

Neither solved the other's problem. The conversation still helped.

When Nia checked her phone, Julian had sent an apology for the laboratory argument and a note saying he would film Saturday's outreach session.

She replied: **Come see the cape before judging it.**

His response arrived immediately: **I am already judging the cape. Affectionately.**

For one evening, the joke felt like them again.

Saturday, November 1: The Edge in the Joke

Julian arrived forty minutes late to the family outreach session.

Band rehearsal had run long, and campus media had needed equipment returned before he could collect the camera. By the time he entered North Star, Nia and Malik were demonstrating how the rectangle estimates changed with partition size.

Julian filmed from the doorway.

Zoe returned with her mother and pointed at them. "Those are the two math people."

Julian stepped closer. "They do come as a matched set."

His tone was light enough for the family to laugh.

Nia heard the edge.

Malik did too.

"We are accountability partners," Nia said.

"I know," Julian replied, still smiling behind the camera. "Very accountable."

The session moved on, but the joke stayed in the room. Nia became overly formal with Malik. Malik moved to another table. Julian filmed more footage than necessary and disliked himself for every extra minute.

After the families left, he lowered the camera.

"That came out wrong."

"It came out exactly how you meant it for about two seconds," Nia said. "Then you regretted it."

Julian rubbed one hand over the back of his neck. "Maybe."

"I am not doing this here."

She carried the mask supplies toward storage.

Malik watched her go, then looked at Julian. "Can we talk?"

Sunday, November 2: Not a Competition

Malik met Julian outside the union Sunday afternoon.

He had no interest in winning an argument about Nia. Winning would be the wrong goal.

"I am not trying to interfere in your relationship," Malik said.

Julian leaned against the terrace rail. "I did not say you were."

"You implied that our friendship needs explaining."

"You two have a connection."

"Yes. We are friends. We study together. We care about similar work."

"And you have feelings for her."

Malik's silence answered too much.

Julian looked away toward Cypress Walk. "I am not imagining everything."

"No," Malik said carefully. "But Nia is with you. I have respected that. She should not have to make our friendship smaller to prove your relationship is real."

"Easy for you to say. You get to be the understanding friend while I am the jealous boyfriend."

"I am not especially understanding. Ask anyone."

Julian almost smiled.

Malik continued. "This is not a competition I am entering. If you are worried about what Nia needs, ask her. Do not make her defend me."

"And what do you need?"

Malik thought of the photo beneath the Delta sign, the bus conversation, and every private hope he had treated like patience.

"Better boundaries," he said.

It was not a complete answer. It was the answer he could responsibly give.

Monday, November 3: The Drop

The rivalry game against Bayland State began with DJ dropping a pass.

The ball hit both hands on a short third-down route and fell to the turf. The crowd groaned. DJ returned to the sideline with every camera in the stadium apparently pointed at his failure.

His receivers coach met him near the bench. "What happened?"

"Looked upfield before I secured it."

"Fix your eyes. Next play."

No speech. No punishment. No promise of another target.

DJ spent two quarters blocking, running clear-out routes, and trying not to beg the quarterback with his body language.

In the fourth quarter, McCall-Hart trailed by four. On fourth-and-five, DJ ran a crossing route beneath the linebackers. The pass arrived low. He bent, caught it cleanly, and absorbed the tackle beyond the marker.

First down.

The drive stayed alive. Two plays later, McCall-Hart scored the winning touchdown.

DJ's conversion did not erase the drop. The drop did not erase the conversion. Both belonged to the same game and the same player.

In the locker room, he texted Malik: **I HAVE EXPERIENCED THE FULL EMOTIONAL RANGE OF RECEIVING.**

Malik replied: **Secure the message before looking upfield.**

DJ sent back twelve angry symbols and saved the text anyway.

Tuesday, November 4: Advance

The Heron Analytics team received its regional decision at 10:03 Tuesday morning.

Selected: Regional Semifinal Presentation

Simone read the message aloud in the lab. Andre shouted. Priya covered her face. Dr. Bennett permitted exactly thirty seconds of noise before asking when the presentation file was due.

Malik opened the schedule.

Nine days.

His first instinct was not celebration. It was calculation.

Presentation revision, rehearsals, classes, North Star shifts, family calls, make-up work, travel preparation. Nine days became blocks, then hours, then a narrowing path between obligations.

Simone closed his laptop.

"We advanced," she said. "Experience the event before you convert it into a countdown."

Malik looked around the room. The model had survived review because the team showed uncertainty instead of hiding it. They had earned the chance to be questioned in person.

He allowed himself one full minute.

Then he reopened the schedule.

"Hopeless," Simone said.

"Prepared."

"Those words are cousins, not twins."

Wednesday, November 5: Public Laughter

The basketball exhibition at Ruth Ellis Fieldhouse introduced the men's and women's teams before the season.

Nia attended with Julian and several of his media friends. She wanted an ordinary night: snacks, music, friendly arguments about which team had the better entrance.

Instead, one of Julian's friends mentioned the Delta photo.

"Your girl looked real happy at the lab," Marcus joked. "Math husband in the frame and everything."

Nia waited for Julian to stop it.

He laughed once. "Apparently accountability is a full-contact partnership."

The group laughed.

Nia did not.

"Can we not?" she said.

Julian noticed her expression. "It is a joke."

"It is our argument performed for your friends."

"Nobody knows our argument."

"They know enough to laugh at me."

Marcus began apologizing, but Julian tried to smooth the moment with another joke about mathematicians taking everything literally.

Nia stood.

"Where are you going?"

"Somewhere I do not have to become content before I can have a feeling."

She left before the women's team scrimmage began.

Julian remained in his seat, surrounded by friends who suddenly found the court very interesting.

Thursday, November 6: Known in Private

Keisha found Nia sitting on the floor between their beds, still wearing the exhibition wristband.

"Do you need soft or useful?" Keisha asked.

"Soft first."

Keisha sat beside her without speaking.

After a while, Nia said, "Julian tells people he is proud of me. He posts me. He introduces me like I am brilliant. Everybody thinks he adores me."

"Does he?"

"I think so."

"That was not the whole question."

Nia pulled at the paper wristband. "Being loved in public is not helping me feel known in private."

She explained the joke, the friends, and how quickly Julian had protected the mood of the group instead of the dignity of their conversation.

"I also keep score," Nia admitted. "I count every late arrival and missed date. Then I act like I am above the performance because I am the one hurt by it."

Keisha leaned back against the bed. "Do you want the relationship, or do you want to prove it can work?"

Nia's eyes filled.

"I do not know anymore."

Outside, campus workers removed the last Halloween decorations. Ordinary November returned, carrying a withdrawal deadline, a semifinal, and choices that could no longer be disguised as scheduling problems.

Week Fifteen: What Can Still Be Changed

During advising week, honesty spread across campus like a weather system.

Students who had spent months saying "good" and "busy" began using more precise language. A chemistry major admitted she was failing lab. A senior learned one missing prerequisite could delay graduation. Two roommates compared emergency-aid forms over lunch. Outside Eliza Moss Hall, an adviser explained to a tearful student that withdrawing from one course was not the same as withdrawing from a future.

The deadline sharpened every conversation: remain, withdraw, change strategy, accept the grade, ask for help.

Malik sat across from Dr. Brooks with his corrected first test, completed make-up quiz, and applications-exam feedback arranged in a careful stack.

"Your work is improving," she said. "Your schedule is not."

He had earned back some credit through corrections. He attended office hours. His explanations now showed the reasoning he once assumed answers could carry alone.

He was also working later, preparing for the analytics semifinal, and answering family calls whenever the insurance company produced a new request.

"Can I stay in the course?" Malik asked.

"Yes," Dr. Brooks said. "The question is whether you will continue making the changes that allow you to succeed in it."

Remaining was not a passive decision.

Friday, November 7: Stay, Leave, Change

Nia attended her own advising appointment expecting praise and received a question instead.

"What are you protecting in your schedule?" her adviser asked.

Nia named calculus, outreach, sleep, and one weekly evening with Julian.

"And what are you protecting emotionally?"

That answer was harder.

Across campus, DJ met with an athletics academic adviser who reminded him that increased playing time did not lower assignment expectations. Keisha adjusted a programming-course deadline around travel for her first indoor-track preparation meet. Students were not choosing between being successful and unsuccessful. They were choosing which consequences they could responsibly carry.

At North Star that evening, Malik checked in a student who had just withdrawn from calculus.

"I feel like everybody is going to know," the student said while returning a calculator.

Malik looked around the busy lobby. "Most people are trying to survive their own decisions."

"Did you ever think about dropping?"

"Yes."

It was not entirely true, but he had thought about whether the course would drop him.

"I am staying," Malik added. "That means I have to change how I am doing it."

The student nodded. "I am leaving this one so I can change how I do the next one."

They handed over the calculator like a small ceremonial object.

Saturday, November 8: More Hours

Marcel's orthopedic appointment ended with another delay.

The knee had improved, but not enough for him to return to repair work safely. He needed physical therapy, more healing time, and a follow-up evaluation.

"How long?" Malik asked over the phone.

"They do not know," Celeste said.

"What did the doctor estimate?"

"Weeks, not days."

Malik opened the family budget. Reduced income had begun to eat through the emergency balance. Temporary aid helped with immediate costs, but insurance had not resolved the equipment claim and repairs required payments before reimbursements.

He emailed Ms. Alvarez and requested two additional North Star shifts.

Then he told Dr. Bennett he could still complete his semifinal rehearsal section.

Dr. Bennett read the schedule Malik had submitted.

"No," he said.

"The shifts are evening hours."

"Your body does not distinguish paid hours from academic hours when deciding whether it needs sleep."

"My family needs the money."

"I am not telling you not to work. I am telling you the current analytics assignment must shrink if work increases."

Malik agreed to remove one data task.

Afterward, he accepted both additional shifts and kept a smaller task Dr. Bennett thought had been reassigned.

It was not a dramatic lie. It was a quiet failure to subtract.

Sunday, November 9: Accumulated Loss

The Fundamental Theorem of Calculus connected rate and accumulation.

Dr. Brooks drew a rate function, shaded the area beneath it, and showed how a definite integral measured net change over an interval. Then she differentiated an accumulation function and returned to the original rate.

"These ideas are not strangers," she said. "Accumulation and instantaneous change describe the same process from different directions."

Then she introduced substitution through an accumulation problem whose rate contained a function nested inside its own derivative. Instead of expanding everything, the class renamed the inner expression, transformed the differential, and recognized a familiar antiderivative.

"Substitution is not a trick for making symbols disappear," Dr. Brooks said. "It identifies the structure governing the change."

Nia checked the result by differentiating. Malik evaluated the endpoints and interpreted the sign of the net change rather than reporting only its magnitude. A positive contribution in one part of the interval and a negative contribution in another both affected the final total.

Malik understood the proof.

He struggled with the example.

A small negative rate sustained over time produced a large total loss. On paper, the effect appeared clean. At home, losses had accumulated through missed workdays, replacement meals, transportation, medical copays, cleaning supplies, temporary storage, and damaged equipment. No single cost had destroyed the budget. The area beneath all of them had.

Nia saw him stop writing.

"Home?" she asked.

"Every day my father cannot work is another change in the total."

"Do you want to talk after class?"

He looked at the semifinal notes in his bag. "I have rehearsal."

Nia nodded. She did not ask him to cancel.

"Later, then."

Malik appreciated the offer and the absence of pressure. He also recognized how easily *later* became his hiding place.

Monday, November 10: Three Slides Too Many

Malik's semifinal section contained fourteen slides.

He presented the source data, missingness audit, model structure, sensitivity analysis, uncertainty intervals, opponent adjustments, decision thresholds, edge cases, limitations, and three alternative visualizations.

At minute eight, he had not yet stated what decision the model supported.

Simone held up one hand. "Stop."

Malik stopped mid-sentence.

She walked to the display and deleted three slides from the sequence.

"Those explain the sensitivity design," he said.

"The appendix explains it."

"A judge may question the intervals."

"Then we answer the question. Right now your need to prove rigor is burying the decision."

"If I simplify it, the model may sound weaker."

"If nobody knows what the model is for, rigor becomes camouflage."

Andre looked down at his notes. Priya pretended to adjust the timer.

Malik stared at the missing slides.

Simone softened her voice. "Lead with the decision context. Show the range. Name the limitations. Let the judges ask for depth. You do not have to force every piece of evidence through the front door at once."

He thought of his schedule, his family calls, his unfinished task, and every fact he used to prove he was not falling apart.

"Again," Simone said.

Malik began from the first slide.

This time, the decision appeared before minute two.

Tuesday, November 11: The Score Between Them

McCall-Hart marked Veterans Day with a morning observance near Founders' Bell. Students read names from the university's history, the band played a restrained arrangement, and Julian recorded oral histories with alumni who had served.

That evening belonged to Nia and Julian.

Their protected time had survived on the calendar. It did not survive contact with everything they had not said.

They ordered dinner from a small restaurant off campus and sat on the Jubilee Library terrace.

For ten minutes, the evening was gentle.

Then Julian asked why Nia had told Keisha about the basketball argument before speaking to him.

"Because I needed to understand what I felt," Nia said.

"But when I talk to Marcus, it becomes public performance."

"You joked about our conflict in front of him. I talked privately to my roommate."

"After you left me sitting there in front of everybody."

"You made me the joke."

They began counting.

Nia counted the late homecoming date, the missed five minutes after Battle of the Bands, the photograph, the Delta argument, and the exhibition.

Julian counted the missed showcase, unanswered lab messages, the photo with Malik, and every time Nia treated his media work as less serious than her academic commitments.

"I never said your work was less serious," she said.

"You do not have to say it. You explain your work to Malik. You tell me the headline."

"Because when I try, you turn the story into how it makes you look."

The protected evening gave them privacy. They used most of it to present evidence against each other.

By nine, the food was cold and neither felt heard.

Wednesday, November 12: No Performance

Nia and Julian met beside the closed radio booth Wednesday afternoon.

No camera. No friends. No beautiful campus backdrop.

"We keep apologizing," Julian said, "and then using the apology as proof the next problem should not count."

Nia nodded. "We fix the event and keep the pattern."

"Do you want to break up?"

The directness hurt.

"I do not know," she said.

"Neither do I."

They agreed to several days apart. No relationship posts, no public explanation, no friends sent as messengers. They would attend their responsibilities and decide what they wanted when the argument was not still speaking for them.

Julian took her hand once before leaving.

Nia returned to the residence hall and told Keisha, "We are taking space."

Keisha opened her arms.

Nia stepped into the hug.

For once, nobody asked her to explain the decision immediately.

Thursday, November 13: What Support Looks Like

Malik noticed Nia's silence during calculus.

She answered when called on and took complete notes, but none of her usual side comments appeared in the margins of his page. After class, she left with Keisha instead of waiting for him.

DJ knew enough from Imani to say only, "Relationship situation. Do not be weird."

"That instruction lacks operational detail."

"It means do not turn into a romance speech while she is hurting."

Malik had an analytics rehearsal in twenty minutes. His instinct pulled in two directions: abandon the rehearsal to prove he cared, or attend it and pretend he had not noticed.

He chose neither performance.

He sent Nia one message:

I can tell today is hard. I have rehearsal until seven. What support do you want after: food, company, help with calculus, or space? No response needed right away.

Then he silenced his phone and entered the lab.

At 6:42, during a scheduled break, he checked.

Nia had replied: **Company. No fixing. Maybe fries. Good luck at rehearsal.**

Malik wrote back: **Fries are within scope.**

He returned to the presentation.

Nia was hurting. Malik did not use the hurt as an opening. He kept the commitment he had already made and offered support on her terms.

Within days, the analytics team would learn whether honest uncertainty could survive a semifinal. Nia and Julian would learn whether affection could survive an honest decision.

For one evening, Malik focused on the next responsible thing.

Week Sixteen: Two Honest Losses

The radio booth sounded different when it was off.

No music filled the pauses. No control-board lights blinked beneath Julian's hands. No red **ON AIR** sign gave either of them permission to perform.

Nia sat in the guest chair where she had corrected his domain-and-range joke in August. Julian sat at the console, turned away from the microphone.

Outside the glass, Bellwether Media House moved through a normal Friday. Students carried cameras down the hall. Somebody laughed near the editing rooms. A printer made the same grinding noise every thirty seconds.

Inside, Nia and Julian faced the question they had postponed for several days.

"I missed you this week," Julian said.

"I missed you too."

The answer did not solve anything.

Friday was the final day to withdraw from fall courses, and campus had spent the morning discussing which difficult things could still be left. Nia had not expected the question to follow her into the booth.

Friday, November 14: Compatible

Julian placed both hands flat on the desk.

"I keep thinking about the good parts," he said. "The first rehearsal. Copper Cup. The game. You making fun of my math on air."

"Your math deserved it."

He smiled. So did she.

Then the smile hurt.

Nia remembered his first kiss, the way he asked permission. She remembered him giving verified storm information instead of chasing attention. She remembered the copper tape around his wrist, quiet dinners, and the care he took with stories when he was not trying to make their relationship into one.

"We do love each other," she said.

Julian looked down. "I think so."

"That sounds uncertain."

"Not about caring. About what word makes this better instead of harder."

Nia understood.

They needed different things from closeness. Nia wanted private conversation deep enough to make her feel known. Julian experienced connection through shared moments, visible celebration, and being welcomed into the stories that mattered. Under pressure, she withheld conflicts until she believed she could solve them. Under pressure, he turned private tension into public ease.

Neither need was shameful.

Together, the pattern exhausted them.

"Affection has not made us compatible," Nia said.

Julian's eyes shone. "No."

The word was quiet.

It still changed the room.

Saturday, November 15: No Villain

They met once more Saturday beneath the arcade outside Media House.

Julian brought the scarf Nia had left in the radio booth. Nia brought a book he had loaned her about documentary storytelling.

The exchange looked too ordinary for the end of a first love.

"I am sorry about the jokes," Julian said. "Especially at the exhibition. I made you carry my jealousy in front of other people."

"I am sorry I kept deciding what you could handle instead of telling you the truth," Nia replied. "And for making every conflict a test of whether you understood me without explanation."

"I wanted to understand."

"I know."

"I also wanted you to need me in the part of your life where Malik already understood the language."

Nia could have argued about Malik. There was no reason now.

"That was not fair to you," she said. "Or to us."

Julian gave her the scarf. Their fingers touched.

"So this is it?"

Nia wanted him to have betrayed her. She wanted one terrible act she could point to whenever she missed him. Instead she had memories of two people who had tried, apologized, repeated patterns, and reached an honest limit.

"Yes," she said.

They hugged for a long time.

When they separated, Julian wiped his face and laughed once at himself. "I had a better exit planned."

"Of course you did."

"It had lighting."

Nia laughed through tears.

They walked in opposite directions without anger strong enough to carry either one home.

Sunday, November 16: The Space Between

Test three asked students to find the area between two curves.

Nia sketched both functions, found their intersections, determined which curve lay above the other, and built the integral of top minus bottom.

Every difficult step created the same impulse: text Julian.

When she found the second intersection after an algebra mistake, she wanted to send him a victory message. When the substitution simplified cleanly, she wanted to tell him calculus had briefly decided to behave. When another student dropped a calculator, she wanted to share the joke she knew he would make.

Her phone remained zipped inside her bag.

The area problem changed where the curves crossed. One expression stayed on top over the first interval; the order reversed over the second. Nia split the integral instead of allowing signed area to cancel the total region she was asked to measure.

She checked the limits, evaluated each part, and added the positive areas.

Grief did not behave so neatly. Good memories and painful ones did not cancel into zero. Missing Julian did not prove the breakup was wrong. Knowing the breakup was right did not make the missing smaller.

Nia finished the test with four minutes left.

Outside, she texted Keisha: **Done. Please tell me there is food.**

Keisha replied: **Food, silence, and one legally binding ban on checking his page.**

Nia smiled for the first time that day.

Monday, November 17: Transferability

The Heron Analytics regional semifinal took place in a conference center two hours from Bellwether.

McCall-Hart presented third.

Simone opened with the decision context. Priya explained the data. Andre described missingness and tagging. Malik presented the uncertainty intervals, showing when the model favored a fourth-down attempt and when the evidence left multiple defensible options.

The timing held. The visualizations worked. Nobody hid the limitations.

During questions, a judge from another university leaned toward the microphone.

"Your model incorporates opponent-specific tendencies and McCall-Hart possession values," she said. "What evidence supports transferring these decision thresholds to a team in another conference with different personnel and game pace?"

Malik knew the honest answer: not enough.

He also knew the answer he wanted to give.

"The framework is general," he began. "Another program could replace the inputs with its own data and estimate team-specific thresholds."

"Have you validated that process on an external team?"

"Not yet."

"Then how do you know the structure transfers rather than only the interface?"

Malik paused.

The room waited.

"We do not know," he said. "We would need external validation across programs and probably a revised model for differences in pace, roster strength, and data quality."

The answer was honest.

It was also incomplete because the work itself was incomplete.

After the session, Malik replayed the question until every possible better response arrived too late.

Tuesday, November 18: Does Not Advance

The finalist announcement appeared on a screen in the conference lobby.

Bayland Institute advanced. So did two other universities.

McCall-Hart did not.

For several seconds, nobody on the team spoke. Around them, another group shouted and embraced.

Malik stared at the list.

"I lost it on transferability," he said.

Simone turned toward him. "We did not have transferability evidence."

"I could have explained the adaptation process better."

"That would not create validation we did not perform."

"The judge asked me."

"Because you presented that section. The model belonged to all of us."

Dr. Bennett gathered the team for a brief debrief and told them not to diagnose the loss in the lobby. They would review scores and comments when available.

On the bus home, Malik opened his presentation notes and rewrote the answer.

Then he rewrote it again.

Every version sounded better than the one he had given. None supplied the missing evidence.

He closed the file only when Simone reached across the aisle and lowered his laptop screen with one finger.

"You are trying to turn grief into editing," she said.

"It was a competition."

"It was also work you cared about. You are allowed to be disappointed before becoming educational."

Wednesday, November 19: What Failed

The official feedback praised McCall-Hart's uncertainty communication and decision framing. It questioned external validation, sensitivity to data quality, and whether the model would support real-time use under limited staff capacity.

Andre called the scoring inconsistent with another team's presentation.

Malik wanted to agree.

Simone did not.

"We are not calling the result unfair because we dislike it," she said. "If there was a procedural error, document it. If not, document the weaknesses."

She created a postmortem file with four headings: **What Worked**, **What Failed**, **What We Do Not Know**, and **What We Would Test Next**.

Malik read the headings. "Can this wait?"

"The emotions can take time. The evidence should not. We will forget details and rewrite history to protect ourselves."

The team listed what worked: honest intervals, strong visual hierarchy, clear decision context, disciplined timing.

Then the failures: no external validation, limited evidence across conferences, incomplete real-time workflow testing, and an interface easier to understand than to operationalize.

"We can discuss next year after this is complete," Simone said.

The loss remained a loss.

It also became legible.

Thursday, November 20: Opposite Ends

Malik found Nia on a couch at North Star after closing.

She sat at one end with her shoes tucked beneath her. He sat at the other, leaving the middle cushion empty.

"We broke up," Nia said.

"We did not advance," Malik replied.

Neither offered congratulations on honesty or speeches about better things ahead.

Nia looked toward the dark tutoring rooms. "I keep wanting to text him when something happens. Then I remember the person I would tell is the person I am grieving."

Malik nodded. "I keep rewriting one answer as if the right sentence would change the evidence we did not collect."

"Do you want to try again next year?"

"I do not know. Do you want to be friends with Julian?"

"I do not know."

They sat with two futures that had existed a week earlier and no longer did.

Malik did not move closer. Nia did not turn his loss into perspective about hers. They shared vending-machine pretzels and the kind of silence that did not demand improvement.

When Ms. Alvarez told them the building was closing, they stood.

Outside, River Classic banners had begun appearing along Cypress Walk.

The campus was already preparing to celebrate something else.

Week Seventeen: The Catch and the Quiet After

The spare radio-booth key weighed less than an ounce.

Nia carried it all Friday morning as if it were made of iron.

Julian had given it to her in September after she began helping with occasional math segments. The key did not open the building, only the booth, and she had rarely used it without him. Still, it had represented access to his world: the microphones, music beds, handwritten schedules, and small red light that transformed ordinary speech into broadcast.

His final fall performance with the Marching Herons would come during River Classic weekend. After that, band activity would slow for exams and the holiday break.

Nia found him near Media House after rehearsal.

"I should give this back," she said.

Julian looked at the key in her palm. "You could keep it through finals."

"I do not think I should."

He nodded.

Their fingers touched during the handoff. Neither made a joke.

"Good luck at the Classic," Nia said.

"You too. I mean, you are not playing."

"I understood."

"Right."

They hugged briefly. Julian walked toward rehearsal, the key disappearing into his pocket.

Nia remained composed until she reached the second-floor bathroom in Jubilee Library. Then she locked herself in a stall and cried hard enough to miss ten minutes of calculus review.

Friday, November 21: The Returned Key

By afternoon, Nia had washed her face and joined a cumulative review session.

Dr. Brooks asked students to explain how definite integrals appeared beyond geometric area. Groups considered accumulated distance from velocity, total cost from a marginal-cost rate, water volume from changing flow, and population change from a growth rate.

"Units tell the story," Nia said when her group reached the water-flow problem. "Rate in gallons per minute, integrated over minutes, gives gallons."

Her voice sounded normal.

Amara did not ask why her eyes looked swollen. She handed Nia the marker for the next explanation.

Nia drew the accumulation graph and communicated the solution in three layers: the equation, the units, and one sentence about meaning. She did not fill every silence. She did not perform extra brightness.

Afterward, Keisha met her outside with two drinks.

"Key returned?"

"Yes."

"How bad?"

"Quiet."

Keisha handed her the sweeter drink. "Those are sometimes the worst ones."

Nia nodded and let herself be known without producing a better ending.

Saturday, November 22: The File Stays Open

Malik returned to the analytics postmortem Saturday morning.

His first instinct had been to bury the semifinal folder beneath a new directory named **SPRING DEVELOPMENT**. Instead, he opened Simone's four-part document.

He added evidence from the judge feedback and linked each limitation to a possible test. External validation required data from other teams. Operational testing required coaches or analysts completing time-limited scenarios. Transferability needed more than replacing inputs; the team had to examine whether model relationships remained stable across styles of play.

Then Malik wrote the part that felt worst:

Our interface communicated uncertainty more effectively than our study established generalizability. The presentation invited users to trust a process we had validated only in one institutional context.

Simone read the sentence over his shoulder.

"Keep it," she said.

"It sounds like we built the wrong project."

"We built a useful project with a smaller evidence boundary than we wanted."

"The judges may have thought it was not useful."

"Do not invent additional rejection. We have enough real rejection."

Malik added a clean diagram showing where evidence ended and proposed testing began. He uploaded the postmortem to his portfolio beside the polished semifinal slides.

The failure would not become a secret file he never opened again.

It would remain visible without becoming the only thing the portfolio said about him.

Sunday, November 23: The River Classic Catch

River Classic tied McCall-Hart and Bayland State at twenty-four with less than two minutes remaining.

The rivalry had filled Bellwether Civic Stadium in two colors and several generations of argument. Bands traded songs. Alumni shouted across sections. Every tackle seemed personal to someone whose graduation year began with nineteen.

McCall-Hart faced third-and-long near midfield.

DJ lined up wide. His defender played tight coverage toward the sideline, daring him to win the boundary.

At the snap, DJ released inside, forced the defender to turn, then broke back outside. The pass sailed high and farther toward the sideline than planned.

DJ jumped.

He caught the ball with both hands, twisted in the air, and brought one foot down inches inside the white line. His second foot dragged across the turf before the defender drove him out.

For one second, nobody knew.

The official raised both arms to stop the clock, then signaled complete.

First down.

The McCall-Hart side detonated.

Malik grabbed the shoulders of a stranger. Nia screamed beside Keisha. Imani nearly climbed over the row in front of her. Julian's alto section launched into the fight song before the stadium had finished replaying the catch.

The gain placed McCall-Hart in range for the winning score. Three plays later, the Herons crossed the goal line.

Final: McCall-Hart 31, Bayland State 24.

DJ's catch did not score the winning touchdown. It made the winning touchdown possible.

He lay on the turf after the final whistle, looking up at the stadium lights while teammates piled onto him.

Monday, November 24: Call Home First

By Monday morning, DJ had appeared on three campus accounts, one regional sports show, and a highlight reel titled **CATCH OF THE CLASSIC?** with a question mark designed to create arguments.

He completed two interviews before breakfast.

Reporters asked about the catch, the route, the sideline awareness, and whether he expected more playing time. DJ thanked the quarterback, the receivers coach, and the teammates whose blocks kept the play alive.

Then he stepped away and called his mother.

"They said this could affect my scholarship review," he told her.

Her voice changed. "How?"

DJ's current aid package required careful family budgeting. A larger football scholarship would mean fewer loans and less money his mother sent each month.

"No promises," he said. "Coach said the staff will review roles after the season."

"Then we do not spend imaginary money."

"I know."

"But I am proud of you right now. No review needed."

DJ went quiet.

Attention was fun. The possibility of easing pressure at home mattered more.

After the call, he returned to the residence hall and found Malik editing the analytics postmortem.

"You have a national celebrity in the room," DJ said.

"Regional, possibly."

"Hater."

Malik looked up. "Good catch."

DJ smiled. From Malik, those two words carried a complete scouting report of affection.

Tuesday, November 25: The Last Fall Song

The Marching Herons performed a farewell set Tuesday evening for students leaving early for Thanksgiving.

Nia considered staying away.

Then she decided avoiding every place Julian mattered would turn the breakup into a new schedule controlling her life.

She stood with Keisha near the back of the crowd. Julian played with the same focus that had first drawn her toward him. The final song slowed into a warm arrangement of the university hymn. Alumni joined softly. Copper lights reflected from the instruments.

Afterward, Nia waited until the band had finished packing.

"You sounded beautiful," she told Julian.

"Thank you. I saw you."

"I figured. Small campus, large cape reputation."

He smiled. "I am glad you came."

"Me too."

They stood close enough to remember what closeness had meant.

"Have a good Thanksgiving," Julian said.

"You too."

Nia walked away before respect became an excuse to reopen the decision. Closure did not feel clean. It felt like choosing not to turn pain into another invitation.

Wednesday, November 26: Stripped Walls

Malik returned to Gulfport for Thanksgiving recess.

The damaged lower walls had been stripped to the studs. Dehumidifiers hummed where the couch once sat. Repair estimates covered the dining table, each one higher than the family had hoped and lower than the worst number Malik feared.

Marcel walked through the room slowly, his injured leg stiff.

"Physical therapy says bend it more," he said. "The knee says mind my business."

Malik watched him grip a doorframe while stepping over an exposed section of floor.

"Sit down."

"I have been sitting for two months."

"You have not. That is part of the problem."

Marcel gave him a look, then accepted the folding chair.

They reviewed estimates together. Insurance would cover part of the structural work but remained uncertain about several tools. Family members had contributed labor. A church fund had helped with temporary materials. The remaining gap was smaller than before and still beyond easy reach.

"Your job money helps," Celeste told Malik quietly. "But school is still your job."

"I can do both."

She looked at him.

Malik corrected himself. "I am working on doing both."

It was less impressive and more true.

Thursday, November 27: Separate Kitchens

On Thanksgiving evening, Nia called Malik from her mother's kitchen in Huntsville.

Behind her, relatives argued about card-game rules and whether macaroni and cheese counted as a vegetable. Behind Malik, Micah searched for foil while Celeste insisted leftovers required a system.

"How is home?" Nia asked.

"Stripped walls. More estimates. My father is walking better than he admits and worse than he claims."

"That sounds like him."

"You met him for zero minutes."

"I understand the genre."

Malik laughed.

He asked about Huntsville. Nia described her aunt's tutoring program, her mother's interrogation about sleep, and the cousin who had asked whether college had made her famous.

Neither mentioned the North Star couch directly. Neither used holiday distance to confess feelings that had not become responsible simply because Nia was single.

"I am glad you called," Malik said.

"Me too."

"You okay?"

Nia looked toward the family noise. "Not all the time. More than last week."

"Same."

They stayed on the phone while washing dishes in separate states, talking about finals, food, and nothing that demanded a decision.

The call ended warm, unfinished, and exactly where it needed to end.

Week Eighteen: The Work Before the Answer

McCall-Hart welcomed students back from Thanksgiving with couple traditions Nia had never noticed before.

People took matching photos beneath the first holiday lights. Two students shared headphones on Cypress Walk. Copper Cup advertised a two-drink study special called **The Perfect Pair**, which felt less like marketing and more like targeted harassment.

Nia returned to the residence hall Friday afternoon, unpacked, and discovered the scarf Julian had returned during their breakup folded between two sweaters.

She sat on the edge of her bed holding it.

Keisha looked up from her laptop. "What do you need?"

The old Nia would have said she was fine. A slightly newer Nia might have created an evening plan involving three friends, a review session, and service work until sadness lost her address.

"Can you stay?" she asked. "Just for tonight. I do not want the first quiet evening back by myself."

Keisha closed the laptop.

"Yes."

The answer contained no advice, which was one reason Nia trusted it.

Friday, November 28: Ask, Then Receive

They ordered food, watched a ridiculous baking competition, and kept their phones on the other side of the room.

Halfway through the second episode, Nia began crying because one contestant dropped a cake.

"This is not about cake," Keisha said.

"The cake worked hard."

"The cake is structurally unsound sugar."

Nia laughed and cried harder.

She told Keisha about seeing Julian's performance, returning the key, and how respectful closure had somehow made the good memories more available.

"If he had been awful," Nia said, "I could be angry every time I missed him."

"You would still miss who you hoped he was."

"Why are you wise during my suffering?"

"Efficiency."

At ten, Nia thanked her.

"You do not have to thank me for living here," Keisha said.

"I asked you to change your evening."

"And I said yes because I wanted to. See how consent makes the schedule less haunted?"

Nia threw a pillow at her. This time Keisha did not catch it. The pillow struck her laptop bag, and both of them laughed until the room felt inhabitable again.

Saturday, November 29: Grounds for Appeal

Malik met Dr. Bennett with the semifinal rubric, score report, and a draft appeal.

"I think the transferability question affected the judges too much," Malik said.

"That is not grounds for appeal."

"Another team also lacked external validation."

"Did the panel violate a published scoring rule?"

"Not that I can prove."

"Was there a mathematical error in the feedback?"

"The feedback did not include enough detail to determine that."

"Was your score recorded incorrectly? Did a conflict of interest go undisclosed? Was your team denied presentation time promised in the rules?"

"No."

Dr. Bennett slid the appeal draft back across the desk.

"Then identify the procedural error before you ask me to support this. Disliking how the judges weighted a real weakness is not evidence that the process failed."

Malik looked at the score report. "So we do nothing?"

"You document. You ask for clarification if the process allows it. You improve the work. An appeal is not a device for converting disappointment into another round."

Malik left angry enough to search every rule.

For two hours, he compared the timeline, scoring categories, judge assignments, and written feedback.

He found ambiguity.

He found no violation.

Sunday, November 30: Withdraw

Malik withdrew the draft appeal Sunday morning.

The email was short: **After reviewing the published process and available records, I do not have evidence of a procedural error. I will not submit an appeal.**

Then he returned to his portfolio.

He added the semifinal result, judge feedback, and technical postmortem. His analysis distinguished performance error from model limitation. He could have framed his unanswered question as a speaking failure. Instead, he wrote that the question exposed an evidence boundary the team had communicated but not fully investigated.

He described what a stronger project would require: multi-team data, out-of-sample validation, operational testing, and a clearer account of which relationships could reasonably transfer.

Simone reviewed the entry.

"This makes us look unfinished," she said.

"We were unfinished."

"Correct answer."

She suggested one edit: add what the team had contributed successfully, not as consolation but as evidence. Malik included uncertainty communication, missing-data transparency, and decision-focused design.

The portfolio no longer read like a victory page or a confession.

It read like work.

Monday, December 1: Share the Board

Nia led the final Calculus I review circle at North Star.

She divided the board into limits, derivatives, applications, and integrals. Normally she would have prepared every explanation herself. This time, she assigned Amara one-sided limits, Malik linear approximation, another student related rates, and two upperclass tutors integral applications.

"What are you teaching?" Amara asked.

"Connections between units," Nia said. "And snacks. I am coordinating snacks."

The circle began well. Then a student asked about optimization, and Nia lost the thread halfway through explaining endpoint checks. For a terrible second, her mind supplied Julian's joke about her turning every idea into a story.

She stopped.

"Amara, can you finish why the critical point is not automatically the maximum?"

Amara stepped forward and completed the explanation.

Nia drank water, looked at her notes, and returned for the next section.

She did not apologize for needing help. She did not reclaim the board with double energy. The review became stronger because several voices carried it.

Afterward, a student told Nia, "I like how everybody explains it differently."

Nia looked at the erased board. "Me too."

Tuesday, December 2: Freshman of the Week

DJ was named conference freshman of the week after the River Classic.

The announcement appeared at nine. By nine fifteen, his family group chat had produced forty-three messages and one aunt had misspelled "conference" in three unique ways.

At ten, coaches congratulated him and reminded the team that the regular-season finale still required preparation. At noon, a student reporter requested another interview.

At two, DJ sat in Jubilee Library staring at a statistics paper due by midnight.

The assignment asked him to compare two measures of player performance and discuss how sample size affected the conclusion. He had chosen catch percentage and yards per route run, then discovered that celebrating online did not generate a literature review.

Malik found him surrounded by articles.

"Freshman of the week," Malik said.

"Freshman with a paper due. The title did not grant immunity."

"Tragic."

DJ showed him the comparison. Malik asked questions instead of rewriting it: Did catch percentage account for target difficulty? Could limited snaps inflate yards per route? What did each metric reward?

"So the answer is both numbers have agendas," DJ said.

"The numbers do not. The definitions do."

DJ typed that sentence into his notes, then added quotation marks and Malik's name.

"Do not cite me."

"Too late, Professor Data Man."

He submitted at 11:47 p.m.

Public success had not completed his private assignments. It had made them harder to schedule.

Wednesday, December 3: The Group Outing

The basketball home opener gave everyone an excuse to leave their review notes for two hours.

Malik and Nia could have gone together. Neither suggested it.

Instead, they joined DJ, Keisha, Imani, Amara, and three analytics teammates at Ruth Ellis Fieldhouse. The group occupied most of a row and disagreed immediately about which concession line moved faster.

McCall-Hart's women opened with aggressive defense and a quick transition game. The men's team followed in the second half of the doubleheader. DJ analyzed spacing as if secretly auditioning for another sport. Keisha informed him that knowing statistics did not qualify him to coach from row twelve.

Nia cheered without checking whether Julian was covering the game. Malik sat beside Simone for part of the second half and listened to her explain why one lineup's apparent efficiency came from a favorable three-minute matchup.

No one used the evening to escape into romance.

When Nia became quiet during the band's halftime feature, Keisha squeezed her hand. When Malik checked a family message, Simone asked whether he needed to step out. Care moved through the group without becoming a spotlight.

McCall-Hart won both games.

For one night, uncomplicated celebration was allowed.

Thursday, December 4: The Review Map

Malik and Nia finished their Calculus I review map at a wide table in Eliza Moss Hall.

They began with August: function values versus limits, one-sided behavior, and the first graph that had unsettled Malik. From there they linked continuity, derivatives as limits, rules, applications, antiderivatives, Riemann sums, definite integrals, the Fundamental Theorem, and net change.

Beside each topic, they wrote three things:

What we thought. What changed. What still needs work.

Malik wrote that he once believed a correct answer could speak for itself. Now he knew reasoning had to reveal assumptions, boundaries, and meaning. He still needed to slow down under time pressure.

Nia wrote that she once believed explaining quickly proved understanding. Now she knew listening could improve both the mathematics and the group. She still needed to check algebra when emotion scattered her attention.

For their final project, they used the map to build a short guide showing how one concept supported the next. The guide did not present their semester as a straight line. It showed loops, revisions, and ideas they had to encounter more than once.

"This is messy," Malik said.

"Accurately messy."

"The arrows cross."

"Learning does that."

He let the arrows remain.

Finals would produce grades soon. Football still had a conference title to chase. Neither result would answer every question the semester had raised.

For now, the work before the answer was complete.

Week Nineteen: Everything That Counts

On the last day of Calculus I, Dr. Brooks placed two papers on Malik's desk.

The first was his corrected test from September. The original score, sixty-four, remained visible in red at the top. Beneath it, the correction credit and comments documented what he had repaired.

The second paper was recent work on the Fundamental Theorem of Calculus. Malik had built the accumulation function, connected its derivative to the original rate, interpreted the units, and stated the conditions supporting the argument.

Dr. Brooks tapped both pages.

"Do not compare only the numbers," she said. "Compare the reasoning."

Malik did.

The corrected first test showed understanding added after consequence. The recent work showed understanding made visible the first time. It was not flawless. He had lost points for skipping one endpoint interpretation. But the explanation no longer hid behind the answer.

"You improved," Dr. Brooks said. "That does not mean the difficult beginning was secretly good for you. It means you responded to it."

Malik looked at the sixty-four one last time.

The grade still belonged to him. So did everything he had done after it.

Friday, December 5: Last Class

Fall classes ended with no dramatic speech.

Dr. Brooks reviewed final-exam expectations, reminded students that justification mattered, and asked them to write one concept they understood differently now.

Nia wrote: **A complete explanation leaves room for other people to enter it.**

Malik wrote: **An answer is not complete if its assumptions remain private.**

Amara wrote longer than either of them and covered her response with one hand when Nia tried to peek.

After class, students lingered in Eliza Moss Hall. Some exchanged study times. Others photographed the board before it was erased. The room where Malik and Nia had first argued over limits now held months of accumulated evidence: stress, repair, missed sleep, better questions, and friendships that had survived correction.

"Championship tomorrow," DJ announced when Malik returned to the residence hall. His game bag was packed with enough precision to suggest Malik's influence or panic.

"Finals Monday," Malik replied.

"Let joy have one full sentence."

Malik looked at him. "Championship tomorrow."

"Thank you."

Saturday, December 6: The Catch Before the Score

The Southern Collegiate Heritage Conference championship stayed close into the fourth quarter.

McCall-Hart trailed by three when the offense faced third-and-eight. DJ lined up in the slot. The defense disguised pressure, then dropped a linebacker beneath his route.

DJ adjusted without abandoning the pattern. He settled in the narrow space behind the linebacker and in front of the safety. The quarterback delivered the ball high.

DJ caught it, absorbed a hit, and held on.

Nine yards. First down.

The catch did not appear on the final scoring graphic. Four plays later, another receiver caught the touchdown. The defense protected the lead, and McCall-Hart won the conference championship by four.

DJ sprinted onto the field with everyone else. Indigo confetti caught in his hair. Imani reached the front rail and screamed his name. Malik, Nia, Keisha, Simone, Amara, and half the analytics team celebrated from the stands.

During the trophy ceremony, cameras focused on captains and senior stars. DJ stood behind them, smiling so hard his face hurt.

He had made the River Classic catch. He had made the third-down catch that kept the championship drive alive. He had not scored the final touchdown.

He did not need to.

In the locker room, the receivers coach found him.

"Good feel against the zone," he said. "And you secured the ball."

DJ nodded solemnly. "I have experienced growth."

The coach stared at him.

"Yes, sir," DJ corrected.

Sunday, December 7: Leave Before the Song

Campus celebrated the championship through Sunday.

Nia joined Keisha, DJ, Imani, and friends at Hart Student Union. She wore an indigo championship shirt over a long-sleeved top and let herself enjoy the uncomplicated part: DJ's grin, alumni dancing, the trophy reflecting Copper Cup lights.

Julian arrived with band members before their gathering upstairs.

He and Nia saw each other across the terrace. He raised one hand. She returned the gesture.

For a moment, she imagined staying. The band gathering would have music she knew, people who still thought of them together, and the familiar possibility of standing beside Julian until the breakup blurred.

Keisha noticed her watching.

"Want to go?"

Nia nodded. "Before I turn missing him into a reason."

She congratulated DJ again, hugged Imani, and left with Keisha before the band moved upstairs.

Walking away did not feel powerful. It felt sad and responsible.

Imani caught them at the bottom of the union steps.

"You leaving because you want to," she asked Nia, "or because you think being healed means never sharing a room with him?"

Nia looked back through the glass. Julian was laughing with two band members, unaware of the conversation.

"I can share a room with him," she said. "I did at the farewell performance. Tonight everybody is celebrating, people are taking pictures, and I know exactly how easy it would be to stand beside him until the old version feels available."

"So this is strategy, not fear."

"Tonight, yes. Ask me again next month."

Imani nodded. "Good answer. Healing is not attending every event to prove you can survive it."

Keisha linked her arm through Nia's. They walked toward the residence hall and bought convenience-store ice cream on the way. The night became smaller than the championship celebration and more suited to what Nia could honestly carry.

Behind them, the first song began.

Nia did not turn around.

Monday, December 8: One Argument

Final examinations began Monday.

The Calculus I final required more than separate techniques. One long problem displayed a graph of a function, asked students to analyze its derivative, and then interpret accumulated signed area over an interval.

Students had to connect increasing and decreasing behavior, critical points, concavity evidence, net change, and units in one argument.

During the review briefing, Dr. Brooks had warned them: "A graph, a derivative, and an integral are not three unrelated chapters. They are three ways of asking what changes, how it changes, and what accumulates."

The exam schedule divided sections across several days. Malik's appointment was Tuesday morning. Nia's was Wednesday.

On Monday night, they reviewed separately.

Malik used the map they had built but stopped at ten thirty. Nia redrew regions until the integration bounds felt visible. Neither called the other for reassurance.

At 9:48, Malik texted: **Sleep is part of test preparation. Evidence remains annoying.**

Nia replied: **Agreed. Phone going across room. Good luck tomorrow.**

They honored the message.

Tuesday, December 9: Leave One Blank

Malik entered the final with a rule: no answer without the reasoning that made it defensible.

He moved more slowly than he had on the first test. He stated one-sided behavior. He checked derivative signs. He wrote what accumulated area meant in context instead of leaving a number alone.

With twenty-two minutes left, he reached a proof-style question he did not fully know how to finish.

The old panic returned. One unfinished part threatened to turn the entire exam into evidence of failure.

Malik read the prompt again. He wrote the conditions he knew, established the first implication, and marked the step he could not justify instead of inventing one.

Then he used the remaining time to check every complete argument.

When the exam ended, the proof remained unfinished.

So did one era of Malik's thinking.

He had not rushed the rest of the work to attack one blank. He had not made confidence perform where understanding ended.

Outside, Dr. Brooks collected his paper.

"How was it?" she asked.

Malik considered the automatic answer.

"Mostly strong," he said. "One part incomplete."

"That sounds like information."

"I am trying to treat it that way."

Wednesday, December 10: Redraw the Region

Nia froze on the integration setup.

Two curves enclosed a region but exchanged order after their intersection. She knew the process. Find the intersection, identify top and bottom, split the integral, evaluate.

Her mind supplied nothing.

For several minutes, she stared at the equations as if they belonged to a course she had never taken.

Then she stopped trying to remember the finished setup.

She redrew the region.

The first sketch was wrong. She marked test points and corrected it. The intersection became visible. So did the change in which curve lay above the other.

Nia built two integrals.

She checked the bounds and continued.

No glance toward Malik. No imagined explanation from Julian. No need to become the fastest voice in the room. She used the remaining time and the tools she had practiced.

When the exam ended, Nia walked outside and leaned against the limestone wall.

Keisha waited with two snacks.

"How bad?"

"I froze. Then I drew. Then I recovered."

"So which snack?"

"Both. Recovery is hungry work."

Thursday, December 11: The Only Promises

After the final, Malik and Nia met beneath Founders' Bell.

The semester had begun with them standing near the same place and agreeing to become accountability partners. Now students rolled suitcases down Cypress Walk while residence halls prepared to close.

"How did you do?" Nia asked.

"Mostly strong. One incomplete proof."

"I froze on area between curves. Recovered after redrawing."

Neither inflated the answer. Neither softened it to protect the other.

"What now?" Nia asked.

Malik thought of Gulfport, stripped walls, insurance documents, and a living room that would become his bedroom. Nia thought of Huntsville, family questions, and the first holiday season without Julian in her phone.

"Get home safely," Malik said.

"Tell the truth when grades post."

"Agreed."

No promise to call every day. No confession timed to the end of calculus. No claim that surviving one semester had made them ready for every next step.

They hugged, wished each other safe travel, and walked away carrying everything that counted, including the things no grade would measure.

Week Twenty: After the Grades

Fall commencement made finishing look simple.

Names were called. Graduates crossed a stage inside Ruth Ellis Fieldhouse. Families screamed from the stands, flowers crowded the lobby, and every program reduced years of work to a name, degree, and line of honors.

Malik sat with Nia, Keisha, and DJ near the back.

They watched a mathematics graduate hug Dr. Brooks after crossing. They saw a father lift a toddler above his head when the child's mother received her degree. One older graduate stopped midway across the stage, closed her eyes, and pressed a hand to her heart before continuing.

"I wonder what her semester was like," Nia said.

"Probably more than the program says," Malik replied.

Commencement displayed the answer. It concealed most of the work before it.

The first-years understood that now.

They also understood they were still near the beginning.

Friday, December 12: Invisible Work

After the ceremony, the group moved through the fieldhouse lobby while families took photographs beneath indigo banners.

DJ carried his travel bag for the Heritage Bowl. Residence halls closed Saturday, so the football team had moved directly into bowl preparation.

"Imagine our graduation," he said. "They will need additional applause time for me."

Keisha looked at him. "You have completed one semester."

"A decorated semester."

"One paper almost took you out last week."

"The public does not need every detail."

Malik laughed, then watched another family surround a graduate.

His own parents had talked about his future as if the degree were a bridge to stability. They did not see every correction form, overnight shift, or moment he considered whether the path still fit. Today reminded him that invisible difficulty did not make completion less real.

Nia noticed him watching.

"Four years," she said.

"Approximately."

"Do not add uncertainty to graduation."

"Evidence requires it."

She smiled. The joke felt like an old piece of their friendship returning without the pressure to become anything else.

Saturday, December 13: The Block

The Heritage Bowl came down to one decisive play.

McCall-Hart led by three late in the fourth quarter and needed a first down to protect the clock. The offense called a run toward the edge. DJ lined up wide, far from where television viewers expected the action to matter.

His assignment was to block the cornerback.

At the snap, DJ released as if beginning a route, forced the defender backward, then engaged cleanly. The running back cut outside and passed behind him. DJ kept his hands inside, moved his feet, and avoided holding.

The runner gained eleven yards.

First down.

McCall-Hart drained the remaining clock and won the Heritage Bowl.

The highlight replay focused on the runner. The announcer praised the offensive line. DJ appeared at the edge of the frame for less than two seconds.

In the film room later, the coach paused on those two seconds.

"Cole seals the corner," he said. "No edge, no first down."

DJ nodded.

The ball had gone elsewhere. His work still shaped the result.

He texted Malik: **I WON A BOWL GAME WITHOUT RECEIVING A PASS. EXPLAIN THE STATISTICAL INJUSTICE.**

Malik replied: **Your sample contains one excellent block. Report the correct variable.**

DJ saved that message too.

Sunday, December 14: More Than Imaginary Money

The head coach asked DJ to stay after Sunday's team meeting.

DJ sat across from him expecting a discussion of spring training.

"Your role changed this fall," the coach said. "Special teams, offensive snaps, River Classic, championship. Your academic reports are solid. We are increasing your athletic scholarship for spring."

The new amount would not make college free. It would reduce the gap enough to change his family's monthly decisions.

DJ thanked the coach, left the office, and called Malik before the athletics department announced anything.

"It increased," DJ said.

Malik sat up on Aunt Renee's couch in Gulfport. "How much?"

DJ told him.

"That covers most of the remaining housing gap."

"I know."

For once, DJ's voice held no joke.

"You earned it," Malik said.

"The team earned the season."

"Your scholarship is not a group assignment."

DJ laughed, then became quiet again. "My mom can breathe a little."

That mattered more than the public post that appeared an hour later.

Monday, December 15: B

Malik opened his final grade from the living room in Gulfport.

Calculus I: **B**.

In August, he had expected an A. He had arrived with a budget, a roadmap, and the belief that preparation could protect him from outcomes that belonged to less disciplined people.

The letter on screen first looked like distance: from his expectation, from the image his family held, from the transcript he had planned.

Then he opened the grade details.

Sixty-four on the first test. Improved applications exam. Strong corrections. Completed make-up work. A final exam that confirmed recovery without perfection.

The B did not mean the storm was good for him. It did not reward exhaustion. It did not transform the poor first test into an inspirational requirement.

It measured a semester in which he had nearly hidden himself out of the course and then learned to ask for structure.

Celeste looked over his shoulder. "Is that bad?"

"No."

"You made the face you make when a number insults you."

Malik looked again. "It is not the grade I expected."

"Is it the grade you earned?"

"Yes."

"Then greet it properly."

Malik laughed. "Hello, B."

"See? Manners."

Later, Malik opened his spring registration audit. Calculus II required more than the letter grade that unlocked enrollment. His final feedback identified concrete prerequisites: reliable algebraic manipulation, confident substitution, interpretation of definite integrals, and the ability to explain why a method applied.

He created a two-week review plan, then deleted half of it. Winter break was not a hidden semester.

The revised plan contained three short sessions: algebra patterns that had slowed him, integral setups he still confused under pressure, and one explanation exercise using words rather than compressed notation. He also blocked North Star work hours only after confirming his spring class schedule.

For the first time, transcript review did not become a judgment of who Malik was. It became evidence about what the next course would ask him to carry.

Tuesday, December 16: A-Minus

Nia's A-minus arrived in Huntsville while her mother was reorganizing holiday decorations and asking questions from another room.

"What did you get?"

"A-minus."

Denise Reynolds appeared in the doorway. "That is excellent."

"It is."

Nia waited for the grade to erase the exhaustion.

It did not.

The A-minus reflected strong understanding, improved listening, and a final exam recovery after freezing. It did not change the missed showcase, the overcommitted review, the breakup, or the nights she confused being needed with being valued.

"You are doing the face too," Denise said.

"What face?"

"The one where good news has to defend itself in court."

Nia put down her phone. "I am proud. I am also tired. And sad."

"Those feelings are not fighting for one chair."

Nia hugged her mother.

She celebrated the grade that evening with family. She did not post it as proof the semester had gone beautifully.

The next morning, she reviewed her own spring prerequisites. Calculus II would move quickly into integration techniques and applications. Her A-minus showed conceptual strength, but the exam history showed that emotional overload made routine algebra less dependable. She wrote one goal beneath the transcript: **Practice the fragile skills before they become emergency skills.**

Then she closed the portal. Reflection had produced a next step. It did not need to consume the holiday.

Wednesday, December 17: Easy Without a Deadline

An alumni actuarial workshop brought Malik back to Bellwether for a day.

The session covered exam pathways, internships, professional communication, and how early-career analysts should discuss model limitations with people who wanted certainty.

Simone attended for the finance-and-data panel.

Afterward, she and Malik found a quiet table at Porter Center.

"B in calculus," he told her.

"Congratulations."

"It feels complicated."

"Most earned things do."

They debriefed the analytics loss without slides or a countdown. Simone admitted she had known transferability was weak but hoped clear uncertainty communication would carry more weight. Malik admitted he had blamed his answer because personal failure felt easier to fix than a limited study design.

"You cannot rehearse your way into evidence," Simone said.

"I tried."

"Aggressively."

Their conversation moved from analytics to spring classes, career goals, and the terrible workshop coffee. Without a deadline, Simone's directness felt less like pressure and more like ease. Malik's dry humor appeared often enough to surprise both of them.

When they finally checked the time, ninety minutes had passed.

"We are better at talking when nobody needs a deliverable," Simone said.

"Preliminary result."

"We may need replication."

They smiled, leaving the possibility unnamed.

Thursday, December 18: The Living Room

Malik returned to Gulfport after dark.

His old bedroom had new lower drywall but still smelled of removed wallboard, sealant, and damp wood. The floor remained unfinished. Boxes occupied the bed.

"You can sleep at Aunt Renee's," Celeste offered.

"I want to be here."

They set up an air mattress in the living room beside the dehumidifier. Micah brought three blankets and claimed one was "structural support."

Malik lay awake beneath the ceiling fan, hearing his parents speak quietly in the kitchen about repair costs.

He had earned a B. DJ had earned more scholarship support. Nia had earned an A-minus. The Herons had won two championships.

None of those answers rebuilt the room.

Still, they mattered.

The semester had ended without the competition victory Malik wanted. It had also ended with work he could defend, people he trusted, and a transcript that showed recovery rather than collapse.

He turned onto his side as the dehumidifier hummed.

Spring would begin from here, not from the version of home he remembered.

Week Twenty-One: Christmas Without the Old Version

Nia found Julian's playlist in a box labeled **DESK / IMPORTANT / DO NOT LOSE**, which guaranteed it had been packed beneath three less important boxes.

The playlist was not digital. Julian had made it by hand after their first official month together: twelve songs written on a copper card, each with one sentence explaining why he chose it. Beside track four, he had written, **This sounds like you explaining an idea faster than the rest of us can think.**

Nia sat on her childhood bedroom floor and played the songs in order.

The list held their good parts without including the arguments that followed. It remembered Copper Cup, band rehearsals, campus rain, the Heritage Kickoff, and one late-night radio segment when Nia laughed so hard she snorted on air and Julian promised to delete the recording.

He had not deleted it.

She smiled at the memory.

Then she cried.

Missing those moments did not mean she should call him. Loving what had been good did not make the relationship compatible after all.

Nia let the playlist finish.

Friday, December 19: The Good Parts

When the final song ended, Nia placed the card back in the box instead of throwing it away or leaving it on top.

Her mother found her downstairs making tea.

"Julian?" Denise asked.

"Playlist."

"That sounds like Julian."

Nia looked into the mug. "He was thoughtful. People act like breakups reveal the relationship was fake. Ours was not fake."

"No."

"It was also not working."

"Both facts get to stay."

Nia had spent weeks trying to sort the relationship into a clean result: good or bad, right or wrong, worth it or mistake. The playlist resisted the categories. It had been loving. The public jokes had been hurtful. The first kiss mattered. The ending was still necessary.

She carried her tea to the living room and helped untangle holiday lights with her cousins.

The good memories came with her. They did not drag her backward.

Saturday, December 20: Chosen

Denise asked the harder question Saturday morning.

They were driving to Nia's aunt's tutoring program, where families were collecting holiday learning kits and donated books.

"Do you miss Julian," Denise said, "or do you miss being chosen?"

Nia looked out the window. "That feels rude before ten."

"We can reschedule truth for noon."

"No."

Nia thought about Julian asking her to be his girlfriend beneath Founders' Bell. The label had made her feel visible and wanted. She had liked belonging to an *us* that other people recognized.

"I miss him," she said. "His jokes when they were not defensive. How serious he was about band. The way he listened when he forgot to perform listening."

"And being chosen?"

"Yes. I miss that too. I cannot separate them yet."

Denise nodded. "You do not have to separate them today. Just do not call one feeling by the other's name."

At the tutoring program, Nia helped children build paper bridges and estimate how much weight each design could hold. She did not volunteer to redesign the entire event. She stayed at her assigned table.

Her mother noticed and said nothing.

Sunday, December 21: Dependence

In Gulfport, Malik helped his father complete physical-therapy exercises.

Marcel sat in a sturdy chair while Malik counted knee bends and checked the printed range-of-motion guide.

"Ten," Malik said.

"That was twelve."

"That was ten."

"College has damaged your counting."

"Again."

Marcel bent the knee. Pain crossed his face.

"Stop if it is sharp," Malik said.

"It is not sharp."

"You made the sharp face."

"I have one face."

They completed the set. When Marcel tried to stand, he refused Malik's hand, failed on the first attempt, and became angry at the chair.

Malik waited instead of grabbing him.

"Want help?" he asked.

His father stared at the floor. "Yes."

Malik offered his forearm. Marcel stood.

The humiliation in his father's expression unsettled him more than the weakness. Marcel had built his identity around providing, repairing, and being the person others called. Dependence made him feel as if his usefulness had been removed along with the damaged walls.

"You are still my father when I help you stand," Malik said.

Marcel looked at him. "I know that in my head."

"The rest takes time?"

"Apparently."

It was the closest they came to discussing fear.

Monday, December 22: Which Rooms Wait

The contractor called Monday with another delay.

A material shipment would not arrive before January. One subcontractor had overbooked holiday work. The estimate for the back rooms had increased after hidden moisture damage appeared behind the remaining wall.

Repairs would continue into spring.

The family gathered around the dining table with floor plans and costs. They could complete the kitchen and one bedroom first, then delay Malik's room and the utility area. Or they could spread work across all rooms and leave everything unfinished longer.

"Finish Mom and Dad's room," Malik said. "I am at school most of the time."

Celeste objected. Marcel objected louder.

"This is not about whose room matters," Malik said. "It is about which space gets used every day."

He used a rough accumulation estimate to compare temporary housing and storage costs under each schedule. Small weekly expenses, extended across months, changed which delay was actually cheaper.

Micah watched Malik shade weekly cost bars on a hand-drawn timeline.

"Is that another integral?" he asked.

"A rough preview. If the cost rate changes over time, total cost is what accumulates under the rate. Right now we only have weekly estimates, so we are adding pieces."

"Like the flood-water math?"

"Related idea. Different thing we wish we did not need to measure."

They compared two schedules. Finishing every room slowly looked fair, but it extended storage and temporary-living costs. Completing essential rooms first created an earlier drop in the weekly expense rate. The area represented by those later weeks became smaller.

Malik explained the result to his parents without pretending the estimates were exact. Material delays could change. New damage could appear. The calculation clarified the tradeoff; it did not make the decision for them.

The calculation offered no painless choice.

They prioritized the kitchen, primary bedroom, and safe utility access. Malik's room would wait.

He agreed because the decision made sense.

He grieved because the room was his.

Tuesday, December 23: The Pie Model

Micah decided to bake a pie from an online recipe and treated measuring cups as nonbinding suggestions.

The crust emerged from the oven shaped like a continent nobody recognized. Filling leaned heavily toward one side.

Malik photographed it.

He started to text Nia, **How are you doing? Are you lonely?**

Then he stopped.

The question was not wrong, but he recognized the habit beneath it. Care could become surveillance. Checking on Nia's heartbreak every day could turn him into her primary emotional witness and make his reliability feel like a claim on what happened next.

He sent the photograph instead.

Micah has invented non-Euclidean pie. Volume may require Calculus II.

Nia replied with a photograph of a paper bridge collapsing beneath canned beans.

Structural engineers unavailable. Recommend whipped cream stabilization.

They exchanged three more jokes and no emotional inventory.

Malik put down the phone and helped Micah reshape the next crust.

Nia returned to wrapping gifts with her cousins.

Connection did not require constant evaluation.

Wednesday, December 24: Phone in the Other Room

The Reynolds family held its main Christmas dinner on Christmas Eve.

Nia's phone vibrated through appetizers: club messages, grade celebrations, holiday posts, and a notification that Julian had added a new radio recording.

She carried the phone to her bedroom and left it on the dresser.

For the first time all fall, she sat through dinner without being reachable.

Her younger cousins performed a chaotic holiday song. An uncle told the same college story everyone had heard. Denise brought out a dessert that cracked down the center and blamed the oven with great confidence.

Nia was present for all of it.

She still wondered whether Julian had messaged. She still thought about Malik's pie and Keisha's family gathering in Mobile. Being present did not require every other connection to disappear from her mind.

It meant she stopped leaving the table to maintain them.

After dinner, she checked the phone.

There was no message from Julian.

The absence hurt. It also let the boundary remain intact.

Thursday, December 25: Spring Goals

On Christmas night, Malik and Nia separately wrote spring goals.

Malik used a plain notebook page. His first list began with grades, actuarial preparation, work hours, and financial support for home. He crossed it out and started again.

People: call home on planned days when possible; ask before assuming what help is needed; make room for friendships that are not projects.

Sleep: protect six and a half hours as a minimum, seven as the goal; reduce something if the schedule makes that impossible.

Uncertainty: state what is unknown before building a plan; do not treat incomplete control as personal failure.

Nia wrote in copper ink.

People: ask what others need; say what I need before resentment; let friends contribute without directing every contribution.

Sleep: stop treating midnight as free real estate.

Uncertainty: an open opportunity is not an emergency; a difficult feeling is not a decision deadline.

Neither wrote the other's name.

That omission was not distance. It was space.

The new year would begin with Malik more willing to move forward and Nia still learning that grief could coexist with curiosity about what came next.

Neither knew yet how much she would mind when forward movement stopped meaning her.

Week Twenty-Two: The Year Turns Quietly

Malik finished the analytics postmortem the day after Christmas.

The final page listed the work a future team would need: external data, operational testing, a transferability study, and a version of the interface that remained useful when staff had seconds rather than minutes. He added source links, archived the code, and gave Simone final editorial access.

Then he sent her a message.

Thank you for refusing to let us call the result unfair before we understood it. Also for cutting the slides. They needed to die.

Simone replied: **I have waited six weeks for you to admit that. Call me. I need to hear the sincerity.**

Malik called from the Baptiste porch.

The conversation began with deleted slides. It moved to the alumni workshop, spring schedules, DJ's scholarship, Simone's finance internship search, and the strange relief of having a break long enough to discover which people they wanted to talk to when no deliverable required it.

When Malik checked the time, sixty-eight minutes had passed.

"We did it again," he said.

"Replication," Simone replied. "Our finding may be robust."

Malik smiled into the cold Gulfport evening.

Friday, December 26: The Thank-You

Simone asked about the house without turning the call into an interview.

Malik told her which rooms had been delayed and how his father handled physical therapy like a personal feud. She described her family's holiday debate over whether her international-internship plans counted as "going too far away on purpose."

"Do you want to go that far?" Malik asked.

"If the right opportunity is there, yes."

She did not soften the answer.

He liked that about her.

Before hanging up, Simone said, "We should get coffee when we are back. Not a postmortem. Not a team meeting."

Malik leaned against the porch rail. "Personal coffee?"

"You are an analyst. Interpret the available evidence."

"I would like that."

The invitation created a nervousness distinct from his old hope around Nia. It was not built on waiting for an opening. Simone had asked. Malik had answered.

Inside, Celeste called him to help move a cabinet.

Malik ended the call and carried the new possibility into the house without trying to define it further.

Saturday, December 27: The Call for Proposals

In Huntsville, Nia received Dr. Price's research announcement.

The Founders' Research Forum was accepting early proposals for a spring flood-resilience track. Strong projects could advance to the Southeastern Undergraduate Mathematics Symposium and compete for a national summer fellowship.

Nia read the message three times.

The Delta laboratory visit returned to her in pieces: water moving through low roads, uncertainty layers on the visualization wall, Dr. Washington saying failure was information about work rather than a complete measurement of the worker.

She opened a new document titled **Bellwether Flood Evacuation Model**.

Her first idea was too large. It included road capacity, vehicle access, shelter choice, warning trust, mobility, traffic flow, and dynamic flood depth. The project would have required an entire laboratory, two government agencies, and possibly a minor deity.

Nia reduced it to a question: **How might missing road-capacity and household-access information change a recommended evacuation route?**

For readiness practice, she graphed a simplified rate of traffic accumulation, recovered antiderivatives, and repaired the algebra she had marked as fragile. The math was review. The application made it feel pointed toward spring.

She texted Keisha: **Research proposal. Flood evacuation. I need a real programmer and somebody who tells me when the question is impossible. Interested?**

Keisha replied: **Define "need."**

Nia recognized the test.

Sunday, December 28: Coauthor

Keisha joined the video call from Mobile wearing track gear and holding a bowl of cereal.

"What do you want me to do?" she asked.

Nia shared the draft. "Build the route model, clean data, help decide what the system can actually compute--"

"Stop."

Nia stopped.

"You just listed code, data, and model design as if they are support services around your idea."

"I did not mean it that way."

"Meaning is not the project structure."

Keisha set down the bowl. "I will join if I am a collaborator. That means I help define the question, choose methods, reject bad data, and own the computational work. My name goes on the application from the beginning. I am not emergency technical help after you promise something the code cannot do."

Nia felt the reflex to defend herself. Then she remembered the spring goal written in copper ink: let friends contribute without directing every contribution.

"Coauthor," Nia said. "Shared method decisions. You can veto computational claims we cannot support."

"And track meets remain on my calendar."

"Agreed."

"Then send me the data description. Not the whole giant dream."

Nia smiled. "The giant dream has excellent visual language."

"I am sure it does. Send the data."

The partnership began with a boundary, which made it stronger than a favor.

Monday, December 29: Delete Reminder

Malik's private calendar contained a reminder he had created in October.

Tell Nia after finals.

No details. No explanation of what he intended to tell her. The reminder assumed finals would create a perfect moment, Nia's relationship would resolve somehow, Malik's family crisis would calm, and his patient feelings would become a claim worth presenting.

He stared at it.

Nia did not owe him a moment because he had waited. He did not owe his past self indefinite loyalty to a possibility that had never become a mutual decision.

Malik deleted the reminder.

The action did not erase his feelings. It changed what he planned to do with them.

For several minutes, he let himself grieve the scene that would never happen: finding Nia after finals, explaining that he had cared through every other relationship and crisis, hearing that his

loyalty had finally become the right answer. The imagined scene had asked nothing of Nia except to recognize a role Malik had written for her.

He could admit the fantasy had comforted him without treating it as a contract she had broken.

Malik opened their message history, not to search for evidence, but to see the friendship as it actually existed: jokes, study plans, disagreements, storm updates, and honest support. That relationship was real. The promised romantic ending had been private.

Deleting the reminder protected the friendship from becoming an invoice.

He opened his spring calendar and added Simone's coffee without marking it "networking" or "analytics."

Then he completed a registration check. Calculus II, actuarial prerequisites, North Star hours, and one open evening remained visible. He practiced antiderivative patterns for thirty minutes, corrected two algebra errors, and stopped when the timer ended.

Moving forward looked less dramatic than confession.

It looked like making room for the future to contain evidence he did not already control.

Tuesday, December 30: Warm and Final

Julian messaged Nia before New Year's Eve.

Hope Huntsville has been good to you. Thank you for the good parts of this year. Wishing you a spring that feels like yours.

Nia read the message slowly.

No question. No reference to missing her. No disguised invitation to restart the relationship at midnight.

She replied: **Thank you for the good parts too. I hope spring gives you stories worth telling and some you keep for yourself. Happy New Year, Julian.**

His response was a simple heart.

The exchange felt warm, sad, and finished.

Nia placed the phone down and returned to the proposal call with Keisha. They repaired an algebraic relationship in the simplified flow model and compared two graph interpretations. Keisha rejected a variable Nia could not define from available sources.

"The map looked better with it," Nia complained.

"We are not applying for Prettiest Unsupported Arrow."

"That award has prestige."

"No funding."

They removed the arrow.

Wednesday, December 31: Background Laughter

At midnight, Nia called Malik.

Her family had counted down in the living room. Fireworks sounded several streets away. Nia expected Malik to answer from the Baptiste porch or the temporary living-room bed.

Instead, several voices filled the connection.

"Happy New Year," Malik said.

In the background, DJ shouted something about championship energy. Andre argued with a video filter. Then Simone laughed, clear and close enough to be unmistakable.

Nia's chest tightened.

"Group call?" she asked.

"Analytics team and DJ. Simone started it after somebody posted the wrong time zone."

"Sounds fun."

Her voice became brighter than the moment required.

Malik paused. "You okay?"

"Yes. Just loud here. Happy New Year."

"Happy New Year, Nia."

She ended the call before she could ask why Simone was there, whether they had talked over break, or why any answer mattered.

The fireworks continued.

Nia told herself the sharp feeling was surprise.

Thursday, January 1: Open the Application

New Year's Day began quietly.

Nia woke late and saw no missed call from Malik. That was reasonable. They had spoken. Nothing had gone wrong.

The sharp feeling remained.

She considered calling Keisha and turning it into a full analysis. She considered calling Malik back with a casual question. She considered checking Simone's social media, which would have produced data and no wisdom.

Instead, Nia opened the research application.

The form asked for the question, team roles, available data, proposed methods, anticipated limitations, and how the work would involve affected communities.

She entered both names: **Nia Reynolds, mathematical modeling and communication. Keisha Morgan, computation and data-method co-lead.**

For the limitations section, Nia wrote that missing road-capacity values might prevent a reliable route recommendation. She did not promise the model would solve what the data could not support.

The work steadied her without erasing the feeling.

Spring would return with two new partnerships: Malik and Simone exploring something personal, Nia and Keisha building something competitive.

The emotional current had reversed before Nia was ready to name it.

Week Twenty-Three: The First Return

DJ had placed the Heritage Bowl trophy beside an unfinished economics assignment.

Malik discovered both when he returned to the residence hall Friday afternoon. The trophy occupied the center of their shared shelf beneath a battery-powered spotlight DJ had apparently purchased for this purpose. Beside it, a laptop displayed half a paragraph about labor markets.

"One of these is evidence of completed work," Malik said.

DJ emerged from beneath his bed holding a missing shoe. "One is inspiration for future work."

"Your paper is due Monday."

"The trophy believes in me."

The room had been reorganized. DJ's expanded football schedule claimed a new section of wall. Malik's desk remained clear except for mail, his spring books, and a note from Ms. Alvarez confirming North Star shifts.

His old room in Gulfport remained unfinished. This one had become more recognizably home.

Malik unpacked his calculus materials and placed the analytics postmortem in a drawer rather than on top of the new semester.

Then his phone lit up with Simone's message.

Coffee Sunday? Personal, in case the analyst remains confused.

Malik replied: **Interpretation confirmed. Yes.**

Friday, January 2: Reorganized

DJ showed Malik the scholarship update in his student account.

"Official," he said. "My mother checked twice and then made me check while she watched."

"Reasonable audit procedure."

"She also told me the money does not make me too important to complete economics."

"Strong methodology."

They worked side by side for an hour. Malik reviewed algebra and antiderivatives for Calculus II. DJ finished the missing paragraph, then argued that football had given him practical experience with labor specialization.

"You catch passes," Malik said.

"Specialized labor."

"You also block."

"Cross-functional expertise."

The familiar nonsense settled Malik into campus life more effectively than the unpacked boxes.

Before bed, he looked at Simone's coffee on his calendar. He felt hopeful, nervous, and free of the old obligation to compare every possibility with Nia.

That freedom was not complete.

It was real enough to begin.

Saturday, January 3: The Skeptical Mentor

Research matching took place in Eliza Moss Hall.

Nia and Keisha pitched their evacuation-model idea to Dr. Price and a room of faculty, graduate mentors, and student teams. Nia explained the public question. Keisha explained the computational limits. Their application named missing road capacity as a central problem rather than an inconvenience to hide.

Dr. Price assigned them Alexis Grant, a second-year applied mathematics master's student.

Alexis read the one-page proposal without smiling.

"What decision will this model support?" she asked.

"Route recommendation under flood risk," Nia said.

"For whom?"

"Households and emergency planners."

"Those are different users with different authority. Which one?"

Nia glanced at Keisha.

"Emergency planners first," Keisha said. "Household communication would require another interface and trust assumptions we do not have."

Alexis nodded slightly. "What is your smallest defensible question?"

Nia described how missing road capacity might change which route appeared feasible.

"Better. Do not tell me you are saving Bellwether. Tell me what comparison you can complete by the campus forum."

The skepticism irritated Nia.

It also prevented the giant dream from swallowing the project before it began.

Alexis scheduled their first data audit for Wednesday.

Sunday, January 4: Personal Coffee

Residence halls officially reopened Sunday, filling campus with rolling suitcases and reunion noise.

Simone met Malik at Copper Cup.

She wore a rust-colored coat over a cream sweater and had selected a table away from the foot traffic.

"No laptops," she said when he arrived.

"I did not bring one."

"Good. I was prepared to confiscate it."

Their coffee began with holiday stories. Simone described her younger brother attempting to build a stock portfolio using only companies whose commercials he liked. Malik described the non-Euclidean pie and showed photographic evidence.

"That crust needs structural analysis," Simone said.

"Nia recommended whipped cream stabilization."

The name entered naturally. Simone did not react. Malik did not turn the conversation toward Nia.

After an hour, Simone rested her elbows on the table.

"I asked you here because I like talking to you," she said. "Not because I want to rebuild analytics."

"I like talking to you too."

"Are you available to find out what that means?"

Malik thought of the deleted reminder, the friendship he still valued, and the distinction between being uncertain and being unavailable.

"Yes," he said.

This yes belonged to the person in front of him.

Monday, January 5: Too Bright

Malik told Nia about the coffee during their first accountability check-in.

"Simone and I met yesterday," he said. "It was personal. We are going out again."

He did not ask whether Nia approved. He told her because their friendship had room for significant news.

Nia's smile arrived too quickly.

"That is great! Simone is amazing. Smart, direct, accomplished, very good at telling you when you are being ridiculous. Honestly, ideal."

Malik stared at her.

"What?"

"That was a lot of approval."

"I am happy for you."

"Thank you."

The exchange should have ended there. Instead, Nia asked where they went, how long they talked, and whether Simone had called it a date.

"Coffee," Malik said. "Personal coffee. We are having dinner Thursday."

"Dinner. Nice. Great."

Her brightness confused him. It confused her more.

That night, Nia told herself she was protective. Malik had been through a hard fall. Simone was a second-year with large ambitions. Nia only wanted clarity for her friend.

The explanation had too many words.

Tuesday, January 6: What Can an Integral Measure?

Dr. Victor Delgado opened Calculus II with one question.

"What can an integral measure besides area?"

Hands rose.

"Volume," one student said.

"That is accumulated area. Try again."

"Distance."

"From what? Under which conditions?"

"Work."

"Define it."

Five memorized answers failed under follow-up questions.

Dr. Delgado was precise without being cold. He did not reject the topics; he rejected labels offered without relationships.

Nia described total change accumulated from a rate. Malik explained that integrating velocity gave displacement, while integrating speed gave distance traveled. Amara added units and conditions.

"Better," Dr. Delgado said. "Calculus II is not a catalog of integration tricks. Every method must answer why this structure represents this quantity."

He assigned an accumulated-area review using water inflow and outflow. Nia saw immediate connections to flood modeling. Malik saw repair costs and risk over time.

The rate graph crossed the horizontal axis twice. Positive regions represented water entering a reservoir; negative regions represented water leaving. A student added the absolute values and reported total movement.

Dr. Delgado shook his head. "The question asks for net change. Direction matters."

Nia split the integral at the sign changes, evaluated each signed region, and combined them. Malik checked that rate units multiplied by time produced volume. Amara explained why total water moved would require absolute accumulation instead.

"Same graph," Dr. Delgado said. "Different quantity. Your integral does not know what you meant to ask."

Nia wrote the sentence beside her research notes. A route model could accumulate travel time, vehicle count, or exposure, but the team had to decide which quantity matched the decision. Computation would not rescue a vague objective.

The course began by demanding meaning before technique.

Neither student could accuse that demand of being unfamiliar.

Wednesday, January 7: The Model Cannot Run

Spring classes began Wednesday, along with add-drop and the research team's first data audit.

Keisha loaded the road network. Nia prepared flood-zone overlays. Alexis watched without helping them avoid the problem.

Road-capacity values were missing for nearly thirty percent of the network.

Not evenly missing. Smaller neighborhood roads had the least documentation, while major roads had the most. Filling every gap with an average would make poorly documented streets resemble well-measured roads.

"The proposed model cannot run as written," Keisha said.

Nia looked at Alexis. "Could we estimate from road width?"

"Do you have width?"

"For some roads."

"Then you have another missing-data pattern."

The team tested a simplified route set. Even there, capacity assumptions changed the recommended path.

Nia felt the proposal collapsing.

Keisha did not. "We asked how missing capacity changes recommendations. The missing data is not blocking the question. It *is* the question."

Alexis finally smiled. "Now decide what experiment can demonstrate that honestly."

They stayed late, replacing a promise of one best route with a comparison of how route choices shifted under plausible capacity scenarios.

Thursday, January 8: Coffee Becomes Dinner

Malik met Simone after his North Star shift.

They began at Copper Cup again, but the cafe closed before they ran out of conversation. Simone suggested dinner at a small place off Cypress Walk.

Malik checked his schedule. He had left the evening open on purpose.

"Yes," he said.

Across campus, Nia and Keisha worked with Alexis to define the smallest research question their data could survive. Nia's phone showed no new message from Malik. That was normal. He was not required to report a date in progress.

At dinner, Simone asked Malik what he hoped spring would contain.

"Better calculus. Stable work hours. Progress on the house."

"Those are outcomes. What do you want to experience?"

Malik had no prepared answer.

"I do not know yet," he said.

"Good. Something we cannot turn into a deliverable."

They shared dessert and talked until the server began resetting nearby tables.

At Eliza Moss Hall, Nia erased the phrase **optimal evacuation route** and replaced it with **route sensitivity under missing capacity data**.

Two commitments took shape that night: one relationship and one research question, each becoming more honest as it became narrower.

Week Twenty-Four: Volumes and Openings

Dr. Delgado refused to let anyone integrate.

He drew a region between two curves and announced that it would be rotated around a vertical line. Students reached for formulas.

"No computation," he said. "Choose a method first."

The room became uneasy.

Washers would slice perpendicular to the axis of rotation. Shells would slice parallel. Both could produce the same volume, but one setup required solving each curve for the other variable and splitting the region. The other used one clean integral.

"Shells," Malik said.

"Why?"

"Vertical slices match the current equations. Rotating them around a vertical axis creates shells. We avoid rewriting and splitting."

Dr. Delgado looked at Nia. "Would washers be wrong?"

"No. Just less efficient here. If the axis or equations changed, the choice could change."

"Exactly. Technique is a decision, not a reflex."

Only after the class defended its choice did he allow the first integral.

Nia drew a shell beside the region. Malik labeled radius, height, and thickness. The volume came last.

Friday, January 9: Choose Before Computing

The class compared washer and shell methods across several solids.

Dr. Delgado required a short justification before every setup. "Because I remember the formula" earned no credit. Students had to name the slice, axis, radius or radii, and reason the method reduced complexity.

Nia liked the visual logic. She could imagine each rectangle turning through space. Malik liked that method choice could be defended by structure rather than preference.

Amara found a case where both methods required two integrals.

"Which is better?" she asked.

"Define better," Dr. Delgado replied.

Fewer algebraic steps? Easier bounds? Lower risk of sign error? More meaningful units? The answer depended on what they were trying to protect.

After class, Malik left to meet Simone for lunch. He did not announce it.

Nia noticed anyway.

She returned to her research notes and drew flood zones as regions. If a region rotated, she could visualize volume. If water depth varied across the actual city, the elegant solid became an approximation with geography hidden inside it.

Her project demanded a method choice too.

Saturday, January 10: Elegant and Impossible

Nia presented the team with a polished three-dimensional sketch.

The flood zone became a rotated region. Height represented water depth. Concentric layers suggested growing exposure. The image was elegant enough for a poster.

Keisha placed the road network over it.

The recommended paths crossed water, ignored a rail line, and sent traffic toward a bridge with incomplete capacity data.

"Your picture is beautiful," Keisha said.

"I hear the word *but*."

"But the roads did not agree to become radial coordinates."

Alexis asked what the visual was supposed to establish.

"Accumulated exposure," Nia said.

"Then do not let the audience confuse exposure volume with an evacuation network."

They separated the layers. One visual estimated accumulated flood exposure. Another displayed the real road graph. A third showed where uncertain road capacities changed feasible routes.

To test the distinction, Nia used washers to estimate the volume represented by one simplified cross-section. Outer radius described the projected flood boundary; inner radius excluded a raised region. Keisha verified the numerical setup, then pointed to three roads inside the same geometric band.

One road crossed a low underpass. One ended at a locked service gate. The third appeared connected on the map but lacked a verified capacity value.

"The volume estimate can be mathematically sound," Keisha said, "and still tell us nothing about whether a bus can reach a shelter."

Alexis made Nia write that limitation directly beneath the image. The picture could describe exposure. It could not stand in for transportation access.

The result was less elegant and more truthful.

Nia saved the original image in a folder labeled **ATTRACTIVE WRONG IDEAS**.

Keisha approved. "That folder will be full by March."

"From both of us."

"Correct answer."

Sunday, January 11: After the Error

The Heritage Tip-Off began with the women's basketball game at Ruth Ellis Fieldhouse.

Nia sat with Keisha and Imani. The McCall-Hart women led early, then lost the lead after two turnovers. A first-year guard made the second mistake in front of the student section and immediately looked toward the bench.

"That walk back is the longest distance in sports," Imani said.

As a softball shortstop, she knew what a visible error felt like: the ball rolling beneath a glove, the crowd reacting before the play finished, the next batter arriving while shame still occupied the last pitch.

The guard returned in the fourth quarter. She did not take a miraculous game-winning shot. She defended well, made the simple pass, and helped stabilize the offense during a winning run.

"People think confidence means forgetting the error," Imani said. "Usually it means making the next choice while remembering it."

Nia thought about the attractive wrong image, her first relationship, and the too-bright congratulations she had given Malik.

"How do you know when to trust yourself again?" she asked.

"You do not wait for trust to become a feeling. You prepare, then make the next defensible choice."

McCall-Hart won by seven.

Nia left the fieldhouse with no clear answer about Malik, only a better rule for what not to do next.

Monday, January 12: Leave on Time

The men's Heritage Tip-Off game ran late.

Overtime began at 7:28. Malik's dinner with Simone was scheduled for eight. The student section begged everyone to stay. DJ argued that leaving overtime violated campus law.

At 7:34, Malik stood.

"The game is tied," DJ said.

"I can see that."

"History is occurring."

"Simone is waiting at eight."

"Tell her basketball requested an extension."

Malik put on his coat. "I told her I would be there."

Nia watched from two seats away as he left before the final score.

In fall, Malik had rushed a calculus test for analytics. Nia had tried to squeeze a review and Julian's showcase into one evening. Now Malik chose the prior commitment and accepted missing the campus moment.

He arrived at the restaurant at 7:56.

Simone glanced at the game updates on his phone. "You left overtime?"

"Yes."

"I am impressed and slightly concerned about your school spirit."

"DJ has enough for both of us."

McCall-Hart won while they ordered dinner.

Malik was disappointed to miss it.

He did not make Simone pay for the choice.

Tuesday, January 13: Outside Achievement

Spring add-drop ended Tuesday, locking schedules into something more serious.

At dinner, Simone returned to the question Malik had not answered Thursday.

"What do you want outside achievement?"

Malik considered giving a polished response. He had none.

"Stability," he said. "A home where one storm does not undo everything. Work that pays enough for my parents to stop treating every bill like a threat."

"Those are still outcomes."

"I know."

He looked at his hands. "I want to be able to enjoy something while it is happening. I want people to tell me bad news without worrying I will turn it into a plan before they finish. I want to rest without feeling like someone else is becoming more prepared than me."

Simone's expression softened.

"That is unfinished," Malik said.

"Good. I asked what you want, not for a mission statement."

He asked her the same question.

Simone wanted work that placed her in consequential rooms, travel, financial independence, and relationships that did not require her to make ambition smaller to appear loyal.

Neither promise fit perfectly with the other.

They liked the honesty enough to keep learning.

Wednesday, January 14: The Smile

Malik returned to the residence hall courtyard smiling.

Nia was crossing toward North Star with research maps under one arm. She saw him before he saw her.

The smile was not the public grin from a team announcement. It was loose, private, and attached to whatever message he had just read from Simone.

Nia stopped walking.

All fall, she had assumed Malik's feelings would remain where she left them: patient, quiet, available if she ever looked directly. She had never asked him to wait. She had also benefited from believing he would.

Malik noticed her. "Hey."

"Hey. Good date?"

"Yes."

No apology. No attempt to make the answer easier for her.

"Good," Nia said, less brightly this time.

He asked about the research maps. Nia explained the road-network problem. Malik listened, asked one useful question, and continued toward his room.

She watched him go.

The sharp feeling from New Year's Eve finally acquired a more honest name.

Loss of possibility.

And perhaps desire.

Thursday, January 15: No Plan to Interfere

Nia told Keisha after track conditioning.

"I may have feelings for Malik."

Keisha drank half a bottle of water before responding. "May?"

"Fine. I have feelings for Malik."

"And Malik is dating Simone."

"They have been on two dates."

Keisha looked at her.

"I know how that sounded," Nia said. "I am not trying to interfere."

"Good, because I am not helping you build a strategy."

"I did not ask."

"Your face opened a planning meeting."

Nia sat beside her on the bench. "What am I supposed to do?"

"Feel it. Respect their relationship. Keep being honest with yourself. Do not turn friendship into a campaign."

"That sounds deeply inactive."

"It is active restraint. You should recognize the concept by now."

Nia groaned.

Keisha continued, "Also, our proposal is due soon. My code does not care about your romantic reversal."

"The code has poor emotional intelligence."

"The code has boundaries."

Nia opened the research folder.

The spring relationship had begun. So had her feelings. Only one of those facts gave her permission to act.

Week Twenty-Five: Work Worth Doing

By nine Friday morning, the gym at Bellwether Community Center had become a machine made of folding tables, canned beans, clipboards, and people shouting helpful instructions in opposite directions.

Nia stood near the entrance holding a map that said the line should move clockwise.

The line had other plans.

Families entered through the east doors, checked in beside the bleachers, crossed to the produce tables, doubled back for dry goods, and then collided with volunteers bringing boxes from the loading dock. On paper, the path was a clean loop. In reality, one grandmother had stopped beside the oranges to reorganize three bags, two toddlers were conducting an unauthorized sprint relay, and a pallet of bottled water had narrowed the safest aisle to one person at a time.

Keisha stepped around a rolling cart. "Your map is being defeated by juice boxes."

"My map is a preliminary model."

"Your preliminary model is still losing."

Nia looked down at the evacuation network she and Keisha had brought for comparison. Roads, capacities, and shortest paths covered the page. It assumed movement happened along available edges. It did not account for people waiting, carrying supplies, helping relatives, or reaching a narrow point at the same time.

She circled the crowded aisle.

"Congestion," she said.

"Here? Absolutely."

"In our model. We treat a route like it stays equally usable no matter how many people choose it."

Keisha stopped teasing. "That is not a small problem."

"No," Nia said, watching the line bend around the water. "It is finally a useful one."

Friday, January 16: The Map Meets the Room

The service project was part of McCall-Hart's Martin Luther King Jr. weekend, which meant students arrived in matching cream volunteer shirts and spent the first fifteen minutes taking pictures before anyone trusted them near inventory.

Malik and Simone were assigned to packing. Malik counted items with quiet precision. Simone redesigned the station after observing that everyone reached across everyone else for rice.

"You moved my beans," Malik said.

"I improved your beans."

"They were alphabetized by category."

"They are canned goods, not scholarship applications."

Within ten minutes, their table filled boxes faster than either neighboring station. Malik staged empty cartons. Simone called quantities. When supplies ran low, she announced it before the line stopped. They did not compete for control because each noticed what the other was already doing well.

Across the gym, Nia and Keisha timed how long families spent at each station. They asked permission before recording anything and used station numbers rather than names. A route that looked shortest was often slowest because it crossed the loading path. An older volunteer explained that the center normally placed water near the exit, but a delivery delay had forced them to improvise.

"So today's bottleneck is not permanent," Nia said.

"None of them are," the volunteer replied. "That is why a pretty plan can embarrass you."

Nia wrote the sentence in her notebook.

At cleanup, she showed Keisha a new question: how sensitive were recommended evacuation routes to missing road-capacity information and changing congestion?

Keisha read it twice. "Now we have something testable."

"Not just admirable?"

"Admirable does not compile."

Nia laughed. The project felt less like a promise to save everybody and more like work they could honestly do.

Saturday, January 17: Clear Terms

The second service shift ended with flattened boxes stacked shoulder-high and Malik discovering rice inside one shoe.

Simone sat beside him on the community-center steps while volunteers waited for the campus shuttle. The winter sun was bright without being warm.

"We make a good station," Malik said.

"An irresistible declaration."

"I had a more complete thought."

"I was hoping."

He smiled, then became serious. "I like what we are doing. I do not want to keep calling it two dinners and coffee as if naming it would damage it."

Simone rested her forearms on her knees. "What name are you proposing?"

Malik had rehearsed several sentences. All of them sounded like contract language now.

"I want to date you exclusively," he said. "If you want that too."

Simone did not rescue him from the silence. She considered the offer with the same respect she gave important data.

"I do," she said. "Exclusively, but not invisibly. I am applying for internships, including one overseas. I am not shrinking that plan to make a relationship feel safer."

"I would not ask you to."

"You might try to solve the distance before it exists."

Malik conceded the point with one lifted hand.

"And you," Simone continued, "do not get to present calm when you are actually upset and then expect me to discover the difference."

"That seems specific."

"I pay attention."

"Then yes. Clear terms."

"You make dating sound like a well-designed study."

"Replication is important."

She laughed and leaned against his shoulder. When the shuttle arrived, they boarded as boyfriend and girlfriend, though neither said the titles aloud until DJ asked why Malik looked as if his credit score had improved.

Sunday, January 18: The Long Way Home

Nia heard the news over brunch.

Malik said it simply. Simone reached for the hot sauce. Keisha studied her waffle with the concentration of a person refusing to become an emergency-response team.

"That is good," Nia said. "Really. Congratulations."

She meant it.

That was the inconvenient part.

Simone deserved someone who listened to her ambition without treating it as a threat. Malik deserved a relationship he had chosen rather than a waiting room built around Nia's uncertainty. Wanting those things for them did not prevent something inside Nia from folding in on itself.

After brunch, Malik and Simone walked toward the Porter Center. Nia said she needed to stop by the library.

She did not.

Instead, she took the longest reasonable route to North Star Hall. She crossed the arts quad, circled Ruth Ellis Fieldhouse, and followed the campus edge where bare trees scratched at the blue sky. Her phone offered shortcuts she ignored.

The walk was not punishment. It was privacy.

She did not want to perform being unaffected for friends who knew her too well. She also did not want pain to turn into evidence that Malik had done something wrong.

Near the residence hall, she found Julian loading saxophone cases into a van.

"You know North Star is the other direction," he said.

"I am pursuing a scenic theory of navigation."

"Your theory looks cold."

He offered no questions. She offered no explanation. They lifted the final case together, exchanged a small goodbye, and continued with separate days.

In her room, Nia opened the research map. A longer route was not always a mistake. Sometimes the shortest available path cost more than distance could measure.

Monday, January 19: What the Work Requires

The university was closed for Martin Luther King Jr. Day, but Dr. Delgado had posted one optional problem to prepare for Tuesday.

A cart carrying relief supplies moved along a route while the force required to push it changed with distance. Students had to calculate the work.

Nia nearly skipped it. Then she pictured the community center: bottled water narrowing an aisle, full bags becoming heavier, volunteers slowing at turns.

The integral did not simply multiply one force by one distance. It accumulated changing effort across many tiny intervals.

She covered her desk with notes.

If evacuation difficulty changed along a road, then route length alone was not enough. A mile with reliable capacity, level access, and low congestion was different from a mile that narrowed near a flooded underpass. They could define a cost that changed by segment, then test how recommendations shifted when uncertain capacities changed.

Keisha returned from an early conditioning session and found Nia talking to a diagram.

"Should I give you privacy?"

"The diagram and I are developing a weighted route cost."

"That sounds serious."

Nia explained distance, expected load, access constraints, and uncertainty. Keisha listened, then opened her laptop.

"We can run scenarios instead of pretending we know one exact capacity," she said. "But we have to state which weights are assumptions."

"Agreed."

"And we are not calling it the Reynolds model."

"I was thinking Morgan-Reynolds."

"Alphabetical order has briefly saved you."

They worked until dinner, building a method that admitted what it did not know. The mathematics did not make the project noble. It made the work accountable.

Tuesday, January 20: A Question, Not a Halo

Dr. Alana Price read their symposium draft in complete silence.

Nia had written about flooding, unequal access, vulnerable neighborhoods, and the urgent need for better evacuation planning. The introduction glowed with purpose. The method occupied four uncertain lines near the bottom.

Dr. Price placed the pages on her desk.

"You care," she said.

"Yes."

"That is not a research method."

Nia felt the sentence hit every paragraph she had polished.

Dr. Price tapped the title. "Symposium reviewers are not judging whether flooding is sad or whether service is good. They are judging whether you asked a precise question, used a defensible method, and understood your limits. Noble intentions can still produce unreliable claims."

Keisha turned the draft sideways and began crossing out entire sentences.

Nia stared at her. "Those took hours."

"They are wearing a halo where the method should be."

Dr. Price almost smiled.

Together, they narrowed the application. They would not claim to identify the best evacuation plan for Bellwether. They would test how missing or uncertain road-capacity data changed route recommendations in a defined sample network. They would compare scenarios, report instability, and name assumptions.

"Better," Dr. Price said. "Now who made which decisions?"

Nia began, "I developed--"

Keisha's chair made one quiet sound against the floor.

Nia stopped.

The application named Nia first. It described Keisha as technical support.

The project had survived its first inflated claim. Its next problem was sitting beside her.

Wednesday, January 21: Put Her Name on the Decision

Keisha did not argue in Dr. Price's office. That would have made the correction too easy.

Back at North Star, she changed for track practice while Nia stood beside the desk holding the application.

"I wrote that badly," Nia said.

"You wrote what you believed."

"No. I know you are a coauthor."

"Then describe my authorship."

Keisha tied one shoe. "Who chose the data structure? Who built the scenario runner? Who flagged that one missing capacity should not become zero by accident? Who decided we need uncertainty ranges instead of one dramatic result?"

"You did."

"That is not support. Those are research decisions."

Nia wanted to explain that she had been rushing, that application language was awkward, that she had not meant to diminish anyone. Each explanation placed her intention at the center again.

"You are right," she said. "I will rewrite it. You decide whether the new version is accurate."

While Keisha practiced, Nia rebuilt the contribution statement. She named their shared question development. She credited Keisha's data-cleaning rules, code architecture, scenario design, and decision to preserve uncertainty. She described her own mathematical formulation, literature synthesis, and interpretation plan. She replaced every vague *we* with an actual responsibility where the distinction mattered.

Keisha returned after dark, damp with sweat and unimpressed by Nia's hopeful expression.

She read the new version.

"Move scenario design above implementation," she said. "The decision came before the code."

Nia moved it.

Keisha read again, then typed her name into the coauthor field herself.

"I am in," she said.

Nia did not hug her without asking. She did, however, perform a seated dance so embarrassing that Keisha threatened to withdraw on aesthetic grounds.

Thursday, January 22: A Clean Exit

Malik found the symposium draft open on a shared-lab monitor Thursday evening.

Nia was at the whiteboard, trying to write a route-cost expression without making every variable look equally certain. Malik read the title, then the research question.

"This is sharper," he said.

She turned. "Sharper than the version you saw last week?"

"That version wanted to solve evacuation. This one asks what your data can support."

He pointed to the scenario table. "You are measuring how often the recommended route changes?"

"And where it changes. Keisha thinks instability near one bridge could matter more than an average over the whole network."

"She is right."

"I know. I credited her this time."

Malik looked at her, understanding more than the sentence directly said. "Good."

For several minutes, they talked about the model. It was familiar and easy. Nia felt the old rhythm return: question, answer, correction, dry joke. She wanted to ask whether becoming official felt different. She wanted to tell him that she had taken the long route Sunday. She wanted, most dangerously, to see whether the quiet between them could still become something else.

Malik checked the time.

"I am meeting Simone," he said. "Your question is strong. Submit it."

He packed his notebook and left before Nia could turn intellectual closeness into emotional trespassing.

The door clicked shut.

Nia faced the whiteboard again. Respecting a boundary did not require pretending the feeling vanished. It required deciding what the feeling was allowed to do.

She completed the equation, sent the draft to Keisha, and waited for her coauthor's approval before touching the submit button.

Week Twenty-Six: Choosing a Method

Dr. Delgado wrote three integrals across the board.

At first glance, they looked like siblings: each contained a product, each included an exponential or trigonometric expression, and each appeared designed to ruin somebody's morning.

"Which formula are we using?" a student asked.

"That," Dr. Delgado said, "is the question that causes the trouble."

One integral yielded to substitution. One required integration by parts. The third could be manipulated either way, but one choice produced a longer problem than the one they started with.

Nia raised her hand. "Can we have a decision tree?"

"You may build one after you understand what the branches mean."

A groan moved across the room.

Dr. Delgado did not sympathize. "Methods are not recipes you match by appearance. Ask what changes when you differentiate one part. Ask what simplifies. Ask what new difficulty your choice creates."

Malik stared at the third integral. "So choosing a valid method is not enough."

"Correct. You are responsible for where the method takes you."

Nia wrote the sentence beside the symposium deadline in her notebook.

Friday, January 23: The Recipe Revolt

By the end of class, the board looked like a family argument conducted in symbols.

Amara had chosen the wrong factor for (u) in integration by parts and produced an integral more complicated than the original. Nia used substitution where no matching differential existed. Malik reached a correct answer, but only after two pages of algebra that Dr. Delgado reduced to six lines.

"I object to the phrase *only after*," Malik said.

"Your objection has been recorded and denied."

Dr. Delgado made them annotate each attempt: what they noticed, why they selected a method, and the first sign that the choice was helping or failing.

Nia hated the exercise until she saw the pattern. Her worst decisions were not random. She noticed one familiar feature, committed too early, and then defended the method because changing course felt like admitting defeat.

After class, she met Keisha in the lab for the research data audit.

"Today I learned we are allowed to abandon a method," Nia said.

"I have been telling you that since August."

"Dr. Delgado used notation."

"I will add notation to future complaints."

They divided the evacuation records. Nia checked route assumptions and units. Keisha tested identifiers, missing values, and duplicate rows. Their application had been submitted, but Dr. Price required a full audit before they presented a single result.

For two hours, everything looked encouraging.

Then Keisha said, "Do not celebrate that graph."

Saturday, January 24: The Beautiful Duplicate

Nia's first graph was excellent news.

Under most simulated capacity changes, the recommended routes remained stable. The result suggested their network could tolerate uncertain data better than expected. The bars were clean. The colors were accessible. The title almost wrote itself.

Keisha turned her laptop around.

"These records have different row numbers but the same location, time stamp, and route code."

"Could two reports be identical?"

"Four hundred and twelve times?"

Nia's excitement began backing slowly toward the exit.

The duplicated records were not evenly distributed. One well-documented route appeared hundreds of times more often than several uncertain routes. Their graph did not prove broad stability. It proved that repeated copies of one stable case could dominate an average.

"Maybe the duplicates represent confirmed observations," Nia said.

Keisha gave her a look.

"I heard it while I was saying it."

They traced the error to merged files from two municipal exports. One dataset had already included the other's records. Nothing malicious had happened. The mistake was ordinary, quiet, and powerful enough to manufacture good news.

Nia stared at the graph. "The application deadline passed."

"Our question is still valid."

"Our preliminary result is not."

"Then we do not use it."

Nia saved the audit notes, removed the graph from the slide deck, and renamed the image **DO_NOT_RESURRECT.png**.

"Very technical," Keisha said.

"I want future me to feel warned."

The corrected data produced a messier picture: several route recommendations changed dramatically when capacity estimates moved. It was less comforting and far more relevant.

Sunday, January 25: Delete in Daylight

Dr. Price convened the team Sunday afternoon. Alexis joined by video from the graduate lab, her face appearing above a stack of route maps.

Nia projected the beautiful graph first.

"This result is invalid," she said.

She explained the duplicate records, the biased average, and the corrected output. Then she deleted the graph from the active presentation while everyone watched.

There was no applause. Good research habits rarely received movie music.

Alexis asked why the duplicates had survived their first cleaning step.

Keisha explained that the files used distinct row identifiers, so exact-row detection failed. She proposed a composite check using location, time, and route attributes, followed by manual review of ambiguous matches.

"And what changes in the claim?" Dr. Price asked.

Nia took a breath. "We cannot say recommendations are generally stable. We can identify which parts of this sample network are sensitive to plausible capacity changes. The instability may be the finding."

"May be," Dr. Price repeated. "Keep that word until the evidence earns stronger language."

After the meeting, Nia expected to feel humiliated. Instead, she felt disappointed and strangely lighter. The false graph no longer required protection.

Keisha bumped her shoulder. "You deleted it before anyone had to wrestle the mouse away."

"Growth."

"Do not become unbearable about it."

They began the corrected run. Progress did not look like recovering the result Nia wanted. It looked like trusting the question enough to survive an inconvenient answer.

Monday, January 26: Her Room, Her Work

The Porter Center career panel was called **Data in High-Stakes Financial Decisions**, a title that guaranteed half the audience came for insight and the other half for free sandwiches.

Simone sat onstage beside an alumna from a regional bank and a professor who studied consumer credit. She spoke about model outputs that appeared objective while encoding historical decisions about who received loans, which neighborhoods attracted investment, and whose missing data was treated as risk.

Malik sat in the third row.

He had helped Simone practice Sunday night, but none of her answers belonged to him. When questions opened, he waited while several students asked about salaries and software certifications.

Then he raised his hand.

"When a model influences a financial decision," he asked, "what should an analyst document so someone outside the technical team can challenge its assumptions?"

Simone's expression brightened, not because he had rescued her, but because the question gave her room.

She discussed model cards, data lineage, uncertainty, monitoring, and the need to record who had authority to override an automated recommendation. The alumna expanded on regulatory review. The conversation became the strongest part of the panel.

Afterward, Malik waited while other students approached Simone. He did not hover behind her chair or tell anyone they were dating. When she finally joined him, she carried three internship contacts and one untouched sandwich.

"Good question," she said.

"Good answer."

"You knew I had one."

"That was the point."

She kissed his cheek in the crowded hallway, then handed him the sandwich because she knew he had skipped lunch.

Supporting her had not required becoming visible in her success. It required paying attention to what she wanted the room to understand.

Tuesday, January 27: A Seat Without a Sequel

Ruth Ellis Fieldhouse was almost full when Nia arrived for the men's basketball game.

Keisha was at track study hall. Imani was helping with softball recruits. The only open seat Nia could see was beside Julian, who had a camera bag under one knee and a paper tray of fries balanced on the other.

"This seat comes with media obligations," he said.

"I refuse to be interviewed during free throws."

"Reasonable boundary."

She sat.

The conversation began with the game and moved to the Marching Herons' spring travel schedule. Julian was helping produce short documentaries about student musicians balancing rehearsal, classes, and road trips. One trumpet player had recorded a statistics lecture from a hotel stairwell because it was the only quiet place in the building.

"You would like her," Julian said. "She labels every practice recording by date and emotional damage."

Nia laughed. "That is excellent metadata."

They did not discuss why their relationship ended. They did not test whether old tenderness remained. They talked about work they cared about, shared fries, and complained when an official missed an obvious traveling call.

Across the fieldhouse, Malik saw them.

His first reaction arrived before his better judgment: a tightness in his chest, a story about Nia and Julian finding their way back to each other, an old desire to know whether he had lost something.

Then Simone texted him a photograph of four internship application tabs and the caption: **ROMANCE IS TEMPORARILY UNDER REVIEW.**

Malik smiled, but the jealousy did not disappear.

He decided not to feed it with imagination.

Wednesday, January 28: Ask the Actual Person

Malik found Nia outside Dr. Delgado's classroom.

"Can I ask you something directly?"

Nia closed her notebook. The formality in his voice made her brace herself. "Yes."

"Are you and Julian considering getting back together?"

The question was so clean that she had no place to hide inside it.

"No. We happened to sit together. We talked about his band project."

Malik nodded once.

Nia studied him. "Why are you asking?"

"Because I saw you, felt jealous, and did not want to invent an explanation."

Her heart made one disloyal leap at the word *jealous*.

Malik continued before she could build a future out of it. "The feeling is mine to understand. I am not asking you to change anything."

That sentence returned the room to its proper dimensions.

"Julian and I had closure," Nia said. "Not the fake kind where people say they are fine and then communicate through playlists. We mattered to each other. We are still over."

"Thank you."

"Are you going to tell Simone you asked?"

"Yes."

Nia believed him.

Dr. Delgado opened the classroom door and announced that anyone conducting emotional conferences in the hallway should conduct them elsewhere or begin evaluating an integral.

"We choose the integral," Nia said quickly.

"Speak for yourself," Malik replied, but he followed her inside.

Thursday, January 29: Wanting the Wrong Proof

Nia told Keisha about the conversation while they checked the corrected dataset.

"He was jealous," Nia said.

"That is a feeling, not a proposal."

"I know."

"Your voice has created a parade for something you know."

Nia lowered her voice. "He cared."

"He asked a direct question, accepted your answer, and plans to be honest with his girlfriend. Those are good actions. Do not convert them into secret permission."

The correction stung because it was accurate.

Nia had told Malik the conversation with Julian was closure. It was true. She had also wanted Malik's jealousy to prove that his relationship with Simone had not changed what existed between them.

That was not a demand she had the right to make.

Across campus, Malik told Simone exactly what had happened.

She listened without pretending the admission was comfortable.

"Do you want to be with Nia?" she asked.

"I chose to be with you," he said.

"That is an action. I asked about the feeling."

Malik looked down. "Some of it is unresolved. I do not want to act on it."

Simone appreciated the truth and disliked needing it. Both reactions were allowed.

"Then do not make me manage what you refuse to examine," she said.

"I will not."

Neither called the conversation a victory. They stayed, asked harder questions, and made plans for Friday.

In the lab, Nia reviewed the corrected route results. She highlighted uncertainty instead of hiding it. A method was not good because it reached the answer she wanted. A relationship was not meaningful because it supplied the proof she wanted either.

Both required a more honest choice.

Week Twenty-Seven: Identity in the Integral

Nia volunteered for the board before Dr. Delgado finished asking.

The integral contained an odd power of sine and an even power of cosine. She knew the pattern. Save one sine factor, convert the remaining sine squared using an identity, and substitute.

She wrote $(1 + \cos^2 x)$ where $(1 - \cos^2 x)$ belonged.

The error sat in the center of the board, large and confident.

Nia continued for three more lines before Amara raised one careful hand.

"Should that be minus?"

Nia stopped.

Every instinct told her to repair the line quickly enough that the class might forget who had made it. Instead, she stepped aside.

"Yes," she said. "I used the wrong identity. Will you finish from there?"

Amara approached the board with visible surprise. She corrected the sign, completed the substitution, and reached the answer Nia had been charging toward.

Dr. Delgado asked Nia what had gone wrong.

"I recognized the problem type and stopped checking the actual relationship."

"And what repaired it?"

Nia looked at Amara. "Letting someone else see what I could not."

Friday, January 30: Finish the Solution

At lunch, Nia replayed the board mistake as if embarrassment improved with repetition.

Keisha stabbed a piece of broccoli. "You made a sign error, not a declaration of war."

"I began with tremendous confidence."

"That is your natural habitat."

"Amara had to finish my solution."

"And the university remained open."

Nia knew the embarrassment was not really about trigonometry. She liked being the person who moved first, connected ideas, and made the room less afraid. Stepping aside felt dangerously close to becoming unnecessary.

Later, she sent Amara a photograph of the corrected work with a thank-you. Amara replied that she usually knew the answer but talked herself out of raising her hand.

Then we both practiced something, Nia wrote.

In the research lab, the corrected data run finished. Keisha projected a network map covered in route changes. A few uncertain roads caused recommendations to swing across entire neighborhoods.

Nia nearly began assigning tasks. She caught herself.

"What do you think we should examine first?" she asked.

Keisha zoomed toward the bridge corridor. "Not the largest average change. This cluster. It affects fewer routes, but those routes have no close alternative."

Nia saw it after Keisha pointed it out.

Being a co-lead did not mean finishing every solution. Sometimes it meant recognizing whose view made the answer possible.

Saturday, January 31: Advancement With Notes

The campus research office sent its decision at 10:07 Saturday morning.

Nia was brushing her teeth when her phone began vibrating across the sink. She grabbed it with one wet hand and read the first line.

Their proposal had advanced to the campus presentation round.

Her scream sent Keisha running from the bedroom holding one track shoe.

"We advanced!"

Keisha screamed too. They jumped in a circle, nearly collided with the shower curtain, and called Dr. Price before remembering it was Saturday.

Then they read the reviewer notes.

The question was timely. The sensitivity approach was promising. The division of technical contributions was clear.

The assumptions about human decisions were vague.

Why would residents choose the modeled route? Did access to a vehicle change the recommendation? What happened when families traveled together, waited for relatives, or avoided roads they considered unsafe? The model treated route choice as if every person responded to the same cost in the same way.

Nia sat on the closed toilet lid, celebration temporarily adjourned.

"They are right," she said.

"Probably," Keisha replied. "But we should not invent human behavior because reviewers asked for it."

They called Alexis, who told them not to fix social uncertainty with decorative numbers.

"Separate what your model decides from what a person decides," she said. "Then ask people who understand the difference."

Advancement did not mean approval of everything they had done. It meant the work was strong enough to receive more demanding questions.

Nia printed the reviewer notes and taped them above her desk.

Sunday, February 1: Not Everybody's Weekend

Nia scheduled a six-hour Sunday rehearsal without consulting anyone.

She created an agenda, assigned sections, and brought enough snacks to make the assumption look generous. Keisha arrived at noon in track warmups.

"I have to leave at two," she said.

"The practice presentation is at four."

"My meet check-in is at three."

Nia blinked. "Today?"

"It has been on the calendar for a month."

"Can you join remotely afterward?"

Keisha stared at her. "After I race?"

Nia heard herself and disliked the sound.

"I am sorry. I assumed we would work through the weekend."

"You assumed *my* weekend belonged to the project."

Keisha packed her laptop. She had already completed the data-audit slides and left notes for the sections she would miss.

"We advanced because of both of us," she said. "That does not make you the owner of my time."

After she left, the room felt too large for Nia's agenda.

Nia shortened the rehearsal. She moved the code demonstration to Monday and sent Keisha a revised schedule rather than an apology disguised as another request.

Then she attended the meet.

She did not bring presentation notes.

Monday, February 2: A Life Beside the Project

Keisha crouched in the starting blocks beneath white fieldhouse lights.

Nia sat with Imani high in the bleachers. She knew Keisha trained, of course. She had seen the alarm go off before sunrise and watched damp practice clothes colonize their bathroom. But

knowing an activity existed was not the same as understanding that somebody had built a life inside it.

The starter raised the pistol.

Keisha exploded forward.

For less than a minute, there was no code, no symposium, no Nia. There was the curve of the indoor track, the tight rhythm of spikes, and Keisha hunting the stagger ahead of her. She crossed the line second in her heat and bent with both hands on her knees.

The board updated.

Personal best.

Nia shouted so loudly that Imani moved one seat away for hearing preservation.

Afterward, Keisha accepted Nia's congratulations but not an instant repair.

"I should have asked before scheduling," Nia said. "And I should know your meet calendar because you matter, not because I need to work around it."

Keisha considered that.

"Better apology."

"I practiced."

"Do not over-celebrate basic respect."

They took a picture beneath the results board. Back on campus, Nia rebuilt the project calendar with shared availability, separate task owners, and explicit approval before major meetings moved.

Keisha's goals did not orbit the research project. The project was fortunate to travel beside them.

Tuesday, February 3: The Planned Road Trip

Malik sent Simone a road-trip itinerary with departure time, fuel stop, arena parking, dinner options, backup dinner options, and a weather contingency.

She replied with a single question.

Are we attending basketball or evacuating a nation?

They were driving two hours to an away game with a student-alumni group. Malik wanted to leave at 2:15. Simone wanted to stop at a bookstore she had found near the highway and decide about dinner after the game.

"After the game, every restaurant near the arena will be crowded," Malik said.

"Then we wait or go somewhere else."

"That is avoidable uncertainty."

"It is dinner, Malik."

The disagreement sharpened in the Porter Center lobby. To Malik, planning protected limited money and time. To Simone, planning every hour made a short trip feel like a supervised field exercise.

"You said you wanted to enjoy things while they happen," she reminded him.

"Enjoyment does not require logistical failure."

"Spontaneity is not failure."

They stood in silence as the group loaded the bus.

Finally, Malik folded the itinerary and tore off the lower half.

"We keep the departure and tickets," he said. "You choose one unscheduled stop."

"One?"

"I am negotiating against my nature."

Simone accepted.

They visited the bookstore, missed Malik's planned dinner reservation, and ate excellent tacos from a truck outside the arena. McCall-Hart lost by four, but the trip did not.

Wednesday, February 4: Compatible Is Not Identical

On the ride home, Simone admitted that the bookstore had almost made them late.

Malik admitted the tacos were better than his reservation.

"Please document that conclusion," she said. "I may need it in future disputes."

"The sample size is one."

"A historic one."

They laughed quietly while most of the bus slept.

The disagreement had not revealed a fatal incompatibility. It had revealed two reasonable needs that could become unreasonable when treated as universal rules. Malik wanted predictability because surprises had often arrived carrying bills, damage, or bad news. Simone wanted room because ambition already placed enough of her life on schedules built by institutions and deadlines.

"I do not want every trip to be unplanned," she said.

"I do not want every minute assigned."

"That sounded painful."

"It was."

They agreed that future trips would have fixed anchors and open space. Neither described the compromise as one person winning.

Back at McCall-Hart after midnight, Malik walked Simone to her residence hall. She had an internship application due the next evening. He had an integration quiz in the morning.

They did not turn tiredness into a test of affection. They said goodnight and went to do separate work.

Compatibility, Malik was learning, was not sameness. It was the ability to remain curious when difference interrupted the plan.

Thursday, February 5: Shared Ownership

Nia opened Thursday's team meeting by projecting a new schedule.

Every task had an owner. Every meeting had confirmed availability. Keisha's track meets were marked as commitments, not inconveniences. Nia's mathematical analysis, Keisha's software work, and their joint interpretation were separate colors with equal space.

"You gave me veto authority over code-demo changes," Keisha said.

"Because you own the code demo."

"I accept this constitutional reform."

They turned to the reviewer comments about human decisions. Neither had the training to make a documentary, conduct public interviews, and redesign the model alone. Nia knew who could help with one part without becoming absorbed into all of it.

She met Julian at the campus radio studio.

"We need advice on public visualization," she said. "Only that. We are not asking you to speak for residents or make the research look more certain than it is."

Julian leaned back. "What do you want people to understand?"

"Where route recommendations become unstable and what assumptions cause the change."

"Then stop using three nearly identical shades of blue. Also, animation might show the route changing better than five frozen maps."

He sketched a sequence: one road capacity shifted, the recommended path moved, and a caption named the assumption responsible. He suggested testing the visual with viewers who had not spent six weeks staring at the network.

"That is exactly the scope we need," Nia said.

"Good. I have band travel and two films. I cannot become your media department."

"I know."

And this time, she did.

Nia returned to the lab with Julian's notes. Keisha approved the visualization test and added it to the shared plan.

Outside, February rain silvered the campus walkways. A research conference, a Calculus II test, and the opening of spring sports waited in the next week. Their calendar was crowded, their model was unfinished, and no one person owned the whole answer.

For the first time, that made Nia feel more prepared rather than less.

Week Twenty-Eight: The Room Beyond the Classroom

Dr. Delgado placed the Calculus II test face down on every desk.

"Before you turn it over," he said, "understand the first instruction."

Nia had never enjoyed a sentence that began that way.

"For each integral, identify the method you would use and justify the choice before computing. A correct answer with an unsupported method may lose credit. A correct setup with incomplete computation may earn substantial credit."

Someone near the windows whispered, "Substantial is not a number."

"Neither is panic," Dr. Delgado replied. "Yet many of you assign it great value."

He started the clock.

Nia turned over the paper. The first problem used substitution. The second required integration by parts. The third was a rational expression waiting to be decomposed into partial fractions. The fourth asked for a numerical approximation and an error comparison.

Her mind wanted to sprint. The instructions demanded that it choose a direction first.

Friday, February 6: Commit Before Comfort

Malik wrote his method choices in the margin before touching a single antiderivative.

Nia wrote one, began computing, doubted herself, and nearly erased everything. She stopped with the eraser pressed against the paper.

Dr. Delgado had not asked them to predict whether the method would feel comfortable. He had asked them to justify why its structure fit.

She left the line and continued.

The numerical-integration problem described changing water depth along a roadway. Exact measurements existed only at fixed intervals. Students could use left endpoints, right endpoints, trapezoids, or Simpson's rule, but they had to explain what information the approximation preserved and what it might miss.

Nia drew the road segments. The problem felt uncomfortably close to her research. One clean number could hide rapid changes between measurements. A method that performed well on a smooth curve might misrepresent a sudden dip beneath an underpass.

She chose Simpson's rule, wrote the conditions under which she trusted it, and named the risk.

Across the aisle, Malik caught himself beginning integration by parts with a choice that made the remaining integral worse. He crossed out the setup and restarted. The clock continued without sympathy.

When Dr. Delgado called time, the room released one collective breath.

"I would like to file a complaint against method selection," Nia said in the hallway.

"On what grounds?" Malik asked.

"It forces me to reveal my decisions before I know whether they work."

"That may be the point."

"I withdraw my request for your opinion."

Saturday, February 7: The Honest Blank Space

The final partial-fractions problem had survived Nia's test.

She had factored the denominator, written the correct decomposition, and solved two of the constants. Then time ended. Half the page remained white.

At breakfast, students compared answers with the energy of people investigating a crime they had all witnessed differently. One group insisted the last coefficient was negative. Another said the entire denominator had been copied wrong.

Nia refused to check.

"You are showing maturity," Keisha said.

"I am showing fear with excellent posture."

Dr. Delgado returned the tests electronically that afternoon. Nia's score was strong. The incomplete problem lost points, but her setup and explanation earned most of the credit.

His comment read: **Correct structure. Incomplete is preferable to unsupported invention.**

Nia stared at the blank portion of her scanned page.

In the fall, she had filled uncertain spaces with words because an empty answer felt like public evidence that she did not belong. This time, she had shown exactly what she knew and where time had stopped her.

Malik received a slightly higher score and a note warning him that his restart had cost too much time.

"We have opposite problems," Nia said.

"You commit before checking. I check until commitment becomes expensive."

"Together, we form one adequately timed student."

They laughed, then separated for the weekend. Nia and Keisha had conference bags to pack. Malik had already promised Saturday to Simone.

Sunday, February 8: Imperfect Work, Serious Questions

The Southeastern Mathematics Futures Conference occupied three floors of a downtown convention hotel and smelled like coffee, carpet cleaner, and printer ink.

Nia expected polished graduate research presented by people who had never made sign errors in public. Instead, the first poster she visited belonged to a first-year student studying bus arrival predictions with incomplete location data.

The student's model failed during rush hour.

She showed the failure on the poster.

"Why not remove that plot?" an audience member asked.

"Because that is when riders most need the estimate," the student replied. "If I only report the quiet hours, I am answering an easier question."

At another session, two undergraduates modeled food-pantry demand and admitted that their training data covered only one semester. A judge asked whether the model should guide purchasing. They said not yet, then described the validation they would need.

Nobody laughed at the unfinished work. The questions became more serious because the presenters were honest about it.

Nia filled pages with notes: define the decision, show the failure, name who is missing, do not confuse a visual with evidence, explain why uncertainty matters to a real person.

Keisha attended a session on reproducible computing. She returned carrying a sample data dictionary and the expression of someone who had discovered twelve new ways their project could be inadequate.

"Having fun?" Nia asked.

"Extremely. We need versioned datasets."

"That sounded less like fun and more like a threat."

They stayed until the final student poster closed, surrounded by imperfect work taken seriously.

For the first time, Nia could imagine their project in the room without needing it to pretend it was finished.

Monday, February 9: Mathematics in the Decision Room

The national-laboratory panel began with a storm map projected across a ballroom screen.

A Delta National Laboratory scientist explained how teams combined weather observations, infrastructure data, computation, social science, and emergency-management knowledge. The mathematical model did not command officials to evacuate. It clarified scenarios, uncertainty, and possible consequences so people could make decisions under pressure.

"Communication is not the decoration added after the mathematics," she said. "If a result cannot be interpreted, challenged, or connected to a decision, the work is unfinished."

Nia wrote the sentence in capital letters.

Another panelist described a technically accurate flood forecast that local officials misunderstood because the uncertainty range appeared as a faint shaded band. Residents saw one bold line and treated it as a guaranteed boundary.

Julian's advice about color suddenly felt less cosmetic. Keisha's insistence on data lineage felt less like documentation and more like trust.

During questions, Nia asked how early-career researchers could contribute without claiming expertise they did not have.

"Join a team where your limits are visible," the scientist said. "Learn to ask what decision your work affects and who carries the cost when it is wrong."

Afterward, Nia stood beneath the conference banner while people streamed toward lunch.

She did not merely want to visit rooms like this. She wanted to become capable of contributing inside them.

The fellowship connected to the spring symposium could place an undergraduate with a national research team. Until that moment, Nia had treated it as a bright possibility attached to good work.

Now it had shape.

She wanted it.

Tuesday, February 10: Both Parts of the Story

Imani's first softball game began with a routine ground ball rolling beneath her glove.

The error put a runner on base. Two batters later, the runner scored.

Imani returned to the dugout furious, but she did not throw her glove or search the stands for sympathy. She reviewed the play with the infield coach, adjusted her starting depth, and took the field again.

In the seventh inning, McCall-Hart trailed by one with two runners aboard. Imani drove a pitch into the right-center gap. Both runners scored. She reached second standing, shouting toward the dugout as her teammates spilled against the rail.

The Herons won.

A student reporter met her near the field afterward.

"How does it feel to erase that early error with the game-winning double?"

Imani wiped dirt from one forearm. "It did not erase it. The error happened, and the run counted. The double happened too. I adjusted and helped us win. Both are part of the game."

Nia, listening behind the fence, felt the answer settle beside her test and research notes.

Public stories loved replacement: one heroic moment canceling one bad moment, one award proving every earlier struggle worthwhile. But an achievement did not travel backward through time. It added to the story without deleting what came before.

Imani joined the group and pointed at Nia's conference badge. "How was the math convention?"

"Conference."

"Did anybody hit a double?"

"A first-year student defended a failed bus model."

Imani nodded solemnly. "So yes."

Wednesday, February 11: Say How Much You Want It

Nia and Keisha spread conference notes across their room.

They had collected ideas about validation, reproducible code, audience testing, uncertainty, and multidisciplinary teams. Every page suggested more work. The symposium fellowship application now looked less like a reward at the end of a good presentation and more like a narrow doorway surrounded by excellent people.

"I want it," Nia said.

Keisha continued typing. "We established that in December."

"No. I said I wanted the experience. I said presenting would be valuable either way. Those things are true, but they were also protective."

Keisha looked up.

"I want the fellowship badly enough that losing it will hurt," Nia said. "I want to work with people making infrastructure decisions. I want access to the lab, the mentoring, all of it."

The confession made her feel ambitious and childish at once.

Keisha did not tell her awards were unimportant. "Good."

"Good?"

"Now we can build for the actual standard instead of acting like wanting less makes us noble."

She pointed to their project plan. "Wanting the fellowship means we test harder. We document what fails. We do not overclaim because a dramatic result feels competitive. And if we lose, we call it a loss instead of pretending the experience was secretly all we wanted."

Nia exhaled. "You make emotional honesty sound like project management."

"Everything improves with version control."

They created a new milestone for the campus pitch. Honest ambition did not guarantee the outcome. It clarified what the work required.

Thursday, February 12: A Choice Without a Scoreboard

Malik had missed the conference.

Months earlier, that fact would have become a private competition in his mind. Nia would have gone somewhere important; he would have felt left behind; every enthusiastic detail would have sounded like evidence that she was moving into a future without him.

This time, he had chosen a planned day with Simone.

They visited a museum exhibit on Black business history, ate lunch without checking the time, and worked on separate applications in a quiet cafe. Malik did not spend the day refreshing conference posts to measure what he was missing.

Thursday evening, Nia showed him her notes at North Star.

"This panelist said communication is part of the mathematics," she said, turning pages quickly. "And one presenter kept the failed rush-hour plot because that was the exact situation the project was supposed to serve."

Malik read the notes with real interest.

"You should use this question," he said, pointing to a line about decision consequences.

Nia waited for him to explain why he had not attended, or for herself to imply that serious students would have gone.

Neither did.

"How was your day with Simone?" she asked.

"Good. She found an exhibit on a mutual-aid bank and spent twenty minutes correcting the wall text."

"That sounds like her."

Malik returned the notebook. "I am glad you went."

"I am glad you had your day."

The choices did not need a scoreboard.

Still, when Nia later passed a campus store overflowing with red hearts, she felt the reversed shape of spring. Malik had chosen someone else without failing her. She wanted a future he did not have to witness for it to be real.

Both truths followed her into Valentine's weekend.

Week Twenty-Nine: Valentine's Data

By Friday morning, McCall-Hart had been attacked by paper hearts.

They hung from residence-hall doors, bookstore windows, dining-hall napkin holders, and one deeply confused bronze statue near Cypress Walk. The campus store sold stuffed herons holding signs that read **YOU MAKE MY HEART TAKE FLIGHT**, which Nia considered an institutional failure.

"If anybody gives me that bird," she told Keisha, "I will release it into the wild."

"It is polyester."

"Then it will learn resilience."

Nia joked through breakfast, class, and three different student-organization rose tables. Humor kept every display at a safe distance. It worked until Julian's campus-radio show played a dedication from a student celebrating two years with her girlfriend.

The message was simple, affectionate, and public.

Nia stopped walking beneath the radio speaker outside the student center.

Friday, February 13: The Dedication

The student on the radio thanked her girlfriend for learning her late-night study order, attending dance showcases even when she was tired, and making ordinary Tuesdays feel chosen.

There was no proposal, marching band, or drone carrying roses. Still, everybody crossing the plaza heard it.

Nia remembered how badly she had once wanted visible romance. With Julian, public celebration had first felt like proof that love was real. Later, the pictures had become a place to hide what they were not saying in private.

Now Malik was dating Simone quietly. He had left overtime to keep a dinner promise. He attended her panel without taking the room. Their relationship did not need Nia to observe it, which somehow made it harder to dismiss.

Julian's voice returned after the dedication and introduced the next song without adding commentary.

Nia continued toward class.

She did not want Julian back. She did not want Malik to perform affection for the campus. What hurt was remembering that she had once stood at the center of someone's public choice while Malik waited nearby, and she had not understood the cost of treating his feelings as a possibility she could revisit later.

At the calculus review, Dr. Delgado returned their test corrections. Every student had to explain one wrong method and the evidence that should have changed the decision.

Nia selected her rushed partial-fractions work.

Recognizing a pattern was not the same as understanding what it required. Valentine's week, apparently, had assigned the same lesson twice.

Saturday, February 14: Questions for Later

Malik gave Simone a notebook.

It was small, copper-colored, and completely free of glitter. On the first page, he had written:

Questions we have not had time to answer yet.

Below it were six prompts.

What place do you want to visit without turning it into a career opportunity?

What does support feel like when you are disappointed?

Which part of your future are you afraid to say aloud because it may change someone else's plan?

Simone read the final question twice.

"This is either thoughtful or an extremely sophisticated homework assignment," she said.

"No due date."

"Extra credit?"

"No points."

"Now I know you are serious."

They spent Valentine's afternoon at a used bookstore and dinner at a small restaurant away from campus crowds. Simone had brought Malik a set of archival sleeves for the storm-damaged family photographs he kept sorting, plus a card that said she admired how he was learning to care without immediately controlling the outcome.

Neither gift was expensive. Both revealed attention.

At dinner, Simone wrote one question of her own in the notebook:

What opportunity would you want me to take even if it made our relationship harder?

Malik looked at it, then at her.

"You do not have to answer tonight," she said.

He appreciated the permission.

He also understood that the question had not appeared by accident.

Sunday, February 15: The Missing Warning

Nia began the campus research pitch with confidence.

She introduced Bellwether's flood-route problem, showed how uncertain road capacities could change a recommended path, and used Julian's animation to reveal each shift. Keisha demonstrated the scenario engine. The audience followed. Dr. Price nodded once from the back row.

Then a visiting reviewer raised her hand.

"Your model recommends a route after an official warning. Why do you assume every driver receives the warning at the same time?"

Nia moved to the next slide. "Our current focus is network capacity rather than message distribution."

"But the route recommendation depends on when people leave."

"We account for changing congestion."

"After equal notification. Do residents without reliable mobile service receive the same alert? Do they trust it? What if a message is only in English? What if one neighborhood hears through family before the official system?"

The questions opened a hole beneath the presentation.

Nia knew the reviewer was right. She also knew everyone in the room could see that she had not prepared for it.

"Those factors are outside the current model," she said, too quickly. "Every model requires scope."

"Certainly," the reviewer replied. "But a boundary should not hide an assumption that changes the decision."

Nia thanked her and called for the next question.

The pitch ended on time.

For Nia, it did not end at all.

Monday, February 16: The Answer Nia Would Not Give

During the feedback session, Nia defended the scope again.

They could not model everything. Communication data was difficult to obtain. Their proposal concerned route sensitivity. Adding trust, language, device access, and social networks could make the project impossible to finish before the symposium.

Each statement was true.

Together, they sounded like a wall.

The reviewer turned to Keisha. "How does the current software represent the warning?"

Keisha answered without looking at Nia. "It treats notification as simultaneous and universal. That is not evidence-based. It was a simplifying assumption we did not make visible enough."

Nia felt betrayed before she had time to feel ashamed of feeling betrayed.

"Would you remove the project from consideration?" the reviewer asked.

"No," Keisha said. "I would test how delayed or missing information changes departure timing, then state what we still cannot represent."

That was the answer the team needed.

Nia heard only that Keisha had given it in public.

After the session, she packed the laptop too aggressively.

"You could have discussed that with me first," she said.

"The question happened during the pitch."

"You made it sound like we ignored the problem."

"We did ignore the problem."

Keisha's voice stayed level. "I am your coauthor, not your agreement generator."

She left for track practice.

Nia remained beside the empty presentation screen, furious at criticism, furious at Keisha, and most furious because the honest answer had not belonged to her.

Tuesday, February 17: The Alert That Arrived Late

The baseball opener began beneath a sky that could not make up its mind.

Sunlight crossed the infield while dark clouds gathered beyond left field. Nia sat with DJ and Imani, still carrying the argument with Keisha like a stone in her coat.

During the fourth inning, DJ's phone buzzed with a campus weather alert warning of lightning nearby. Nia's phone remained silent. Imani had received a text from her softball coach five minutes earlier. Students in the upper rows began leaving, but the public-address system said nothing.

"Did you get an alert?" DJ asked.

"No."

The umpire stopped play several minutes later. Only then did the stadium announcement instruct everyone to move indoors.

Rain arrived while people crowded the concourse.

Nia looked around. Some students had left before the delay. Some learned from friends. Others waited until the official announcement. One older visitor asked what the phone message had said because she did not use the campus app.

Same storm. Different information. Different departure times. Different congestion.

DJ tilted his screen toward Nia. "Your research face is happening."

"The warning did not reach us equally."

"My phone is on the football-team system too. That may be why mine came first."

Imani added, "Coaches get alerts through athletics. Students get the campus app. Visitors get whatever somebody tells them."

The reviewer had not asked the team to model everything. She had exposed one assumption that controlled the entire sequence.

Nia texted Keisha: **You were right. I was defensive. I want to explain without asking you to forgive me immediately.**

Keisha replied after practice: **Tomorrow. Bring the alert times.**

Wednesday, February 18: A Role With Edges

Julian had already heard about the weather-delay confusion.

Campus radio received the official notice after athletics but before the stadium announcement. Several volunteers had reposted the alert on personal accounts, each using different wording.

"We can test message designs," he told Nia and Keisha. "Not emergency behavior. Just whether people understand what an alert asks them to do, how urgent it feels, and what information they think is missing."

Nia looked at Keisha before answering.

Keisha nodded. "If participation is voluntary and we do not collect personal emergency histories."

Julian suggested recruiting campus-media volunteers who could evaluate sample messages and explain how wording, audio, captions, and timing affected understanding.

"I will need a defined role," he said. "I do not want to become the person responsible for every public-facing decision because I know where the microphones are."

They wrote the role together.

Julian would advise on message design, coordinate a small comprehension test after Dr. Price approved it, document revisions, and manage the presentation animation. He would not conduct community interviews, interpret evacuation behavior, or alter the mathematical model without the co-leads.

Nia added authorship and credit terms.

"This is impressively specific," Julian said.

"Keisha has constitutionalized the project."

"Because your monarchy failed," Keisha replied.

Nia accepted the joke because she had earned it.

They sent the written role to Dr. Price. The project had gained another collaborator without pretending collaboration meant unlimited access to his time.

Thursday, February 19: Criticism Is Not Disloyalty

Nia apologized in the research lab.

She did not begin with intention.

"When you answered the reviewer honestly, I treated it like you had embarrassed me instead of protected the project," she said. "I wanted loyalty to mean agreeing with my defense. That was unfair to you as a coauthor."

Keisha closed the data window but did not soften the moment for her.

"You also made me absorb the criticism you would not accept," she said.

"Yes."

"And if that happens at the symposium, I will answer honestly again."

"You should."

Keisha waited long enough to see whether Nia would add a condition.

Nia did not.

They rebuilt the proposal around information flow. The model would no longer begin with every driver receiving one warning at the same instant. It would test several notification patterns: immediate official alerts, delayed delivery, partial reach, and staggered word-of-mouth spread. They would not claim the patterns represented every neighborhood. They would show how communication failure changed departure timing and route congestion.

The new design made the project harder. It also connected the road network to the people trying to use it.

Keisha restored Nia's access to the presentation controls, an action she described as "conditional democratic reform."

Nia laughed, then became serious. "Thank you for not protecting my confidence at the expense of the work."

"That is not what confidence is for."

On the whiteboard, Nia drew three alert sequences spreading through the same network at different rates.

The next mathematical unit would ask whether an infinite sequence approached a stable limit. Their project now had a more urgent question: after repeated updates, did useful information reach everyone soon enough to matter?

Week Thirty: The First Infinite Question

Dr. Delgado began the sequences unit without writing an infinity symbol.

Instead, he described a warning system that updated its estimated arrival time every minute. The first message predicted water in forty minutes. The next predicted thirty-four. Then thirty-one. Then twenty-nine and a half.

"If the updates continue," he asked, "are they approaching a stable warning time, or are we only hoping they are?"

Students proposed answers immediately.

"Twenty-eight minutes."

"It depends on the pattern."

"The storm does not care about our sequence."

"An excellent observation," Dr. Delgado said. "The mathematics describes the updates. It does not guarantee the world obeys the model."

He wrote the terms on the board and asked whether the sequence was monotonic, whether it was bounded, and what evidence would support a limit.

Nia thought about messages moving through the evacuation network. One alert was a snapshot. Repeated updates could approach clarity, amplify confusion, or never reach some people at all.

Friday, February 20: Getting Closer Is Not Arriving

The class built sequences from formulas, graphs, and recursive rules.

One sequence increased forever but never passed a fixed bound. Another bounced above and below a value while moving closer to it. A third looked stable for ten terms and then wandered away.

"Ten calm terms do not prove convergence," Dr. Delgado said. "A convincing pattern is not the same as a result."

Malik liked the definitions. Monotonicity described direction. Boundedness described restraint. Together, under the right conditions, they could guarantee convergence.

Nia liked the movement. A sequence carried its own history: each term related to an index, sometimes to the term before it, always to the question of what happened next.

During group work, she modeled the delay between an alert entering the system and reaching a growing share of recipients. Malik noticed that the percentage approached one hundred only because her recurrence assumed every unreached person had the same chance of receiving the next update.

"That is probably false," he said.

"Definitely false. People without service may remain unreachable across every term."

"Then your upper bound may be below one hundred percent."

The idea was painful and useful. A warning system could converge and still converge to an unacceptable limit.

Nia circled the sentence.

Getting closer did not answer the ethical question. They also had to ask what they were getting closer to.

Saturday, February 21: The Summer Door

Delta National Laboratory's virtual briefing filled a lecture room in the Porter Center.

The opening slide showed storm-surge simulations layered over roads, power systems, hospitals, and population data. Students from mathematics, computer science, engineering, public health, communications, and social science attended.

A Delta scientist described the summer partnership with McCall-Hart. Teams would examine how storm conditions and infrastructure failures changed evacuation options. No single major could own the problem.

"A fast model that ignores human decisions is incomplete," she said. "A perfect message that arrives after the road floods is incomplete. A community study disconnected from physical constraints is incomplete. We need teams capable of disagreeing across disciplines."

Nia looked at Keisha. Keisha was already taking notes.

The scientists emphasized data governance, reproducibility, uncertainty, and public accountability. Students would not receive unrestricted access to real emergency records. They would begin with carefully managed datasets and document every transformation.

Then Dr. Price explained the path forward. Spring symposium work could inform summer placements, but attendance at the briefing was not an invitation. Strong students might still be rejected. Selected teams would need faculty sponsorship and clearly defined roles.

Nia felt ambition rise without mistaking it for a promise.

During questions, Keisha asked about computation limits. Julian asked how public-facing media would be reviewed. Nia asked whether iterative route updates could be tested against changing warning reach.

The scientist said yes, if the team stated what drove each update and who remained outside the model.

The summer door had opened a few inches. Nobody had been invited through it yet.

Sunday, February 22: A Map That Can Change Its Mind

Their original project produced one recommended evacuation map for each scenario.

Nia no longer trusted the stillness.

Storm forecasts changed. Road capacities changed. Warnings reached people at different times. A route that was sensible at noon could become dangerous at 12:20, and a static map could not show why the recommendation moved.

She proposed an iterative model.

At each time step, the system would update estimated road capacity, warning reach, and departure volume. It would recalculate route costs and record whether recommendations stabilized. Keisha immediately identified the danger of making the software appear more certain simply because it updated more often.

"Frequent wrong answers are not live intelligence," she said.

"Put that on the poster."

They defined update rules, confidence labels, and stopping conditions. If new data stopped changing the route, the model could report temporary stability. If recommendations continued to oscillate, it should display instability rather than selecting the most recent path as truth.

Julian tested a rough animation. Roads shifted from copper to indigo as conditions changed. A side panel showed which assumption caused each update.

"It looks alive," Nia said.

"Do not fall in love with movement," Julian warned. "Animation can make weak evidence look authoritative."

She added the warning to their design notes.

The new project did not offer one perfect map. It showed a map capable of changing its mind and explaining why.

Monday, February 23: The City in the Notebook

Simone met Malik in the Porter Center courtyard carrying the copper notebook he had given her.

She opened to the question about opportunities that might make their relationship harder.

"I applied for a summer internship in London," she said.

Malik's first thought was distance. His second was cost. His third was the time difference, which he calculated before he could stop himself.

Simone continued. "It is a financial-data program with placements across banking and public policy. I have wanted it since October. I submitted the final application last week."

Last week.

Malik felt the delay, but he also heard the rest: she had wanted it for months and had been afraid the truth would become a relationship negotiation before the application was even real.

"You should have told me," he said.

"Yes. I should have."

She did not blame his planning for her silence. "I waited because I wanted the application to belong to me before it became about us. That was not fair."

"How badly do you want it?"

Simone met his eyes. "Very badly. If I receive it, I am going."

No softening. No promise that love would automatically solve geography.

Malik took a slow breath. "Then I hope you get it."

He meant that.

The future still rearranged itself inside him.

Tuesday, February 24: Solving Before Asking

By Tuesday morning, Malik had researched international phone plans, compared flight prices, mapped the five-hour time difference, and built a summer schedule around work, classes, and video calls.

He had not asked Simone whether she wanted a long-distance relationship.

The spreadsheet looked excellent.

That was the problem.

DJ found him staring at it in North Star Learning Commons.

"Is this a budget?"

"A preliminary feasibility analysis."

"For romance?"

Malik closed the laptop.

"Did she ask for one?" DJ said.

"No."

"Then you are doing emotional group work alone."

The phrase was ridiculous enough to be useful.

Malik deleted no information, but he moved the file out of sight. That evening, he told Simone he had started planning before asking what she wanted.

"I do not know yet," she said. "I do not even have the offer. I know I care about you. I also know I do not want my interview to become a referendum on whether we survive the summer."

"It will not."

"And if I get it, we need to decide together whether long distance makes sense. Not assume staying together is the only respectful answer."

Malik wanted to promise they could make it work. Instead, he asked what interview help she wanted.

"Practice questions," Simone said. "No optimization model."

"That boundary feels targeted."

"It is supported by data."

Wednesday, February 25: Nobody Attends Everything

McCall-Hart's baseball and softball schedules collided with a track meet, a Calculus II problem set, and DJ's offseason film review.

The friend group attempted to support everybody and nearly created a transportation crisis.

Imani wanted someone at the softball doubleheader. Keisha raced across town. Baseball hosted a conference opponent at the same time. DJ had promised to help Malik review sequences before reporting to football conditioning.

"We cannot divide one person into partial fractions," Nia said.

"That is not what partial fractions means," Malik replied.

"It expresses the emotional truth."

They built a coverage plan without pretending attendance measured friendship. Nia and Julian went to Keisha's early heat, then Julian left for baseball media work. Simone attended Imani's first softball game. DJ brought study notes to the second game and reviewed between innings. Malik stayed in the learning commons, where he hosted a shared call for anyone who needed sequence help.

Imani sent score updates. Keisha sent a picture of her relay team. Julian uploaded one baseball clip. Nobody demanded immediate replies.

The day was less cinematic than all of them arriving together beneath one banner. It was also more sustainable.

That evening, Keisha joined Malik's study call from the team van. DJ logged in from a quiet fieldhouse corridor. Imani watched the recording after treatment.

Support did not always mean witnessing the event. Sometimes it meant making sure the person could return to the rest of life afterward.

Thursday, February 26: Ambition Has a Direction

Nia found Malik and Simone in a Porter Center practice room.

Simone stood at the front answering an interview question about model risk. Malik sat at the table with a list of follow-ups. He did not correct her mid-answer. When she finished, he asked where she could make her role in a team project more specific.

"I designed the monitoring thresholds," Simone said. "The answer makes it sound like I only interpreted results."

"Then claim the decision."

Nia paused outside the partly open door.

The scene resembled evenings when Malik had helped her prepare for calculus or listened to her research ideas. But the care moving through this room belonged to the relationship he had chosen. More importantly, it served Simone's future even though that future might carry her across an ocean.

Simone saw Nia and waved her in.

"We need a hostile interviewer," she said.

"I can be constructively alarming."

Nia asked why the London program should select Simone over candidates with more experience.

Simone answered with clarity, then improved the answer when Nia pressed her.

For half an hour, the three of them worked without turning the room into a romantic contest. When the session ended, Malik gave Simone the marked question list to keep.

Walking back to North Star, Nia understood something she had only partly learned from Julian.

Loving someone's ambition did not mean cheering because their success kept them close. It meant wanting the work to open in its true direction, even when that direction moved away from you.

The thought hurt.

It also made Malik's support look less like loss and more like love practiced honestly.

Week Thirty-One: What Converges

Nia drew a warning network across the whiteboard.

The first alert reached half the households. If each reached household informed one unreached neighbor, the next round reached half of whoever remained. Then half of the new remainder. Then half again.

"Geometric series," Malik said.

"Exactly. One-half plus one-fourth plus one-eighth, continuing toward one."

On paper, the warning reached almost everyone as the number of rounds increased. The total approached one hundred percent with satisfying obedience.

Keisha turned her laptop around.

"The real access survey does not behave like your board."

Households with stable internet access received alerts at much higher rates. Households relying on prepaid mobile service, shared devices, or intermittent connections did not simply join the next round at the same probability. Some remained outside every update.

Nia erased the final arrow pointing toward one hundred percent.

"So the series converges," she said, "but to the wrong promise."

Friday, February 27: The Missing Remainder

Dr. Delgado introduced geometric series by dropping a rubber ball.

Each bounce reached a fixed fraction of the previous height. Students calculated the total vertical distance the ball traveled if the pattern continued forever. The answer was finite, though the motion was described with infinitely many pieces.

"Infinite activity does not require an infinite total," he said. "But you must justify the ratio and its range."

Nia adapted the structure to repeated warning reach. The first model assumed every unreached household had the same chance of receiving the next message. It was elegant, computable, and unsupported.

Keisha separated the population into access groups. Julian's message test suggested that receiving an alert did not guarantee understanding it. A warning filled with unfamiliar abbreviations could arrive technically and fail practically.

"We need at least three states," Keisha said. "Not reached, reached but unclear, reached and understood."

"And trust," Nia added. "Somebody can understand a message and still not act on it."

Their clean series became several interacting sequences with uncertain transition rates.

Alexis reviewed the revision and asked where the rates came from.

"Campus volunteers and published communication studies," Nia said.

"Then do not call them community behavior. Campus volunteers are not a substitute for Bellwether neighborhoods."

Nia added a limitation in bold.

The model could demonstrate sensitivity. It could not claim to predict every household. The remainder was not merely a mathematical quantity. It represented people the system might repeatedly fail to reach.

Saturday, February 28: What People Actually Trust

Dr. Price approved a small set of recorded community interviews under strict limits.

Julian explained the project and consent form before turning on any equipment. Participants chose whether their names, voices, or only anonymous notes could be used. They could stop at any time. The team asked about how people received severe-weather information, what made a warning credible, and what details they needed before changing plans.

The answers disrupted nearly every convenient assumption.

One resident trusted local radio more than phone alerts because storms often interrupted service. Another waited for a sister who worked at the hospital to confirm official messages. A parent said an instruction to "evacuate immediately" was useless without information about transportation and where children could be collected. An older man kept a weather radio but distrusted maps that did not show street names he recognized.

"If City Hall tells you to leave, would you?" Nia asked one participant.

"Depends who at City Hall is talking and whether my neighbor got the same message," she replied.

Trust was not a switch. It had history.

Julian recorded only what each person allowed. Keisha kept consent status separate from research notes. Nia resisted translating every answer into a parameter before the speaker finished.

Afterward, Julian packed the microphone.

"Your model keeps asking when information arrives," he said. "They keep answering who it arrives from."

Nia looked at the interview cards. "We treated the source like a label."

"To them, the source is part of the message."

The project had gathered richer evidence and become less certain. That was not a contradiction. It was what listening had done.

Sunday, March 1: Winning With the Unknowns Visible

The campus semifinal took place in a lecture hall with a timer large enough to threaten the entire front row.

Nia opened with the original problem: uncertain road capacities changed route recommendations. Keisha demonstrated the iterative model. Julian's animation showed alerts arriving at different times and routes shifting as congestion grew.

Then Nia displayed a slide titled **WHAT WE DO NOT YET KNOW**.

They did not know reliable trust rates for Bellwether neighborhoods. Their interviews were too small to estimate community behavior. They could not represent every transportation constraint. They had not validated the update model against a real emergency.

One judge asked whether those gaps made the project premature.

"They make any broad prediction premature," Nia said. "But the sensitivity analysis is useful now because it shows which assumptions can reverse a recommendation. We are not presenting one evacuation answer. We are identifying where an answer becomes unstable and what evidence would be needed to improve it."

Keisha explained how the software preserved scenario histories instead of overwriting inconvenient runs. Julian described message testing without claiming to represent all residents.

The judges advanced them to the regional presentation stage.

For several seconds, Nia forgot every lesson about dignified academic conduct and bounced beside Keisha in the hallway.

"We won by listing everything wrong with us," she said.

"We advanced because we knew what the model could support."

"That is the mature wording. Mine has more rhythm."

The celebration was real. So were the unknowns. Neither canceled the other.

Monday, March 2: One Final, Two Endings

The rivalry basketball doubleheader filled Ruth Ellis Fieldhouse in indigo and copper.

The women's game came first. Imani led chants from the student section while Keisha, Nia, Julian, Malik, Simone, and DJ crowded one row. McCall-Hart's women defended relentlessly, forcing a late turnover and scoring in transition to secure the win.

The fieldhouse shook.

Thirty minutes later, the men's rivalry finale began with the same crowd expecting the same ending.

It did not arrive.

McCall-Hart trailed by one with six seconds left. Their guard drove, kicked the ball to the corner, and a senior took an open shot at the buzzer.

The ball struck the rim and bounced away.

For one confused moment, cheers from the visiting section collided with the silence around them. The senior stood beneath the basket staring at the floor. His teammates reached him before the cameras did.

DJ exhaled. "Same building. Completely different walk home."

The women's team crossed the court carrying their rivalry trophy. The men's team disappeared into the tunnel.

Campus social media immediately combined the results into one graphic: **HERON BASKETBALL SPLITS RIVALRY FINALE.**

Nia disliked the word *splits*. It made triumph and disappointment sound like equal halves of one tidy object.

The people living each result did not experience a split. They experienced a win and a loss, each complete.

Tuesday, March 3: Let Both Results Be Full

The next day's celebration honored the women's team in the student center.

Some students complained that the event should be quieter because the men's team had lost. Others spoke about the men's missed shot as if the women's trophy repaired it.

Imani rejected both ideas.

"The women do not have to shrink their win to protect anybody," she said. "And their win does not mean the men should stop hurting."

She helped hang a banner for the women's team, then delivered handwritten notes to two men's seniors whose final home game had ended at the rim.

Nia thought about convergent series. Mathematics could combine infinitely many terms into one total. Human experience resisted that kind of compression. A shared crowd could hold two results without averaging them into emotional neutrality.

At lunch, Simone congratulated Nia on the regional advancement.

"You should be proud," she said.

"I am. I am also aware that our trust model is currently held together by caveats."

"Those can both be true."

Nia noticed how naturally Simone made room for more than one truth. She understood why Malik valued her.

The realization no longer felt like a challenge to win. It felt like evidence Nia had to respect.

Wednesday, March 4: The Interview Becomes Real

Simone received the London interview invitation between classes.

She read the email once, walked directly to Malik, and handed him her phone.

"Next Wednesday," she said. "Video interview. Two case questions and a behavioral panel."

Malik hugged her before speaking. "Congratulations."

She held him tightly, then stepped back. Excitement made her eyes brighter. Fear sharpened everything else.

"I need to tell you something before we start planning," she said. "I cannot promise what I will decide about us this summer before I even have an offer."

Malik felt the old spreadsheet opening inside his mind.

"I am not asking for a promise tonight."

"Not tonight. But you keep talking as if distance is a problem with a solution, and I do not know whether I want our first months together to become a maintenance project across time zones."

"So you are already deciding against it?"

"No. I am refusing to decide from fear before I know what the actual choice is."

Malik wanted certainty because uncertainty felt passive. Simone wanted room because premature certainty felt like surrendering ownership of her future.

They scheduled interview practice for the weekend.

The calendar entry was easy.

Everything beneath it was not.

Thursday, March 5: Pleasant Semester or Shared Plan

Malik asked the question during a walk along Cypress Walk.

"Are we planning a relationship," he said, "or preserving a pleasant semester until your internship begins?"

Simone stopped beneath the bare branches.

"That is not a neutral question."

"I know."

"It makes every good thing we have done sound temporary unless I promise the future you want."

"I do not know what future you want."

"Neither do I. That is what I keep telling you."

Malik looked away. "I do not want to invest in something you have already decided to leave."

"And I do not want affection to become evidence that I owe you continuation."

They stood close enough to touch and did not.

Simone opened the copper notebook to the unanswered question about opportunities. "We have evidence that we care about each other. We have evidence that we work through disagreement. We do not have evidence about distance, London, or what either of us will need by summer."

"So we wait?"

"We keep being honest. We stop pretending uncertainty means one of us is secretly disloyal. And we gather more evidence."

Malik almost laughed. "You turned our relationship into a research design."

"You started it."

They continued walking, hands linked but not relaxed.

Some series converged. Some diverged. At that moment, Malik and Simone had only terms, not a theorem.

Week Thirty-Two: Tests of Convergence

Dr. Delgado wrote four infinite series on the board and forbade anyone from calculating.

"Choose a convergence test," he said. "Defend the choice. Then you may touch the algebra."

Students stared at the series as if they had been asked to identify four strangers from childhood photographs.

One resembled a geometric series but contained an extra factor. One had factorials that suggested the ratio test. One alternated signs. One looked suitable for comparison with a familiar benchmark.

"Can multiple tests work?" Nia asked.

"Yes."

"Then how do we know which one you want?"

"I want the one you can justify. Mathematics is not mind reading."

Malik examined the factorial series. "The ratio test exposes the structure directly."

"Good. Do not use three weaker arguments because you are afraid to commit to one strong one."

The advice landed beyond the board.

Friday, March 6: Name the Test

Nia chose comparison for a positive-term series.

She bounded it above by a convergent benchmark, then paused. An upper bound by something convergent could establish convergence, but only if the inequalities pointed the correct way. She checked each term rather than trusting the shape.

Across the room, Malik applied the ratio test. The limit fell below one. For once, the conclusion arrived cleanly.

Amara selected the alternating-series test and established conditional convergence. Dr. Delgado asked whether absolute convergence had also been shown.

"No," Amara said. "That would require another test."

"Exactly. A result may be true under one standard and unresolved under another."

After class, Nia and Keisha prepared for the symposium decision. Their project had passed the campus semifinal, but regional reviewers could still reject it. Nia refreshed the portal twice.

"Choose a test," Keisha said.

"For what?"

"Whether the email has arrived. Test one: look at the inbox. Test two through seventeen are still looking at the inbox."

Nia placed her phone face down.

The project would either advance or it would not. Repeated observation could not influence the result.

At 4:38 p.m., the portal changed.

Neither saw it until Saturday morning.

Saturday, March 7: Two Invitations in One Email

Keisha opened the acceptance while standing in line for oatmeal.

She made a sound so sharp that three people checked the fire alarm.

Nia ran across the dining hall. "What happened?"

Keisha held up the phone.

Their project had been accepted to the Southeastern Undergraduate Mathematics Symposium.

Below that sentence was another.

The team had also been selected for a final-round interview for the national summer fellowship.

Nia read the paragraph until the words stopped moving. Then she grabbed Keisha's hands and jumped. Keisha joined for exactly two jumps before remembering she was carrying oatmeal.

They called Julian, Dr. Price, Alexis, Nia's mother, and Keisha's track teammate who answered half asleep and screamed anyway. Nia typed a message to Malik, erased an overly emotional version, and sent the simple news.

He replied immediately: **You earned the room. Congratulations to all three of you.**

All three.

Nia noticed the wording.

The interview instructions emphasized collaboration, public relevance, and evidence of revision. Fellowship judges would examine not only the final model but how the team responded when assumptions failed.

"We have abundant failure evidence," Julian said when they met.

"Finally, a competitive advantage," Keisha replied.

Nia laughed, but fear moved beneath the joy. She had admitted how badly she wanted this. Now the desired outcome was close enough to imagine losing in detail.

Sunday, March 8: No Single Hero in the Frame

Julian rebuilt the route animation.

The first version opened on Nia speaking beside a glowing map. Her narration drove every transition. Keisha's code appeared as a small technical label. Community interview clips functioned like supporting evidence in Nia's explanation.

Julian watched the sequence once and deleted the opening.

"What are you doing?" Nia asked.

"Fixing the point of view."

The revised version began with three contradictory warning experiences, used with permission. Keisha then showed how those differences became scenario inputs. Nia explained how route recommendations changed. Julian's visual sequence connected each update to its source and uncertainty.

No one person appeared as the project.

"You removed my strongest introduction," Nia said.

"Your introduction made everybody else's work arrive as proof that you were insightful."

Nia winced. "Accurate and rude."

"Accurate and billable."

Keisha reviewed the animation and requested clearer labels for the software's decision states. Nia shortened her narration. Julian added credits by role rather than placing three names beneath the vague phrase *project team*.

The result was easier to understand because the audience could see where each claim originated.

Nia still served as lead presenter. Leadership no longer required the camera to treat everyone else as scenery.

Monday, March 9: The Pep-Bus Deadline

McCall-Hart's women's basketball team reached the conference final.

The student pep group organized an overnight bus. Keisha wanted to go. She also owed the research team a final code review before the fellowship-interview materials were locked.

Old Nia would have suggested Keisha skip the trip, then praised her sacrifice as commitment.

Current Nia asked, "What do you need from us to finish before departure?"

They divided the review. Nia checked whether every visual matched the correct scenario output. Julian verified that consent restrictions followed each interview clip. Keisha ran automated tests, examined the route-history logs, and froze the presentation version at 3:12 p.m.

At 3:20, she left for the pep bus wearing an indigo sweatshirt and carrying a statistics worksheet.

"You are taking homework to a championship game?" Julian asked.

"The bus has seats."

"This university does not understand leisure."

Keisha completed the worksheet before the bus crossed the county line. That evening, she sent one message to the team: **Code review clean. I am now unavailable unless the model catches fire. If it catches fire, document it.**

Nia did not contact her.

Shared ownership meant trusting the work after the owner stepped away.

Tuesday, March 10: A Future After the Buzzer

The conference final stayed close until the final minute.

Keisha's voice disappeared somewhere in the third quarter. She texted score updates to the group, each one containing fewer vowels as tension increased.

McCall-Hart tied the game with twenty seconds left. Their opponent answered with two free throws. The Herons' final shot rolled around the rim and out.

This time, the loss did not end the season.

During the trophy ceremony, the conference announced McCall-Hart had earned a postseason invitation. The players were devastated by the final and proud of the opportunity, sometimes within the same expression.

On the bus home, Keisha joined the research team's call.

"Do not ask me to describe the last shot," she said.

"We will not," Nia replied. "How is the team?"

"Sad. Also already discussing film tomorrow."

The future did not erase the immediate result. It gave the result somewhere to go.

Nia looked at the symposium acceptance taped above her desk. If the fellowship interview went badly, other work could still follow. That did not mean she needed to reduce her hope in advance.

She could prepare for the next round and still admit the current one mattered.

Wednesday, March 11: The Opportunity Gets a Voice

Simone's London interview lasted forty-seven minutes.

Malik waited in the Porter Center lobby with two coffees growing cold. He had helped her practice case questions, but she entered the interview alone.

When she emerged, her face revealed nothing for three steps. Then she smiled.

"It went well."

Malik stood and hugged her. "Tell me everything."

She described the panel, the market-risk case, the question about adapting to a new city, and the program director's detailed explanation of summer placements. The opportunity had offices, mentors, transit routes, and a welcome week. London was no longer a word in an application. It had acquired a voice.

Malik congratulated her sincerely.

Then he said, "Part of me hoped the interview would make it less real."

Simone went still.

"Not that you would fail," he added. "I hoped you would dislike the program, or they would describe something you did not want. I wanted the problem to disappear without either of us choosing."

"Thank you for telling me," she said. "I do not like hearing it."

"I know."

She accepted one of the cold coffees. They sat in the lobby while students moved around them.

His honesty did not repair the conflict. It prevented false enthusiasm from becoming another one.

Thursday, March 12: Not Yet Is Still an Answer

Malik and Simone met again before spring break.

They could break up now, protecting themselves from an offer that might never come. They could promise long distance now, protecting themselves from admitting they might choose differently later. Both decisions would convert uncertainty into action.

Neither felt honest.

"I do not want to end something meaningful because I am afraid of a possible email," Simone said.

"I do not want staying together this month to become an automatic promise about summer."

"Then it does not."

They agreed to continue the relationship without pretending it was uncomplicated. Simone would not minimize London to reassure him. Malik would not make every difficult feeling a forecast of their ending. If an offer arrived, they would decide from the life in front of them, not a hypothetical version.

Malik took her hand. "I still want this."

"So do I."

The words were true and not sufficient to solve everything.

Across campus, Nia, Keisha, and Julian finalized plans to remain for the first two days of spring break. The symposium presentation needed revisions, interviews needed editing, and the route animation still moved too quickly for viewers to read its uncertainty labels.

Malik saw their shared calendar notification.

He told himself it was project work.

That was true too.

Spring break opened with several honest answers and no final conclusions.

Week Thirty-Three: Spring Break, Old Angles

By Friday afternoon, McCall-Hart sounded abandoned.

Residence-hall doors slammed. Suitcases rolled over brick paths. Cars filled with students, laundry, snacks, and the confidence that every item would fit if somebody pushed hard enough.

Nia stayed.

So did Keisha and Julian. They had two days before Nia left for Huntsville, Keisha joined family outside Bellwether, and Julian traveled with the Marching Herons' postseason group.

The Porter Center lab felt enormous with most of campus gone. Their footsteps echoed. A vending machine offered six varieties of chips and rejected Julian's dollar twice.

"Spring-break luxury," he said.

"We have unrestricted access to the good whiteboard," Nia replied.

"Your standards are concerning."

They opened the presentation files.

Friday, March 13: Two Days to Rebuild

The symposium version had to do three things at once: explain the mathematics, preserve uncertainty, and remain understandable to someone who had not lived inside the project since January.

Nia's narration ran four minutes too long. Keisha's live demonstration required six setup steps the audience would never see. Julian's animation moved beautifully and labeled nothing long enough to read.

They dismantled all three.

Nia cut historical background she loved but did not need. Keisha recorded a reproducible demonstration with a live fallback. Julian slowed the route transitions and added a visible source for every change.

At lunch, they ate vending-machine crackers and one questionable microwave pizza.

"This is what fellowship candidates eat?" Julian asked.

"The funding begins after selection," Nia said.

Keisha pointed at the pizza. "This may affect our survival to selection."

The work was tiring and unexpectedly fun. Without the pressure of ordinary classes, they argued through details, played music too loudly, and celebrated every removed slide as if subtraction were a sport.

Nia and Julian fell into an easy creative rhythm. He asked what the audience should feel. She translated the mathematical stakes. Keisha interrupted whenever either of them attempted to make uncertainty visually inconvenient.

Their old romance existed in the room as history, not instruction.

Saturday, March 14: Elegant Models, Messy People

Julian recorded Nia's interview against a plain cream wall.

He asked her to describe the moment the project changed.

"Which one?" she said. "We have changed it every four business days."

"The deepest one."

Nia thought about the community interviews, the delayed baseball alert, and Keisha answering the reviewer more honestly than she had.

"I began with an elegant model of roads," she said. "Roads were easier than people. They had capacities and distances. Then people kept making choices the map did not contain. They waited for family. They trusted different sources. They understood the same message differently."

"So was the elegant model wrong?"

"Not useless. Incomplete. The danger was treating elegance like proof that we had included what mattered."

Julian remained behind the camera. "Does that happen outside mathematics?"

Nia looked directly at the lens.

They both understood the question.

"Yes," she said. "You can have a beautiful picture of a relationship. You can have a story about who two people are together. If the picture becomes more important than how they actually feel, the story stops helping."

Julian lowered the camera after the answer.

"That was about us," he said.

"Partly."

"Fair."

There was no accusation in his voice and no invitation in hers. They had made mistakes without making their entire relationship one.

Keisha returned with lunch and found them laughing because Julian had recorded the first half of the interview with a strip of tape visible on his sleeve.

She took a still image for the production log.

Sunday, March 15: The Cropped Story

The still image reached Malik through a student-media post.

Nia and Julian sat close beneath the interview lights, laughing over the camera screen. The caption read: **Spring break does not stop symposium season.** Keisha was not visible. Neither were the consent sheets, route maps, or twelve hours of work surrounding the moment.

Malik looked at the image too long.

He knew the facts. Nia and Julian were collaborators. Keisha had been present. The project needed media work. Nia had directly said the relationship was over.

His jealousy arrived anyway.

It offered an old story: Nia and Julian had discovered that safe collaboration was actually reunion. Malik had moved forward only to learn that the possibility he abandoned had become available after he stopped looking.

He did not message Nia.

He did not ask Julian.

He also did not tell Simone what he was feeling.

Instead, he closed the post and carried the silence into their interview-practice call.

Simone noticed within three minutes.

"You are reading questions from a list," she said, "but you are not listening to the answers."

"I am tired."

That was true.

It was not the truth he owed her.

Monday, March 16: The Cost of Saying Nothing

Spring break officially began Monday, and campus offices shifted to limited hours.

Malik joined Simone's practice session from Gulfport, where he was helping his parents review repair estimates. Simone called from Bellwether before leaving to visit family.

She answered a case question about detecting bias in a credit-risk model. Malik responded, "Good," and moved to the next question.

"What was good?" she asked.

"The structure."

"Which part?"

He could not say because he had barely heard it.

The image of Nia and Julian kept returning, followed by irritation at himself, followed by more distance. Simone had done nothing. Still, she was receiving the shortened answers, flat voice, and missing attention.

"We should stop," she said.

"We have six questions left."

"I am not an item on your schedule. Something is wrong, and you are making me work around it without telling me what it is."

Malik almost said family stress. His father's recovery and the repair estimates were real pressures. Using them to hide another feeling would make truth into cover.

"I saw a picture of Nia and Julian working together," he said. "I am jealous."

Simone went silent.

The confession came late enough that she had already paid for it.

"We will talk tomorrow," she said. "Not while you are still deciding whether to be honest."

She ended the call.

Tuesday, March 17: The Direct Question

Simone called at noon.

"Are you jealous of Julian because you think Nia wants him," she asked, "or because you still want Nia?"

Malik had spent the morning constructing distinctions. Old feelings. Unresolved possibility. Fear of replacement. None relieved him of the answer.

"Both may be true," he said. "I do not know what Nia wants. I know I still have feelings I did not resolve."

"And yesterday you punished me for them."

"Yes."

He did not say he had not intended to. Intention would not return Simone's wasted practice session or remove the experience of being treated as the obstacle between him and another possibility.

"I chose this relationship," Malik said. "But I have been acting as if choosing should have erased everything else. It did not."

Simone looked hurt rather than surprised.

"I have felt you comparing," she said. "Not every day. Not in every room. But enough."

Malik wanted to deny it. He remembered the basketball game, his jealousy over Julian, and the private relief he sought whenever Nia seemed emotionally available.

"You are right."

"I do not need another apology that becomes a promise to control your feelings better. I need you to understand what relationship you are actually in."

"I will."

"That is still a future answer."

The call ended without resolution. Honesty had stopped the hiding. It had not made the truth harmless.

Wednesday, March 18: Safe Because It Ended

Nia went home to Huntsville and found her mother reorganizing a kitchen cabinet that had survived perfectly well for years.

Denise Reynolds asked about the symposium, Keisha's track season, Malik's family, and Julian, in that order.

"Julian and I worked together all weekend," Nia said.

Her mother placed a stack of bowls on the counter. "How did that feel?"

"Safe."

Denise waited.

"Not safe like I want him back," Nia added. "Safe because I do not. We can remember what was good without testing whether it should restart."

"Does he know that?"

"Yes. I think so. We interviewed each other about elegant models and accidentally discussed our breakup on camera."

"That sounds like a terrible documentary."

Nia laughed. "The research part is better."

She explained that Julian had changed the animation so she was not the sole hero, that Keisha controlled the code decisions, and that the project had become stronger as Nia owned less of it alone.

"And Malik?" Denise asked.

Nia's smile faded. "He is with Simone. I care about him. I am respecting that."

"Respect is not only what you avoid doing," her mother said. "It is also refusing to build private hope out of somebody else's difficulty."

Nia thought of London.

"I know."

This time, she meant that she was practicing, not that she had mastered it.

Thursday, March 19: Return With What Changed

Students began returning to McCall-Hart Thursday evening.

Nia carried a revised script. Keisha returned with a clean software build. Julian brought edited interview clips and a signed record of every participant's permissions.

The project was stronger because each person had protected a different truth.

Malik returned from Gulfport carrying repair documents and the knowledge that Simone no longer trusted his choice as completely as before. Simone returned with a stronger interview performance and a clearer understanding that London was not the only pressure on their relationship.

They met outside the Porter Center.

"How was home?" Malik asked.

"Good," Simone said. "How is your father?"

"Improving. The contractor thinks the back rooms may be finished by summer."

They exchanged facts because facts were safer than the conversation still waiting.

Across the courtyard, Nia and Julian carried equipment toward the lab. Malik saw them and made himself remain present.

He did not confront Nia. She had done nothing requiring explanation.

Nia noticed the strain between Malik and Simone but did not ask for private details. Their relationship was not an opening in her calendar.

Dr. Price sent the team its next itinerary: a Delta National Laboratory preview visit after break, with research sessions, communication workshops, and a joint review of symposium projects.

The trip would place Nia, Keisha, Julian, Malik, and Simone inside the same professional space.

They returned with a stronger project, a strained relationship, and old feelings stripped of their easiest excuses.

No confrontation came that night.

The silence was no longer empty. It was carrying everything the next trip would force them to name.

Week Thirty-Four: Radius of Influence

Nia replaced one expensive calculation with a power-series approximation and watched the model run faster.

The improvement was dramatic. A route update that had taken several seconds now appeared almost instantly.

"We fixed it," she said.

Keisha did not celebrate. "Where does the approximation converge?"

Nia looked at the expression again.

They had expanded the function around a typical congestion value. Near that center, the first few terms approximated it well. Farther away, the error grew. At extreme congestion levels, the shortcut could produce a route cost less reliable than the slow calculation it replaced.

"We accelerated the model inside one neighborhood of values," Nia said.

"Then label the neighborhood."

On the board, Nia wrote the center, radius of convergence, and error bound. Speed was useful only where the approximation deserved trust.

Friday, March 20: Valid Here, Not Everywhere

Spring break ended with students returning to Dr. Delgado's classroom in various stages of denial.

He introduced power series as functions represented by infinite polynomial expressions. Around a chosen center, a complicated function could become easier to calculate term by term. But the representation did not necessarily work for every input.

"A formula can be excellent inside its interval and disastrous outside it," he said. "State the domain of your confidence."

Nia tested her approximation across possible congestion values. The first few terms matched the full function closely near ordinary conditions. As traffic approached the extreme scenarios, the difference widened.

She added a safeguard: outside the validated interval, the software would revert to the slower calculation rather than continue producing quick uncertainty disguised as precision.

Malik reviewed the logic before the Delta trip.

"You could also display the expected approximation error," he said.

"Keisha already demanded it."

"Naturally."

They spoke easily about the model, though both knew the last weeks had made ease complicated. Nia did not ask about Simone. Malik did not mention the spring-break image.

Professional limits were still limits.

That evening, the five students packed for Delta National Laboratory: Nia and Keisha for the symposium project, Julian for communication design, Simone for data-governance sessions, and Malik for risk analysis.

They were traveling together because their skills intersected.

Nothing about the trip promised that their feelings would converge as neatly.

Saturday, March 21: Behind the Glass

Delta National Laboratory's supercomputing floor lived behind thick glass and a security door that opened only after orientation, identification checks, and a lecture about devices nobody was allowed to connect.

Rows of dark cabinets stretched beneath white lights. Cooling systems filled the room with a low mechanical roar. A scientist explained that the computers could run thousands of storm scenarios, but larger capacity did not remove uncertainty. It allowed teams to examine more versions of what might happen.

"Computation multiplies assumptions," she said. "It does not purify them."

Keisha wrote that down immediately.

During an uncertainty-communication talk, researchers compared three maps built from the same forecast. One used a single sharp flood boundary. One displayed several possible boundaries without explanation. The third connected probability ranges to specific planning decisions.

Most viewers preferred the first because it looked decisive.

Emergency planners found the third more useful.

"The clearest image is not always the most truthful," Julian whispered.

"Please frame that above your editing station," Nia said.

The speaker demonstrated how color, animation speed, and label placement could make low-confidence outcomes look inevitable. Julian asked about testing visuals with residents rather than technical teams. Simone asked who approved communication standards when agencies disagreed.

Nia watched each person enter the discussion from a different direction.

The project belonged in this kind of room, not because it was finished, but because its weaknesses required more than one discipline to see.

Sunday, March 22: Pricing the Rare Event

Malik attended a session on extreme-event risk.

An actuarial researcher described the difficulty of estimating events that were both rare and enormously costly. Historical records were limited. Climate conditions changed. Property data favored documented financial loss over losses that insurance never recorded.

Malik raised his hand.

"How do agencies price a rare risk without presenting the estimate as more certain than it is?"

The researcher distinguished between expected loss, tail risk, scenario ranges, and decisions made under uncertainty. A premium or reserve was not proof that analysts knew the future. It was a policy choice informed by models, available evidence, and tolerance for failure.

"The ethical problem begins," she said, "when the number's precision is allowed to hide the judgment inside it."

Malik thought of his family's insurance claim after the Gulf storm. Every damaged item had required documentation. Emotional loss, unpaid recovery time, and rooms his parents could not safely use had entered the calculation unevenly, if at all.

After the session, Nia asked what he had learned.

He explained the difference between a rare-event estimate and the decision built from it. She connected it to route instability near uncertain roads.

Simone joined them and expanded the question to financial institutions deciding which communities received resilience investment.

For several minutes, the conversation was balanced among three people.

Then a scientist approached with a question that narrowed the room.

Monday, March 23: The Old Ease

The scientist had reviewed Nia's poster abstract.

"If your warning updates and route calculations change at the same time," she asked, "how do you distinguish instability caused by communication from instability caused by road capacity?"

Nia began with the scenario matrix. Malik entered at the exact point where risk decomposition mattered.

"Hold one uncertainty source fixed," he said, "then vary the other across its plausible range. After separate sensitivity runs, test interactions."

"But holding communication fixed is not realistic during an actual event," Nia added.

"It is not a forecast. It isolates influence. The combined scenario comes after."

"And the display must show which run the audience is seeing."

"Otherwise interaction looks like one unexplained risk score."

They passed the answer back and forth without interrupting. Nia drew the scenario grid. Malik named the assumptions. Each anticipated the other's missing step.

The scientist nodded. "That design could work. Document the artificial separation so no one mistakes it for reality."

Only after she left did Nia realize Simone had been watching.

The exchange had felt like Summer Bridge: two students discovering that the other person's mind moved differently but arrived at the same problem. The ease was real. So was the history attached to it.

Malik returned to Simone and asked about her afternoon session.

He was present.

The fact that he could be present afterward did not erase where part of him had just gone.

Tuesday, March 24: The Part Not Available

Simone did not blame Nia.

She waited until she and Malik were walking from the guest residence to breakfast.

"Yesterday, when you answered that scientist with Nia, you looked relieved," she said.

"Relieved?"

"Like you had returned to a conversation that never required translation."

Malik searched for a less dangerous description. "We know how each other thinks about these problems."

"I know. I watched it."

Simone stopped near a courtyard bench. "Has part of you remained unavailable all spring?"

He could have answered with actions. He had chosen Simone. He kept dates, supported London, attended her panel, and told the truth when it was difficult. All of that mattered.

It did not fully answer her.

"I thought choosing you meant the old feelings would become irrelevant," he said.

"That is not a no."

"No."

Simone absorbed the word without turning toward Nia's building or asking what Nia had done. "Then London is not the only uncertainty between us."

"No."

"I need you to stop acting as if geography created a problem that was already here."

Malik nodded.

The walk to breakfast continued. Neither reached for the other's hand.

Wednesday, March 25: Strong Splits and One-Run Games

Keisha opened outdoor track season with her strongest relay split of the year.

She received the baton in third, closed the gap on the backstretch, and handed off nearly even. Her team finished second, but the coaches replayed her split on a tablet and showed how her curve mechanics had improved.

"No medal for one leg," Keisha told Nia afterward.

"Still your work."

"Yes. Both things."

Imani's softball team played two road games decided by one run. She did not produce a dramatic highlight. She moved a runner with a sacrifice bunt, made a difficult backhand stop, and called a defensive shift that prevented a tying run.

McCall-Hart swept the series through accumulated decisions that would look small in a summary.

The friends followed both events through updates because the Delta trip and travel schedules prevented everyone from attending. No one confused distance with lack of support.

Malik saw the relay video while sitting beside Simone on the return bus. They spoke politely about sports, the lab sessions, and work due Friday.

Politeness had become a boundary around the conversation they could no longer postpone.

Thursday, March 26: Honest Is Not Harmless

Simone asked Malik one final question after they returned to campus.

"What does your connection with Nia mean?"

They sat in an empty Porter Center classroom. The projector fan hummed above them.

Malik could name what it had meant: friendship, competition, attraction, waiting, resentment, shared academic ambition. He could not name what it meant now without reaching beyond what Nia had said or what he had chosen.

"I do not know," he answered.

It was honest.

Simone's face tightened. "And you have been dating me while not knowing."

"I know what you mean to me."

"Do you? Or do you know that I am the person you chose when you decided waiting for Nia was unhealthy?"

"That is not all this is."

"I believe you. That is why this hurts."

Simone did not accuse him of using her. Their relationship had contained real affection, attention, humor, and growth. It had also contained a room he kept comparing with another room he had never entered.

"I need time," she said.

Malik did not ask how much. He had turned enough feelings into schedules.

She left the classroom alone.

His honesty had ended one kind of hiding. It had also given Simone information she could use to make a choice he might not like.

Truth did not promise mercy. It promised that the person affected could finally decide with the real evidence.

Week Thirty-Five: Approximation Is Not Arrival

Nia began the symposium rehearsal with a power series, three convergence intervals, and a sentence containing the phrase *heterogeneous notification latency*.

Six minutes later, the community reviewer raised one hand.

"I understand that the model changes," she said. "I do not understand what decision you want anybody to make."

Nia looked at the slide behind her. It contained two equations, a route network, a color key, and enough footnotes to qualify as a separate presentation.

"The decision is whether a route remains reliable under changing conditions," she said.

"Reliable for whom? And who is deciding?"

Nia opened her mouth.

Dr. Price stopped the timer.

Friday, March 27: Correct and Unclear

The reviewer, Ms. Elaine Carter, worked with a Bellwether neighborhood preparedness coalition. She had agreed to evaluate whether the team's presentation communicated anything residents or local organizers could use.

Nia had prepared for mathematical questions. Ms. Carter asked where a parent without a car should look on the map. She asked whether one changing route meant everyone should leave differently. She asked what the warning colors instructed people to do.

The presentation contained answers to some of those questions, but they were buried beneath method names and validation language.

"I wanted to prove the model was rigorous," Nia said.

"To whom?" Ms. Carter asked.

The fellowship judges mattered. So did technical reviewers. But Nia had presented as if complexity itself demonstrated readiness.

Keisha's live model performed correctly. Julian's animation displayed every uncertainty. Neither mattered if the audience could not connect the output to a decision.

Ms. Carter pointed to one route change. "If I am watching this, what should I know now that I did not know before?"

Nia finally answered without jargon. "That a recommended road can stop being the safest choice when warnings arrive late and traffic concentrates there. The map should show why the recommendation changed and who may not have received the same information."

"That," Ms. Carter said, "sounds like your talk."

The talk Nia had given was technically correct.

It had not arrived where the audience stood.

Saturday, March 28: Unfinished at Minute Six

Dr. Price replayed the first six minutes the next morning.

Nia watched herself define every term before stating the decision. She sounded prepared, intelligent, and almost impossible to follow.

At minute six, Dr. Price paused the video.

"Correctness without audience understanding is unfinished work," she said. "Do not confuse density with seriousness."

Nia felt defensive. Unlike last month, she recognized the feeling before it became an argument.

"What must stay?" she asked.

Keisha named the scenario comparison, uncertainty limits, and data gaps. Julian named the changing route and the source of each warning. Ms. Carter wanted one household's choices visible from alert to departure.

Nia wrote all four lists.

Dr. Price compared the current talk to a Taylor polynomial. A limited set of terms could approximate a complicated function near a useful center. Adding more terms might improve accuracy, but only if the audience could still use the representation and the error remained visible.

"Your presentation is an approximation of the full research," she said. "It is not the full research read aloud."

Nia deleted the opening definition slide.

Then she deleted eleven more.

Each removal hurt for approximately four seconds.

Sunday, March 29: Less Motion, More Meaning

Julian removed half the animation.

The old version displayed alerts pulsing, roads changing color, probability bands expanding, and route markers moving simultaneously. It looked impressive. It required the viewer to watch four events with one pair of eyes.

The new version followed one household.

An official alert reached late. The household waited for a family member. Traffic increased on the initial route. The recommendation changed, and a caption explained which assumptions drove the update. Only then did the view widen to show other scenarios.

Keisha rebuilt the demonstration around the same sequence. Instead of clicking through every software feature, she changed one input at a time and showed the stored history.

"We are not saying this household represents everybody," she said.

"We say that aloud," Nia replied.

Ms. Carter reviewed the revision and immediately identified the decision: do not publish one route without showing when and why it may change.

"Now I can disagree with you," she said.

Nia smiled. "That is good?"

"It means I can understand enough to challenge the recommendation."

The team added her criticism to the notes.

Communication was not successful because the audience nodded. It was successful when the audience could locate the claim, inspect its limits, and ask a better question.

Monday, March 30: The Offer Is Hers

Simone received the London offer at 8:14 Monday morning.

The internship included placement with a financial-data team, housing assistance, professional mentoring, and eight weeks in a city she had imagined since high school.

She read every condition. She checked the dates against McCall-Hart's calendar. She called her mother. Then she accepted.

She told Malik that afternoon.

"You already accepted," he said.

"Yes."

He was proud of her. He was also hurt that the decision had happened without him.

"I thought we would discuss it first."

"We discussed whether I wanted it. I told you that if I received the offer, I was going."

"Discussing the offer is different from deciding without me."

Simone held his gaze. "The career decision is mine. The relationship decision is ours. I did not need permission to accept London."

Malik knew she was right. Knowing did not remove the feeling of being outside an important moment.

"I did not want you to ask me to wait while we evaluated us," she continued. "I have waited too often to name vulnerable things. This time I decided what I wanted."

"I would not have asked you to reject it."

"Maybe not. But you wanted consultation to prove I placed the relationship inside the decision."

Malik had no honest denial.

The offer removed the shelter of *if*.

London was now on the calendar.

Tuesday, March 31: Consultation Is Not Commitment

Malik walked with DJ after football conditioning.

"She accepted before telling me," he said.

DJ adjusted the strap of his equipment bag. "Would you have told her not to?"

"No."

"Did she say she would go if she got it?"

"Yes."

"Then what did you want the conversation to do?"

Malik considered the question.

He had wanted Simone to bring the offer to him before accepting so they could examine dates, distance, and consequences. Beneath that reasonable desire was another: he wanted her pause to demonstrate that their relationship had enough authority to delay her answer.

"I treated consultation as proof of commitment," he said.

"That sounds like something Dr. Bennett would make you write in a reflection."

"It feels worse than that."

Malik messaged Simone. He congratulated her again without adding the relationship question. He apologized for making her acceptance sound like a procedural failure.

She thanked him.

She did not reassure him about summer.

Pride and hurt remained together. Malik allowed both without turning the hurt into evidence that Simone had chosen wrongly.

Wednesday, April 1: The Next Two Plays

Imani misplayed a ground ball in the softball rivalry opener.

The error extended the inning. McCall-Hart lost by two.

The story seemed prepared to offer her a dramatic correction in the next game. It did not.

Imani went hitless Saturday but fielded every routine ball cleanly. She communicated a coverage shift that prevented an extra base. In the final game, she made a disciplined cutoff throw instead of attempting a spectacular play at home.

The Herons won the series two games to one.

A teammate teased her about not producing a redemption home run.

"Redemption is expensive," Imani said. "I chose defense."

Nia attended the final game after rehearsal. She watched Imani handle ordinary chances without trying to manufacture one heroic moment that would erase Friday.

Afterward, Imani asked about the presentation.

"I removed twelve slides."

"Did they deserve it?"

"Eleven did. I am grieving one."

"You will survive."

Improvement did not always announce itself through spectacle. Sometimes it was the next routine play handled with care.

Thursday, April 2: Strong Is Not Guaranteed

Nia's second rehearsal began with one household receiving a delayed alert.

Within thirty seconds, Ms. Carter understood the stakes. Keisha changed one assumption and showed the route history. Julian's visual slowed at each decision. Nia explained the mathematics after the audience knew why it mattered.

At minute six, Dr. Price did not stop the timer.

The full talk ended with twelve seconds remaining.

Questions came quickly. Nia admitted where interview data was too limited. Keisha distinguished software behavior from human prediction. Julian explained why the animation displayed uncertainty instead of smoothing it away.

Ms. Carter could name the decision, the limitation, and the question she still wanted answered.

The rehearsal had landed.

Nia expected relief. Dr. Price gave her perspective.

"This is strong work," she said. "Strong work does not guarantee the fellowship. Other teams will be strong. Some will have more data, more experience, or methods that better match the judges' priorities."

"I know."

"Knowing before the result is different from living it afterward. Prepare to present what you can defend, not to control what they choose."

Nia looked at the final slide.

The talk approximated months of work. The judges would approximate the team's potential from one brief encounter. Both processes had error.

She wanted the fellowship anyway.

Wanting it did not make the outcome hers.

Week Thirty-Six: Different Parameters

Dr. Delgado drew two parametric curves.

Both used time as the parameter. At every moment, each curve had its own horizontal and vertical position. For several values, the points appeared close. Then one curve turned while the other continued forward.

"Sharing a parameter does not mean sharing a path," he said.

Nia calculated velocity components. Malik found where one curve slowed. Amara identified the moment their directions diverged.

Outside class, Friday was the course-withdrawal deadline. Students made decisions about classes they had entered months earlier with different information. Staying was not automatically brave. Leaving was not automatically failure. The question was which path remained honest under current conditions.

Malik copied both curves into his notes.

Two people could share time, affection, and important experiences without moving toward the same destination.

Friday, April 3: Same Time, Different Motion

Dr. Delgado asked the class to distinguish speed from direction.

Two objects could move at the same speed and travel apart. One object could change direction without stopping. Arc length could measure the distance along a path without explaining why the path had turned.

"Do not let one shared quantity persuade you that two motions are identical," he said.

After class, Malik met Simone at the Porter Center.

They had spent the week discussing London in careful pieces. Underneath every practical question was the larger one neither could postpone: was distance creating their incompatibility, or revealing it?

Simone carried the copper notebook. Many pages now contained answers, crossed-out thoughts, and new questions.

"I want to talk tomorrow," she said. "Not between meetings. Not during interview practice."

Malik understood that she had chosen the time deliberately.

"Okay."

They did not fill the silence with one more pleasant evening.

Across campus, Nia reviewed the final symposium materials with Keisha and Julian. She knew Malik and Simone were strained. She did not ask whether the strain had created an opening.

Respect, her mother had said, was something active.

Nia practiced it by remaining on her own path.

Saturday, April 4: London Is Not the Whole Reason

Simone met Malik beneath the covered terrace behind Porter Center.

"London matters," she began. "I want the internship. I do not want to begin it by promising that every free hour belongs to maintaining a relationship across an ocean."

Malik listened.

"But London is not the whole reason," she continued. "I have felt you comparing us with an unfinished possibility. Sometimes when Nia enters a room, you become more aware of what our relationship proves. When Julian is near her, you become more afraid of what you lost."

"I did not choose you to prove something."

"I believe that. I also believe you entered this relationship partly because moving forward felt healthier than waiting."

Both statements could be true.

Simone opened the notebook to one of Malik's original questions: *What does support feel like when you are disappointed?*

"Support is not asking me to remain inside a comparison until you resolve it," she said. "And care is not pretending London alone is taking me away."

Malik's instinct was to promise he would stop comparing. The promise would demand that Simone trust a future correction she had already spent spring waiting to see.

He did not make it.

"You deserved my full presence," he said.

"I deserved honesty about what full meant."

They sat with the difference.

Sunday, April 5: The Apology Without a Request

Malik returned Sunday with no argument for why Simone should stay.

"I am sorry," he said. "I thought moving forward meant never looking back. I treated choosing you as proof that everything unresolved had disappeared. Then whenever it came back, I hid it because admitting it felt disloyal."

Simone listened.

"That made the feeling more powerful," he continued. "And it made you carry consequences for something you did not cause."

He apologized for the distant interview practice, the private comparisons, and the expectation that consultation would prove commitment. He did not describe every good thing he had done as a counterweight. Care was not a credit balance.

"Our relationship was real," Simone said.

"Yes."

"I do not want your apology to rewrite it as a mistake."

"I do not either."

They remembered the food-distribution station, the road trip, her panel, the copper notebook, and the many ordinary lunches that had never needed to become lessons.

Malik did not ask her to give him more time. He did not promise that Nia would become irrelevant. He apologized without converting accountability into a request for another chance.

For Simone, that made the apology kinder.

It did not change her decision.

Monday, April 6: No Promise After London

They ended the relationship where it had grown: the Porter Center.

Students moved through the lobby carrying laptops and coffee. Somewhere upstairs, a finance club meeting began. The ordinary building refused to become a private stage.

"I am leaving for London," Simone said. "But even if I were staying in Bellwether, I would need to step out of this comparison."

"I understand."

"Do not tell me we can try again after summer."

Malik swallowed. "I will not."

They made no promise to resume when she returned. They did not call the relationship a failure because it ended. Simone had learned that she could name ambition without apology. Malik had learned that choosing someone required more than stopping pursuit of somebody else.

Simone returned the archival-photo sleeve she had borrowed for a presentation. Malik told her to keep the copper notebook.

"The questions are yours now," he said.

She held it against her bag.

They hugged once. Neither hurried away afterward. Sadness occupied the lobby with them until Simone finally turned toward the stairs and Malik walked outside.

No one was humiliated. No one had won.

Two paths that had shared a season separated with both histories intact.

Tuesday, April 7: Hope Arrives Too Fast

Malik told Nia himself.

He asked her to meet on Cypress Walk in the afternoon. His face told her the news before the sentence did.

"Simone and I ended our relationship yesterday."

Hope rose inside Nia with terrible speed.

It was immediate, bright, and followed by guilt so sharp that she almost apologized aloud.

Malik looked exhausted. "She chose London. But that was not the only reason."

Nia did not ask whether she was another reason. "I am sorry."

"Thank you."

They stood beneath new spring leaves. Nia wanted to comfort him. She also knew that part of her had already turned his pain into possibility. The knowledge made every instinct suspect.

"Do you want company?" she asked.

"Not right now. I wanted you to hear it from me rather than through the group."

"Okay."

She let him leave.

Back in North Star, she told Keisha about the hope.

"A feeling can arrive before your values," Keisha said. "What matters is whether you let it drive."

Nia opened the symposium script instead of Malik's messages.

Hope had arrived.

It did not receive permission to act.

Wednesday, April 8: No Shortcut Through Grief

Nia found Malik after calculus.

Dr. Delgado had assigned an arc-length problem. Nia used the mathematics as an excuse to begin talking, then heard herself drifting toward the conversation she wanted.

"We never really discussed fall," she said. "Not directly."

Malik closed his notebook.

"No," he said. "We did not."

The quiet invited her to continue.

"Maybe after the symposium, we could--"

"Nia."

He did not sound angry. That made the boundary clearer.

"I am not turning your breakup or mine into a shortcut," he said. "Julian mattered to you. Simone mattered to me. We both need to understand what happened without using each other to prove we are ready."

Embarrassment heated Nia's face. "I was not asking you to date me tomorrow."

"I know. But you were asking us to begin moving in that direction. I cannot."

She wanted to argue that her relationship had ended months ago, that she had respected his, that waiting now felt unfair.

Respect was not a ticket that matured into a claim.

"You are right," she said.

"I care about you. That is why I need the boundary."

The sentence hurt and steadied her at once.

They left separately.

Thursday, April 9: Submit Without the Answer

The research team completed its final symposium submission at 6:42 Thursday evening.

Keisha verified the software package and checksum. Julian confirmed every media permission and caption. Nia uploaded the presentation, methods summary, limitations statement, and fellowship-interview materials.

Dr. Price required each person to approve the final version.

Keisha clicked first. Julian clicked second. Nia clicked last.

The portal displayed **SUBMISSION COMPLETE**.

They celebrated with takeout in the lab. Simone sent a brief message congratulating all three. Nia replied with thanks and did not mention Malik. Julian discussed the documentary cut. Keisha made everyone close their laptops for twenty minutes.

Later, Malik arrived to return a risk-analysis article Nia had lent him. They stepped into the hallway.

"The submission is done," she said.

"Congratulations."

"I meant what I said yesterday. You were right."

Malik nodded. "Through the presentation, we need distance. No private late-night preparation. No using the research as a reason to have the conversation early."

"Agreed."

The boundary protected both of them. It also removed the person Nia most wanted to use as evidence that she would be okay no matter what the judges decided.

She returned to her team.

The symposium would ask her to stand behind the work without certainty, romance, or reconciliation as emotional support beams.

For the first time all year, Nia would have to enter the most important room wanting something deeply and carrying no private promise about what waited after the answer.

Week Thirty-Seven: The Presentation and the No

Dr. Delgado placed a map of concentric warning zones on the screen.

Every point within the outer circle lay the same maximum distance from the broadcast tower. The picture suggested equal access.

Nia raised her hand. "Distance from the source is not distance to a safe route."

"Explain."

She walked to the board and marked two households at the same radius. One had a nearby road leading away from the flood zone. The other sat beyond a rail crossing and a low underpass. In polar coordinates, both shared the same value of (r) . In the road network, their choices were not remotely equal.

"A coordinate system makes some relationships easy to see," she said. "It can make others disappear."

Dr. Delgado nodded. "Then choose the system that serves the question, and state what it hides."

The symposium presentation waited the next morning.

Nia wrote the sentence at the top of her final notes.

Friday, April 10: Equal Radius, Unequal Access

The class calculated polar area for regions shaped like petals, loops, and overlapping circles.

Nia loved how a complicated Cartesian boundary could become a simple radial description. She also recognized the temptation to confuse mathematical convenience with human truth.

For the symposium, the team used a polar overlay to show distance from a warning source. Then they placed the real road network above it. Households at equal radial distance faced different travel times, bridge access, vehicle availability, and warning delays.

Keisha tested the live model one last time. Julian checked the order of every visual. Nia rehearsed the opening until she could say it without rushing.

Malik stayed away, honoring their agreement. He sent one message to the full team: **You have prepared the evidence. Trust each other in the room.**

Nia appreciated the message because it did not become a private promise.

That evening, she packed her conference clothes, calculator, backup drive, printed slides, and enough snacks for a small emergency shelter. Keisha removed half the snacks.

"We are traveling for three days, not establishing a colony."

"Preparedness is part of our research identity."

"Preparedness has weight limits."

Nia finally closed the suitcase.

She had done everything she knew how to do. The next step was not more preparation.

It was entering the room.

Saturday, April 11: The Other Posters

The Southeastern Undergraduate Mathematics Symposium occupied a university conference center two hours from Bellwether.

The first poster Nia saw used a dataset with millions of records. The second listed a federal grant. A third belonged to seniors who had worked together for two years and already had a journal manuscript under review.

Nia looked at their foam-board poster and suddenly saw every taped edge.

"Do not compare our January to somebody else's second year," Keisha said.

"I am comparing our printer budget to federal funding."

"That comparison is valid and unhelpful."

They attended presentations before their own session. One team predicted hospital demand using carefully anonymized records. Another modeled wildfire evacuation with a cleaner road dataset than anything Nia had imagined possible. The presenters answered questions with practiced ease.

Julian noticed what Nia did not. "That hospital team has no public-facing explanation of their uncertainty."

Keisha noticed that the wildfire model stored only final outputs, not scenario histories.

Every project had strengths and omissions. More funding did not make a team flawless. Less funding did not make McCall-Hart's work secretly superior.

Nia stopped sorting the room into threats and proof.

They pinned up the poster, connected the laptop, and tested the backup.

Their work had its own question to answer.

Sunday, April 12: The Talk They Built Together

Nia began with one household receiving a delayed warning.

Julian advanced the visual sequence. The audience watched the initial route fill as other households departed earlier. Keisha changed one road-capacity assumption in the live model. The recommended path shifted, and the history panel displayed why.

Nia explained the mathematics only after the decision was visible.

Questions came from every side.

How were trust rates estimated?

"They are not population estimates," Nia said. "We use bounded scenarios informed by a small approved interview set and published studies. The local interviews identify mechanisms, not prevalence."

Could the system predict individual behavior?

"No," Keisha answered. "It tests how different patterns affect network recommendations."

Why animate the changes?

Julian explained that a still map hid the sequence of assumptions, then acknowledged that animation could imply false authority. He showed the source labels and pause controls added after audience testing.

A judge asked whether officials should use the model now.

Nia felt the fellowship hanging inside the question. She could make the work sound ready.

"Not for operational routing," she said. "It has not been validated for that. It can help identify which data gaps and communication assumptions make a route recommendation unstable."

The answer limited the project.

It also told the truth.

When the session ended, Keisha squeezed Nia's hand. Julian whispered, "No one fainted, including the software."

They had given the talk they built together.

Monday, April 13: Praise and the Gap

The fellowship interview took place in a smaller room.

Three judges asked about public value, technical design, team roles, and future work. They praised the project's integration of mathematics, software, and communication. They praised the decision to expose assumptions rather than publish one authoritative route.

Then they identified the gaps.

The model lacked validation against a real event or exercise. The community interview sample was too limited. Transportation access remained underdeveloped. The route network covered too small an area to establish scalability. The team had not yet tested whether repeated route updates confused users.

Nia answered without defensiveness.

"Those are the next validation questions," she said. "We would not expand the tool before testing them with community and emergency-management partners."

One judge asked who would own the project if the fellowship funded it.

"No one student," Nia replied. "Keisha and I are co-leads. Julian owns the approved media workflow. Community participants control how their contributions are used. Any operational partnership would require shared governance beyond our team."

Afterward, Dr. Price told them they had represented the work well.

Nia wanted to ask whether that meant they would win.

She knew better.

Praise described what the judges valued. It did not erase what remained unresolved or predict their final choice.

Tuesday, April 14: The Other Name

The awards ceremony began at four.

Nia sat between Keisha and Julian. Her hands were cold despite the crowded ballroom.

Several project awards came first. She applauded each team. When the fellowship category appeared on the screen, the room seemed to narrow around the presenter holding the envelope.

The fellowship went to a team studying heat-risk alerts for outdoor workers.

For one fraction of a second, Nia waited for another name.

None came.

She applauded.

The winning students stood in shock, then hugged. Their work was strong. Their joy did not insult her. Nia smiled when they passed her row.

As soon as the ceremony ended, she told Keisha she needed the restroom.

She walked past it and found a concrete stairwell between conference floors.

The door closed behind her.

Nia sat on the second step and cried.

She cried because she had wanted the laboratory placement, the mentors, the money, the title, and the proof that the better version of herself could receive a better ending. She cried because the judges' gaps were real and because she had still hoped the strength of the talk would outweigh them.

No audience watched. No one needed her to be gracious or inspirational.

The fellowship belonged to another team.

The no belonged fully to her.

Wednesday, April 15: Wait Outside the Door

Keisha found Nia's location from a short message: **Stairwell B. I am safe. Not ready.**

She entered, sat two steps below, and said nothing.

Julian stayed in the hallway with their bags. Dr. Price handled checkout. The team protected Nia's privacy without pretending disappointment was an emergency to solve.

Malik had traveled to the symposium for the final day with Dr. Bennett and several actuarial students. He heard the result, found Julian outside the stairwell, and stopped.

"Is she in there?"

"Yes."

Malik did not enter.

He waited against the opposite wall. The boundary from last week still existed. Grief did not cancel consent.

Keisha eventually came out.

"She asked if you are here," she said. "I told her yes. She wants to talk to you."

Only then did Malik open the door.

Nia had washed her face, but her eyes were swollen. She shifted to make room on the step.

"I did not win," she said.

"I know."

Malik sat beside her without touching her.

The stairwell remained quiet enough for the truth to stay unperformed.

Thursday, April 16: No Lesson Tonight

"I did everything better," Nia said.

Her voice broke on the final word.

"I shared ownership. I fixed the model. I admitted uncertainty. I listened to criticism. I gave the best presentation I have ever given, and I still lost."

Malik did not tell her the experience would open another door. He did not say rejection built character, the project still mattered, or the judges might regret their choice.

"Yes," he said. "You did everything better, and you still lost."

Nia looked at him, almost angry that he agreed.

"That is all?"

"The loss is real. It does not need a lesson tonight."

The sentence removed the work of finding a silver lining before she was ready.

Nia leaned forward with her elbows on her knees. "I wanted it so much."

"I know."

"I do not want to be mature about it."

"Then do not be mature in a stairwell."

She laughed once through tears.

Malik waited until she asked before holding her hand. The gesture was comfort, not a promise. Keisha remained near the door. Julian guarded the luggage and told anyone approaching that the stairwell was temporarily experiencing advanced mathematics.

Eventually, the team left together.

The project was still theirs. The fellowship was not.

Nothing that night required Nia to pretend those facts weighed the same.

Week Thirty-Eight: What Remains

Nia opened the project folder and selected everything.

The computer displayed one question: **Move 487 items to Trash?**

She hovered over the button.

The fellowship version contained months of code, maps, interviews, drafts, mistakes, permissions, and the presentation that had failed to produce the result she wanted. Deleting it would not change the ceremony. It would remove the evidence that she had cared enough to be hurt.

Nia canceled.

She created an archive folder named **SYMPOSIUM_FELLOWSHIP_VERSION_FINAL**. Then she opened a new project file.

For the title, she typed:

COMMUNITY VALIDATION

She did not feel hopeful.

She simply was not finished.

Friday, April 17: Archive, Do Not Erase

Keisha found the new file during their final full class week.

"You want to continue?" she asked.

"I want to find out whether the model can become useful. I do not want to act like that makes losing okay."

"Good. Because it does not."

They wrote no triumphant comeback plan. Instead, they listed validation needs from the judges: more representative community input, transportation constraints, repeated-message testing, larger-network performance, and governance beyond the student team.

Julian joined later and separated the fellowship media package from raw interview materials. Every participant's permissions remained attached. Reuse would require the same limits, not a vague claim that the project had evolved.

Nia changed the project status from **FELLOWSHIP FINALIST** to **RESEARCH IN REVISION**.

The new label felt smaller.

It was also accurate.

At calculus, Dr. Delgado reviewed polar coordinates, integration methods, and series. He asked students to explain not only how to solve a problem but when the chosen representation stopped helping.

Nia understood the question differently now.

The fellowship version had taken the project as far as it could. Archiving it preserved the work without requiring the future to remain inside its boundaries.

Saturday, April 18: Useful After Ownership

The guest seminar on public mathematics drew a smaller crowd than the free-lunch announcement deserved.

Dr. Laila Monroe described a rejected transit study she had carried for years. The original research belonged to an academic team, used inaccessible language, and assumed public agencies would adopt the model because its predictions were accurate.

They did not.

The work became useful only after researchers shared decision-making with riders, drivers, disability advocates, and local planners. Those partners changed the questions, removed features they did not need, and refused several recommendations the academic team considered elegant.

"Relinquishing ownership did not mean abandoning expertise," Dr. Monroe said. "It meant accepting that being skilled at the mathematics did not make us sole authors of the problem."

Nia asked whether rejection had motivated the change.

"Partly," Dr. Monroe replied. "But do not romanticize it. I would have preferred the grant. Rejection gave us fewer resources, not secret wisdom. People gave the project a different life because we eventually learned to listen."

That answer mattered.

Nia did not need to thank the fellowship judges for saying no. She could dislike the outcome and still refuse to make it the final authority on the work.

After the seminar, she added community decision rights to the validation plan.

The project could continue only by becoming less exclusively theirs.

Sunday, April 19: A Question Julian Is Allowed to Ask

Julian met Nia in the radio studio to finish the symposium documentary archive.

They watched the final interview clip, the one where Nia compared elegant models with beautiful relationship stories. When the screen went dark, Julian remained quiet.

"Can I ask something personal?" he said.

"Yes."

"Working together went well. Better than I expected. Does any part of you think we should try dating again?"

Nia felt no panic, anger, or secret relief. Only affection for someone who deserved a direct answer.

"No," she said. "What we had mattered. What we built this spring matters. I do not want to restart the relationship."

Julian nodded slowly. "I thought that was the answer. I needed to hear it rather than turn collaboration into a sign."

"Thank you for asking instead of producing a documentary called *Signs Nia Missed*."

"The working title was stronger."

They laughed.

Nia did not punish him by withdrawing warmth. Julian did not bargain with the success of the project or invoke their good memories as evidence. They finished the archive, confirmed future media responsibilities, and walked out as collaborators whose past no longer required a sequel.

Closure was not silence. Sometimes it was a question answered clearly enough that neither person had to keep interpreting.

Monday, April 20: Return Without Rewriting

Simone and Malik exchanged the remaining pieces of spring.

He returned a finance book and a scarf she had left in North Star. She returned his museum ticket, which had been tucked inside the copper notebook, and a folder of family-photo scans she had backed up.

They met in the Porter Center lobby again.

"London orientation starts after commencement," Simone said. "I leave for the program in May."

"Do you need the international phone-plan research?"

She smiled faintly. "Send me the comparison without the relationship schedule."

"Agreed."

They discussed practical details and mutual friends. Neither used friendliness to suggest reunion. Neither turned the breakup into evidence that dating had been a mistake.

"I am glad we had spring," Simone said.

Malik felt sadness arrive without emergency. "So am I."

She kept the notebook. He kept what its questions had taught him.

When they parted, Malik did not watch her leave and imagine Nia waiting somewhere beyond the door. He walked to Dr. Bennett's office to prepare for finals.

Meaning did not require continuation.

Tuesday, April 21: One Finale Wins, One Series Does Not

Imani's softball team needed one victory in its home finale to secure a conference-tournament place.

They won behind disciplined pitching, two sacrifice bunts, and a sixth-inning double that scored the decisive run. Imani fielded the final ground ball and threw to first. The team rushed the circle as the tournament berth became official.

Across campus, baseball lost its home series and fell out of realistic postseason contention.

The two outcomes arrived within an hour.

The friend group celebrated softball at the field, then visited baseball friends packing equipment after the loss. No one asked the baseball seniors to become inspirational about it. No one told Imani to mute her joy.

"This is becoming a recurring campus lesson," DJ said.

"Apparently people keep needing it," Imani replied.

Nia cheered until her throat hurt. The softball win did not repair the fellowship rejection. That made the celebration easier, not harder. It asked nothing from her story.

For one evening, she could be happy because her friend had earned a future game.

Wednesday, April 22: Different Times Are Not Enough

Malik and Nia met in daylight, on purpose, with no research materials between them.

"I wanted you in fall," Malik said. "You were with Julian."

"I wanted you in spring," Nia replied. "You were with Simone."

The symmetry sounded neat. Their lives had not been.

Malik had waited too long and treated patience as a private future claim. Nia had mistaken his availability for permanence. Both had formed real relationships with other people. Both had used jealousy to discover feelings they should have examined directly.

"If timing were the only problem," Nia said, "we would be together now."

"Timing is not enough."

Trust had changed. So had their understanding of themselves. Malik did not know whether he could choose Nia without making her the resolution of spring. Nia did not know whether she wanted Malik as he was or as proof that the reversed year had finally become fair.

"I do care about you," she said.

"I care about you too."

Neither converted the admission into a plan.

They had finally arrived at the same emotional moment.

That did not mean they were ready to travel from it together.

Thursday, April 23: Nobody Waiting in the Wings

Nia and Malik chose finals.

The decision sounded boring enough to be healthy.

They would not schedule a first date after exams, promise to revisit the relationship in summer, or wait for the other person to become ready. They would study, finish their responsibilities, and allow the next semester to reveal who they were without romantic suspense organizing every interaction.

"No private promises," Malik said.

"No hidden countdowns," Nia added.

"No asking Keisha or DJ for intelligence reports."

"I have never called them intelligence reports."

"Your face has."

She laughed.

They returned to Dr. Delgado's review session and sat at different tables. Nia studied polar area with Amara. Malik reviewed integration methods with DJ. Keisha joined both groups only after completing track recovery.

No one waited in the wings.

The unresolved future remained open without becoming anyone's assignment.

Finals were next.

For once, the exam was the simpler uncertainty.

Week Thirty-Nine: No Shortcut Through Finals

The Calculus II final began with a page titled **METHOD SELECTION**.

Before computing anything, students had to identify a technique for six problems and justify each choice. Substitution. Integration by parts. Partial fractions. A convergence test. Parametric arc length. Polar area.

No answer from a later page could rescue a method chosen without reasoning.

Nia read the full set before writing. Malik did the same.

All year, both had tried to use action as reassurance. Start calculating. Build the schedule. Enter the relationship. Give the presentation. Movement felt safer than uncertainty.

The exam demanded a commitment before computation offered comfort.

They began.

Friday, April 24: Choose Before the Work Begins

Nia labeled each method in the margin.

For the rational function, she factored the denominator before choosing partial fractions. For the series, she noted that factorial growth made the ratio test efficient. For polar area, she sketched the interval to avoid tracing the region twice.

Malik identified integration by parts, then checked which factor should become (u) . The obvious-looking choice was not always the one that simplified under differentiation.

Dr. Delgado moved silently between rows.

The last full spring class week ended with no speeches. Students carried notes, snacks, and exhaustion toward finals. Outside, organizations advertised move-out drives and summer storage. The campus had begun preparing to empty while everyone still had work left.

Nia saw Malik at the water fountain during a break. They exchanged one nod.

No whispered predictions. No emotional check-in. Their agreement held.

The final was not a metaphor they could solve for their relationship. It was an exam, and each needed to complete it independently.

That fact felt almost restful.

Saturday, April 25: Restart While the Clock Moves

Malik reached the integration-by-parts problem and moved too fast.

He selected (u) poorly, differentiated, integrated the remaining factor, and produced a new integral worse than the original. In October, he might have forced the method forward rather than admit the first choice had failed.

The clock displayed fifty-two minutes remaining.

He crossed out the setup.

Restarting cost time. Continuing would cost the problem.

Malik chose a logarithmic factor for (u) , simplified correctly, and completed the integral. He marked the abandoned attempt clearly so Dr. Delgado could see the correction rather than mistake it for competing work.

The restart changed his pace. For the next problem, he paused before moving.

He thought briefly of Simone, then returned to the page. Their relationship could not be restarted with a better method. The lesson was not that every wrong choice deserved another attempt. It was that honesty about a failing process mattered before the clock decided for you.

Malik completed the final line with nine minutes left.

He used all nine to check assumptions.

Sunday, April 26: Distrusting the Right Instinct

Nia recognized the divergent series immediately.

The terms did not approach zero. The n th-term test settled the question.

She wrote the conclusion, then doubted it.

The fellowship rejection had made confidence feel suspicious. She had given a strong talk and still been judged incomplete. Now every clear instinct seemed like possible evidence that she had missed something.

Nia attempted a comparison test. Then she considered the ratio test. Neither was necessary. Minutes disappeared while she tried to prove the result three different ways.

Finally, she heard Dr. Delgado's review-session warning: use the simplest test that resolves the question.

She crossed out the extra work and restored the original argument. If the terms of an infinite series failed to approach zero, the series diverged. No elaborate proof made the conclusion more true.

Confidence was not certainty that every instinct was right. It was the ability to test an instinct against an appropriate standard and stop when the evidence was sufficient.

Nia moved to the next problem with less time than she wanted and enough time to finish.

Monday, April 27: Work Without Points

When the exam ended, students flooded the hallway and began reconstructing questions from memory.

"Was the polar interval zero to π or zero to two π ?"

"What did you get for the ratio limit?"

"Did anybody finish the arc length?"

Dr. Delgado stepped into the doorway. "I will not grade by hallway vote. Stop conducting statistical analysis on a sample selected by panic."

He refused every request to estimate scores.

Instead, he asked one final question.

"What work from this course would you still choose if no points were attached?"

Amara named tutoring another student through identities because teaching had made her less afraid to speak. Malik chose risk problems where the method changed a decision. Nia chose the evacuation research, though the fellowship had assigned it no reward.

"Then protect that answer from grades," Dr. Delgado said. "A course evaluates specific work under specific conditions. It does not own every reason you learned."

Outside, Nia did not ask Malik how he performed. He did not ask her.

They left the result where it belonged: with the exam.

Tuesday, April 28: One Uncomplicated Celebration

The softball rivalry game reached the bottom of the seventh tied.

McCall-Hart needed the win to secure a stronger conference-tournament seed. Two outs. Runner on second. Imani at the plate.

The first pitch missed outside. The second became a foul. The third came low and fast.

Imani drove it through the left side.

The runner rounded third. The throw arrived late. Safe.

The dugout emptied.

Imani disappeared beneath teammates, dirt, and an indigo sports-drink shower. The crowd shouted until every difficult conversation, rejected fellowship, final exam, and uncertain summer briefly lost volume.

Nia hugged Keisha. DJ nearly climbed the fence. Malik laughed when the celebration carried Imani's helmet in one direction and Imani in another.

The walk-off did not teach them how to handle loss. It did not symbolize convergence, trust, or second chances.

It was simply wonderful.

For one night, nobody translated it.

Wednesday, April 29: Continue Under New Conditions

Dr. Price invited Nia and Keisha to her office.

The summer Quantitative Scholars program had space for the evacuation project to continue. The invitation came with conditions.

The team would not repackage the symposium model and pursue another award. They would build a community-validation plan, obtain appropriate approvals, expand transportation assumptions, and share governance with local partners. Dr. Renee Okafor would oversee the mathematical work alongside Dr. Price.

"This is not the fellowship," Dr. Price said.

"I know," Nia replied.

The program was campus-based, paid less, and offered no national title. It also provided time, mentoring, and a path to make the rejected work useful.

Nia looked at Keisha. "Co-leads?"

"In writing," Keisha said.

Dr. Price slid the draft appointments across the desk. Nia was project lead. Keisha was computation co-lead.

Keisha raised one eyebrow.

Nia did not accept.

"Both titles need to say co-lead," she said. "Different responsibilities, equal project authority."

Dr. Price nodded and marked the revision.

They took the offer home to consider.

The work had continued because its questions remained. It had not transformed the no into a yes.

Thursday, April 30: A Day Before the Answer

Dr. Bennett invited Malik to join the same summer project as a risk-modeling assistant.

"Your actuarial perspective could strengthen the uncertainty and loss assumptions," he said.

"You would report to the project co-leads and Dr. Okafor."

Malik understood immediately that Nia and Keisha were the co-leads.

He also understood what accepting would mean: daily work with Nia, unresolved feelings, and a project tied to storms like the one that had damaged his family home.

"I am interested," he said. "Can I have a day before answering?"

Dr. Bennett smiled. "That is why I did not hand you a pen."

Malik reviewed the role rather than the romantic possibility. The project needed scenario risk, documentation of uncertain loss, and validation that did not privilege only insured property. His family experience could inform questions, but he would not turn private damage into evidence without their permission.

He called his parents. He spoke with DJ. He did not call Nia.

Across campus, Nia reviewed her own offer with Keisha. Neither knew whether Malik had been invited.

The summer path offered proximity.

It offered work.

It offered no romantic resolution, and for the first time, Malik waited a day because the decision deserved more than the answer he wanted fastest.

Week Forty: The Space Between Semesters

Spring grades arrived before breakfast.

Nia opened hers under a blanket, as if fabric could protect her from a number already stored in the university system. Malik checked his at the North Star front desk between returning loaner calculators.

Both had passed Calculus II strongly.

Nia stared at the grade and waited for it to change how she felt about the fellowship. It did not. Malik waited for his grade to make the summer project decision obvious. It did not.

A course result could confirm that they had learned integration methods, series, parametric equations, and polar coordinates. It could not evaluate whether Nia's work deserved national funding. It could not determine whether Malik was ready to work beside her without treating proximity as a promise.

They sent each other brief congratulations.

No hidden message traveled underneath.

Friday, May 1: The Grade Stays in Its Lane

Final examinations ended, and McCall-Hart changed moods in one afternoon.

Students who had moved silently through the week now shouted across courtyards. Library tables emptied. Residence halls filled with open boxes, discarded hangers, and arguments about whether one microwave belonged to a roommate or to "the room as a community."

Nia celebrated her grade with Keisha and Amara over melting ice cream. Keisha had passed her courses while racing, co-leading research, and protecting her time from Nia's scheduling ambitions. Amara had earned one of her strongest math grades after beginning the year afraid to speak at the board.

"We survived Calculus II," Nia announced.

"We learned Calculus II," Amara corrected.

"That is a much more academic slogan."

Malik called his parents. Marcel joked that two semesters of calculus should qualify Malik to calculate when the insurance contractor would finally finish. Celeste reminded both of them that no equation could make a contractor answer the phone.

The good grade belonged to the course. The unfinished home belonged to another problem. The ended relationship belonged to a third.

For once, Malik did not force the results into one story about whether his life was improving.

Each stayed in its lane.

Saturday, May 2: Walking Past the Fellowship

Spring commencement filled Founders Lawn with cream chairs, family umbrellas, camera phones, and graduates trying not to lose decorated caps in the wind.

Nia watched several student researchers cross the stage. One had presented at the symposium. Another had worked at Delta National Laboratory the previous summer. Their faculty mentors cheered from the side.

The sight reopened the fellowship grief.

Nia imagined the professional photograph she would not take, the laboratory access she would not receive under that award, and the title that would not appear beside her name. The pain arrived without making her feel fraudulent among mathematicians.

That difference mattered.

In the stairwell after the ceremony, she had felt as if rejection might define the edge of her ability. Now she could recognize the fellowship as a door she had not entered, not a verdict that she did not belong in the building.

Dr. Price passed with a group of graduates.

"Are you considering the summer offer?" she asked.

"Yes. I am still disappointed."

"Those facts do not compete."

Nia watched another mathematics student pose with three generations of family beneath the Founders' Bell.

She wanted a future in this work.

The no had changed its route, not its direction.

Sunday, May 3: The Semifinal

Residence halls closed while Imani's softball team played its conference semifinal.

Nia and Keisha loaded half their room into Denise Reynolds's car, watched the first innings on a phone balanced against a storage bin, and yelled whenever the screen froze at the worst possible moment.

McCall-Hart entered the seventh inning trailing by one. Imani reached base, advanced to second, and was stranded when a deep fly ball died at the warning track.

The game ended there.

No walk-off came. No postseason invitation waited beyond the scoreboard.

Imani's team had produced its most successful season in years. The seniors had changed the program's expectations. They still lost the semifinal they wanted to win.

On the field, players stood in a long line after shaking hands. Some cried immediately. Others remained composed until the coaches gathered them near the dugout.

Nia did not tell herself the season mattered more than the result. The season mattered, and the result hurt.

She understood the grammar now.

Keisha closed the stream only after every senior left the field.

Then they finished moving out of the room where spring had changed both of them.

Monday, May 4: Pride Without the Trophy

The softball team held a senior dinner on campus before everyone left.

Imani invited the friend group to help decorate. Photographs covered one wall: early losses, rain delays, bus rides, study halls, wins, taped wrists, and seniors laughing beneath stadium lights.

The coach did not call the semifinal a moral victory.

"We wanted the championship," she said. "We did not win it. We also built a season future teams will inherit. Both deserve honest names."

Each senior spoke about one thing she was proud of and one thing she wished had ended differently. The room held both without correcting either.

Nia wrote the sentence on the back of a program: **Pride does not require pretending the trophy was irrelevant.**

Imani saw it. "Are you turning our banquet into research?"

"Personal reflection."

"That sounds worse."

They laughed, took too many pictures, and danced when the formal program ended. The seniors carried no trophy out of the room. They carried their own records, friendships, and the knowledge that the next team would begin from a higher standard.

Nia left still wishing they had won.

She also left proud.

Tuesday, May 5: Do Not Keep It Half-Alive

Simone left for international internship orientation with one suitcase, one garment bag, and the copper notebook in her backpack.

Malik met her at the shuttle stop. They had already returned personal items and ended the relationship. This goodbye was not another breakup.

"I want to ask one thing," Simone said.

"Okay."

"Let spring remain meaningful without keeping it half-alive. Do not send messages designed to make me remember us. Do not wait for London to fail. Do not treat friendship as a holding pattern."

Malik felt the precision of every request.

"I will not."

"And I will not send you loneliness as if it means we chose wrong."

They hugged. Simone stepped onto the shuttle and chose a seat near the window. She did not make a dramatic final gesture as it pulled away. Malik did not chase the bus with one more thought.

He watched until it turned beyond the Porter Center, then left.

Their relationship had an ending. Respecting it meant not stretching affection into an unofficial continuation neither had chosen.

London belonged to Simone now.

Spring belonged to both of them as history.

Wednesday, May 6: Roles in Writing

Malik accepted the summer risk-modeling role.

He told Dr. Bennett that he understood Nia and Keisha would be project co-leads and that his family experience could not be used without consent.

"Good," Dr. Bennett said. "You are joining a research team, not a personal narrative."

Across the hall, Dr. Price handed Nia and Keisha revised appointment letters. Both now held co-lead authority. Nia led mathematical modeling and community integration. Keisha led computation, data governance, and reproducibility. Neither title reduced the other's decisions to support.

Keisha signed first.

Nia signed second.

Only afterward did Dr. Price tell them Malik had accepted.

Nia's heart reacted before her face. She let the feeling pass.

"What is his scope?" she asked.

Risk metrics, validation, loss assumptions, and documentation. A professional role with edges.

"That can strengthen the project," Keisha said.

"Yes," Nia agreed.

Neither discussed what it might mean romantically because the appointment letters promised work, not resolution.

Thursday, May 7: Leave Without a Promise

Before the short break, Malik and Nia met on Founders Lawn.

Campus looked temporary. Chairs were gone. Move-out bins waited near residence halls. Summer students had not yet arrived.

"I accepted," Malik said.

"So did Keisha and I."

"I know."

They reviewed what that meant. They would take Calculus III together, work on the same project, and spend more time in Eliza Moss Hall than either considered medically advisable.

"No private promises before the work begins," Nia said.

"No assuming proximity is progress."

"No pretending we do not have feelings."

"And no letting the feelings make team decisions."

They agreed.

Nia left for Huntsville. Malik left for Gulfport. Keisha traveled to family with her laptop closed for the first forty-eight hours under threat from her track teammates.

For one brief week, no class met and no model ran.

The space between semesters did not resolve anything.

It gave each person room to return by choice.

Week Forty-One: Vectors and Boundaries

Malik returned from Gulfport carrying photographs of new framing inside the Baptiste home.

Fresh lumber outlined the back rooms damaged by the storm. Electrical work had passed inspection. Drywall waited in stacks.

The pictures looked like progress.

They did not contain a move-back date.

One contractor still needed to finish roof work. Insurance reimbursement remained incomplete. Marcel's injured leg had improved, but he could not yet handle every repair task himself.

Malik placed the photographs in archival sleeves. He labeled dates without labeling the family recovered.

The house had a direction.

Its remaining distance was unknown.

Friday, May 8: Framing Is Not a Finished Room

Celeste showed Malik where the repaired wall would divide the back bedroom from the hall.

"By July, maybe," she said.

Marcel responded from the doorway. "Do not give the contractor a date he did not give us."

They had learned to distrust hopeful estimates spoken as promises.

Before returning to Bellwether, Malik photographed the framing, moisture barriers, and uncompleted ceiling. He asked his parents whether he could show the images to the summer research team if the discussion required a real example of documented and undocumented loss.

"Not yet," Celeste said. "Tell them the story first. Let us decide about pictures after we know why they need them."

"Okay."

The permission boundary was clear.

On the drive back, Malik considered how insurance records would price the repaired materials. The records would not capture months of living around closed rooms, his mother's caution about dates, or his father's frustration at being unable to finish work with his own hands.

Risk metrics turned experience into quantities.

The quantities needed to remain answerable to the people whose experience they represented.

Saturday, May 9: Carry the Label

Nia returned to campus with the rejected symposium poster rolled beneath one arm.

Keisha saw the fellowship-finalist label printed across the bottom.

"We can trim that off," she said.

Nia considered it. The label made the loss visible. It also described the version they had actually built.

"No," she said. "We archive honestly."

They mounted the poster in the summer project room beside a blank board titled **COMMUNITY VALIDATION QUESTIONS**. The old project and the new work occupied the same wall without pretending they were the same stage.

Julian would contribute during scheduled media sessions around his summer production work. He was not enrolled in the full quantitative program. Imani was preparing for tournament travel. DJ began offseason training. Simone sent the group a photo from orientation, standing beneath an airport departure board with the copper notebook visible in one hand.

Everyone's summer had a different direction.

Nia unpacked her route maps. She felt nervous about seeing Malik and refused to disguise the feeling as research intensity.

"I have feelings," she told Keisha.

"Historically verified."

"I am also a co-lead."

"Then lead the project, not the feelings."

The advice lacked poetry and possessed excellent timing.

Sunday, May 10: Separate Responsibilities

Summer Quantitative Scholars orientation began in Eliza Moss Hall.

Dr. Renee Okafor welcomed a smaller group than the spring program. Summer moved faster. Calculus III met nearly every weekday. Research sessions occupied afternoons. Students who treated the compressed calendar like ordinary semester time would discover the error before the calendar felt sympathy.

She introduced the evacuation team by responsibility.

Nia: mathematical model and community-integration lead.

Keisha: computation and data-governance lead.

Malik: risk and validation analyst.

Dr. Price supervised the public-mathematics and research design. Dr. Okafor supervised multivariable modeling. No one described Malik and Nia as a natural pair.

During role questions, Malik asked which decisions required co-lead approval. Keisha answered before Nia. Nia supported her answer without repeating it louder.

Progress already.

The team received one shared workspace and separate task folders. Dr. Okafor warned them that interdisciplinary work would create disagreement.

"Professional collaboration does not mean avoiding conflict," she said. "It means making the conflict inspectable."

Nia and Malik exchanged a glance.

They had several kinds of conflict waiting.

Only one belonged in the first design review.

Monday, May 11: Magnitude Is Not Direction

Calculus III began with vectors.

Dr. Okafor drew arrows in three-dimensional space. Each had magnitude and direction. Two vectors could have equal magnitude while pointing opposite ways. A very large vector aimed badly could move a system far from its goal.

"Students often confuse intensity with progress," she said. "Working harder, caring more, or moving faster tells us nothing about whether the direction is useful."

Nia wrote the sentence beside the rejected fellowship label in her notes.

Malik calculated vector components. Keisha represented a route displacement in three dimensions, adding elevation to the road network. A short horizontal path up a steep grade might impose very different access demands.

During practice, Nia and Malik solved one vector sum almost simultaneously.

The old ease appeared.

Neither treated it as a sign.

After class, Nia went to the project room with Keisha. Malik met Dr. Bennett to review validation standards. They had moved in related directions without attaching themselves to one arrow.

Tuesday, May 12: Put the Boundaries in the Document

Malik and Nia wrote collaboration rules in a shared document.

Keisha attended as co-lead and delighted witness.

No one-on-one work after nine at night unless the task was urgent and logged with the team.

Private relationship conversations would not occur during project meetings.

Technical disagreement could happen in front of the team. Personal history could not be used to win it.

Either person could request a pause without the pause being treated as abandonment.

No private messages about project decisions that excluded Keisha from co-lead authority.

"That one should be first," Keisha said.

They moved it.

Nia added: no interpreting academic ease as romantic progress.

Malik added: no using distance as punishment after disagreement.

The document felt awkward because it named the exact habits they could otherwise pretend were accidental.

They all signed.

"Congratulations," Keisha said. "Your feelings now have governance."

"Please never say that again," Malik replied.

The rules could not guarantee wise behavior. They could make violations visible before the team paid for them.

Wednesday, May 13: The Last Road Loss

Baseball's final road series ended with McCall-Hart outside postseason qualification.

The seniors knew before the last out that no tournament invitation was coming. They packed the dugout quietly, then gathered on the field for a team photograph in another school's stadium.

Julian filmed short interviews for campus media. He did not ask what lesson the seniors had learned from losing. He asked what work they wanted younger players to inherit.

One senior named the tutoring schedule they had established. Another named offseason lifting standards. A pitcher described the system for checking on injured teammates after travel.

The season record remained below .500.

The inherited work remained real.

Back in Bellwether, the friend group sent messages without demanding that seniors perform gratitude. A home finale still waited, but postseason hope did not.

Nia thought about the fellowship poster mounted in the project room. A failed desired outcome and useful inherited work could occupy the same wall.

Summer was already asking them to practice that truth again.

Thursday, May 14: Leave When the Assignment Ends

The first vector assignment took Nia and Malik less than an hour together.

They decomposed forces, found magnitudes, and used unit vectors to express direction. Their approaches fit. Malik checked components. Nia visualized geometry. Each caught one small error from the other.

At 8:17, they finished.

The campus outside Eliza Moss Hall was warm and quiet. In the past, they would have extended the night with another problem, a walk, or a conversation neither was ready to name.

"Good work," Nia said, packing her notebook.

"You too."

They left the building together, reached the courtyard, and separated.

Malik went to North Star. Nia called her mother while walking toward summer housing. Neither turned back to see whether the other did.

The efficient assignment proved they still worked well together.

Leaving on time proved they could decide what that fact was allowed to mean.

Week Forty-Two: Lines That Do Not Meet

Dr. Okafor drew two lines in three-dimensional space.

They were not parallel. Their direction vectors pointed differently. Yet solving their parametric equations produced no shared point.

"Skew lines," Keisha said.

"Correct," Dr. Okafor replied. "Not parallel, not intersecting, and not contained in the same plane."

Nia looked at the board. In two dimensions, nonparallel lines eventually met. The extra dimension allowed them to pass without contact.

"So visual closeness can be misleading," Malik said.

"Frequently. Determine the geometry. Do not infer intersection from appearance."

Their summer roles occupied the same project. Their objectives, they would soon discover, did not yet meet.

Friday, May 15: Passing in Different Planes

The class built equations for lines and planes from points and direction vectors.

Nia solved intersections by matching components. Malik used normal vectors to calculate distance from a point to a plane. Keisha found a computational method for determining whether two route segments crossed in three-dimensional space or only appeared to cross on a flat map.

That distinction mattered for overpasses, underpasses, and elevated roads. A two-dimensional network could mark two roads as connected when one passed above the other.

"That may explain three false route options," Keisha said.

They corrected the map topology before lunch.

The technical win put everyone in a generous mood. Malik used the opening to propose a new risk metric for the first summer design review.

"Minimize expected travel time across all modeled households," he said. "Include uncertainty penalties for unstable roads."

Nia read the equation. The average outcome improved.

Several neighborhoods with only one or two viable routes remained vulnerable.

"This does not protect people with the fewest choices," she said.

The generous mood left quietly.

Saturday, May 16: Average Time or Minimum Access

Malik defended the expected-travel-time metric.

It reduced total exposure on the network. It could compare scenarios clearly. It avoided optimizing around rare edge cases at the expense of thousands of other travelers.

Nia objected to the phrase *edge cases*.

"The neighborhoods with one bridge or one elevated road are not errors at the edge of the data," she said. "They are the people most trapped by a bad recommendation."

She proposed an access metric that penalized scenarios leaving any neighborhood without a reliable route choice. Her approach protected the worst-served group, even if average travel time increased.

Malik pointed out that an extreme penalty could reroute large numbers of people inefficiently to improve one area's score by a small amount.

"And your average can look excellent while the same neighborhood loses every time," Nia replied.

Keisha listened from behind her laptop.

Both objectives were mathematically defensible. They optimized different outcomes.

Instead of recognizing the tradeoff, Malik and Nia each began treating the other metric as a disguised moral failure.

The first design review was scheduled for Sunday.

They carried the disagreement into it without translating first.

Sunday, May 17: The Rejected Proposal Enters the Room

Dr. Okafor asked Nia to explain why her access penalty used the chosen threshold.

Nia cited the symposium model, community interviews, and the need to prevent route isolation.

Malik interrupted. "That threshold was designed for the fellowship presentation. We are supposed to validate the rejected proposal, not preserve it."

The word *rejected* changed the room.

Nia heard more than the technical criticism. She heard that her attachment to the project made her incapable of revising it, that the fellowship loss still defined her judgment, and that Malik had decided he was the person willing to say so.

"I am not preserving anything," she said. "I am protecting the exact households the judges said we had not represented."

"Then test whether the threshold does that. Do not keep it because it carries the values you presented."

"And do not remove it because averages are easier to price."

Dr. Okafor stopped the review.

"Your technical disagreement has become a trial of each other's motives," she said. "No useful design decision will come from that."

She ended the meeting without approving either metric.

The written boundaries had survived less than one week before pressure found their weakest seam.

Monday, May 18: The People Missing From the Price

Nia arrived Monday still angry.

She reviewed Malik's metric and highlighted every place sparse data reduced estimated loss. Neighborhoods with fewer documented trips, lower insured property values, or inconsistent road records contributed less to the expected total.

"Your objective optimizes away the people whose data are hardest to price," she told him.

Malik went still.

The accusation struck his family history. Insurance records had captured repair materials more easily than displacement, lost work, or months of restricted rooms. Nia did not know that he had spent the weekend thinking about exactly those omissions.

"You think I do not understand missing loss because I use expected value?"

"I think the equation rewards whatever is easiest to count."

"Then criticize the equation. Do not assign me the values inside it."

Nia recognized too late that she had done what Dr. Okafor prohibited. Malik had challenged her threshold as preserved from rejection. She had answered by challenging his care for underdocumented people.

Neither had stayed inside the technical claim.

Keisha shut her laptop with a sound that ended the argument more effectively than shouting.

"Tomorrow," she said. "You are both bringing written work."

"What work?" Nia asked.

"Each other's."

Tuesday, May 19: Write the Other Objective First

Keisha assigned the exercise at nine.

Malik had to write Nia's access objective accurately, including what it protected, where it could distort decisions, and what evidence would validate the threshold.

Nia had to write Malik's expected-travel-time objective with the same care.

They could not rebut anything until the other person approved the description.

Malik wrote that Nia's metric protected neighborhoods from route isolation and prevented aggregate improvement from hiding repeated harm. He identified its risk: an arbitrary threshold or extreme penalty could worsen systemwide evacuation without enough benefit.

Nia approved the description after changing *small neighborhoods* to *neighborhoods with fewer viable routes*.

Nia wrote that Malik's metric minimized total expected travel and exposure while accounting for uncertain capacity. It enabled scenario comparison and efficient use of the network. Its risk was that sparse or undervalued loss data could make severe local harm nearly invisible inside an average.

Malik approved it after she distinguished a flaw in the data from a flaw inherent to expected value.

Only then did Keisha allow discussion.

The room sounded different. They were no longer arguing over which person cared correctly. They were examining two objective functions with visible benefits and costs.

"We may need both," Malik said.

Nia nodded. "And we may need to show when they disagree."

Wednesday, May 20: What the Standings Do Not Hold

Baseball's home finale honored seniors from a losing season.

The team was already eliminated from postseason contention. Still, the stands filled with families, alumni, and students. Senior posters lined the fence. A first baseman's little brother threw the ceremonial pitch several feet short of home and celebrated as if he had broken a record.

McCall-Hart lost the game in extra innings.

Afterward, seniors circled the field, thanked staff, and handed equipment to younger players. Julian's video featured the tutoring schedule, injury check-ins, and training standards they had created.

The standings measured wins and losses accurately.

They did not measure everything the seniors left behind.

Nia sat beside Malik with Keisha between them. No one used the game to solve the design review. But the evening gave their disagreement a useful frame: one metric could be valid and incomplete without becoming dishonest.

On the walk back, Malik said, "Expected time is still important."

"Yes," Nia replied. "So is minimum route access."

Keisha looked between them. "Amazing. Two days ago, that sentence required judicial intervention."

Thursday, May 21: Show the Tradeoff

The revised model did not combine both objectives into one magical score.

Instead, it reported them side by side.

One panel showed expected travel time and total modeled exposure. Another showed the number of neighborhoods below the minimum access threshold and the severity of route isolation. A tradeoff curve displayed where improving one objective worsened the other.

Decision-makers could adjust weights, but the model recorded those choices rather than hiding them inside a default.

At the second design review, Malik explained the expected-value metric. Nia explained the access metric. Keisha demonstrated scenarios where they agreed and one where they strongly diverged.

"Which result do you recommend?" Dr. Okafor asked.

Malik answered first. "We cannot recommend a weight without community and agency input."

Nia continued, "Our result is that the tradeoff exists and becomes most severe where route data and options are sparse."

Dr. Okafor approved the design for community review.

Afterward, Nia apologized to Malik for assigning him the values of a flawed dataset. Malik apologized for turning her access threshold into evidence that she could not release the fellowship version.

The technical disagreement remained.

That was the point.

They had made it visible enough for evidence and community priorities to enter, rather than forcing one metric to pretend the conflict had disappeared.

Week Forty-Three: Motion in the Real World

The first resident rejected both of the team's routes.

Nia placed the printed map on a folding table inside the Bellwether neighborhood center. One route minimized expected travel time. The other protected access for the area with the fewest alternatives.

"I would start here," the resident said, pointing to neither line. "Then if water reaches the service road, I turn north. If traffic backs up by the school, I call my daughter and use the church lot."

"So you would change routes during the trip?" Nia asked.

The woman looked at her. "Wouldn't you?"

The model assumed a household selected one path and followed it to safety.

People did not.

They watched water, traffic, fuel, messages, children, neighbors, and one another. Their routes moved because the world moved.

Friday, May 22: The Fixed Path Breaks

The approved interview session used large maps, removable route markers, and no recording until participants made separate choices about consent.

One resident changed routes after hearing a bridge had closed. Another avoided a road long before official closure because she knew where water collected. A parent described beginning toward one shelter, then turning when a family group chat reported that it was full.

The team's fixed-path assumption failed repeatedly.

Malik asked what made participants abandon an initial route. Answers included visible water, stalled traffic, trusted phone calls, low fuel, police direction, and fear based on previous storms.

Keisha documented decision points instead of forcing every story into one category. Nia moved markers across the map as people spoke.

"Your model thinks the route is a promise," an older man said. "A route is what I am doing until I learn better."

Nia wrote the sentence down.

At the end, the two-metric display still mattered. Expected travel and minimum access shaped choices. But neither metric described motion if the system evaluated only the starting decision.

The model needed a path that could change over time without pretending every change happened instantly.

Saturday, May 23: Position as a Function of Time

In Calculus III, Dr. Okafor represented motion with vector-valued functions.

Position depended on time. Differentiation produced velocity. Differentiating velocity produced acceleration. Curvature described how sharply a path turned.

Nia saw the interviews inside the notation.

A household's location could become a vector function. Traffic and warnings could update desired velocity. Route changes could alter direction. The model should not ask only which path was shortest or most accessible. It should ask how movement evolved as conditions changed.

She brought the redesign to Keisha and Malik.

Keisha divided the simulation into time steps. Malik proposed risk updates tied to new road and warning data. Nia defined position, direction, and route-choice states.

"We cannot let a car jump from one road to another because the recommendation changes," Keisha said.

"Physical continuity," Malik replied.

"And human delay," Nia added. "People need time to receive, trust, and act on an update."

Their static map became a motion model.

It was more complicated, slower, and closer to the decisions residents had actually described.

Sunday, May 24: Why Averages Make Him Nervous

The community advisory group reviewed the redesign.

Malik explained the two-metric display and why expected travel time could hide severe local harm. A member asked why he cared so much about losses that averages did not capture.

For several seconds, Malik considered giving an academic answer.

Then he told the team about Gulfport.

He described water entering the Baptiste home, Marcel's injury, the insurance documentation, and the months during which rooms remained unusable. The claim recorded damaged property more easily than lost work, disrupted sleep, family strain, or the cost of living around repairs.

"Our documented loss was not our total loss," he said. "That is why a clean average makes me nervous. It can be mathematically accurate and still reward whatever was easiest to record."

Nia had heard pieces privately. Keisha knew the storm had affected his family. The advisory group had not known any of it.

Malik did not display photographs. His parents had not approved that use.

One resident thanked him, then challenged him. "Your experience can help you ask a question. It cannot answer for every family."

"Agreed," Malik said.

He wrote the correction into the meeting notes himself.

Personal stake had entered the project as context, not authority.

Monday, May 25: A Day Not Available for Data

McCall-Hart closed for Memorial Day.

The team had originally marked the day as an optional interview opportunity because many residents would be off work. The advisory group declined.

Instead, the neighborhood hosted a remembrance event honoring military service members and local residents lost during the year. Families brought photographs. Volunteers placed flags and flowers near a temporary memorial. Names were read without turning the ceremony into university programming.

Nia, Keisha, Malik, Julian, DJ, and Imani attended as participants and volunteers. They set up chairs, served water, and packed supplies afterward.

No clip entered the documentary. No quote entered the dataset. Julian left his recording equipment zipped inside its case.

When a resident began discussing storm evacuation with Malik, he listened but did not open a consent form.

The holiday was not spare capacity in the research calendar.

Pausing data collection showed that community life did not exist to feed the project. Some gatherings deserved presence without extraction.

Tuesday, May 26: Cars Cannot Teleport

Keisha's first motion simulation looked impressive until twelve hundred vehicles changed direction in the same second.

Onscreen, cars leaped across lanes, accelerated beyond physical possibility, and entered side roads as if traffic laws had been suspended by mathematics.

DJ watched the replay. "I do not drive often, but I believe that is illegal."

"It is computational enthusiasm," Keisha said.

She calculated acceleration whenever the model issued a new route recommendation. Sudden updates produced impossible jumps in speed and direction. The system optimized where vehicles should go without modeling how they could physically get there.

Nia added decision delay. Malik added congestion costs for simultaneous rerouting. Keisha constrained acceleration and turn rates. Updates now spread across time rather than commanding instant obedience.

The new simulation produced a less dramatic improvement in travel time.

It also stopped teleporting cars through buildings.

"A difficult tradeoff," DJ said.

Keisha removed his guest access to commentary.

Wednesday, May 27: Permission Before the Microphone

Julian returned for an audio session with the community advisory group.

Before recording, he presented four choices. Participants could allow identifiable audio, anonymous edited audio, written quotation only, or no media use. Research participation did not require media permission. A person could change the media choice later without withdrawing the entire interview.

One participant allowed written notes but not her voice. Another approved audio only for community workshops, not public social media. A third wanted to review the final clip before use.

Julian recorded each restriction with the file, not in a separate memory-based list.

Nia asked whether the extra steps slowed production.

"Yes," he said. "Consent is allowed to take time."

The final clips were fewer than he hoped and more trustworthy than a larger collection would have been.

His spring role had taught him that making work public created responsibility beyond visual quality. Summer made that responsibility operational.

Every voice kept its owner's terms.

Thursday, May 28: Tell the Team, Not Only Me

Nia thanked Malik after the advisory meeting.

"For talking about your family," she said. "I know that was not easy."

They stood outside Eliza Moss Hall in late afternoon heat.

"I used to think telling you was the same as being honest," Malik said. "It was not."

Nia felt the weight of the distinction.

During the fall, Malik had let her see pieces of his fear while hiding them from teammates, faculty, and sometimes his family. Private disclosure had made their bond feel special, but it had also concentrated responsibility in one relationship.

"Trust now means telling the people who need the information," he continued. "Not only the person whose understanding matters most to me."

He did not take back the final phrase. Nia did not turn it into a romantic decision.

"The team needed to know why the metric mattered," she said.

"And they needed permission to challenge my interpretation."

The next test would happen at Delta National Laboratory, where a larger road network could expose failures no private understanding would fix.

They entered Eliza Moss Hall together and joined Keisha before the meeting began.

Week Forty-Four: The Gradient Trip

Dr. Okafor drew a surface representing storm risk.

Road capacity varied along one axis. Warning delay varied along another. Height represented modeled exposure.

She held warning delay fixed and changed road capacity. The resulting rate of change was one partial derivative.

Then she held capacity fixed and changed warning delay.

"Useful mathematics," she said. "Now tell me when holding one factor fixed becomes impossible."

Nia thought of traffic responding to warnings. Malik thought of insurance loss changing with both hazard and access. Keisha thought of software inputs that shared the same source.

In the real system, variables moved together.

Partial derivatives could isolate influence. They could not make isolation physically true.

Friday, May 29: Hold One Thing Still

The class examined multivariable functions through tables, contour maps, and slices.

Nia used partial derivatives to test how sensitive route isolation was to one factor near a chosen scenario. Malik used them to examine expected loss. Keisha checked whether one input appeared in multiple transformations, making the assumption of independence suspect.

"A partial derivative answers a controlled question," Dr. Okafor said. "Do not report it as the whole system's response."

Before the Delta trip, the team created a dependency map. Warning delay affected departure volume. Departure volume affected congestion. Congestion affected travel time and route access. Changing one value while freezing the others could reveal local sensitivity, but the combined simulation had to restore the links.

They packed code, methods documents, consent limitations, and the rejected symposium poster.

"Do we need the poster?" Malik asked.

"It shows the version we are testing," Nia said.

"And what failed," Keisha added.

They rolled it into the travel tube.

Delta would receive the work with its history attached.

Saturday, May 30: Orientation Before Access

The three-day Delta National Laboratory visit began with four hours of orientation.

Security staff checked identification and devices. An ethics officer explained acceptable data use. A governance specialist reviewed who could access each dataset, what transformations required documentation, and why downloading a convenient copy to a personal laptop could become a serious breach.

Only after lunch did the team see the supercomputing floor.

Keisha appreciated the order.

"Every brochure begins with the machines," she said. "The actual work begins with permissions."

Julian attended the communication track and learned which images could be recorded. Nia and Malik signed agreements acknowledging that lab data could not be blended with community interviews without review. Dr. Okafor made everyone describe the limits in their own words.

The computers were extraordinary. Rows of cabinets glowed behind glass while cooling systems moved heat away from thousands of processors.

None of that capacity granted the team authority to use every available record.

Power arrived after responsibility, not before it.

Sunday, May 31: The Steepest Way Is Not the Safe Way

A Delta scientist projected a contour map of storm-surge height.

At one point, the gradient vector pointed in the direction of fastest increase. The negative gradient pointed toward fastest decrease.

"Would you evacuate exactly along the negative gradient?" she asked.

Several students said yes.

She added the road network.

The fastest decrease crossed marshland, a barrier, and an area without a drivable surface. Another direction reduced surge more slowly but followed an elevated road toward a shelter.

"Steepest improvement in one variable is not the safest feasible path," she said.

Nia saw their two-metric model again. Malik's expected-time objective and her access objective each defined a direction of improvement. Constraints and community knowledge determined which directions were possible and acceptable.

The scientist asked them to map the gradient of route risk. Keisha produced a local visualization. Malik identified where one small capacity change caused a large increase in expected exposure. Nia identified where the same change eliminated the only feasible route for one area.

The most important direction depended on what loss the team refused to hide.

Monday, June 1: Fast Computer, Slow Model

Keisha ported a reduced model to Delta's test environment.

On the campus network, it handled a few thousand road segments. Delta supplied a much larger synthetic network with tens of thousands, denser intersections, and more scenario updates.

The model slowed to a crawl.

More computing power helped. It did not rescue an inefficient design.

The route-history system stored too much duplicate state. The access calculation recomputed neighborhoods unaffected by an update. Julian's visualization output was generated during simulation instead of afterward.

"Our model has reached the world's fastest environment and chosen embarrassment," Nia said.

Keisha did not laugh yet.

She profiled the code and displayed the bottlenecks. The team reduced redundant storage, separated simulation from media generation, and recalculated only affected regions. Runtime improved, then failed the emergency-response target anyway.

"Do not hide this from tomorrow's presentation," Dr. Okafor said.

Keisha added the failed benchmark to the first results slide.

The lab had not proven their model was powerful. It had made the weakness measurable.

Tuesday, June 2: What Insurance Can See

Malik presented the risk assumptions to Delta scientists.

He showed expected travel time, modeled exposure, uncertainty penalties, and the gaps in insurance-derived loss data. He explained that documented property values could dominate records while displacement, unpaid caregiving, lost wages, and uninsured damage remained sparse.

A scientist asked whether adding a simple multiplier for underdocumented communities would correct the bias.

"It could acknowledge undercounting," Malik said, "but an unsupported multiplier may replace one false precision with another."

Another asked why the model used insurance data at all.

"Because it contains detailed, standardized records we do not have elsewhere. We need to use it without pretending documented financial loss equals total harm."

They challenged him to separate what the data measured, what proxies implied, and what the model could not price.

Malik revised the risk panel into three layers: documented loss, bounded proxy estimates, and unquantified impacts requiring narrative or community evidence.

The final category contained no convenient score.

Its emptiness was information.

Wednesday, June 3: The People Outside the Vehicle Model

Nia presented the access metric.

She explained route isolation, minimum alternatives, warning delay, and motion updates. Then a transportation researcher asked how the model represented people without private vehicles.

It did not.

Nia could have pointed to future scope. Instead, she said the full sentence.

"Our current motion model begins after a private vehicle enters the road network. It cannot represent someone waiting for a bus, sharing a ride, walking to a pickup point, or depending on assisted transportation."

The omission affected every result. A neighborhood could appear to have road access while many residents had no way to enter the route.

The researcher recommended separating road availability from household mobility access. Nia added vehicle access, pickup delay, and transit capacity to the validation plan, but did not improvise values.

The presentation ended with fewer claims than it began.

Delta scientists praised the team's willingness to expose the gap and warned that honesty alone did not fix it.

Nia agreed.

Thursday, June 4: The Terrace Without a Decision

The hotel terrace overlooked a parking lot and one determined tree growing through a crack near the wall.

After the final Delta session, Malik and Nia sat outside while the rest of the team packed.

"We said we would discuss fall after the work began," Nia said.

"We said no private promises before it began."

"That is not the same thing."

Malik agreed.

They spoke about Julian first. Nia explained that the relationship had been real, that public romance had hidden private disconnection, and that working together in spring felt safe because the relationship was over.

Malik spoke about Simone. He admitted that their relationship had been real too, and that he had compared it with an unfinished possibility often enough to make Simone feel partly unchosen.

"I was jealous of Julian before I had any right to be," he said.

"I was jealous of Simone while telling myself restraint made the feeling harmless," Nia replied.

They named the missed timing: fall, when Malik wanted Nia; spring, when Nia wanted Malik; summer, when both feelings existed but trust remained under construction.

"I do not want an answer tonight," Malik said.

"Neither do I."

The conversation brought them closer because it removed secrecy, not because it produced a decision.

They returned inside before the terrace could become another private world carrying more weight than the team.

The model still failed its runtime target. Malik's home still needed furniture moved. Closeness would have to live beside work that demanded action first.

Week Forty-Five: Tangent to Home

The full model took eleven minutes to produce an updated route recommendation.

The emergency-use target was under thirty seconds.

Keisha ran the benchmark again. Eleven minutes and four seconds.

"Consistency," Julian said, "is sometimes the enemy."

The Delta improvements had removed obvious inefficiencies. The remaining calculation examined too many interactions across the full network after every update.

Nia proposed a local approximation. Near the current conditions, a tangent-plane model could estimate how risk changed without rerunning everything.

Malik looked at the error plot.

"Approximation is how confident models lose when somebody finds the simplification," he said.

The room remembered his fall analytics competition, even if he did not name it yet.

Friday, June 5: Eleven Minutes Late

Dr. Okafor asked what an emergency planner could do with a more exact answer delivered after traffic had already changed.

Malik defended the full model. It preserved interactions and avoided approximation error.

Keisha defended the benchmark. "It is too slow. That is not a minor implementation issue. Runtime changes whether the result can affect the decision."

Nia proposed using the full model for planning and precomputed scenarios, then a local linear approximation for rapid updates within a validated neighborhood of conditions.

The approximation would use partial derivatives to estimate how the output changed when warning delay, road capacity, and departure volume shifted slightly. It would fail if conditions moved too far from the expansion point or crossed a sudden discontinuity such as a road closure.

"Then we publish the interval and error bound," Nia said. "Outside it, the system reports that a full recalculation is required."

Malik heard the logic. Fear remained.

An eleven-minute answer felt irresponsible. A fast answer with visible error felt vulnerable to criticism. He had not yet separated those two threats.

Saturday, June 6: The Judge in Malik's Head

Malik rebuilt the fall analytics loss in his memory.

His team had used an assumption that worked under ordinary scenarios. At regionals, judges found the hidden uncertainty. The model failed to advance. Malik had learned the wrong half of the lesson: any simplification could become the flaw that destroyed otherwise good work.

"You are arguing against approximation as a category," Nia told him. "Not this approximation."

"Because once people depend on the result, the error matters."

"Yes. That is why we measure it."

"And if conditions move outside the bound before the system detects it?"

"Then we design a trigger and test it."

Malik continued finding failure modes. Each one was legitimate. Together, they functioned as a refusal to choose any imperfect method.

Keisha interrupted. "The full model is also imperfect. Its error is arriving too late."

The sentence exposed the hidden comparison. Malik had treated exact computation as the safe baseline, though timing made it operationally unreliable.

He agreed to benchmark the local method.

Agreement did not make him comfortable.

Sunday, June 7: Responsible in Time

Dr. Okafor compared two warnings.

One used the full model and arrived ten minutes after a road became unusable. The other used a bounded approximation and arrived in twenty seconds with a clearly displayed uncertainty range.

"Which is more responsible?" she asked.

"It depends on whether the approximation remains inside its validated region," Malik said.

"Good. Now answer under that condition."

He looked at the scenarios. "The approximation."

"Why?"

"Because decision value depends on timing as well as numerical accuracy."

They designed safeguards. The system monitored distance from the expansion point, changes in network topology, and estimated local error. If any threshold failed, it stopped presenting the approximation as current and requested a full model update.

The method would not be called exact. It would not be called safe under every condition. It would publish where it worked, where it did not, and how quickly that judgment could change.

Responsible mathematics was not the absence of approximation.

It was refusing to hide the terms under which an approximation deserved use.

Monday, June 8: The Rooms Can Open

Celeste called Malik during lunch.

The final inspection had passed. The repaired back rooms could reopen if the family returned enough furniture over the weekend.

"Not everything," she said. "The large dresser may never come back. Your father says it can. Your father is wrong."

Marcel protested loudly in the background.

The family had stored furniture with relatives and in a rented unit. Moving it would require more hands than Marcel's recovering leg could safely provide.

Malik began building a schedule.

Then he paused.

"Would you be comfortable if some friends came to help?"

Celeste considered who he meant. "Friends, yes. Not a university service project. We are moving home, not becoming anybody's lesson."

"Understood."

Nia, Keisha, DJ, and Imani volunteered when Malik asked. They did not create matching shirts, social posts, or a fundraising caption.

They arranged rides and asked what tools to bring.

The rooms were ready for people.

That did not mean the house had returned to before.

Tuesday, June 9: Come to Work, Not Rescue

The drive to Gulfport began before sunrise.

DJ controlled music until Keisha revoked his authority after three repeated songs. Imani brought breakfast. Nia carried work gloves and no prepared speech about resilience.

At the Baptiste home, Celeste assigned tasks within five minutes. DJ and Malik handled bed frames. Keisha labeled storage boxes. Imani organized kitchen items. Nia worked with Celeste to return books and photographs without blocking the hallway.

Marcel supervised more than he lifted, a limitation he disliked and respected after one warning look from his wife.

Twelve-year-old Micah appeared from a relative's house and appointed himself quality-control manager.

"That bed is crooked," he told DJ.

"The floor is expressive," DJ replied.

"The bed is crooked."

Micah was right.

No one framed the day as charity. The Baptistes fed everyone, gave orders, argued about furniture, and decided what returned. The friends supplied labor inside a family plan.

By evening, one bedroom held a made bed again.

Celeste stood in the doorway without calling the moment complete.

"Better," she said.

Better was enough for the day.

Wednesday, June 10: The Line in the Closet

Nia carried a box of winter clothes into the back closet.

Inside, beneath fresh paint and above new baseboard, a faint waterline remained on an unfinished strip near the doorframe. The repair had covered most of the damage. Someone had chosen not to sand away this section yet.

Malik found her looking at it.

"My father wants to paint over it," he said. "My mother says we should photograph it first."

The line was not dramatic. It did not announce the months of repairs, the injury, insurance arguments, or uncertainty. It marked the height water had reached.

"This is why you hear uncertainty as danger," Nia said.

Malik nodded. "When people say a model is probably right, I see what happens in the probability they leave outside."

"And when I say approximation, you hear someone asking your family to accept the leftover risk."

"Yes."

Nia did not tell him the local method was safe. She understood why proof of bounded error mattered to him beyond academic rigor.

They photographed the line for Celeste, not for the project.

Then they returned to moving boxes.

Understanding did not require extraction.

Thursday, June 11: Name the Fear in the Method

Back in Bellwether, the team completed the approximation benchmark.

Within the validated region, the local method produced updates in twelve seconds. Error stayed below the published threshold. When conditions approached a road closure or moved too far from the expansion point, the safeguard correctly stopped the estimate and requested full recalculation.

The result was not perfect.

It was usable under stated conditions.

At the design review, Malik supported the method.

"I resisted it because I feared hidden simplification," he said. "That fear comes from our fall analytics loss and from watching incomplete estimates shape my family's recovery. The fear identified real questions, but I used rigor as a way to avoid choosing any bounded uncertainty."

Nia described the local model. Keisha demonstrated the safeguard. The documentation listed runtime, error bounds, trigger conditions, and known failures.

Dr. Okafor approved the method for the next community-validation round.

Malik had not defeated fear by proving the approximation harmless. He had named the fear, tested its claims, and allowed the team to make a decision with visible limits.

The work moved forward.

So did the repaired rooms in Gulfport, holding new framing, old photographs, and one waterline the family had not yet decided whether to cover.

Week Forty-Six: The Constraint Is Real

Dr. Okafor gave the class an evacuation problem with too few buses.

The goal was to maximize the number of people reaching safety. The constraints included bus capacity, travel time, staffing, fuel, road limits, and the requirement that no vehicle enter a flooded zone after a certain point.

Every desirable solution collided with something finite.

"Can we request more buses?" Nia asked.

"Not inside this problem."

"Can we extend the time?"

"The water declined to negotiate."

Using Lagrange multipliers, they searched for extrema while respecting the constraint surface. The method did not make scarcity fair. It made the tradeoffs visible enough to examine.

"Optimization does not mean receiving everything you want," Dr. Okafor said. "It means deciding honestly inside what is real."

Nia looked across the room at Malik.

They had constraints too.

Friday, June 12: Safety With Too Few Resources

The bus problem refused every heroic shortcut.

Prioritizing the largest shelter left one neighborhood without transportation. Sending buses to the most isolated area increased total travel time. Waiting for perfect route data delayed departure.

Malik wrote the expected-risk objective. Nia added a minimum-access condition. Keisha tested whether the proposed schedule could physically run.

Their first answer violated the driver-hour constraint. Their second overloaded one pickup point. The third met every mathematical condition but depended on all passengers arriving exactly on time.

"Human beings have again rejected our schedule," Keisha said.

They added bounded arrival delays and produced a less efficient, more defensible plan.

The exercise prepared them for Saturday's community review. Their own model now proposed routes under limited time, uncertain data, and incomplete transportation access.

One route looked especially efficient.

The advisory group recognized a problem before the team finished describing it.

Saturday, June 13: The Underpass Everyone Knows

The efficient route crossed the Linden Street underpass.

The model treated it as open because official road records listed it as passable under the simulated rainfall level. Residents rejected it immediately.

"That dip fills before the sensor says it should," Ms. Carter said.

Another advisor described two storms when water collected there despite moderate forecasts. A bus driver said large vehicles slowed approaching the narrow turn, creating backup even when the road remained technically open.

Nia checked the work behind the route. The local approximation was within its error bound. Expected travel improved. Access remained above threshold. Weeks of careful mathematics supported the recommendation.

The recommendation was still wrong for the community test.

"We need to remove the underpass," she said.

"Or represent its local failure history," Malik added.

They did both. The immediate scenario marked it unavailable. The long-term validation plan recorded the mismatch between official status, sensor behavior, and resident knowledge.

The mathematically efficient path had crossed a place the people using it already knew not to trust.

No amount of work invested in the route changed that fact.

Sunday, June 14: Do Not Defend the Hours

Nia presented the correction to Dr. Okafor.

"The advisory group rejected the route," she said. "The underpass has a failure history our inputs do not represent."

She did not begin with how many hours the team had spent tuning the approximation. She did not argue that official data technically supported the choice. Work already completed was not evidence that a result deserved to survive.

Keisha updated the topology and attached a provenance note describing why. Malik proposed a reliability penalty for roads where local reports and official records consistently diverged, subject to validation rather than automatic acceptance.

Dr. Okafor approved the revision.

"What made this correction difficult?" she asked.

"The model behaved exactly as we designed it," Nia said. "The design was missing knowledge."

"And?"

Nia sighed. "I liked the route."

"There it is."

They preserved the rejected result in the audit log. The route would not disappear merely because it embarrassed the team. Future reviewers could see what changed and why.

Accepting correction did not require pretending the discarded work had taken no effort.

It required refusing to make effort the final judge.

Monday, June 15: The Marker

Poster preparation stretched into evening.

Keisha left at eight for a remote developer meeting. Dr. Okafor had gone. Nia and Malik remained in the lab arranging the tradeoff curve, motion simulation, and local-approximation results.

One copper marker rolled beneath the table.

They both reached for it.

Their hands met. They looked at each other and laughed because the moment was so obviously written by a less subtle universe.

"We could use another color," Malik said.

"Copper is on brand."

Neither moved away.

The laughter faded. Malik's eyes dropped briefly to Nia's mouth. She noticed, then leaned closer.

For one suspended second, the empty lab, fluorescent lights, fellowship poster, deadlines, and months of missed timing narrowed into the distance between them.

Malik stopped.

He sat back and placed the marker on the table.

Nia's heart continued as if nobody had informed it of the decision.

"I am sorry," he said.

"Do not apologize for stopping."

They did not finish the conversation that night.

They finished the poster section and left before the almost-kiss could become a secret agreement.

Tuesday, June 16: Outside the Fluorescent Light

Malik asked Nia to walk before work.

"I wanted to kiss you," he said.

"I was present."

"I stopped because I do not want our first decision to happen in an empty lab during a deadline."

Nia understood. Their strongest moments had often formed under pressure: exams, storms, presentations, family repairs. Crisis could make closeness feel inevitable because no one had time to ask what ordinary life required.

"What do you want instead?" she asked.

"One date. Planned as a date. No project materials. No pretending it accidentally happened because we worked late."

"After the Summer A exam."

"After Summer B begins, so the date is not part of surviving this deadline."

The delay felt both sensible and unbearable.

"Okay," Nia said.

They returned to Eliza Moss Hall separately. The almost-kiss remained real. It did not receive control of the schedule.

Wednesday, June 17: Wanting Is Not Readiness

Nia told Malik what she wanted.

"I want you too," she said. "Not just a date. I have imagined the relationship."

Malik's expression softened.

"But wanting is not enough evidence that we are ready," she continued. "I wanted you while you were with Simone. You wanted me while I was with Julian. We have spent a year learning feelings can be honest and still produce bad timing."

"Agreed."

They named questions a date would not automatically answer. Could Malik disagree without withdrawing? Could Nia receive attention without turning it into proof? Could they maintain separate work? Could they talk about prior relationships without treating Julian and Simone as mistakes on the route toward each other?

"This is a very serious conversation about one bookstore date," Malik said.

"We have a documented history of under-modeling risk."

He laughed.

The humor helped. It did not reduce the standard.

They scheduled Sunday, June 28.

Thursday, June 18: Put the Date After the Exam

The Summer A examination covered vectors, motion, partial derivatives, gradients, tangent planes, and constrained optimization.

Nia and Malik entered separately. The almost-kiss did not improve either person's understanding of Lagrange multipliers.

Malik checked each constraint before solving. Nia caught a boundary case before declaring an interior maximum. Keisha finished early enough to review every orientation sign in a cross-product problem.

Afterward, nobody turned the date into a reward for performance.

"Still June twenty-eighth?" Malik asked outside.

"Still June twenty-eighth."

"No laptops."

"No project talk."

"What if the bookstore has a mathematics section?"

"We walk past it with discipline."

The date entered both calendars.

Between them stood Juneteenth, the community festival, grades, project responsibilities, and ten days in which momentum would have to tolerate intention.

The constraint was real.

They chose inside it.

Week Forty-Seven: Freedom Is a Practice

The team unrolled a floor-size map at the Bellwether Juneteenth community festival.

Children immediately stepped on it.

Keisha looked at the carefully printed roads beneath three pairs of shoes.

"We should have predicted this," she said.

"It is a floor map," Imani replied.

"It is also our only floor map."

Families received route markers, warning cards, bus tokens, and scenario prompts. They could move through the map as a household, change plans when new information arrived, and challenge any route that did not match what they knew.

No one had to understand an equation before participating.

The mathematics waited inside the choices.

Friday, June 19: A Map Large Enough to Enter

McCall-Hart was closed for Juneteenth, and Summer A had officially ended.

The festival honored freedom through history, music, food, local businesses, health resources, and community organizations. The research table occupied one modest corner. It was not the center of the celebration.

Nia welcomed families without introducing the fellowship rejection. Keisha explained how route updates worked. Malik helped participants compare expected travel and minimum access. Julian managed only the audio permissions already approved. Neighborhood advisors led the scenarios.

One family received an alert saying a familiar road might close. They chose to leave early. Another waited for a grandparent. A third selected a longer route because it passed a trusted pickup point.

The floor map made tradeoffs physical. People stood where a bottleneck formed. Children moved bus tokens. Adults argued about whether a warning source felt credible.

At the end of each scenario, the team asked what the model had missed.

The answer board filled faster than the success board.

That was useful.

Saturday, June 20: The Children Rewrite the Routes

Children refused the team's intended marker rules.

One eight-year-old moved a car backward to pick up a friend. Another placed two households inside one vehicle. A girl carried her route marker off the road entirely and announced that her aunt knew a parking lot connecting two streets.

"That is not in the network," Malik said.

"It is in real life," she replied.

The adults laughed. Malik wrote it down.

The children also exposed a hidden assumption in the pickup model. The simulation treated every household as a separate travel unit. Real families combined, split, waited, and returned for people.

Nia transformed the discovery into a simple challenge. How many people could reach safety if vehicles had different capacities and not every household owned one? Children arranged tokens, discovered bottlenecks, and invented cooperative strategies the optimization routine did not contain.

The activity made mathematics approachable without pretending every playful choice was validated data. Keisha marked observations for future testing rather than inserting them directly into code.

"We have been outperformed by third graders," Julian said.

"They had fewer assumptions to defend," Nia replied.

Sunday, June 21: Credit the Actual Work

A local reporter asked Nia how it felt to turn her failed fellowship project into a successful festival workshop.

The question offered a perfect comeback story.

Nia declined it.

"The fellowship version was built by a team and did not receive the award," she said. "This workshop exists because the work changed after that."

She named Keisha as computation and data-governance co-lead. She named Malik's risk and validation work. She credited Julian's consent-based media design. She named Ms. Carter and the neighborhood advisory group as decision partners. She described Dr. Price and Dr. Okafor's supervision.

"My role is mathematical modeling and community integration," she said. "I am not the project by myself."

The reporter asked whether the festival proved the model worked.

"No. It showed people could use the activity to identify assumptions and compare choices. Operational validation is a different standard."

The resulting story was less cinematic than redemption.

It was more accurate.

Nia still wished she had won the fellowship.

Public usefulness did not travel backward and award it to her.

Monday, June 22: Sooner, Not Safe Forever

Marcel Baptiste attended the festival with Celeste and Micah.

He moved carefully on his recovering leg and rejected every chair until Celeste selected one for him. Micah immediately joined the route challenge and attempted to become a facilitator without training.

Malik showed his father the two-metric display.

Marcel studied the route changes. "Can this stop what happened to our house?"

"No."

"Good answer."

Malik explained that the model could identify unstable routes and warning gaps. It could help planners see where one efficient average left some households with no good option.

Marcel nodded. "Modeling risk cannot prevent every loss. It can help families act sooner. Sometimes sooner is the difference you get."

He did not call the project a cure for uncertainty. He gave it a limited, human purpose.

Nia heard the conversation from the next table and did not join it. Father and son did not need her witness to make the moment meaningful.

Tuesday, June 23: One Dinner for the Grades

Summer A grades arrived.

Nia and Malik had both passed strongly. Keisha's course and research evaluation were equally strong. Dr. Okafor's feedback praised their technical growth and warned all three against mistaking one successful term for mastery.

They celebrated with one dinner.

DJ proposed a weeklong academic festival. Imani vetoed it on financial and emotional grounds. Amara joined by video. Julian arrived late from editing and ate the fries nobody had successfully protected.

No one used the grades to predict future relationships, prove identity, or erase the fellowship loss. They ordered dessert, toasted Summer A, and went home.

"That was suspiciously healthy," Nia told Keisha.

"Do not ruin it with analysis."

Nia obeyed.

Wednesday, June 24: Why Ending Was Right

Julian sent Nia the finished community-audio piece.

It centered residents' route choices, identified every limitation, and used only clips allowed for public release. Nia's voice appeared briefly. No romantic history entered the production.

At the end of his message, Julian added: **Working together helped me understand why our breakup was right. We can make good things without needing to be the same thing again.**

Nia listened twice.

She replied: **I understand that too. Thank you for asking clearly and for building this with us.**

There was no grief sharp enough to demand repair. Their relationship had mattered. Their collaboration had mattered differently. Each could remain true without reopening the other.

Nia saved the audio file in the approved public folder and the message in her private memory.

Then she returned to the date question waiting four days ahead.

Closure with Julian did not certify readiness with Malik.

It simply let one past relationship remain fully itself.

Thursday, June 25: Apart on Purpose

The final break day contained no required class or research meeting.

Nia and Malik could have spent it together.

They did not.

Malik stayed with family friends in Bellwether, reviewed no project files, and called Simone only through the group thread when she posted her arrival in London. He responded with a simple congratulations and did not start a private continuation.

Nia spent the day with Keisha and Imani at a market, where both friends prohibited discussion of what she would wear Sunday after the first twenty minutes.

"I need options," Nia said.

"You have clothes," Keisha replied.

"Those are not the same thing."

By evening, Nia and Malik had exchanged only one message confirming the time.

Distance made the date a choice rather than the next event in continuous project momentum.

For the first time, they would arrive from separate days with nothing urgent forcing them into the same room.

Week Forty-Eight: The First Date, Again

Summer B began informally on Friday with a research transition exercise.

Dr. Okafor projected an irregular floodplain bounded by a river, two curved elevation contours, and a road embankment. Students needed to accumulate a risk density over the region.

The region was not a rectangle.

One set of integration bounds worked for part of it and failed for the rest. A polar description simplified the curved boundary but complicated the embankment. Rectangular coordinates did the opposite.

"The double integral is not the difficult part yet," Dr. Okafor said. "First describe where you are."

Official Summer B classes would begin Monday. The problem arrived early to establish the standard.

Before calculating what a region contained, they had to tell the truth about its shape.

Friday, June 26: The Irregular Region

Nia sketched the floodplain three times.

Malik identified where risk density changed with elevation. Keisha overlaid the road network and found that one boundary in the simplified region cut through an actual drainage channel.

They could divide the area into vertical slices, horizontal slices, or polar sectors. Each representation described the same land while making different features easier to integrate.

"There is no single natural description," Nia said.

"There is a description appropriate to the calculation," Malik replied.

They selected a piecewise Cartesian setup for the embankment and a polar conversion for the curved flood zone. The final method looked less elegant than one integral and represented the region more accurately.

Sunday's date sat on both calendars.

Neither mentioned it during the research session.

Saturday, June 27: Divide Without Losing the Whole

The team divided the irregular region into workable pieces.

One piece used bounds that changed with (x) . Another was easier with reversed order. The final curved section became a polar integral with a Jacobian factor.

Keisha checked that shared boundaries were not counted twice. Nia verified that no gap remained. Malik compared the accumulated risk with a numerical estimate.

Different descriptions produced the same total within expected numerical error.

"That is deeply reassuring," Nia said.

"About integration?" Keisha asked.

"I am choosing not to answer."

They finished before evening. Nia resisted the urge to rehearse Sunday's conversation with Malik. Relationships were not oral exams, even if she had prepared several possible follow-up questions.

Keisha confiscated her draft list.

"You wrote date objectives."

"Only three."

"Go be a person."

Sunday, June 28: No Laptops at the Bookstore

The bookstore occupied a narrow brick storefront in downtown Bellwether. New releases filled the front. Used books leaned at dangerous angles in the back. A cafe served tea, coffee, and pastries on plates that did not match.

Malik arrived first. Nia arrived two minutes later wearing copper earrings and the expression of someone pretending she had not considered twelve outfits.

"You look nice," he said.

"You also look intentionally assembled."

"Thank you, I think."

They placed their phones face down. No laptops. No project talk. No friends positioned nearby to provide reaction shots.

They browsed travel writing, music biographies, and a shelf labeled **BOOKS WE CANNOT EXPLAIN BUT LOVE**. Malik selected a strange collection of maps from fictional cities. Nia found essays about storytelling through food.

At the cafe, they talked about Gulfport summers, Huntsville family reunions, music they secretly disliked, and the jobs they had imagined before mathematics.

The date felt familiar because they knew each other.

It felt new because no crisis had assigned them to the same table.

When the bookstore closed, neither wanted to leave.

They left anyway, letting the evening end before exhaustion turned honesty into impulse.

Monday, June 29: What We Admired and Misunderstood

Official Summer B classes began Monday.

After double integrals, Malik and Nia continued the date conversation during a walk, with no project work in hand.

Nia spoke about Julian. She had admired his public ease, creative discipline, and ability to make people feel celebrated. She had misunderstood public visibility as proof of private understanding.

Malik spoke about Simone. He admired her ambition, directness, and refusal to shrink a future to reassure him. He had misunderstood choosing a relationship as proof that unresolved feelings no longer required attention.

"I do not want us to turn them into people who prepared us for each other," Nia said.

"Agreed. They had their own lives. We mattered to them too."

Nia appreciated the sentence. It removed the easy story in which Julian and Simone existed only as lessons along an inevitable path.

They also named what they had misunderstood about each other. Malik had mistaken Nia's warmth for availability. Nia had mistaken Malik's patience for permanence.

The date had gone well.

The conversation did not allow that success to erase history.

Tuesday, June 30: Not Proof of a Purpose

Nia stated her boundary directly.

"I will not become proof that your breakup with Simone had a purpose."

They sat beneath a shade tree near Eliza Moss Hall before research.

"You are not," Malik said.

"If we date, I do not want the story to become that spring ended so the right relationship could begin."

"Spring ended because Simone made a decision about the relationship she was in. London mattered. My divided attention mattered. None of that requires us to become a couple."

Nia nodded.

"And I do not want to be proof that ending with Julian was secretly about you," Malik added.

"It was not."

They agreed that any relationship between them had to stand on current choices, not retroactively justify pain experienced by four people.

The boundary was not romantic.

It made romance safer.

Wednesday, July 1: The Bottleneck Beside the Fieldhouse

The campus emergency-tabletop exercise simulated a severe storm during a summer event at Ruth Ellis Fieldhouse.

The model routed vehicles toward two exits and recommended opening a secondary shelter when the main route approached capacity.

Then facilities staff introduced one ordinary detail the network lacked: delivery trucks occupied a service lane beside the fieldhouse during event breakdown.

The route narrowed. Pedestrians crossed the same area. Campus police temporarily reversed traffic flow.

The dashboard missed the bottleneck.

Expected travel increased sharply. One accessible shuttle could not complete its modeled turn. The secondary shelter recommendation came later than planners needed.

Keisha logged the failed scenario. Malik documented the risk consequences. Nia asked facilities staff how often the service lane was occupied and who controlled it.

They did not remove the trucks from the replay to make the demonstration cleaner.

The exercise turned a campus detail into a serious validation gap.

Their first date had gone well. Their model had not.

Neither result needed to become a prediction about the other.

Thursday, July 2: Honesty Before Exclusivity

Nia and Malik met outside the bookstore for a shorter walk.

"I want a second date," Malik said.

"Good. I have already developed a favorable preliminary finding."

"That sounds dangerously close to project talk."

"I am adapting."

They planned dinner after the Independence Day weekend.

Neither asked for exclusivity yet. One date and years of history did not automatically create a relationship. They agreed on the immediate commitment: if either felt uncertainty, jealousy, pressure, or a desire to step back, they would say it before distance turned into punishment.

"Honesty first," Nia said.

"Exclusivity only if we choose it directly."

They stood close. This time, no deadline controlled the room and no project emergency waited inside the moment.

Malik kissed her.

The kiss was brief, mutual, and not a contract.

When they separated, Nia smiled. "Second date confirmed."

They walked back toward campus holding hands for part of the route, then released them before entering Eliza Moss Hall.

Inside, Keisha had a failed fieldhouse scenario waiting.

Ordinary work continued, which was exactly what they needed the beginning to survive.

Week Forty-Nine: A Place at the Table

Dr. Okafor drew a three-dimensional region shaped like a tilted storage tank.

"Set up the triple integral," she said.

Students reached for (dz, dy, dx) .

"You have not described the region."

They stopped.

The tank could be sliced in several orders. Cylindrical coordinates simplified one boundary. Cartesian coordinates made the tilted plane easier to express. No calculation could begin responsibly until the class stated what points belonged inside.

"Integration accumulates what a region contains," Dr. Okafor said. "Before you count anything, know where the boundary is."

Nia thought about the relationship beginning around her and Malik. One date, one kiss, and years of history did not define its region automatically.

They would have to name what belonged inside.

Friday, July 3: Describe the Region First

The class compared triple integrals for mass and density.

Uniform density allowed volume to stand in for mass. Variable density required the function inside the integral to change across the region. Two objects of equal size could carry very different weight.

Malik connected the idea to evacuation zones. Counting households by area ignored how population and transportation needs varied. Nia added vertical elevation and building density. Keisha sketched a data structure for three-dimensional shelter capacity.

After class, Malik invited Nia to the Baptiste family Independence Day cookout.

"As my date," he said. "Not as project labor."

"Will there be a density exam?"

"Micah may create one."

Nia accepted.

The invitation placed her inside ordinary family time: food, teasing, folding chairs, and relatives who knew pieces of the year but did not owe her a romantic welcome ceremony.

The region had a boundary.

She entered by invitation, not assumption.

Saturday, July 4: Fruit, Density, and the Kitchen Scale

The Baptiste cookout spread across the backyard and kitchen.

Marcel guarded the grill with a seriousness unsupported by his apron. Celeste directed traffic between dishes. Cousins arrived carrying foil pans. Music competed with three separate conversations and a child declaring every firework visible before sunset.

Micah recruited Nia for an experiment.

He had a kitchen scale, a measuring cup, a watermelon, oranges, grapes, and a question about which fruit was "most packed."

They measured mass. For smaller fruit, they used water displacement to estimate volume. The watermelon exceeded the measuring cup's ambitions, so they approximated its volume and labeled the result accordingly.

"Density is mass divided by volume," Nia explained.

Micah ranked the fruit and discovered that the largest object was not automatically the densest.

"So size is dramatic but not informative," he announced.

"That lesson will serve you in many meetings," Malik said.

Nia laughed with the family. She helped carry plates because everyone carried plates, not because she needed to prove usefulness. Malik disappeared to help his father. Nia stayed at the table with Celeste and cousins without treating his absence as a test.

The day included no crisis.

They remained important to each other anyway.

Sunday, July 5: His Healing Is Not Your Assignment

Celeste thanked Nia while they packed leftovers.

"You and the others helped us get the rooms open," she said. "That mattered."

"We were glad to come."

Celeste closed one container and met Nia's eyes. "Malik is learning how to carry uncertainty without trying to control everyone around it. You understand him. That does not make his healing your assignment."

Nia listened carefully.

"I do not want it to be."

"Good. Love can become another kind of work somebody assigns the girl who listens best. Do not accept that job."

The word *love* remained in the room without requiring a response.

Celeste continued, "And do not let him make your ambition his project either."

Nia smiled. "I can promise resistance."

"I believe that."

On the drive back to Bellwether, Nia told Malik about the conversation.

He was embarrassed for one second, then grateful.

"She is right," he said.

"About both of us."

The family visit had not approved their future. It had clarified one condition: care could support change without becoming responsible for producing it.

Monday, July 6: Preserve or Discard

The field-sensor test failed halfway through.

A water-depth sensor near the campus service road stopped transmitting for eleven minutes. Before and after the gap, readings appeared stable. Malik proposed interpolation so the team could preserve the run and evaluate the dashboard response.

Nia objected.

"We do not know what happened inside the gap. Filling it makes the field test look complete."

"Discarding the entire run wastes valid readings on both sides."

"Preserving it with invented values could validate behavior we never observed."

The disagreement sharpened. Malik emphasized continuity and bounded estimation. Nia emphasized auditability and the danger of smoothing failure away.

Their weekend warmth did not make the technical choice easier. It made both more aware of how disagreement might spill into the relationship.

They stopped before motives entered.

"Keisha owns data governance," Nia said.

"We take it to her," Malik agreed.

The field run remained unresolved overnight.

So did the date they had planned for Tuesday.

Tuesday, July 7: The Failed Run Stays Failed

Keisha reviewed the sensor logs.

Her decision preserved the run and preserved the failure.

The observed readings would remain intact. The eleven-minute gap would stay missing. The team could generate an interpolated comparison labeled as synthetic, but it could not use that series to claim the field test succeeded.

"We keep the evidence we have," she said. "We keep the missingness visible. We do not discard valid observations, and we do not manufacture completion."

Malik and Nia accepted the ruling.

Neither appealed privately. Neither carried resentment into dinner.

Their second date took place at a small noodle restaurant. They discussed books, family, summer heat, and whether Micah's fruit-density ranking had any peer-review future.

The sensor disagreement entered only once.

"I am glad we took it to Keisha," Malik said.

"Me too."

Then they left it with the project.

The date did not become cold because Malik's preferred method lost. Nia did not make extra warmth prove she was not upset.

They practiced being together after disagreement without making punishment the bridge between work and affection.

Wednesday, July 8: Choice Without Fate

Malik asked Nia to walk along Cypress Walk after dinner.

"I want to be your partner," he said. "Exclusively."

Nia waited, not because she doubted him, but because both had learned that silence could give a sentence its full meaning.

"I care about you," Malik continued. "I am attracted to you. I trust the way we have handled difficult work recently. I also know we will disappoint each other and that choosing this does not guarantee where we end."

No destiny. No claim that the year had been leading inevitably toward this point. No promise that love solved uncertainty.

"I am asking because I want the relationship," he said. "Not because I need the outcome to repair fall or spring."

Nia smiled. "That is the least poetic and most convincing invitation I have received."

"I can revise."

"Do not."

She took his hand.

"Yes."

Thursday, July 9: Important Without a Crisis

Nia repeated the yes the next day with one condition.

"We still have to learn how to be together when no crisis is making us important to each other."

Malik understood.

Their bond had strengthened through exams, storms, rejection, family repairs, and project failures. Emergency created clarity: show up, solve the immediate problem, protect the person beside you. Ordinary time required different skills.

"We need days when nothing is wrong," he said.

"And we do not invent something wrong because calm feels unfamiliar."

They agreed to maintain separate friendships, roles, and study time. They would not make Keisha or DJ relationship referees. They would keep project decisions inside project governance.

Then they told their friends.

Keisha said, "Finally," followed immediately by, "Do not make me regret that word."

DJ requested a formal timeline and was denied.

Nia and Malik were a couple.

The next morning, Bellwether's emergency drill would care nothing about their relationship status.

That was their first ordinary test.

Week Fifty: A Field With Consequences

Dr. Okafor drew a wind field across a map.

At every point, an arrow showed the force and direction of wind. The field existed across the region. A traveler experienced only the vectors along one chosen path.

"Do not confuse what acts everywhere with what accumulates along a curve," she said.

Line integrals measured the effect experienced along a path. Conservative fields allowed a potential function, making the total depend only on endpoints. Other fields carried path dependence.

Nia thought about evacuation. Two households could begin and end in similar places while experiencing different delays, warnings, and risk along the way.

Malik thought about relationships. Arriving at the same label did not erase the paths taken to reach it.

The Bellwether emergency drill would test what their model accumulated along actual routes.

Friday, July 10: What Acts Along the Path

The team represented water flow, traffic pressure, and warning movement as fields.

Some quantities described conditions at every location. Others depended on a household's route and departure time. The line integral of exposure along one path could differ even when total travel time matched another.

Keisha connected the vector-field layer to the motion simulation. Malik validated risk accumulation. Nia prepared the decision dashboard for city staff. Community advisors checked the language.

The drill scenario would involve volunteers and agency staff, not a real evacuation. The team still treated every recommendation as if someone might ask what evidence supported it.

Nia and Malik worked on different stations. They exchanged one good-morning kiss outside the operations room, then became co-workers inside.

No one needed their relationship to improve the model.

Saturday, July 11: Open the Secondary Shelter

The drill began with simulated heavy rainfall and a steady primary-shelter route.

As volunteer movement increased, the dashboard showed expected travel rising. The minimum-access panel flagged one neighborhood approaching route isolation. A facilities update confirmed the fieldhouse service-lane bottleneck discovered last week.

The model recommended opening a secondary shelter before the primary route reached full capacity.

City staff reviewed the tradeoff. Opening early required staffing and supplies. Waiting risked a sharper congestion surge.

They opened it in the exercise.

Volunteer traffic split. The isolated neighborhood retained an alternative. Expected travel improved less dramatically than a single-metric model predicted, but the access threshold stayed above minimum.

For several minutes, the system worked as intended.

Nia watched staff interpret the two panels without asking the team to collapse them into one answer.

Useful did not mean automatic. The dashboard helped people see a choice they still had to make.

Sunday, July 12: The Recommendation That Arrived Late

The delayed data feed appeared in the drill review.

One road-capacity update had entered the system four minutes late. The dashboard's shelter recommendation was mathematically correct for the data it had and too late for the actual simulated condition.

The team could have edited the replay to use the correct timestamp. The final demonstration would have looked smooth.

Keisha locked the raw log.

Malik documented the timing failure and its risk effect. Nia added a red marker to the public timeline showing when the recommendation should have arrived and when it did.

"The model did not fail alone," a city staff member said. "The data pipeline failed."

"The dashboard depends on that pipeline," Keisha replied. "The system includes the dependency."

They refused the comforting separation.

The exercise had produced one useful decision and one consequential delay. Both entered the report.

Monday, July 13: Adopt the Tradeoff, Not the Promise

Bellwether staff chose to retain the two-metric display for future exercises.

They did not adopt the student model for live emergency operations. They adopted the way it showed expected travel beside minimum access, plus the audit timeline that made delayed information visible.

"This helps us ask what one efficient plan costs a specific neighborhood," the emergency coordinator said.

The limited adoption mattered.

It did not certify the system.

The team wrote conditions for future use: training exercises only, visible data timestamps, fallback procedures, and no claim of individual behavior prediction. Community advisors requested public reporting after every pilot.

Nia signed the draft as co-lead after Keisha. Malik signed as validation analyst.

The rejected fellowship project had entered a real preparedness process in a narrow form. It remained rejected. It also remained alive.

Tuesday, July 14: Speak About the Loss

Dr. Bennett invited Malik to the preseason athletics analytics workshop.

"Not to present a new winning model," he said. "Talk about why the fall model failed."

The audience would include student analysts, coaches, and athletes preparing for the next season. Malik's original model had overfit one set of game conditions and transferred poorly to a different opponent. Its confidence had exceeded its evidence.

Months earlier, Malik would have wanted a repaired model to accompany the confession. Without a comeback, failure felt unfinished.

Now he accepted the invitation as stated.

Nia offered to help rehearse. Malik thanked her and chose to prepare first with Dr. Bennett and Simone's archived analytics notes, crediting the team that had built the work.

Nia did not interpret his independence as distance.

His failure belonged to his academic story. Her role as partner did not make her co-author of the lesson.

Wednesday, July 15: No Comeback Slide

Malik began the workshop with the fall model's strongest graph.

Then he showed where it failed.

The model fit home-game patterns too closely. It treated one opponent's defensive behavior as transferable. It underestimated uncertainty and offered a recommendation more confident than the evidence supported.

Malik named his own decisions. He credited Simone and the full team for earlier corrections. He explained how competition pressure had encouraged them to optimize for an impressive result rather than robust transfer.

There was no final slide announcing a new championship model.

A coach asked whether Malik planned to rejoin analytics.

"I may apply again," he said. "Failure does not guarantee me a return, and reflection does not guarantee a better result."

The answer disappointed anyone waiting for a comeback announcement.

It told the truth.

Afterward, two younger analysts asked for his validation checklist. An athlete asked how to challenge a recommendation that contradicted film experience.

The failed model became useful as a warning, not a prophecy of redemption.

Thursday, July 16: Let His Work Stand

Nia attended the workshop as Malik's partner.

She sat with Keisha and DJ near the middle. When questions opened, she had several. She asked none.

Malik did not need a supportive question designed to make him look prepared. He did not need Nia to signal their relationship from the audience. His work could stand, be challenged, and remain his.

After the session, she waited while students approached him.

Only when the room cleared did she hug him.

"You did not turn the ending into a trailer for next season," she said.

"I wanted to."

"I know."

They went to dinner and discussed the talk because Malik chose to. Nia listened without offering to manage his next opportunity.

Being his partner meant showing up.

It also meant knowing when her presence should not become part of the presentation.

Week Fifty-One: Around the Boundary

Dr. Okafor drew a closed curve around a region.

Green's Theorem connected circulation around the boundary with derivatives accumulated across the interior. One problem could be described by what happened inside or by what happened around the edge.

"Two views," she said. "Equivalent under stated conditions. Not interchangeable without checking orientation, smoothness, and the region itself."

Nia saw the summer project in both views. Inside were code, metrics, interviews, tests, failures, and revisions. Around the boundary were the people encountering the dashboard, the agencies maintaining it, and the conditions under which it could leave the university.

A polished interior result meant little if the boundary excluded everyone needed to sustain it.

Friday, July 17: Inside and Around

The class used Green's Theorem to convert difficult line integrals into double integrals and back again.

Keisha cared about orientation because one reversed boundary changed a flux sign. Malik cared about assumptions because holes in a region required attention. Nia cared that choosing the easier form did not change the physical interpretation.

For the Summer Scholars preliminary review, she structured the presentation around both interior work and boundary governance.

Keisha would demonstrate software and failure handling. Malik would explain risk and validation. Community advisors would respond before Nia concluded. Julian's media would appear only where permissions allowed.

Nia would not introduce every person as if their role became real through her voice. Each would speak from their own work.

The review would show a team, not a central hero surrounded by evidence.

Saturday, July 18: The Review Belongs to More Than Nia

Keisha opened the preliminary review.

She demonstrated the time-step simulation, local approximation, data-lineage system, and missing-sensor handling. She intentionally triggered one failed input and showed the preserved log.

Malik followed with the two risk metrics, underdocumented loss categories, and the delayed-feed failure from the emergency drill.

Ms. Carter described how the advisory group had rejected the Linden Street route and changed the project's definition of usable access. A transit representative named the remaining private-vehicle bias.

Only then did Nia connect the pieces. She explained the mathematical evolution from static routes to motion, multivariable sensitivity, constrained optimization, and field-based exposure.

Questions went to the person responsible. Nia did not answer software questions over Keisha. Malik did not interpret community priorities for Ms. Carter.

The distributed structure made the project look less like one student's accomplishment.

It made the evidence stronger.

Sunday, July 19: Who Maintains It After August?

A reviewer asked one question the team had not answered.

"Who maintains this after the students leave?"

The room became quiet.

The model depended on Keisha's code knowledge, Nia's interpretation, Malik's validation procedures, Julian's media workflow, and community relationships held partly through specific people. Documentation existed, but no outside maintainer had installed or updated the system independently.

"At present, we do," Keisha said. "That is a sustainability gap."

The reviewer asked what happened when a library changed, a data format shifted, or a consent restriction required media removal.

They had partial answers and no complete handoff process.

The project could perform a pilot and still fail the moment its creators graduated, changed courses, or simply became unavailable.

Nia added sustainability to the critical-risk list. She did not promise Keisha would keep supporting the code indefinitely.

Maintenance was not an invisible extension of co-leadership.

It was work requiring ownership, training, and resources.

Monday, July 20: Keisha's Name on the Documentation

Keisha proposed an open documentation plan.

The public repository would include installation steps, dependency versions, data schemas, test scenarios, failure logs, and role-based maintenance guides. Sensitive community data would remain outside. Media permissions would have a removal process. A new maintainer would complete a reproducibility test before receiving pilot access.

She presented the plan at the student-developer forum under her own name.

Nia and Malik attended from the audience. Neither introduced her. Neither reframed the work as part of Nia's project or Malik's validation system.

Developers challenged Keisha on version support, security updates, and whether "open" documentation could expose system weaknesses. She answered directly and added a security-review step.

The forum invited her to lead a fall workshop on reproducible student research software.

Keisha accepted the invitation provisionally around track and course schedules.

Her technical leadership produced an opportunity belonging to her.

Tuesday, July 21: Conditions on the Vote

The community advisory group voted to support a limited pilot.

The support came with conditions.

No personally identifiable interview data could enter the operational dashboard. Public reports had to list failures as well as successes. Route recommendations required visible timestamps and human review. Residents needed a process to challenge roads marked usable. The pilot license had to expire unless renewed after review.

The vote was not unanimous. One member abstained because transportation access remained underdeveloped. The team recorded the abstention and reason.

"Support does not mean you can quote us as endorsing the finished system," Ms. Carter said.

"We will call it a conditional limited pilot," Nia replied.

The wording mattered because public approval could become marketing if stripped of its limits.

Community authority remained inside the agreement, not merely inside the acknowledgments slide.

Wednesday, July 22: Show Us the Failure Live

The Summer Scholars committee granted the team a showcase slot.

One condition surprised them: the committee wanted a live failure scenario.

No polished replay. During the showcase, Keisha would interrupt or corrupt one data source. The team would have to demonstrate detection, fallback behavior, and public explanation in real time.

"They want us to fail on purpose," Nia said.

"They want evidence that failure remains visible," Malik replied.

Keisha began designing a test no presenter could quietly control. Dr. Okafor would select the failure type from an approved set moments before the demonstration.

The showcase slot was not a reward for looking finished. It depended on proving that limits and errors could survive public pressure.

The team accepted.

Thursday, July 23: Keep the Dinner

Friends celebrated the showcase slot at the student center.

DJ proposed banners. Imani proposed food. Keisha proposed that nobody touch her test environment before Friday. Julian brought a tiny cardboard trophy labeled **MOST TRANSPARENTLY IMPERFECT**.

Afterward, Nia and Malik had a private dinner scheduled.

The team wanted to continue planning the live failure test. Nia almost stayed. Malik almost offered to reschedule.

They did neither.

They trusted Keisha's work plan, closed their laptops, and went to dinner.

For ninety minutes, the project continued without consuming the relationship. They talked about second-year housing, family, books, and whether DJ's cardboard trophy violated visual standards.

The showcase mattered.

So did keeping an ordinary promise after the celebration ended.

Week Fifty-Two: What Crosses the Surface

Dr. Okafor stretched a mesh across a three-dimensional shelter model.

Air, water, people, and supplies could move across its boundary. Surface integrals measured flow through the surface rather than motion along one path.

"Capacity is not only what a shelter contains," she said. "It is also what can enter, leave, and be processed across time."

The team's dashboard had treated shelter capacity like one fixed number. In practice, arrivals crossed entrances at different rates. Registration slowed flow. Medical screening created another boundary. Buses departed and returned.

Nia added a flow-based measure. Malik connected arrival rates to exposure outside. Keisha linked the calculation to timestamped capacity updates.

The live failure test would now examine not just whether the model recommended a shelter, but whether people could actually cross its boundary fast enough.

Friday, July 24: Capacity Through the Door

The class parameterized surfaces and calculated flux.

Orientation mattered. An outward normal counted movement leaving a region as positive; reversing the normal changed the sign. A correct integral with the wrong orientation told the opposite physical story.

For the shelter model, the team defined inflow and outflow explicitly. A building with four hundred open spaces could still become unsafe if arrivals exceeded processing capacity and people accumulated outside.

Nia revised the public display. It no longer showed **400 SPACES AVAILABLE** as a complete answer. It showed current occupancy, arrival rate, processing rate, and the time associated with every value.

Community advisors asked for plain language beside the flux calculation.

Keisha wrote: **People are arriving faster than this shelter can safely receive them.**

The sentence carried more decision value than the symbol alone.

Saturday, July 25: The Impossible Road Appears

The live failure test began before reviewers, faculty, city staff, and community advisors.

Dr. Okafor selected a failure from the approved set and handed the instruction to Keisha. No one else knew which source she would interrupt.

Keisha cut the live road-closure feed.

The model continued using the last known topology. A road closed in the test scenario remained marked available. The optimization layer recommended it because expected travel looked excellent and minimum access remained high.

The road was impossible.

For two seconds, the recommendation existed inside the system.

Nia saw it on the internal monitor. Malik saw the stale timestamp. Keisha kept her hands away from the controls.

No one edited the moment.

The live test had produced exactly the kind of failure polished demonstrations tried to avoid.

What happened next would determine whether the system failed dangerously or visibly.

Sunday, July 26: Stop Before the Public Display

Malik's validation layer compared the route with data freshness requirements.

The road-closure feed had exceeded its allowable age. The layer flagged the recommendation, blocked it from the public display, and switched the dashboard to a fallback message.

CURRENT ROUTE RECOMMENDATION WITHHELD: ROAD STATUS DATA OUT OF DATE. USE VERIFIED CONTINGENCY PLAN.

The safeguard worked.

Malik did not celebrate yet.

The internal system had still generated an impossible route. A different feed, threshold, or validation bug might pass unnoticed. The fallback plan also depended on city staff maintaining verified alternatives.

Keisha restored the source. The model recalculated and displayed a feasible route with a full audit history.

Reviewers could see the wrong recommendation, the validation flag, the withheld output, and the fallback.

Safe failure did not mean nothing went wrong.

It meant the wrong result stopped before becoming an instruction and remained visible for investigation.

Monday, July 27: Do Not Call the Safeguard Proof

Nia explained the test to reviewers.

"The route layer initially recommended a closed road because one source became stale," she said. "The validation layer detected the timestamp failure and withheld the result before public display."

A reviewer asked whether that proved the dashboard would always fail safely.

"No," Nia replied. "It proves this safeguard handled this tested failure under these conditions. Unknown failures remain possible."

She described the fallback process, human review, audit log, and conditions requiring the system to stop recommending routes.

Keisha explained how the source was cut. Malik explained the validation threshold. Ms. Carter asked what the public would see and whether the message invited false confidence in the contingency route.

The team revised the wording during the review.

No one called the live failure a success without naming what had failed.

Their claim stayed narrow enough to defend.

Tuesday, July 28: Permission With Limits

The team passed the Calculus III project review.

Dr. Okafor praised their integration of surfaces, fields, constrained optimization, and multivariable interpretation. The committee granted permission to demonstrate the limited pilot at the Summer Scholars Showcase.

The permission included conditions: preserve the failed run, display the fallback process, state that the dashboard was not approved for live emergency operation, and allow community advisors to describe remaining concerns.

Nia accepted without adding celebratory language to the conditions. Keisha scheduled a clean reproducibility run. Malik updated the validation documentation.

The approval was real.

So were its limits.

Wednesday, July 29: Required Courses Do Not Coordinate Romance

Second-year registration opened at noon.

Nia's required proof course met during the only section of an actuarial class Malik needed. Their preferred electives overlapped. Keisha's computer-science lab conflicted with the afternoon the research team hoped to reserve.

Malik proposed choosing a different actuarial section so he and Nia could share one class.

The alternate instructor had a format that did not fit his learning needs and placed a work shift at risk.

Nia wanted him to switch anyway. Malik wanted her to move an elective so they could preserve afternoons together.

Their first serious scheduling disagreement as a couple sounded ordinary because it was.

"We said proximity was not the measure," Nia reminded them both.

"Saying it was easier before the schedules existed," Malik replied.

They paused before sacrifice became proof of love.

Thursday, July 30: Choose the Majors First

Nia registered for the courses serving her mathematical-sciences path.

Malik registered for the actuarial courses, instructor, and work schedule serving his. Keisha protected her required lab and fall track commitments.

Only afterward did Nia and Malik compare open time.

They reserved one weekly dinner, one study block that could be canceled during exams, and a weekend check-in. They did not force shared classes that weakened either degree plan.

"Our schedules look unrelated," Nia said.

"Our majors are related, not identical."

"That sounded suspiciously reasonable."

They laughed and confirmed registration.

Commitment would have to cross the space between their schedules rather than erase it.

The model had learned to make boundaries visible. Their relationship would need the same honesty.

Week Fifty-Three: The Work Leaves Their Hands

The Calculus III final opened with one storm field, one closed boundary, and four possible mathematical tools.

Students had to choose a coordinate system, connect a vector field to a boundary theorem, perform the calculation, and explain what the result meant physically.

No isolated skill was enough.

Nia read the orientation arrows before writing. Malik checked the region for holes. Keisha identified the data represented by the flux term.

The exam asked them to integrate an entire summer of choices: not only which theorem produced an answer, but whether the answer described the world they claimed it did.

Friday, July 31: Connect the Mathematics to the Meaning

The first problem could be solved with a surface integral or the Divergence Theorem.

Nia chose the theorem because the closed surface and divergence were simpler than direct parameterization. She wrote the physical interpretation before calculating: net outward flow across the shelter boundary.

Malik selected Stokes' Theorem for a circulation problem, then checked boundary orientation against the chosen normal. Keisha used a direct parameterization where converting methods would have created more work.

Dr. Okafor had taught them to choose rather than perform rituals.

Outside, showcase materials waited. Inside, the exam demanded full attention.

One year earlier, Nia and Malik might have rushed the academic work toward the more exciting event. This time, each stayed with the page in front of them.

Saturday, August 1: Check the Signs

Summer classes ended Saturday.

Nia reached the final exam problem with twelve minutes remaining. Her calculation was complete. The old version of her would have used every remaining minute to add explanation and examples.

Instead, she checked orientation signs.

One boundary segment ran clockwise while her normal convention required counterclockwise orientation. She corrected the sign before the error traveled through the final answer.

The explanation became shorter.

The interpretation became right.

When time ended, Nia closed the booklet without adding one more paragraph.

Clarity had finally outranked performance.

Sunday, August 2: Less Elegant, More Defensible

Malik found an unjustified assumption in his final solution.

He had treated a field as conservative because the problem's geometry looked familiar. The required derivative condition failed in one component.

His elegant endpoint calculation could not stand.

With limited time, he crossed it out and set up the direct line integral along the specified path. The revised work was longer and less polished. It matched the actual field.

Malik finished the setup but not every arithmetic simplification.

He submitted it anyway.

An incomplete defensible answer was better than a complete result resting on a false assumption. The lesson had taken two semesters, one competition loss, a family storm, and a summer model to settle into habit.

Monday, August 3: Residents Name the Use

The Summer Scholars Showcase filled Eliza Moss Hall with posters, demonstrations, families, faculty, and community partners.

At the evacuation table, residents spoke before Nia's conclusion.

Ms. Carter did not endorse the dashboard as finished. She explained that it had changed the questions planners asked. Instead of only asking for the fastest route, they now asked which neighborhood lost access, how old the data was, and who remained outside private-vehicle assumptions.

A transit representative described the conditional pilot. Another advisor named the unresolved mobility gap.

Keisha demonstrated the failure log. Malik explained the validation layer. Julian played approved audio. Nia described the mathematics and limits.

The dashboard's value appeared through better questions and more visible tradeoffs, not through a claim that the students had solved evacuation.

Tuesday, August 4: The Handoff Has Conditions

The team handed documentation and a limited pilot license to the Bellwether emergency office and community advisory group.

The package included code, installation guides, dependency records, validation tests, failure logs, public-reporting templates, permission controls, and expiration terms. Sensitive interviews did not transfer into the operational system.

Keisha trained the designated maintainer. Malik reviewed risk thresholds. Nia walked through interpretation limits. Community advisors retained authority to challenge road status and public language.

The students did not hand over ownership and disappear. Nor did they retain control while calling the project community-owned.

The license divided authority, responsibility, and review.

The work had finally begun leaving their hands in a form other people could inspect, maintain, limit, and reject.

Wednesday, August 5: An Invitation Is Not the Fellowship

Dr. Price invited Nia to present the community-validation method at next year's public-mathematics seminar.

The invitation recognized how the project changed after rejection: shared ownership, visible failure, consent, and community challenge.

It did not provide the national fellowship, funding, or laboratory placement Nia had lost.

"I am honored," she said. "And I still wish I had won."

Dr. Price smiled. "Then you are capable of holding an invitation without asking it to impersonate a different outcome."

Nia accepted the seminar invitation.

She did not rename it redemption.

Thursday, August 6: Accept the Application

Dr. Bennett invited Malik to reapply for the Heron Analytics team as a peer-mentor candidate.

"Candidate," Malik repeated.

"You would submit a plan, interview, and be evaluated with everyone else. Reflection on failure makes you eligible to contribute. It does not guarantee selection."

Malik accepted the application packet.

He did not announce that he had returned to the team. He had not.

He told Nia about the invitation over dinner. She congratulated him on the opportunity to apply, not on a role he did not yet possess.

"You are learning my preferred level of precision," he said.

"I contain multitudes and caveats."

The application joined their second-year plans as an open possibility.

The project had left their hands. The future had not arrived to replace it with certainty.

Week Fifty-Four: The Bell Before Year Two

The final week contained only three days.

No new theorem waited. No competition bracket, fellowship result, or project deadline promised to summarize the year.

Summer grades, one gathering, and a walk remained.

That was enough space for an ending that did not pretend to be a solution.

Friday, August 7: Tell Home First

Summer grades arrived Friday morning.

Nia called Denise before posting anything. She had earned a strong Calculus III grade and completed the scholars program. Her mother celebrated, asked whether Nia had slept, and reminded her that a new year would not require becoming impressive on the first day.

Malik called Celeste and Marcel. Micah joined from the background to ask whether triple integrals had finally established the densest fruit. Malik reported his grade, the project handoff, and the analytics application with every uncertainty intact.

Only after family knew did Nia and Malik share the news publicly.

Their posts credited the team and community partners. Neither announced that the year had made them complete.

Grades confirmed work finished under specific conditions.

Home received the news before the audience did.

Saturday, August 8: Ring for Every Story

The group gathered at Founders' Bell.

DJ arrived from preseason training. Keisha carried workshop notes and a track schedule. Imani wore her softball tournament shirt. Julian brought no camera until everyone agreed to one final photograph. Simone joined by video from London, where evening light filled the window behind her.

Dr. Price, Dr. Okafor, Dr. Bennett, Dr. Delgado, and Dr. Brooks stood with them.

They marked what had changed without ranking whose year mattered most.

DJ had earned more responsibility on the field. Keisha had become a co-lead and independent developer. Imani's team had changed expectations without winning the title. Julian had learned consent and closure through better media work. Simone had chosen London and kept spring meaningful without keeping it alive. Malik had named loss without converting it into destiny. Nia had lost the fellowship and continued the work without pretending continuation erased the no.

The bell rang once.

Not for the best story.

For all of them moving forward.

Sunday, August 9: The Future Is Not a Forecast

Malik and Nia walked Cypress Walk as a couple.

They compared second-year schedules. Their required classes barely overlapped. Work, track meets, analytics applications, community reviews, football, softball, media projects, London calls, and family responsibilities would pull the friend group in different directions.

"We are going to be busy," Nia said.

"That is a generous interpretation."

They planned one dinner and left the rest open.

At the end of Cypress Walk, the Founders' Bell sounded for arriving students gathering nearby. New families carried boxes. Someone unfolded a campus map upside down. A first-year student stood beneath the bell looking excited and terrified at once.

Malik took Nia's hand.

"Do you think we will be okay?" she asked.

He considered every model, assumption, failure, and revision of the year.

"I think we will keep choosing," he said.

It was not a prediction.

It was better.

Together, they walked toward year two while the bell rang behind them for whoever came next.